THY KINGDOM COME

VOLUME ONE

The World Dossier

A story and scripture companion for the drafting and revision of the novel. Kept by its author, and revised as the manuscript revises itself.

DANY · OCTOBER 2026

NOTES

ANYTHING THIS SPREAD STARTED AND DID NOT FINISH

VOLUME ONE

Contents

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What this companion is

This is a working reference for a novel about a Christian empire, kept by the person writing it. *Thy Kingdom Come* can't be written honestly by someone guessing at scripture, and it can't be written well by someone who has only absorbed the version of scripture that power finds convenient. So the companion does two jobs at once. It teaches the book patiently and from the beginning, as literature, as history, and as an argument that has never stopped arguing with itself. And it keeps a record of what the Empire does to that book once it has the authority to quote it.

It isn't a devotional and it isn't a study guide. Nothing in here asks you to arrive at a settled conclusion about God, and nothing hands you a single meaning for a passage people have fought over for two thousand years. Where a reading is contested, the contest is printed. Where the text is stranger, more violent or more tender than its reputation, that's printed too. You're being handed summaries, analysis, references and tools that send you back to the text itself. Volume One is the world: the scripture the Empire inherited, and the history, institutions, beliefs and places that produced Eden's story. The people and the chapters belong to Volume Two. When a fact about the world matters to one particular person, this volume points to her dossier instead of working it out here. Above all, this is a book you're allowed to ruin. Write in the margins, argue with the entries, cross out anything the drafting proves false, and date the page when you do. The manuscript is the authority here, and this companion serves it. When the two disagree, the manuscript wins and this book gets amended.

"Every empire that has ever quoted a holy book has also decided which parts of it were quotable."

WHAT IT ISN'T

A devotional. A curriculum. A settled theology. An apologetic, in either direction. A book with the right answer at the back.

MARGINALIA

How to use it

There's an order to this book, and it's worth following the first time through. The parts move outward from the text itself to the empire that interprets it, and then into the world that empire built: its fall, its institutions, its twelve Dominions and its Trials. You can read a single entry in ten minutes or spend an afternoon on one. Both are legitimate uses.

Work in one of two modes. In study mode you're simply learning, reading an entry with no scene in mind and letting the margins fill with whatever surprises you. In drafting mode you come in with a scene that isn't working, find the entry or the doctrine page that touches it, and take only what you need. The canon register and the logs at the back keep the second mode fast. They're the book's memory, and they only work if you write in them the day you discover something. Discoveries are the real product. If an entry teaches you that a passage the Empire loves is addressed to slaveholders, or that the woman you'd cast as a warning is the only person in her chapter who tells the truth, that's a change to the novel. It belongs in the discovery log at the back, with a date, so that six months from now you can tell the difference between something you decided and something you only absorbed. Nothing here has to be finished. A half-filled page is more useful than a blank one.

The working arc

1. Learn the book before anyone tells you what it means.
2. Recognize its people and its patterns on sight.
3. Watch how power reads it, and what power leaves out.
4. Build the Empire's religion on purpose, doctrine by doctrine.
5. Know the world well enough that every room in it has a history.
6. Apply it to the manuscript, then record what changed.

Two modes

Study

No scene in mind. Read, take notes, follow the cross-references.

Drafting

A scene that resists. Take only what the scene needs, and go.

Marginalia

✣ *See also:* the Canon Register and the Discovery Log, at the back.

Reading the page

The layout carries meaning. Once you know the five signals below, you can tell at a glance whether you're reading the text, reading the Empire, reading an argument with no settled answer, or looking at space that belongs to you. The signals hold in black and white, because most of this book will be photocopied at some point.

INFORMATION

Plain roman type with no rule beside it. The text and its history, reported as plainly as the material allows. Where the material is disputed, the entry says so.

SCRIPTURE

> *Your desire shall be for your husband, and he shall rule over you.*
> GENESIS 3.16

Quoted text is italic behind a single fine rule, with the reference beneath it in small tracked capitals.

WHAT THE EMPIRE DOES WITH IT

The heavy frame with the pink edge, and the only one in the book. Anything marked this way is the Empire's reading, not the text's. Someone made that decision, and the novel is free to expose it.

CONTESTED

A broken frame means the companion isn't deciding. Contested always names a real biblical, historical, linguistic or theological dispute among serious readers. It's different from Possible, which marks an idea of your own that you haven't approved.

YOURS

Ruled space, on nearly every working page. If it's ruled, it's yours.

✤ Cross-references sit at the foot of the outer column, never inside a sentence, so following one is a choice and not an interruption.

Labels and sources

In the scripture parts (I to IV), unlabeled prose is research: what the text or scholarship says, with scholars named where a position belongs to them. Your own canon carries a source tag and no label. Everything else is labeled at the start of the sentence it governs.

LABEL	WHAT IT MEANS
RESEARCH	Outside fact, with a source. Unlabeled in Parts I to IV.
INTERPRETATION	A reading of the material, offered as a reading
CONTESTED	A real scholarly or theological dispute
INFERENCE	A conclusion drawn from your files that they don't state
POSSIBLE	An idea worth considering, and not canon
OPEN QUESTION	Something you still have to decide
CONFLICT	Two of your sources disagree
SUPERSEDED	Older material that no longer controls
DECIDED	A call you've made. Canon from here on.

TAG	SOURCE
FR 0–44	Final Rulings, by number. These outrank everything.
TL	Timeline Updated
TR	The Covenant Trials Updated
TR-ORIG	The original Trials file, where the update is silent
DOM	The Dominions Update
MEN	Men in the Covenant Empire
CR	The Crownward
DR3	Draft Three (Chapter One so far)
WR	Writing Rules
AM	The Audit Master, the old Companion
RULING	A ruling you made in the calibration doc or since

The eight parts

Each part carries a mark on its divider and in the running heads, so the book can be found by thumb as well as by contents. The parts are cumulative: the later ones assume you've at least skimmed the earlier ones.

PART	WHAT'S IN IT
✣ I	Learning the Bible as a novelist. Bible 101, canon, genres, translation, reading in context, contested readings, the sixty-six books, seven focused study spreads and four deep-dive dossiers.
✦ II	The people of the text. The women, then the men: what they're usually reduced to, and what the text actually gives you.
† III	Jesus, kingdom and power. Authority, bodies, women and money, the Lord's Prayer a clause at a time, and the Gospel Grid.
▣ IV	Empire and interpretation. The empires of the Bible, who gets to say what it means, the passages put to work and the passages kept quiet, and American history from the Puritans to now.
✚ V	The Fall of the United States. The timeline, the competing histories, the Restoration Act, living memory and the founder files.
❦ VI	Building the Empire. The Triune Rule, the Crownward, the Temple, the Registry, doctrine and lived religion, and the household order.
◈ VII	The twelve Dominions, one by one.
⌖ VIII	The Covenant Trials as an institution.
≡ BACK	The canon register, sources and editions, the open questions and the discovery log.

WHERE I WANT TO START, AND WHY

WHERE I WANT TO START, AND WHY

THE TEST

Every page in this book answers to the question at the foot of this one.

MARGINALIA

Rules of the House

Seven commitments that keep this companion honest. They're the difference between a novel that takes religion seriously and one that uses it as set dressing.

I · THE TEXT ISN'T THE EMPIRE	Every entry keeps them apart, because the engine of this novel is the gap between what a passage says and what an institution can make it do.
II · CONTESTED STAYS CONTESTED	Where scholars and traditions genuinely disagree, the disagreement is printed and left standing. The Empire may settle a question. The companion doesn't.
III · NO CHARACTER IS AN ALLEGORY	A biblical parallel can light a character up, and it never maps onto her. Every parallel ends with where it breaks, and the break is usually where the character gets interesting.
IV · BELIEF HAS A COST AND A TEACHER	Nobody in this book believes anything for free. Someone taught it to them, and something's at stake in keeping it. Both go in the dossier.
V · DISCOVERY OUTRANKS PLAN	If the research contradicts the outline, the research gets a hearing. The outline is a hypothesis, and this is where it gets tested.
VI · NOTHING ENTERS THE NOVEL UNTESTED	Every borrowed symbol, doctrine and parallel has to answer one question before it earns a scene.
VII · POSSIBLE ISN'T CANON	Freewriting, inference and research notes stay marked until you approve them. A compelling idea stays possible until it survives the manuscript, the source files and your own decision.

"Does this serve Thy Kingdom Come, or does it only prove I did the reading?"

Before you begin

Answer these once, in ink, before you read a single entry, and don't go back and tidy the answers later. The point is a record of where you started, so that in a year you can see what the reading did to you and how much of it belongs to the novel.

WHAT I ALREADY BELIEVE THE BIBLE SAYS, AND WHERE I LEARNED IT

WHAT I'M AFRAID I'LL FIND IN IT

WHAT THE EMPIRE IS FOR, IN ONE SENTENCE I'D DEFEND

WHAT I DON'T YET UNDERSTAND ABOUT MY OWN NOVEL

DECIDED **DATE**

NOTES

ANYTHING THIS SPREAD STARTED AND DID NOT FINISH

I

PART ONE · ✣

Learning the Bible as a Novelist

✣

You can't write about people who've been handed a holy book until you've read what they were handed. Start here, and keep your objections in the margin.

i · What the Bible actually is	014
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OT NT

THE NUMBERS

66 books in the Protestant count · 39 Old, 27 New · Hebrew, Aramaic, Greek · roughly a thousand years of writing · no single author, no single editor, no original title page.

MARGINALIA

✣ *See also:* How it was assembled · Who gets to say what it means, Part IV.

What the Bible actually is

The first thing to understand, and the thing most people who grew up around this book were never told, is that it's a library. Sixty-six separate documents in the Protestant count, written across something like a thousand years, in three languages, by many hands, for audiences who mostly didn't know the other documents existed. Some of it is law written for a small farming people. Some is court history written to support a dynasty. Some is poetry, some is prophecy shouted at a government, and some is letters from a traveling preacher to congregations he was trying to hold together.

The variety is the most useful fact you can hold onto as a novelist, because it means the Bible has an argument going on inside it. Deuteronomy ties faithfulness to flourishing, and Job gives a righteous man catastrophe and lets his friends make the simple version of that argument until it fails. Ezra sends the foreign wives away, and Ruth makes a foreign woman the great-grandmother of the king. Proverbs says wisdom generally pays, and Ecclesiastes says the pattern doesn't hold. Nobody smoothed these out. They sit in the same volume, and every institution that has used this book has had to choose which side of each argument would be the official one. **INTERPRETATION** The choosing is your novel. The Empire doesn't have a Bible problem. It has a Bible strategy, and it's the one scriptural empires have usually used: lift the passages about order, hierarchy and submission into the plain and permanent word of God, and file the passages about jubilee, debt release, foreign widows, prophets who insult kings and a messiah executed by the state under poetry or instructions for another time. Nothing has to be deleted. The canon stays intact and the pulpit still cites chapter and verse. All it takes is a consistent policy about which parts are read aloud, and to whom. So read it as a library with an argument in it. When you meet a passage, the useful question is what it says, which side of the internal argument it's on, who benefits from that side winning, and what it would cost a character to have been raised hearing only one half.

"A canon is the list of things a religion has agreed to keep arguing about."

How it was assembled

No angel delivered a table of contents. The collection you can buy in an airport was assembled slowly, by communities, customs and arguments, over centuries, and the process left visible seams. They're worth knowing about, because your Empire will be running the same process on purpose.

On the Hebrew side the Torah settled first, then the prophetic books, then a looser third group, the Writings, which stayed unsettled for a long time. Some books nearly didn't make it. Esther was questioned partly because God is never named in it. Song of Songs was questioned because it's frankly erotic, and it took a great deal of allegory to make it respectable. Ecclesiastes was questioned because it sounds close to faithless. INTERPRETATION The books that struggled were the ones hardest to use as instruction. On the Christian side the process was slower and messier. For the first centuries there was no fixed New Testament, only a widening pool of gospels, letters and apocalypses circulating unevenly between cities. Lists were proposed, disputed and revised. The four gospels that were kept weren't the only ones written. Revelation was long resisted in the Greek-speaking East, and other apocalypses dropped out entirely. Emperors funded copies and convened councils, and Nicaea in 325 wasn't about the canon. By the time Athanasius listed the twenty-seven books in 367, the shortlist was largely settled, by habit as much as by ruling. Two things follow for TKC. INTERPRETATION Whoever can convene, fund, copy and distribute has outsized influence over which texts stay in circulation. And once a canon closes, the arguing doesn't stop. It moves from which books to which verses. The Empire inherits a closed canon, so it does all its work through emphasis, translation, the calendar of readings and commentary, which is quieter editing and much harder to catch.

WHAT THE EMPIRE WOULD DO WITH THIS

POSSIBLE Never touch the canon. Touch the calendar. Decide which passages are read in public worship, which are kept for clergy, which appear in schoolbooks, and which are never printed in the cheap edition sent out to the Dominions.

BOOKS THAT NEARLY LOST

Esther · Song of Songs · Ecclesiastes · Hebrews · James · 2 Peter · Jude · Revelation

MARGINALIA

✣ *See also:* The canon timeline, ii.3 · Passages kept quiet, Part IV.

GEN–DEUT
JOSH–RUTH
1 SAM–2 CHR
EZRA–ESTH
JOB–SONG
ISA–MAL

The shape of the Old Testament

Thirty-nine books in the Protestant count, and the plot beneath all of them is land: getting it, losing it, and living under someone else's empire on it. Learn the six movements and you'll always know roughly where you're standing.

TORAH · GENESIS TO DEUTERONOMY	Origins, a family, slavery, escape, and a law given in a desert to a people who don't have a country yet. Everything later quotes or argues with these five books.
CONQUEST AND JUDGES · JOSHUA TO RUTH	Taking the land, then failing to hold together. Judges is the most brutal stretch in the collection and ends with a line that works as a political thesis: everyone did what was right in his own eyes, because there was no king. Ruth answers it with a foreigner.
MONARCHY · SAMUEL TO CHRONICLES	A people demand a king, are warned in detail what a king will take, and get one anyway. Dynasty, temple, civil war and succession by murder follow. Chronicles retells the same reigns with some of the embarrassing material left out.
EXILE AND RETURN · EZRA TO ESTHER	The state is destroyed and the population deported, and the survivors work out how to be a people without a country. A partial return, a rebuilt wall, a crisis about foreign wives, and a queen in a foreign court in a book that never names God.
WISDOM AND POETRY · JOB TO SONG OF SONGS	Where the tradition argues with itself most openly: Job accusing God of injustice, a hymnbook that includes rage, orderly proverbs, a book that calls everything vapor, and a love poem.
PROPHETS · ISAIAH TO MALACHI	Mostly political speech to the powerful, about idolatry and about the treatment of the poor, the widow, the foreigner and the worker. Some of it looks ahead. Most of it addresses its own moment. This is the section every empire handles most carefully, and the one your resistance will quote.

CONTESTED

Whether the conquest narratives record history, later national memory, or theology told as narrative is genuinely disputed. Your Empire will read them as precedent for holy war, and your dissidents as a small kingdom explaining itself.

WHICH MOVEMENT THE EMPIRE TEACHES AS ITS OWN STORY

The shape of the New Testament

Twenty-seven documents, all written inside the Roman Empire by members of a movement with no political power, most of them within about seventy years of a public execution. The situation shapes everything, including the parts your Empire will most want to use.

GOSPELS · MATTHEW TO JOHN	Four accounts of one life, and they don't match, which is the most useful thing about them. Mark is urgent and bleak, Matthew argues that this fulfills the Law, Luke keeps putting women and the poor in the frame, and John does high theology. Read side by side, you're watching four communities decide what mattered. See the Gospel Grid in Part III.
ACTS · THE MOVEMENT SPREADS	A small, property-sharing sect argues its way across the Mediterranean, mostly in rented rooms and courtrooms. Again and again it's hosted by women with houses.
PAUL'S LETTERS · ROMANS TO PHILEMON	Occasional letters, and no systematic theology. Each is one side of a conversation with a particular congregation in a particular crisis. Lift a verse out of that and you're quoting an answer while hiding the question.
GENERAL LETTERS · HEBREWS TO JUDE	Written to scattered communities under pressure. James is blunt about the rich, and the letters under Peter's name are about living faithfully without power.
REVELATION · APOCALYPTIC	Resistance literature in symbols, written for believers under an empire that called itself divine. INTERPRETATION Many scholars read the beast as imperial Rome and Babylon as its capital, and the book as a claim that Rome won't last. Read as a timetable for the far future, it loses its first readers. Read as a banned pamphlet, it's the most politically dangerous book in the collection.

> **THE CENTRAL IRONY FOR TKC**
>
> INTERPRETATION Every document here was written by people with no power, about a man the state executed, for readers the state despised. The Empire runs its theology on literature written by the losing side, and the material for its own undoing is bound into the volume it hands out.

THE NEW TESTAMENT BOOK MY EMPIRE WOULD LEAST LIKE A GIRL TO READ FIRST

THE GENRE TEST

Before a character quotes anything at anyone: what kind of writing is this, who was it addressed to, and what does the speaker gain by treating it as a rule?

MARGINALIA

The genres, and why they matter

Reading a poem as a statute is one of the most common ways this book gets turned into a weapon. A lament isn't a doctrine. A proverb is a general pattern that its own collection contradicts elsewhere. Name what you're holding before you decide what it obliges anyone to do.

LAW	Binding instruction for a particular covenant community in a particular economy. Ask who it's addressed to and what it replaced.
NARRATIVE	Stories describe far more than they endorse. The Bible reports polygamy, slavery and massacre without approving them.
POETRY	Compressed, figurative, built on parallel lines. It carries feeling. A great deal of harm done with scripture comes from reading a metaphor flat.
WISDOM	Observed patterns offered as advice, deliberately in tension across books. Proverbs and Ecclesiastes are meant to be read against each other.
PROPHECY	Public address, usually to rulers, usually conditional: change this or the consequence follows. Some of it looks far ahead, and most of it speaks to its own day.
LETTER	One side of a correspondence about a local crisis. Every general rule you pull out of it has a particular quarrel behind it.
GOSPEL	Ancient biography with an argument. Each writer selects, orders and shapes to persuade a particular community.
APOCALYPTIC	Symbolic writing for people under pressure. Its symbols were readable to its first readers and point at the powers of their own day.

✣ *See also:* How to read a passage in context, vii.

Translation, and which one to trust

Every translation is a set of decisions. Someone had to decide whether a Greek word describing a woman in a congregation means servant or deacon, whether an instruction is addressed to wives or to everyone, and whether an ambiguous phrase gets resolved toward hierarchy or toward mutuality. Most of those decisions are honest attempts with a hard word. Some carry theological commitments, and the committees that make them have confessions, funders and readers in mind.

For your purposes the method is simple. Read any passage that matters in at least two translations from different traditions, and when they diverge, stop, because the divergence is where the interesting work is. **POSSIBLE** The Empire lives in that gap. An empire that controls the official edition doesn't need to lie. It only needs to keep choosing the harder rendering, generation after generation, until the gentler reading sounds like a modern invention. Translations sit on a spectrum. Some aim at word-for-word fidelity and read stiffly. Some aim at thought-for-thought clarity and smooth over difficulty. Some are paraphrases with a strong voice. None of these is dishonest by definition, but the smoother the English, the more interpretive decisions have already been made for you out of sight. Chapters and verses aren't original either. They were added centuries later for finding passages, and they've made the whole book quotable in fragments, which is exactly the format a state needs for slogans, wall inscriptions and school recitation.

THE EMPIRE'S EDITION

POSSIBLE Decide early what the Empire's authorized text is, who may own a different one, what has been footnoted into harmlessness, and which single word in the household passages the Temple's authority rests on. A translation dispute is a perfectly good inciting incident.

METHOD

TWO MINIMUM

Two translations from different traditions. Note every divergence. The gap is the material.

MARGINALIA

✣ *See also:* Translation, module vi · the household verse, module ix.

METHOD

JOB 42.7

EPH 5.21–33

How to read a passage in context

Eight questions, in this order, every time. Run them and you'll read better than many people who quote this book professionally, and you'll be able to write clergy who are sophisticated and not merely sinister.

I · WHAT KIND OF TEXT	Name the genre first: law, story, poem, letter, oracle, apocalypse. It decides what kind of claim the passage can make.
II · WHO'S SPEAKING	The narrator, a character, God as quoted by a character, an opponent being paraphrased, or a friend the book will prove wrong. Job's comforters get pages of confident theology that the book itself rejects (42:7).
III · TO WHOM	A named congregation, a king, a nation, an enslaved population, a household. An instruction to the powerful reads very differently when it's turned on the powerless, and that turn is one of the commonest abuses there is.
IV · WHAT COMES BEFORE AND AFTER	Read the paragraph on either side, then the chapter, then skim the book's argument. A verse used as a wall inscription almost always has a sentence beside it that complicates it.
V · WHAT WORLD PRODUCED IT	The economy, the legal status of women and slaves, who owned land, what an honor culture punished. The point is to see what the text was arguing with. Sometimes it's more radical than its setting, and sometimes far less.
VI · WHAT THE WORDS DO	Check a second translation on any word carrying weight. If two respectable versions disagree, you've found a decision and not a fact.
VII · WHO GAINS	Ask it of the passage and of every reading of it, including the ones you like. Interpretations have beneficiaries.
VIII · WHAT IT COSTS	Who has to carry the consequence if this reading is enforced. The answer usually names the character in your novel who lives inside the doctrine.

A PASSAGE I'VE ONLY EVER HEARD WITH QUESTION III SKIPPED

EPH 5.21–33

COL 3.18–4.1

1 PET 2.18–3.7

P46 · VATICANUS

ARISTOTLE, POLITICS I

THE HOUSEHOLD VERSE

A WORKED EXAMPLE

Take the passage scriptural empires have built household law on: the instruction to wives in Ephesians. Run the eight questions and see how much of the standard use depends on stopping early. The full treatment is in module ix.

> *Wives, submit to your own husbands, as to the Lord.*
>
> EPHESIANS 5.22, QUOTED ALONE, AS IT APPEARS ON A WALL

GENRE	A letter to congregations, not a statute.
THE SENTENCE BEFORE	"Submitting to one another out of reverence for Christ" (5:21), addressed to everyone. In some of the earliest manuscripts, P46 and Codex Vaticanus among them, 5:22 has no verb of its own and borrows "submitting" from 5:21. Cut 5:21 and a mutual instruction reads as a one-way command.
THE PASSAGE AFTER	Addressed to husbands and much longer, about 116 Greek words to the wives' 40 by one count. Husbands are told to love three times and to give themselves up as Christ did. They're never told to rule, enforce or correct.
THE WORLD	Household codes were a known form. Aristotle's ran master over slave, husband over wife, father over children. Ephesians speaks to wives, children and slaves as moral agents and gives the stronger party duties. **INTERPRETATION** Read against its setting, it modifies an existing hierarchy. An empire that wants it timeless has to keep the setting out of view.
THE WORDS	**CONTESTED** Whether "head" (*kephalē*) means authority, source or prominence. The verb *hypotassō* means to arrange oneself under, and how much weight its middle voice can bear is argued.
WHO GAINS	Whoever is allowed to quote the fragment and forbidden to read the frame.

What the fragment is for

EPH 5.21–33

MODULE IX

WHAT THE EMPIRE DOES

POSSIBLE Prints the fragment, leaves out the mutual line, shortens the husbands' section in the Dominion edition, and sets the whole thing to music so children learn it before they read it.

WHAT THIS GIVES TKC

POSSIBLE A scene where a character reads the missing line for the first time. It's a revelation about editing, which is worse than a revelation about God, because it means somebody chose.

WHERE MY NOVEL PRINTS THE FRAGMENT, AND WHERE IT PRINTS THE FRAME

FAULT LINES

MODULE VIII

Contested readings

These are the fault lines. Each has been argued in good faith for centuries by people who know the languages, and no amount of reading settles them. **POSSIBLE** For the novel they're gifts. A doctrine the Empire has closed is a doctrine still quietly open somewhere in the Empire, and every one of these is a possible conflict between characters.

HEADSHIP

Whether the household passages set a permanent order of authority or address one culture's arrangements. Both readings have long histories, and neither is fringe.

SLAVERY

Whether the letters accommodate an existing institution, quietly undermine it, or endorse it. Both sides of the American abolition fight quoted scripture fluently.

OBEDIENCE TO RULERS

Romans 13 says authorities are appointed by God. The same collection is full of prophets defying kings and apostles refusing magistrates.

PURITY AND THE BODY

Which purity laws were ritual, which moral, which binding, and who decides. The line drawn here sets what your Empire can regulate about a woman's body and call faith.

WOMEN SPEAKING

One letter silences women in assembly, and the same author greets women leading congregations and names one an apostle. How those fit is a live dispute.

DIVINE VIOLENCE

Whether the conquest commands are history, rhetoric, or a later people's theology of their own past. Holy war in your novel rests on which answer the Empire teaches.

WEALTH

Whether prosperity signals blessing or is itself the danger. Deuteronomy and the prophets pull in opposite directions, and a ruling class finds the first easier to preach.

THE END OF THINGS

Whether apocalyptic language describes a coming event, a present reality, or a verdict on a particular empire. A state that teaches the first can promise anything.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH SIDE THE EMPIRE TEACHES, AND WHO IN MY NOVEL DISAGREES

NOTES

ANYTHING THIS SPREAD STARTED AND DID NOT FINISH

I–II

MODULES

What It Is How It Came Together

The library, its four collections, and the thousand years it took to decide what was in it

TEN PAGES

INFORMATION

CANON

TANAKH · LXX

I.1

What the Bible actually is

A library, not a book. Sixty-six documents in the Protestant collection this companion starts from, written across roughly a thousand years, in three languages, by people who didn't know they were contributing to the same volume, and who sometimes argued with each other.

WHICH BIBLE THIS COMPANION USES, AND WHY THAT NEEDS SAYING

We start with the sixty-six-book Protestant canon, because it's the Bible in the room where you were raised and the Bible the Empire inherited. It isn't the only one. Jewish tradition holds twenty-four books in three divisions and doesn't arrange them as an Old Testament. Catholic Bibles include the deuterocanonical books. Orthodox collections include those and more, and differ among themselves, and the Ethiopian Orthodox canon is the largest of all. The shape of the collection is itself an argument about what scripture is for.

THE INTERNAL CONVERSATIONS

THE TENSION	WHAT'S ACTUALLY IN DISPUTE
DEUTERONOMY AND JOB	Deuteronomy ties covenant faithfulness to flourishing. Job gives a righteous man catastrophe and lets his friends make the simple version of that argument until it fails. The dispute is over retribution used as a rule.
EZRA AND RUTH	Ezra–Nehemiah dissolves foreign marriages as restoration policy. Ruth makes a Moabite woman David's great-grandmother. Two answers to the same question about who belongs.
PROVERBS AND ECCLESIASTES	Proverbs teaches that wisdom can be learned and generally pays. Ecclesiastes watches the same world and reports that the pattern doesn't hold.
COURT AND PROPHET	The court histories tell kingship from inside the palace. The prophets address the same kings from outside, about the poor, the widow, the foreigner and the worker, and also about idolatry, false worship and foreign alliances.

THE WORKING LENS

INTERPRETATION The Bible holds many voices, priestly and prophetic, royal and exilic, addressing different crises. Read these as tensions inside one tradition, not as authors calling each other liars. When a character quotes scripture as if it has one settled opinion, that character is making a choice worth writing about.

Four collections

TANAKH
LXX
TRENT 1546
ETHIOPIAN CANON

The same core, different edges, a different order, and the order is an argument. Where a collection ends tells you what it thinks the story is about.

COLLECTION	BOOKS	HOW IT'S ARRANGED	WHERE IT ENDS
Tanakh (Jewish)	24	Torah, Prophets (Nevi'im), Writings (Ketuvim). A complete scripture, not an "Old Testament."	Chronicles, with Cyrus's decree to go up and rebuild. The story closes on return.
Protestant	66	39 Old Testament books (the Tanakh's books, counted and ordered differently, with the Prophets moved to the end) and 27 New	Malachi, then Revelation. The Hebrew scriptures end on a promise, which frames them as a prologue.
Catholic	73	Adds the deuterocanonical books: Tobit, Judith, Wisdom, Sirach, Baruch, 1–2 Maccabees, and additions to Esther and Daniel	Includes the Maccabean revolt, armed resistance to an empire that outlawed the faith
Orthodox	76 or more	Varies by communion. Greek, Slavonic and Ethiopian traditions differ from each other and from Rome.	No single answer. Canon has never been uniform worldwide.

CORRECTION TO THE OLD COMPANION It gave the Protestant New Testament twenty-eight books. It has twenty-seven.

FOUR WORDS THAT AREN'T SYNONYMS

Canon is which books are in. **Translation** is which words render them. **Edition** is which notes, headings and apparatus surround them. **Lectionary** is which passages get read aloud, and when. An empire that can't change the canon can still change the other three, and the lectionary is the cheapest.

WHAT THE EMPIRE WOULD DO WITH THIS PAGE

POSSIBLE Never print it. A citizen who knows there are four collections knows there was a decision, and a citizen who knows there was a decision asks who made it. The Empire's Bible has to feel like weather, not legislation.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH COLLECTION IS THE EMPIRE'S OFFICIAL BIBLE, AND WHAT IT LEAVES OUT ON PURPOSE

WHAT YOU BROUGHT TO IT

YOURS

BASELINE

Answer these before the research goes further. They're a baseline, so later discoveries can be measured against something real and not against a memory that has quietly revised itself.

WHAT I THOUGHT THE BIBLE WAS BEFORE THIS PAGE

WHICH CANON OR EDITION I GREW UP AROUND: THE TRANSLATION, THE COVER, WHOSE COPY IT WAS

WHAT I WAS NEVER TOLD ABOUT HOW IT'S ORGANIZED

WHAT THIS CHANGES ABOUT THE EMPIRE'S OFFICIAL BIBLE

☐ POSSIBLE ☐ OPEN QUESTION ☐ DECIDED

LOG NO. _____ DATE _____

YOURS

PRACTICE

Run one tension yourself

Take one of the four conversations, or find your own, and work it. The point isn't to resolve it. The point is to be able to say exactly what's in dispute, which is the skill this whole part exists to build.

THE TENSION I'M WORKING

PASSAGES ON EACH SIDE

WHAT'S ACTUALLY IN DISPUTE, IN ONE SENTENCE, WITHOUT TAKING A SIDE

WHO GAINS FROM EACH READING

WHICH SIDE THE EMPIRE PRINTS, AND WHICH SIDE IT LETS PEOPLE SING

WHICH CHARACTER IS ON WHICH SIDE, AND WHETHER SHE KNOWS THERE IS A SIDE

Nothing written on this page is canon until it's logged. A discovery is a discovery, and a possibility isn't canon.

How it was assembled

INFORMATION

IRENAEUS, AGAINST HERESIES 3.11

NICAEA 325

I.2

There was never a room where the Bible was decided. It's the most useful thing to know about it and the hardest to hold onto, because a room would be easier to write about, and every empire in the book would prefer you believed in one.

USE CAME FIRST, RECOGNITION SECOND

Communities read, copied, argued over and prayed with these texts for generations before anyone published a list. Lists, when they came, mostly ratified habits already formed, and the habits were local.

FOUR GOSPELS, AND WHAT THAT MEANS

Other gospels existed and circulated. The four in the canon were the ones most widely read, earliest, across the most communities, and treated as apostolic in origin. Irenaeus was arguing for exactly four by about 180, which shows the number was contested enough to need defending. Calling them the gospels that "won" makes it sound like a vote. It was closer to a consensus hardening around what was already in use, with the theological arguments running alongside.

WHO ACTUALLY HELD THE AUTHORITY

Bishops wrote lists. Councils confirmed regional practice more often than they created it. Emperors funded copies, convened meetings and made some outcomes safer to hold than others. Constantine's role at Nicaea in 325 was real, and Nicaea wasn't about the canon. Local use was the slow current under all of it. Canon formation was a long negotiation among all four, and the balance shifted by century and region.

THE CLAIM WORTH KEEPING, STATED CAREFULLY

INTERPRETATION "Whoever can convene the meeting decides the canon" is too absolute, and it credits meetings with more than they did. What holds is that the people who could convene, fund, copy and distribute had outsized influence over which texts stayed in circulation, and circulation is most of what canon means in practice.

WHY THIS SEQUENCE IS SIX PAGES AND NOT ONE

POSSIBLE The Empire's account of its own Bible will be exactly one page long, and a single page can only give the compressed version.

NEH 8

SIRACH PROLOGUE

LXX

DEAD SEA SCROLLS 1947–1956

Torah, Prophets, Writings

Three divisions, settling at different times. The order they settled in is itself information: the most authoritative material stabilized first, and the edges were still being discussed centuries later.

DIVISION	ROUGHLY WHEN	WHAT WAS HAPPENING
TORAH	By the Persian period, about the fifth century BCE	Working as authoritative law for the restored community. Public reading is already an institution, and Nehemiah 8 shows the practice.
PROPHETS	Later, gradually	The Former and Latter Prophets circulate as a recognized body. By the second century BCE a writer can refer to "the law and the prophets" as a known pair.
WRITINGS	Last to settle	The loose end. Psalms and Proverbs uncontroversial. Esther, Ecclesiastes and Song of Songs still discussed in the rabbinic period.
SEPTUAGINT	Third century BCE onward	The Greek translation for Greek-speaking Jews, begun in Alexandria, with a wider and looser collection. Most New Testament writers quote it, which is why the Christian Old Testament inherited a different shape.

EARLY CHRISTIAN USE OF JEWISH SCRIPTURE

The first Christians had no New Testament. They had Israel's scriptures, read as testimony about what had just happened to them, which is a reading strategy and not a neutral inheritance. Every appeal to prophecy in the gospels is that strategy at work in public.

THE DEAD SEA SCROLLS, IN ONE PARAGRAPH

A library hidden near Qumran and found between 1947 and 1956, with biblical manuscripts about a thousand years older than the standard medieval Hebrew codices. They show a text remarkably stable in most places and genuinely variable in others, which corrects both the idea that the Hebrew Bible never changed and the idea that it was rewritten wholesale.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH DIVISION THE EMPIRE WOULD TEACH CHILDREN FIRST, AND WHICH IT WOULD SAVE FOR CLERGY

ATHANASIUS, FESTAL LETTER 39 (367)

HIPPO 393 · CARTHAGE 397

TRENT 1546

LANGTON · ESTIENNE 1551

A THOUSAND YEARS OF DECIDING

Approximate throughout, and contested in places, since dates in this field are arguments and not measurements. What the shape shows is that there was no single moment, and a very long tail.

WHEN	WHAT MOVED
ABOUT THE 5TH CENTURY BCE	The Torah working as authoritative law in the restored Judean community
3RD TO 1ST CENTURY BCE	The Septuagint translated in Alexandria. The Prophets recognized as a body. Wisdom and apocalyptic writing flourish.
ABOUT 50–60 CE	Paul's letters, the earliest New Testament documents, written to particular congregations before any gospel
ABOUT 70–100 CE	The gospels, written after the Temple's destruction in 70. The institution at the center of the story is already rubble when they're written.
2ND CENTURY	Marcion publishes a deliberately reduced collection, and the reaction sharpens everyone's sense that the boundary matters. Irenaeus argues for four gospels.
DATE DISPUTED	The Muratorian fragment lists much of what becomes the New Testament and leaves some out. **CONTESTED** Most date it to the late second century, a minority to the fourth.
3RD–4TH CENTURY	Eusebius sorts books into accepted, disputed and rejected, a working scholar's triage. Athanasius lists the twenty-seven books in 367.
LATE 4TH CENTURY	Councils at Hippo and Carthage in North Africa affirm lists close to today's. Jerome makes the Latin Vulgate and flags books he considers secondary, a distinction Rome didn't adopt.
MIDDLE AGES	Stable practice in the West. Eastern churches settle differently and not uniformly. Chapter divisions added in the thirteenth century, usually credited to Stephen Langton.
16TH CENTURY	Reformers separate or drop the deuterocanonical books, and Trent affirms them (1546). Robert Estienne's verse numbers (1551). Printing makes a household Bible possible, and a standardized one enforceable.
19TH–20TH CENTURY	Older manuscripts recovered, critical editions built, translations multiply. The text you can buy today rests on more evidence than any earlier century had.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

THE DATE ON THIS TIMELINE THE EMPIRE WOULD TEACH AS THE MOMENT THE BIBLE WAS FINISHED

MEGILLAH 7A

YADAYIM 3.5

EUSEBIUS, H.E. 3.25

LUTHER 1522

The ones they argued about

The tempting theory is that the disputed books were the ones hardest to preach from. It's too tidy. The recorded objections are usually about authorship, origin or particular content, and each book has its own reason. Read the right column as the reasons actually given.

BOOK	STATUS	WHAT THE OBJECTION WAS
ESTHER	Discussed	The Hebrew text never names God, and its festival, Purim, isn't in the Torah. It was received anyway, and the Greek version adds explicitly religious material.
SONG OF SONGS	Discussed	Explicit love poetry with no overt theology. Allegory (God and Israel, Christ and the church) became the standard defense, and it remains a reading.
ECCLESIASTES	Discussed	Its conclusions sit awkwardly beside the rest of wisdom literature. Many scholars read its closing verses as a later frame.
HEBREWS	Disputed	Anonymous. The West accepted it more slowly because Pauline authorship couldn't be shown, and nearly all scholars now agree Paul didn't write it.
JAMES	Disputed	Slow to circulate, and later a Reformation flashpoint over faith and works. Luther placed it at the back of his 1522 New Testament. It stayed in.
2 PETER	Disputed	The most doubted New Testament book in antiquity, on grounds of style and attribution. Its authorship is still a live question.
JUDE	Disputed	Quotes 1 Enoch, a book outside the canon it ended up in
REVELATION	Disputed	Accepted in the West, long resisted in the Greek East. It's scripture for the Orthodox churches and still isn't read aloud in their liturgy.

THE LAST ROW IS THE ONE TO STEAL

POSSIBLE A book can be fully canonical and never read aloud. It's a real historical arrangement and the most elegant instrument on this page. The Empire never has to ban anything.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH BOOKS ARE IN THE EMPIRE'S BIBLE AND NEVER IN ITS READINGS

APPLICATION

TKC: TR · CR · DR3

FR 33

Six instruments

The Empire doesn't need to change a word of the canon. Each instrument below is documented somewhere in history, and none requires editing scripture. Rank them by what the Empire would reach for first.

I · THE CALENDAR · RANK ___	Which feasts exist, which are civic, which are quietly dropped. A calendar decides what a population rehearses every year, and a holiday nobody keeps is a doctrine nobody remembers.
II · THE PUBLIC READINGS · RANK ___	The lectionary, the cheapest and strongest instrument here. For most people, scripture is what gets read aloud. The rest of the book is technically available and functionally silent.
III · CLERGY ACCESS · RANK ___	Who is trained, in what, and who may teach it. Control the training and you don't have to control the pulpit. **POSSIBLE** The Prelate's assessment team is this instrument with a person's name on it. The Prelate's working name is Prelate Aurelia (**FR 33**).
IV · THE SCHOOLBOOKS · RANK ___	Which stories children learn as stories, and in what order. The slowest instrument and the only one that compounds. A generation taught one shape of the book hears anything else as novelty.
V · DOMINION EDITIONS · RANK ___	Same canon, different apparatus, Dominion by Dominion. Headings, footnotes, cross-references and study notes do most of the interpretive work in any Bible a citizen owns, and none of it is scripture.
VI · COMMENTARY AND EMPHASIS · RANK ___	What the Broadcast says a passage means, repeated until the gloss can't be separated from the verse. The only instrument that works backward on people who already own the book.

WHICH INSTRUMENT THE EMPIRE USED FIRST, AND WHICH ONE IT'S STILL AFRAID TO USE

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH INSTRUMENT THE EMPIRE USED FIRST, AND WHICH ONE IT'S STILL AFRAID TO USE

YOURS

WRITING

The Empire's own account

Write the Empire's version of this sequence, one page long, the way a Dominion schoolbook would tell it. Afterward, write what it left out. The gap between the two is a doctrine, and doctrines have authors.

THE EMPIRE'S ACCOUNT OF HOW ITS BIBLE CAME TO BE, IN THE VOICE OF A SCHOOLBOOK

WHAT IT LEAVES OUT, AND WHO WOULD BE DANGEROUS IF THEY KNEW IT

WHICH CHARACTER FINDS THE GAP FIRST, AND IN WHAT DOCUMENT

☐ POSSIBLE ☐ OPEN QUESTION ☐ DECIDED

LOG NO. _____ DATE _____

III–V

MODULES

Genres and the Two Testaments

What each kind of writing can and can't establish, and the shape of each half of the collection

FOURTEEN PAGES

INFORMATION

I.3

Eight genres

Genre determines what a passage is capable of establishing, and misreading it is the most common way a sincere reader reaches a confident wrong answer.

GENRE	WHAT IT'S TRYING TO DO	WHAT IT CAN'T ESTABLISH
LAW	Set a community's obligations, ritual, civil and moral, usually without separating them	Timeless policy. Legal codes address one society's cases.
NARRATIVE	Tell what happened, shaped for a purpose. It often reports behavior without endorsing it.	Approval. A story about polygamy isn't an argument for it.
POETRY	Make something felt, through image, parallel lines and intensity	Doctrine built on a metaphor read literally
WISDOM	Teach how the world generally works, and in Job and Ecclesiastes, how often it doesn't	Promises. A proverb is a pattern, not a guarantee.
PROPHECY	Deliver a message from God to a particular people at a particular moment: indictment, warning, consolation, sometimes prediction. Worship, idolatry and the character of God run throughout.	A calendar. Most prophecy speaks to its own audience's present, though some looks ahead and later readers read it forward.
GOSPEL	Present a life so the hearer has to reckon with it. Ancient biography with a purpose.	A transcript. Selection and arrangement are part of the form.
LETTER	Address a live situation in a named community, often with sustained theological argument	Rules without context. You're reading one side of a conversation.
APOCALYPTIC	Reveal what's really happening behind visible power, in symbols, for people who can't say it plainly	Forecasts of technology. Its symbols were readable to its first audience.

> **WHAT GENRE ERROR COSTS**
>
> Flattening a metaphor into a rule, or a story into an endorsement, has done real harm and still does. It's one mechanism among several, beside deliberate misuse, selective quotation and institutional interest, and it's worth naming exactly instead of blaming it for everything.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

THE GENRE I WAS TAUGHT TO READ WRONG

MATT 1

PS 88

LUKE 15

ISA 13–23

Forms inside the forms

Eight genres is the map. These are the units a passage is actually built from, and naming the unit usually settles what it can be used for.

GENEALOGY	A claim about belonging and legitimacy. Who's included is the argument. Matthew's four women are the point of Matthew's list.
LAMENT	Structured complaint, often addressed to God and often unresolved. Its place in the canon makes protest a sanctioned form of prayer.
HYMN	Communal praise, often older than the book it sits in, and often quoted because it was already familiar.
PROVERB	A compressed observation. Reliable as a pattern, dangerous as a promise, and cruel as a rebuke to someone suffering.
PARABLE	A story built to move the hearer. It usually turns on one hinge, and allegorizing every detail is how it gets defused.
ORACLE	A delivered message with a named addressee, often a foreign nation. Reading an oracle addressed to Babylon as addressed to you is a category error with a long history.
LEGAL CODE	Case law with penalties, comparable to other ancient Near Eastern codes. Comparison is where the distinctive parts show.
COURT HISTORY	A record written near power. Ask who commissioned it and what it leaves out.

THE GENRE TEST, BEFORE QUOTING ANYTHING

1. What kind of writing is this?
2. What is this kind of writing for?
3. What can it establish?
4. What can't it establish?
5. Am I using it for the thing it can do?
6. If not, is the misuse mine, or my character's?

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

THE GENRE THE EMPIRE MISREADS ON PURPOSE, AND THE ONE IT MISREADS SINCERELY

TEMPLATE

ONE BLANK SPREAD PER GENRE

PHOTOCOPY BEFORE FILLING

GENRE: _____

WHAT THIS GENRE IS

WHAT IT'S TRYING TO DO

WHAT IT CAN ESTABLISH

WHAT IT CAN'T

THREE EXAMPLES, WITH REFERENCES

THE PASSAGE I'M PRACTICING ON

What the Empire does with it

HOW THE EMPIRE COULD MISUSE THIS GENRE: THE EXACT MECHANISM

WHO IN THE EMPIRE BENEFITS, AND WHO PAYS

WHICH CHARACTER READS THIS GENRE CORRECTLY, AND WHAT IT COSTS HER

MY QUESTIONS ABOUT THIS GENRE

WHAT I NEED TO RESEARCH BEFORE I WRITE THIS INTO A SCENE

☐ POSSIBLE ☐ OPEN QUESTION ☐ DECIDED

LOG NO. _____ DATE _____

INFORMATION

GEN–MAL

Six movements

An orientation, not a summary. The collection isn't arranged as one story, and these movements overlap, double back, and in places disagree about what happened.

MOVEMENT	WHAT IT'S ABOUT	THE QUESTION IT LEAVES OPEN
BEGINNINGS · GENESIS 1–11	Creation, rupture, flood and the scattering of peoples. Two creation accounts sit side by side, never reconciled.	Whether human power over others is part of the design or part of the damage
THE FAMILIES · GENESIS 12–50	A promise attached to one household and carried through four generations of deception, infertility, favoritism and migration	Why the promise keeps passing through the person who shouldn't have received it
EXODUS AND LAW · EXODUS–DEUTERONOMY	Liberation from imperial forced labor, forty years of learning to be a people, and a law given before the land is entered	Whether a people freed from empire can make law without reproducing it
LAND AND KINGS · JOSHUA–KINGS	Settlement, tribal instability, the demand for a king, David's house, two kingdoms and the slow loss of both	Whether monarchy was a concession, a failure or the plan
EXILE AND RETURN · EZRA, NEHEMIAH, CHRONICLES	Deportation, survival under foreign rule, partial return, rebuilding and a fierce argument about who belongs	Who counts, who's dissolved out of the community, and who writes the record
WISDOM AND PROPHECY · ACROSS THE COLLECTION	Two bodies of writing that comment on all the rest, one asking how to live well, one indicting how power behaves	Whether either one ever changed anything

THIS COMPANION'S LENS, DECLARED

INTERPRETATION Land runs through most of these movements: possession, loss, return, and who may hold it. It's a real and recurring concern of the collection. Reading the whole Old Testament as fundamentally about land is this companion's working lens, chosen because the Empire is a land empire. It isn't a neutral description of the material.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH MOVEMENT MY NOVEL IS SECRETLY RETELLING

2 CHR 36.23

MAL 4.5–6

2 KGS 17

2 KGS 25

WHERE THE STORY STOPS

The same books in two sequences, with two different endings, and so two different claims about what the collection is doing.

TANAKH ORDER

Torah, then Prophets, then Writings, closing with Chronicles and Cyrus's decree to go up and rebuild. It ends on return. **INTERPRETATION** The arc is instruction, then the record of failing it, then the literature of living with that, and the last word is permission to go home.

CHRISTIAN OLD TESTAMENT ORDER

Law, history, poetry, prophets, closing with Malachi and a promise of Elijah's return. It ends on anticipation. **INTERPRETATION** Resequenced this way, the collection reads as unfinished, which makes a New Testament feel like a continuation.

A ROUGH HISTORICAL SPINE

WHEN	WHAT HAPPENED
ABOUT 1000 BCE	The united monarchy of the biblical narrative, David and Solomon. **CONTESTED** Its scale is actively debated by archaeologists.
ABOUT 930 BCE	Division into Israel in the north and Judah in the south. Two kingdoms, two records, one collection.
722 BCE	Assyria destroys the northern kingdom. Deportation and dispersal.
587/586 BCE	Babylon destroys Jerusalem and the Temple and deports the elite. Much of the collection is written, edited or compiled in the shadow of this.
539 BCE	Persia takes Babylon, and return is permitted. Restoration is partial, contested and run under imperial authority.
332–63 BCE	Greek, then Roman, rule. Apocalyptic writing develops under occupation.

WHICH ORDERING THE EMPIRE PRINTS, AND WHAT ENDING IT NEEDS ITS CITIZENS TO EXPECT

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH ORDERING THE EMPIRE PRINTS, AND WHAT ENDING IT NEEDS ITS CITIZENS TO EXPECT

JUDG 21.25

1 SAM 8

RUTH 4

1–2 CHR

Say it more carefully

Four claims worth keeping, restated so they survive contact with someone who knows the material. The memorable version is on the left and the defensible version on the right, and the difference between them is the discipline of this companion.

THE MEMORABLE VERSION	WHAT'S ACTUALLY DEFENSIBLE
Judges says there was no king, so the book wants one.	The refrain, everyone doing what was right in his own eyes because there was no king, sits in a collection that's divided about monarchy. Samuel records the demand for a king as a rejection of God and lists what a king will take. Judges names the cost of no central authority without settling the argument.
Ruth answers it quietly.	INTERPRETATION A good reading. A Moabite woman's loyalty placed in David's genealogy reads as a counterargument to exclusion. The book doesn't announce itself as a rebuttal, and it can't be dated closely enough to prove intent.
Chronicles is the first act of imperial editing in the book itself.	Too confident. Chronicles retells Samuel and Kings with visible selection, David's worst material largely absent and worship in the foreground. It's an excellent case of a community re-telling its past for present purposes. Calling it the first, or imperial, overstates what can be shown.
The prophets are about how power treats the poor.	They're substantially about that, and reducing them to it loses most of the material: idolatry and false worship, foreign alliances, neighboring nations, ritual, exile and consolation, and the character of God. Keep the social indictment central without letting it become the whole subject.

> **WHY THIS PAGE EXISTS**
>
> A character who makes the left-hand claim can be brilliant and still wrong, and that's useful. A companion that makes it is unreliable, and in two years you won't be able to tell which of your own pages to trust.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH CHARACTER MAKES THE LEFT-COLUMN ARGUMENT, AND WHO CORRECTS HER

Nine threads

One line each, in your own words: what the collection actually does with each thread, and not what you were taught it does.

LAND

LAW

MONARCHY

EXILE

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WOMEN

Nine threads, continued

COVENANT

EMPIRE

THE TEMPLE

WHO WRITES THE RECORD

Which movements are TKC

YOURS

TKC

Some movements don't belong in the novel. Mark the ones that do, and be specific about what they're doing there. A movement you can't give a job to is research, not material.

MOVEMENT	IN TKC?	DOING WHAT, AND FOR WHOM
Beginnings		
The families		
Exodus and law		
Land and kings		
Exile and return		
Wisdom and prophecy		

THE ONE MOVEMENT THE EMPIRE IS BUILT ON WITHOUT SAYING SO

WHAT I STILL DON'T UNDERSTAND ABOUT THIS COLLECTION

☐ POSSIBLE ☐ OPEN QUESTION ☐ DECIDED

LOG NO. _____ DATE _____

INFORMATION

ROMAN JUDEA

ACTS 2.44–45

Twenty-seven documents

Written across roughly a century by a movement inside the Roman Empire that had no state power. It wasn't powerless in every sense, and its social position varied by city, decade and class.

THE FIVE KINDS OF DOCUMENT

GOSPELS · 4	Narrative accounts of Jesus, written decades after the events, each for a particular community with particular concerns
ACTS · 1	The movement's spread from Jerusalem outward, by the author of Luke, as the second volume of one work
PAULINE LETTERS · 13	Letters to particular congregations about particular problems. Several contain sustained theological argument, and Romans is a worked case.
GENERAL LETTERS · 8	Hebrews and the letters attributed to James, Peter, John and Jude, for wider audiences and varied purposes
APOCALYPSE · 1	Revelation, a genre with its own conventions

COMPOSITION ORDER ISN'T CANONICAL ORDER

Paul's letters come first in time, written in the 50s before any gospel existed. The collection opens with the gospels because it's arranged as a story and not as an archive. Read in the order written, it shows a movement working out what it believed before anyone had written down the life it believed about.

THE ROMAN SETTING, WITHOUT FLATTENING IT

Occupation, client kings, taxation, crucifixion as public policy, the imperial cult, and a legal status for the movement that changed by place and period. It was tolerated in some cities, prosecuted in others, and not systematically outlawed across the empire for most of this century. Acts shows shared property in Jerusalem specifically, and Paul's letters show congregations with property, patrons and households.

> **FOR TKC**
>
> INTERPRETATION The useful fact isn't that the early movement was poor or illegal. A religion born under an empire was later administered by one, and the same texts served both.

Four accounts, one subject

They differ in selection, arrangement, emphasis and detail, and the differences are the most informative thing about them, because each shows what a particular community needed the story to do.

GOSPEL	ABOUT	WHAT IT EMPHASIZES	WHERE IT BEGINS
MARK	65–75	Urgency, secrecy, suffering. Shortest, probably earliest, and the source most scholars think Matthew and Luke used.	An adult at the river. No birth story.
MATTHEW	80–90	Fulfillment of Israel's scriptures, teaching in five great blocks, a new Moses. Written for a community deeply engaged with Jewish law.	A genealogy with four women in it, one of them Ruth
LUKE	80–95	The poor, women, outsiders and reversal, the powerful pulled down and the hungry filled. Volume one of two.	Two pregnancies and a song about thrones being emptied
JOHN	90–110	Identity and glory. Long discourses, no parables of the familiar kind, a different chronology and mostly its own material.	Before creation

WHY FOUR MATTERS FOR A NOVELIST

The canon keeps four versions instead of harmonizing them into one, and that decision shows on every page. INTERPRETATION An empire that wanted one official account had four to choose from and couldn't quietly reduce them, so the next best thing was deciding which one is read at which festival.

ACTS, AND WHAT IT'S DOING

A narrative of expansion from Jerusalem to Rome, shaped to show the movement's legitimacy and reach. Where Acts and Paul's own letters describe the same events they don't always agree, and historians treat the gap as real.

MARK
MATT
LUKE
JOHN
PART III, THE GOSPEL GRID

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH GOSPEL THE EMPIRE READS ALOUD MOST, AND WHICH ONE IT WOULD RATHER NOT

Who wrote what

ROM 16

1 COR 14.34–35

EPH 5

COL 3

1 TIM 2.11–15

Authorship is a scholarly question, not a settled fact, and the distinctions matter for TKC, because the letters most often quoted about households and women's silence are among those whose authorship is most disputed.

GROUP	SCHOLARLY VIEW	WHY IT MATTERS HERE
UNDISPUTED PAUL · ROM, 1–2 COR, GAL, PHIL, 1 THESS, PHLM	Broad agreement	Here Paul names women as coworkers, a deacon and an apostle. **CONTESTED** 1 Corinthians 14:34–35, the silence passage, sits in an undisputed letter, and some manuscripts place it after 14:40, so many scholars think it was added later.
DISPUTED PAUL · EPH, COL, 2 THESS	Genuinely divided	Ephesians and Colossians carry the household codes. Whether Paul wrote them changes what "the same author" can be claimed to mean.
PASTORALS · 1–2 TIM, TITUS	Most critical scholars: later	The strictest instructions about women teaching are here. Say "the Pauline letters" and not "Paul" when arguing across this line.
HEBREWS	Anonymous	By near consensus, it isn't Paul's. A sustained argument about priesthood and sacrifice, directly useful to any state that runs a temple.
OTHER ATTRIBUTED LETTERS · JAS, 1–2 PET, 1–3 JN, JUDE	Varies. 2 Peter most doubted.	Attributing a letter to a famous name was a convention with a range of practices, so flatly asserting or denying authorship is equally unsafe.

THE SENTENCE TO KEEP

INTERPRETATION Several of the passages that restrict women most come from letters whose authorship, or whose placement in the text, is most in question. **POSSIBLE** The Empire would never mention it, because the instruction's authority rests on the name attached.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH LETTERS THE EMPIRE BUILT ITS HOUSEHOLD LAW ON, AND WHO IN THE EMPIRE KNOWS THE AUTHORSHIP PROBLEM

Four ways to read it

All four are held by serious readers. This companion leans toward the first, and it's still a framework and not a fact about the text. In TKC the reading a character holds is a political position.

I · Resistance literature against Rome

Written for congregations under imperial pressure, using the conventions of apocalyptic to say what couldn't be said plainly. Strong internal support: seven cities, the imperial cult, a city on seven hills, a luxury economy described with contempt. Most historical-critical scholarship works here.

II · A sequence of future events

Read as a program of things still to come. Widely held in popular and some confessional traditions, with enormous cultural influence and a long record of specific predictions failing, which is part of the material too.

III · A cycle, not a timeline

The visions as recurring patterns of empire, judgment and endurance. Explains the repetition, seals, trumpets and bowls covering the same ground three times, better than a sequential reading does.

IV · Liturgy and vision

The book as worship: hymns, thrones, incense and a heavenly assembly, meant to reorder what the hearer thinks is ultimately in charge. The Eastern churches' reluctance to read it aloud sits oddly beside this, and both facts are true.

The two identifications everyone makes

INTERPRETATION The beast as an imperial power and the woman on the beast as a capital city are the readings the evidence best supports, and they're readings. What's nearly beyond argument is narrower: the book's targets are political and economic, and it expects its audience to recognize them.

REV 13

REV 17–18

REV 4–5

EASTERN LECTIONARY

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH READING IS OFFICIAL IN THE EMPIRE, AND WHICH ONE GETS SOMEONE ARRESTED

A RELIGION BORN UNDER EMPIRE

YOURS

WRITING

The New Testament was written by people with no state power. The Empire is a state that runs on it. Work the distance between those two sentences.

WHICH PASSAGES BECOME EASIER TO USE ONCE YOU HOLD POWER, AND WHY

WHICH ONES BECOME EMBARRASSING, AND HOW THE EMPIRE HANDLES THEM

THE VERSE EDEN WAS TAUGHT AS COMFORT AND LATER READS AS INSTRUCTION

☐ POSSIBLE ☐ OPEN QUESTION ☐ DECIDED

LOG NO. _____ DATE _____

NOTES

ANYTHING THIS SPREAD STARTED AND DID NOT FINISH

VI–IX

MODULES

Translation, Context, Fault Lines

How translation decisions get made, the eight questions, the four kinds of disagreement, and the household verse worked all the way through

EIGHTEEN PAGES

INFORMATION

MASORETES

NA28 · UBS5

I.4

Translation, and how to compare it

The old title asked which translation to trust. It's the wrong question, because it implies one exists that never needs checking. The goal is to understand how translation decisions get made, so you can see one being made and say what it did.

THREE LANGUAGES

HEBREW	Most of the Old Testament. Written originally without vowels. The vowel points were added centuries later by the Masoretes, scribes preserving how the text was read aloud, so a consonantal text can sometimes be voiced more than one way, and where it can, translators choose.
ARAMAIC	Parts of Daniel and Ezra, and the everyday speech of Judea in the first century. Jesus taught in it, and the gospels record him in Greek.
GREEK	The New Testament, in Koine, the common Greek of the eastern Mediterranean. It isn't uniform: Mark's is rough and Hebrews' is polished. Translations that flatten every book to one register lose that.

MANUSCRIPTS AND VARIANTS

No original of any biblical book survives. What exists is thousands of copies, and they differ, overwhelmingly in spelling, word order and obvious slips, and occasionally in something substantive. Textual criticism reconstructs the earliest recoverable text from that evidence. A few famous passages are missing from the earliest manuscripts, and reputable Bibles say so in a footnote: the longer ending of Mark (16:9–20), the woman caught in adultery (John 7:53–8:11), and the Trinitarian clause in 1 John 5:7–8.

WHERE DIFFERENCES ACTUALLY COME FROM

Most differences between translations aren't ideological. They come from a genuinely ambiguous word, a construction with no clean English equivalent, a choice of register, or a choice between manuscripts. Some are theologically motivated, and those are worth finding, but if you assume every difference is, you won't be able to spot the real ones.

> **YOU DON'T NEED THE LANGUAGES**
>
> You need to know where the decisions live, and to look at more than one Bible when a sentence is doing something to somebody.

The spectrum

It isn't a scale from honest to dishonest. It runs from keeping the structure of the original to keeping its effect on the reader, and every point on it gives something up.

APPROACH	WHAT IT PRIORITIZES	WHAT IT GIVES UP
INTERLINEAR	Word-for-word correspondence, original order under the line	Readability. A study tool, not a Bible.
FORMAL ("LITERAL") · KJV, NASB, ESV	The original's grammar and ambiguity, kept even where English strains	Clarity in places. An ambiguity preserved is still one you have to resolve.
MIDDLE · NIV, NRSV, CSB	Accuracy in natural English	Some seams
FUNCTIONAL ("DYNAMIC") · NLT, GOOD NEWS	What the sentence does, in idiomatic English	Where the original was ambiguous, the translator has already chosen for you
PARAPHRASE · THE MESSAGE	Immediate impact, often one author's voice	Any claim to precision. Good for hearing a passage fresh, useless for an argument about wording.
COMMITTEE OR SOLO	Committees give consistency, individuals give voice. Committees have institutional homes, traditions, funders and audiences.	Neither is neutral, and neither is disqualified. Knowing who made it is part of reading it.

KJV · NASB · ESV

NIV · NRSV · CSB

NLT

THE MESSAGE

WHY THE FOOTNOTES MATTER MORE THAN THE TRANSLATION YOU CHOSE

A footnote that says "or," "other manuscripts read," or "Greek uncertain" is the translator telling you a decision happened here. When a verse is being used against someone, check whether the page admits an alternative.

CHAPTERS, VERSES AND HEADINGS AREN'T SCRIPTURE

Chapter divisions came in the thirteenth century, verse numbers in the sixteenth, and section headings from modern editors. They make the text findable and quotable, and they also impose breaks the author didn't write. Quoting a verse is normal. The question is whether the unit you quoted is doing the work of the unit around it.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHO AUTHORIZED THE EMPIRE'S TRANSLATION, AND WHAT ITS FOOTNOTES ARE ALLOWED TO SAY

PASSAGE: _____

TEMPLATE

ONE SPREAD PER PASSAGE

PHOTOCOPY BEFORE FILLING

FOUR RENDERINGS. NAME THE TRANSLATION, THEN COPY THE WORDING EXACTLY.

TRANSLATION	HOW IT READS

WHAT THE FOOTNOTES ADMIT, IN ANY OF THE FOUR

TEMPLATE

THE DIFFERENCE

WHAT THE DIFFERENCE DOES

THE WORD OR PHRASE THEY HANDLE DIFFERENTLY

THE CHOICE EACH ONE MADE. DESCRIBE IT, DON'T RANK IT.

AMBIGUITY, IDIOM, MANUSCRIPT, OR THEOLOGY?

DOES THE DIFFERENCE CHANGE WHAT ANYONE MUST DO?

WHICH RENDERING THE EMPIRE PRINTS, AND WHAT IT GAINS

WHAT I STILL NEED A REAL SOURCE FOR BEFORE I USE THIS IN A SCENE

☐ POSSIBLE ☐ OPEN QUESTION ☐ DECIDED

LOG NO.

DATE

Four triggers

LEXICON

COMMENTARY

BDB · HALOT · BDAG

Comparing English Bibles gets you a long way. These four situations mean stop and find a real source, a lexicon, a commentary or a scholar, before it goes into the novel as a claim.

I · THE ARGUMENT RESTS ON ONE WORD

If a whole doctrine hangs on the range of a single term, the range is the question, and English can't answer it. The household verse is in exactly this situation.

II · THE TRANSLATIONS SPLIT ALONG DENOMINATIONAL LINES

When the pattern of who renders it which way matches the pattern of who teaches what, something besides grammar is operating, and you need to be able to name it exactly.

III · A FOOTNOTE SAYS THE TEXT IS UNCERTAIN

Take the admission seriously. The manuscripts disagree or the syntax won't resolve, and building a scene on the resolved version is building on a choice.

IV · YOU'RE ABOUT TO SAY WHAT THE ORIGINAL "REALLY" MEANS

The most dangerous sentence available to a non-specialist, and one used with total confidence by people on every side. A character may say it. The companion may not, without a source.

THE CLAIMS ABOUT THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGES I'VE BEEN REPEATING WITHOUT CHECKING

METHOD

I.5

Eight Questions

Run all eight, in order, before deciding what a passage means. They won't make you an expert, but most confident misuse of scripture happens by skipping one, and skipping is easy to catch in yourself if you have a list.

1 · WHAT KIND OF TEXT IS THIS?	Genre first, always. It decides what the passage can establish before any other question is worth asking.
2 · WHO'S SPEAKING?	The narrator, a character, God as quoted, a rival, a friend who turns out to be wrong. Job's comforters are in the Bible and they're mistaken, and the book says so.
3 · TO WHOM?	A congregation with a particular problem, a king, a foreign nation, one person. Applying an oracle addressed to Babylon to yourself is a category error with a long history.
4 · WHAT COMES BEFORE AND AFTER?	Read the paragraph, then the chapter. Most weaponized verses only work once the sentences on either side have been cut.
5 · WHAT WORLD PRODUCED IT?	Empire, occupation, exile, monarchy, the household economy, the legal status of women and slaves. The setting is often the subject.
6 · WHAT DO THE WORDS DO?	Command, describe, lament, promise, threaten, concede, argue. Compare two translations and see whether they agree about which.
7 · WHO GAINS FROM THIS READING?	Ask it of every reading, including the one you prefer. A reading that benefits you isn't wrong because of it, and it's worth checking twice.
8 · WHAT DOES THIS READING COST?	And who pays. **POSSIBLE** The Empire has never asked this one out loud, and Eden eventually can't stop asking it.

> **WHAT THE METHOD BUYS YOU**
>
> It doesn't buy authority over people who quote this book for a living. Many of them run these questions better than you will. It buys the ability to tell a reading that has done the work from one that skipped a step, including your own, and to say which step.

PASSAGE: _____

TRANSLATION USED

REFERENCE

1 · GENRE

2 · SPEAKER

3 · AUDIENCE

4 · WHAT SURROUNDS IT

5 · HISTORICAL CONTEXT: WHAT WORLD PRODUCED IT

6 · WHAT THE WORDS DO, AND WHETHER TWO TRANSLATIONS AGREE

THE INTERPRETIVE DISPUTE: WHO READS IT WHICH WAY, AND ON WHAT EVIDENCE

TEMPLATE

WHO GAINS, WHO PAYS

WHO GAINS, WHO PAYS

7 · WHO GAINS FROM EACH READING

8 · WHAT EACH READING COSTS, AND WHO PAYS IT

THE EMPIRE'S OFFICIAL READING, AND HOW IT'S TAUGHT

WHERE I CURRENTLY LAND, IN MY OWN WORDS

RESEARCH STILL NEEDED

WHICH CHARACTER HOLDS WHICH READING

THE SCENE, CHAPTER OR DOCTRINE THIS FEEDS

☐ POSSIBLE ☐ OPEN QUESTION ☐ DECIDED

LOG NO.

DATE

Eight fault lines

The eight places where reading this book divides people, and where the Empire has a doctrine. Research won't produce agreement on any of them, but it reliably rules out weak claims and shows what the argument is actually about.

FAULT LINE	WHAT'S ACTUALLY IN DISPUTE	WHERE TKC USES IT
HEADSHIP	The range of one Greek noun, the reach of the mutual-submission verse, and what carries over from a Roman household code	The Binding. Every household in the Empire.
WOMEN SPEAKING	Restriction passages in the Pauline letters set against the undisputed letters, which name women as coworkers, a deacon and an apostle. Authorship and dating carry weight here.	The Vowed. Who may teach, and who may only recite.
SLAVERY	Texts that regulate slavery without abolishing it, and the principle by which a tradition later called it wrong. The verses aren't in doubt. The principle is the argument.	Designation and labor tracks. Who can be assigned.
DIVINE VIOLENCE	Conquest narratives and judgment oracles: history, theological rhetoric, later reflection or ancient war convention, and how any of it fits a God described elsewhere as merciful	The Fall. Every purge called cleansing.
OBEDIENCE TO RULERS	Romans 13 against the prophets, Revelation and the movement's own martyrs. General principle, or advice to a vulnerable congregation in the imperial capital?	The Empire's most quoted text. Its whole legitimacy.
WEALTH	Whether the warnings target attachment, structural injustice or wealth itself, and how they sit beside the prosperity language of the wisdom books	Crownward theology. Blessing as evidence of favor.
PURITY AND THE BODY	Which rules are which, and by whose framework. The ritual and moral distinction is a later category applied to the texts, not a label printed in them.	Designation exams, the Salt Ceremony, fertility review
THE END OF THINGS	Apocalyptic read as address to its own moment, as a future program, as a recurring pattern, or as liturgy	Whose reading is orthodoxy, and whose is sedition

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

THE FAULT LINE MY NOVEL STANDS ON HARDEST

Not all contested alike

The most important distinction in this part. Treating all four as equally open is how a companion becomes useless, and how a well-read person ends up unable to say that something is simply false.

I · SERIOUS SCHOLARLY DISPUTE

Specialists with the languages, the manuscripts and the historical training disagree, and each side can state the other's evidence. The range of *kephalē*. The authorship of Ephesians. Represent both, and don't pick a winner in the companion's own voice.

II · DENOMINATIONAL OR TRADITIONAL DISAGREEMENT

Communities differ because of their confessions, their governance and inherited practice, more than because the evidence is contested. Who may be ordained. Whether Revelation is read aloud. Name the tradition instead of treating its position as the neutral one.

III · OPEN THEOLOGICAL QUESTIONS

Questions the text raises and doesn't close, where evidence runs out and judgment begins. What the conquest narratives say about God. Whether Job is ever answered. These stay open honestly, and they're where a novel does its best work.

IV · UNSUPPORTED CLAIMS

Claims that fail on the evidence: invented etymologies, a word supposedly mistranslated in every Bible, a council that decided something it never discussed. These are wrong, and the companion can say so, while noting that a character may believe one sincerely and build a life on it. The curse of Ham is in this category (Genesis dossier).

THE SORTING QUESTION

Before writing any dispute into a scene, ask which of the four it is. Category I earns two credible characters. Category IV earns one character who's wrong and one who knows it, and that's a different scene entirely.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

THE CATEGORY IV CLAIM THE EMPIRE TEACHES AS SETTLED FACT

Fault line: _____

TEMPLATE

PHOTOCOPY BEFORE FILLING

KIND: I / II / III / IV

THE PASSAGES, WITH REFERENCES

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

THE MAJOR READINGS

THE READING	WHO HOLDS IT	ON WHAT EVIDENCE

The Empire and the people

WHAT THE EMPIRE OFFICIALLY TEACHES

WHAT IT SUPPRESSES, AND HOW

WHO IN THE NOVEL STANDS WHERE

CHARACTER	AGREES · DOUBTS · RESISTS · REINTERPRETS	WHAT IT COSTS HER, AND WHEN SHE LEARNED IT

WHAT STAYS UNRESOLVED, AND SHOULD

WHAT I STILL NEED A SOURCE FOR

☐ POSSIBLE ☐ OPEN QUESTION ☐ DECIDED

LOG NO. **DATE**

Ephesians 5

EPH 5.18–6.9

P46 · VATICANUS

SINAITICUS · ALEXANDRINUS

METZGER, TEXTUAL COMMENTARY

GURRY, NTS 2021

I.7

The worked example, because the Empire's household law is built on this passage and because nearly everything hard about reading scripture is in it at once: a disputed author, a supplied verb, a contested word, a Roman legal background, and a verse break in the wrong place.

WHERE THE SENTENCE ACTUALLY STARTS

Verse 21 tells the whole congregation to submit to one another. Verse 22 addresses wives. In P46 and Codex Vaticanus, verse 22 has no verb at all, and Clement of Alexandria quotes it the same way, so the instruction to wives borrows the participle of verse 21, and the two verses are one grammatical movement. Codex Sinaiticus, Alexandrinus and most later manuscripts supply a verb, and most English Bibles supply one too, with a section heading printed between the verses. The heading is modern apparatus, not scripture.

CORRECTION TO THE OLD COMPANION It listed Sinaiticus among the verbless witnesses. Sinaiticus has the verb (*hypotassesthōsan*). The verbless witnesses are P46 and Vaticanus.

WHAT THE PARTICIPLE SETTLES, AND WHAT IT DOESN'T

The grammatical link isn't in dispute. What it implies is. One reading holds that mutual submission in 21 governs everything after it. Another holds that 21 introduces submission in general and 22 onward specifies its ordered forms. Bruce Metzger's committee preferred the verbless text, and Peter Gurry (New Testament Studies, 2021) argues the verb is original. The grammar alone doesn't decide the meaning, and anyone who says the Greek settles it is overselling, in either direction.

THE AUTHORSHIP QUESTION

Ephesians is one of the disputed letters. Whether Paul wrote it divides scholars, which affects any argument that runs "the same author who names women as coworkers also said this."

THE STRUCTURAL LESSON

Quote verse 22 alone and you have a rule for wives. Quote 21 through 33 and you have a passage that gives husbands three times as many verses (nine to three) and about 116 Greek words to the wives' 40 (Mowczko). **INTERPRETATION** The mechanism isn't mistranslation. It's fragment selection, plus a heading, plus teaching the doctrine before anyone reads the paragraph. Any institution with a lectionary and a catechism can do it without altering a word.

KEPHALĒ

BEDALE 1954

GRUDEM, TRINJ 1985

FITZMYER 1989

CERVIN 1989

BDAG

Head

The Greek word is kephalē. Its range in this period is one of the most argued questions in New Testament lexicography, and the dispute is genuine on both sides.

PROPOSED SENSE	THE CASE FOR IT, AND THE STRAIN AGAINST IT
AUTHORITY OVER	Well attested for rulers and governing bodies, and the natural reading if the passage is arranging a hierarchy. Wayne Grudem surveyed 2,336 instances (1985) and argued "source" is rare, and Joseph Fitzmyer (1989) agreed. Strain: the passage defines the husband's headship by self-giving and nourishing, and gives husbands no order anywhere.
SOURCE OR ORIGIN	Attested in some contexts, a river's head, a source of supply, and fits the body imagery, where the head supplies and the body grows. Stephen Bedale (1954) began the modern debate with it, and Catherine Kroeger and Philip Payne developed it. Strain: how common this sense was in ordinary first-century use is exactly what's disputed.
PREEMINENCE	Foremost, most prominent, first in honor, with no command attached. Richard Cervin's reply to Grudem (1989) is usually grouped here. Strain: honor and authority are hard to separate in a society organized around both.
METAPHOR, UNRESOLVED	The writer is working an extended body metaphor and didn't intend an institutional definition, which would explain why readers have pulled incompatible institutions out of it for two thousand years.

THE WORD RENDERED "SUBMIT"

Hypotassō means to arrange oneself under someone. The middle voice is often read as something the subject does herself, and scholars disagree about how much weight that can bear. **INTERPRETATION** A voluntary act inside a legal system where the alternative is ruin is voluntary only in a limited sense. **POSSIBLE** The Empire understands this perfectly. It never forces. It makes the alternative unlivable.

WHAT NOT TO DO WITH THIS PAGE

Don't use it to announce that the Greek has been solved and the hierarchy dissolved. The point is to be able to say which sense a reading assumes and what that assumption costs.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH SENSE THE EMPIRE'S DOCTRINE ASSUMES, AND WHETHER ITS PRELATES KNOW THERE'S A CHOICE

ARISTOTLE, POLITICS I

BALCH, LET WIVES BE SUBMISSIVE (1981)

EPH 5.25–33

EPH 6.5–9

THE HOUSEHOLD CODE

Wives, children and slaves, addressed in that order, isn't an invention of this letter. It's a recognizable Greco-Roman form, instruction on managing a household, which was a political unit as much as a domestic one, because the ordered household was understood as the foundation of the ordered state.

WHAT THE FORM ASSUMES

A male head with legal authority over wife, children and enslaved people, the household as an economic enterprise, and the state's interest in its order. Aristotle's *Politics* (Book I) sets out the three pairs. A first-century reader would recognize the shape at once, and would notice the departures.

WHERE THIS VERSION DEPARTS FROM THE FORM

It addresses the subordinate parties directly as moral agents. It gives the husband the longer and harder instruction. It grounds the arrangement in Christ's self-giving and not in nature or the head's prerogative. Whether that amounts to subverting the code, a Christianized version of it, or an accommodation that made the movement socially survivable is a live argument, and all three are held by people who've done the work. David Balch argued that 1 Peter's code helped present the movement as respectable to suspicious outsiders.

THE INSTRUCTIONS TO HUSBANDS

Love as Christ loved and gave himself up. Nourish and cherish as your own body. The passage gives husbands no command to rule, enforce or correct. INTERPRETATION A doctrine of headship that produces enforcement is drawing on the noun in verse 23, and not on anything the passage tells husbands to do.

THE PART NOBODY QUOTES AT WEDDINGS

The same code goes on to enslaved people and their masters (6:5–9). An institution that treats the wives section as timeless and the slavery section as historically conditioned is making an interpretive decision it usually declines to defend. Noticing that is the most useful single move available to a character inside such an institution.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

HOW THE EMPIRE HANDLES THE SLAVERY SECTION OF THE SAME PASSAGE

COMPLEMENTARIAN

EGALITARIAN

DANVERS 1987

CBE 1987

PART IV

Four positions

Held by real people with real arguments. Learn to state each one in its own terms before deciding anything. A character who can only caricature the other reading hasn't thought about it yet.

POSITION	WHAT IT HOLDS, AND ON WHAT EVIDENCE	ITS HARDEST PROBLEM
ORDERED ROLES (COMPLEMENTARIAN)	Distinct and permanent roles: the husband leads, the wife submits, both equal in worth. Rests on the plain sense of headship in the era's usage and on the order of the code itself.	Nothing in the passage authorizes enforcement, and verse 21 addresses everyone
MUTUAL SUBMISSION (EGALITARIAN)	Verse 21 governs the whole section, and the household instructions apply a shared obligation. Rests on the grammar of the participle and the content of the husbands' instructions.	The instructions are still asymmetrical, and only wives are told to submit
HISTORICALLY SITUATED	A first-century congregation taught to live inside an existing legal structure without being destroyed by it. Rests on the household-code parallels and the letter's occasional character.	It needs a principle for deciding what carries over to other centuries, and stating that principle is hard
ACCOMMODATION	A movement softening its radical edge to survive scrutiny. Rests on the trajectory from the undisputed letters toward the Pastorals.	It depends on authorship and dating questions that aren't settled

The modern American debate took its current shape in 1987, with the complementarian Danvers Statement and the founding of Christians for Biblical Equality. See Part IV.

ASSIGN ONE POSITION TO EACH CHARACTER WHO HAS AN OPINION, THEN ONE TO A CHARACTER WHO'S NEVER BEEN TOLD THERE'S MORE THAN ONE

ASSIGN ONE POSITION TO EACH CHARACTER WHO HAS AN OPINION, THEN ONE TO A CHARACTER WHO'S NEVER BEEN TOLD THERE'S MORE THAN ONE

METHOD, WORKED

EPH 5.21–6.9

THE METHOD, WORKED

The eight questions, answered on this passage, so you can see a completed run before doing your own.

1 · KIND OF TEXT	A letter containing a household code: correspondence, not legislation, with a recognizable moral-instruction form inside it.
2 · SPEAKER	The letter's author, writing in Paul's name. **CONTESTED** whether Paul wrote it. It's neither a narrator reporting nor God quoted directly.
3 · AUDIENCE	A congregation, or several, in the Roman province of Asia. Wives, husbands, children and enslaved people are all addressed as present and listening.
4 · BEFORE AND AFTER	Before: mutual submission, addressed to all. After: husbands, then children and parents, then slaves and masters. The wives' instruction is the shortest unit in the sequence.
5 · THE WORLD	Roman legal households with a male head, an economy that included slavery, a state invested in domestic order, and a small movement under intermittent suspicion.
6 · WHAT THE WORDS DO	Instruct, in some manuscripts through a participle hanging on the previous sentence. One contested noun. The husbands' portion is longer and makes the heavier demand.
7 · WHO GAINS	From the fragment: whoever holds household authority, and any state that needs orderly households. From the whole passage: much less clear, which is why the fragment is what gets printed.
8 · WHAT IT COSTS	Under the fragment reading, a woman's standing depends on a man's character, with no recourse written into the text. Ask who in Aurelia pays that, and what she's told when she says so.

WHERE MY OWN FIRST RUN OF THIS PASSAGE WENT WRONG

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHERE MY OWN FIRST RUN OF THIS PASSAGE WENT WRONG

YOURS

TKC: CR · DOM · DR3

What this is for

This passage is the seed of the Binding, the Covenant and every household in the Empire (CR). Write what the Empire did with it, and what you were taught about it long before you read the paragraph.

WHAT I WAS TAUGHT THIS PASSAGE MEANT, AND WHO TAUGHT ME

THE EMPIRE'S OFFICIAL DOCTRINE OF HEADSHIP, IN THE EMPIRE'S OWN WORDS

WHICH VERSES THE TEMPLE PRINTS, AND WHICH IT LEAVES FOR CLERGY

THE MOMENT EDEN READS THE WHOLE PARAGRAPH FOR THE FIRST TIME

☐ POSSIBLE ☐ OPEN QUESTION ☐ DECIDED

LOG NO. _____ DATE _____

X

PART ONE · THE LIBRARY

The Sixty-Six Books

One entry per book, in canonical order, each answering the same six questions so the whole library can be read side by side

THE SIXTY-SIX BOOKS

One entry per book, in canonical order, and every entry answers the same six questions so you can compare across the whole library instead of reading each book alone. None of them replaces the book. They're orientation, enough to know what you're walking into, what the book argues about and which of its pressures the novel can use.

Two of the six questions belong to you more than to the Bible. *What it gives TKC* is where the raw material gets named. *What Dominion would do* is where you decide how the Empire has already processed the book before any character opens it. Answer those in pencil, because they'll change as the manuscript changes. The narrative books get a full page each, since story is where characters come from and you'll keep coming back to them. The shorter prophetic books and the letters share pages, because what you need from them is a fast, reliable sense of the argument more than a scene inventory. The layout tells you how much material is in there.

THE SIX QUESTIONS

- **Where we are.** The political and historical position.
- **What happens.** The shape of the thing, briefly.
- **Who matters.** The names worth knowing.
- **What it wrestles with.** The internal argument.
- **What it gives TKC.** Usable material.
- **What Dominion would do.** The Empire's use of it.

"Sixty-six books, and none of them was written for you."

A READING ORDER, IF YOU WANT ONE

Canonical order isn't chronological, and it's a poor first path. To read for competence before completeness, take Genesis, Exodus, Judges, 1–2 Samuel, Mark, Luke, Amos, Isaiah, Esther, Ruth, Romans and Revelation. You'll have origins, law, monarchy, prophetic anger, exile, a life, a movement and an apocalypse, the whole grammar Dominion is built on, in about a tenth of the pages. Come back afterward and do it properly.

MARGINALIA

✣ *See also:* Bible 101, I to IX · the focused studies and the deep dives that follow this section.

Genesis

Bereshit · fifty chapters · Book i of lxvi

OT | START: ORIGINS

WHERE WE ARE

Before nation, before law, before temple. There's no state in this book and no priesthood, only households. Everything the Empire later cites as eternal precedent begins as a family argument about land, inheritance and whose child counts.

WHAT HAPPENS

Two creation accounts that tell the order differently, an expulsion, a flood and a scattered tower. After that, thirty-eight chapters narrow to one family: a promise, a wife who laughs at it, an enslaved surrogate driven into the desert, twin sons who cheat each other, two sisters married to the same man, and a favored son sold by his brothers who ends up running an empire's grain.

WHO MATTERS

Eve · Noah · Sarah · Hagar · Abraham · Isaac · Rebekah · Jacob · Leah · Rachel · Dinah · Tamar · Joseph

WHAT IT WRESTLES WITH

Blessing as a scarce resource that can't be shared, only won or stolen. Naming as an act of authority. Whether obedience is trust or terror. The book never settles it, and the binding of Isaac is left standing without comment.

> *You are El-roi, the God who sees me.*
> HAGAR · GEN 16.13

NOTES ON THE TEXT

READ FIRST

Ch. 1–3 · 16 · 21 · 22 · 29–30 · 38

> **CORRECTION TO THE OLD COMPANION** The old page called Hagar the first person in the book to name God. She's the only person in the Bible who does it (Gen 16.13).

MARGINALIA

✣ *See also:* Deep dive I, Genesis · Hagar and Leah, Part II.

YOURS

TKC

DOMINION

Genesis, for the novel

WHAT IT GIVES TKC

The garden as a supervised enclosure with one prohibition. Naming as ownership. The sister rivalry beneath the candidate system. And Hagar, the woman used for someone else's promise, who is the only person in scripture to give God a name.

WHAT DOMINION WOULD DO

POSSIBLE Read the curse as a constitution. Order of creation becomes order of rank, the expulsion becomes the founding case for permanent supervision, and Hagar becomes a warning about women who run, instead of a woman God followed into the desert.

QUESTIONS THIS RAISES ABOUT TKC

WHERE THIS BOOK IS ALREADY IN THE MANUSCRIPT, OR SHOULD BE

Exodus

Shemot · forty chapters · Book ii of lxvi

OT | START: EMPIRE

WHERE WE ARE

Inside an empire, as its labor force. The family from Genesis has become a population, and the state that once fed them now fears their numbers enough to legislate against their children. Here God is first identified as the one who takes sides in a labor dispute.

WHAT HAPPENS

Midwives disobey a royal order to kill newborn boys and are honored for it. A child is hidden, raised in the palace, kills a slave driver, flees, and is recruited from a burning bush. He comes back and negotiates with the state through escalating catastrophe until the workforce walks out. After the walkout come a sea, a mountain, a law and a gold statue.

WHO MATTERS

Shiphrah and Puah · Jochebed · Miriam · Pharaoh's daughter · Moses · Zipporah · Aaron · Pharaoh

WHAT IT WRESTLES WITH

Whether freedom is the point or only the precondition. The people are barely out before they're handed a legal code and a building project. There's also the terrible arithmetic of liberation. This book's God kills other people's firstborn to free these ones, and the text doesn't soften it.

> *I have heard their cry on account of their taskmasters.*
> EXOD 3.7

NOTES ON THE TEXT

READ FIRST

Ch. 1–3 · 5 · 12 · 15 · 20 · 32

MARGINALIA

✣ *See also:* Deep dive II, Exodus · Empires of the Bible, Part IV.

YOURS

TKC

DOMINION

Exodus, for the novel

WHAT IT GIVES TKC

The template for holy disobedience: two midwives who lie to a king and are recorded by name while the king isn't. A liberation story any oppressed population inside Dominion can read and apply without a word of commentary.

WHAT DOMINION WOULD DO

POSSIBLE Move the weight from the escape to the mountain. Teach Exodus as the book where God gives commandments and punishes the golden calf, and drop the book where God overthrows a government. Freedom becomes the prologue and obedience becomes the moral.

QUESTIONS THIS RAISES ABOUT TKC

WHERE THIS BOOK IS ALREADY IN THE MANUSCRIPT, OR SHOULD BE

Leviticus

Vayikra · twenty-seven chapters · Book iii of lxvi

OT | START: RITUAL

WHERE WE ARE

Still at the mountain, and nothing happens. People give up on this book, and it's also the most important one in the collection for understanding how a religion actually governs, because nearly all of it is administration: who may touch what, who may enter where, what makes a body unclean and what it costs to be restored.

WHAT HAPPENS

Sacrificial procedure. Two priests killed for offering fire they weren't commanded to offer. Dietary law. Childbirth and menstruation as states requiring separation. A day of atonement, prohibition lists, festival calendars, and at the end, startlingly, the jubilee. Every fiftieth year, land goes back to the families who lost it and Israelites sold into debt service go free.

WHO MATTERS

Aaron · Nadab and Abihu · the anonymous priesthood · the goat sent into the wilderness

WHAT IT WRESTLES WITH

Holiness as separation, and the enormous machinery it takes to keep it up. Underneath the procedure sits a question the Empire has to answer. Is a body a temple to be guarded, or a liability to be managed?

> *Proclaim liberty throughout the land to all its inhabitants.*
> LEV 25.10

NOTES ON THE TEXT

READ FIRST

Ch. 10 · 12 · 16 · 19 · 25

CORRECTION TO THE OLD COMPANION The old page had the jubilee cancelling debts. Leviticus 25 returns land and frees Israelites in debt service. Debt release every seventh year is Deuteronomy 15.

MARGINALIA

✣ *See also:* Deep dive III, Leviticus · Deuteronomy, this section.

YOURS

TKC

DOMINION

LEVITICUS, FOR THE NOVEL

WHAT IT GIVES TKC

The whole vocabulary of ritual purity a surveillance theocracy runs on: clean and unclean, permitted and withheld, the body as a jurisdiction. Every ceremony, inspection and enclosure in Dominion can be sourced here.

WHAT DOMINION WOULD DO

POSSIBLE Enforce the purity codes literally and treat the jubilee as symbolic. Land return and release from debt service are among the most economically dangerous laws in scripture, and an empire built on inheritance quietly reclassifies them as poetry.

QUESTIONS THIS RAISES ABOUT TKC

WHERE THIS BOOK IS ALREADY IN THE MANUSCRIPT, OR SHOULD BE

Numbers

Bemidbar · thirty-six chapters · Book iv of lxvi

OT | START: AUTHORITY

WHERE WE ARE

In the desert, and it's going badly. The Hebrew name means "in the wilderness," and the English name comes from the two censuses that bracket the book. Both titles are honest. It's a book about counting a population and about that population falling apart while it waits.

WHAT HAPPENS

A census, and complaint after complaint about food, leadership and the whole project. Scouts come back terrified and the people are sentenced to forty years of wandering. Miriam and Aaron challenge Moses, and Miriam alone is struck with a skin disease. A rebellion is swallowed by the ground. Five daughters petition to inherit their father's land and win.

WHO MATTERS

Miriam · Aaron · Korah · Caleb · Joshua · Balaam · the daughters of Zelophehad

WHAT IT WRESTLES WITH

Legitimate authority and the cost of questioning it. Rebellions are punished spectacularly, and in the same book five women bring a legal challenge to inheritance law and win, with God ruling for them. Chapter 36 then requires them to marry inside their tribe so the land stays put. The text can't decide whether dissent is faithlessness or petition, and neither can any empire.

> *The daughters of Zelophehad are right.*
> NUM 27.7

NOTES ON THE TEXT

READ FIRST

Ch. 12 · 13–14 · 16 · 22 · 27 · 36

MARGINALIA

✣ *See also:* Focused study F1, Numbers · Miriam, Part II.

YOURS

TKC

DOMINION

Numbers, for the novel

WHAT IT GIVES TKC

A census as an instrument of control, and the one precedent in the Torah for women changing the law by asking. Also the psychology of a generation that won't live to see the promise, which suits anyone in Dominion serving a future they've been told isn't theirs.

WHAT DOMINION WOULD DO

POSSIBLE Preach Korah every year and Zelophehad never. Rebellion swallowed by the earth is an excellent lesson for a provincial congregation. A successful female petition to amend inheritance law doesn't get printed in the schoolbook.

QUESTIONS THIS RAISES ABOUT TKC

WHERE THIS BOOK IS ALREADY IN THE MANUSCRIPT, OR SHOULD BE

Deuteronomy

Devarim · thirty-four chapters · Book v of lxvi

OT | START: DOMINION

WHERE WE ARE

On the border, listening to a farewell address. The book is framed as Moses' speeches to a generation that didn't witness the escape, which makes it the collection's first act of national memory management. Here's what happened to us, here's what it means, and here's what you owe.

WHAT HAPPENS

The law is restated for a settled farming people, and blessings and curses are laid out as a conditional contract. Obey and the land yields. Disobey and it's taken. Laws limiting kings, protecting immigrants and releasing debts every seventh year sit beside laws of terrifying severity. It ends with a leader dying in sight of a country he may not enter.

WHO MATTERS

Moses · Joshua · the unnamed generation being addressed

WHAT IT WRESTLES WITH

The retribution formula, in which righteousness produces prosperity and suffering implies sin. It's some of the most quotable theology in scripture and the most politically useful, because it makes wealth a certificate of virtue and poverty a confession. INTERPRETATION Job and several prophets read as answers to it.

> *He must not acquire many horses for himself… nor acquire many wives… nor silver and gold in great quantity.*
>
> ON KINGS · DEUT 17.16–17

NOTES ON THE TEXT

READ FIRST

Ch. 6 · 15 · 17 · 22 · 28 · 30 · 34

MARGINALIA

✣ *See also:* Deep dive IV, Deuteronomy · Job, this section.

YOURS

TKC

DOMINION

Deuteronomy, for the novel

WHAT IT GIVES TKC

Dominion's founding logic, ready-made: a covenant contract in which national obedience produces national survival. Also the buried law limiting what a king may accumulate, a passage that indicts the Emperor in a single sentence.

WHAT DOMINION WOULD DO

POSSIBLE Make this the spine of state theology. Blessing for compliance, catastrophe for dissent, and every hardship in the provinces explained as somebody's hidden disobedience. The debt-release and immigrant laws stay in the canon and out of the lectionary.

QUESTIONS THIS RAISES ABOUT TKC

WHERE THIS BOOK IS ALREADY IN THE MANUSCRIPT, OR SHOULD BE

Joshua

Yehoshua · twenty-four chapters · Book vi of lxvi

CONTENT NOTE Conquest, the destruction of cities and the execution of a family.

WHERE WE ARE

Crossing into the land, with military force. A promise becomes a campaign. It's the hardest book in the collection to read honestly, because what it describes is the taking of inhabited cities, and it describes it as obedience.

WHAT HAPPENS

Two spies are hidden in Jericho by Rahab, a prostitute, who negotiates her household's survival in exchange. A wall falls. One man keeps plunder, and he and his whole family are executed for it. Campaign follows campaign, the land is divided by lot, and the book closes with a public assembly where the people have to choose formally whose god they'll serve.

WHO MATTERS

Joshua · Rahab · Achan · Caleb · the Gibeonites, who survive by lying well

WHAT IT WRESTLES WITH

Whether divine promise can license atrocity, and whether belonging is blood or allegiance. Its own answer is inconsistent. The foreigners who talk their way in are kept.

> *Choose this day whom you will serve.*
> JOSH 24.15

NOTES ON THE TEXT

OT | START: CONQUEST

READ FIRST

Ch. 2 · 6 · 7 · 9 · 24

CORRECTION TO THE OLD COMPANION The old page put Rahab in the royal genealogy as if Joshua said so. Joshua doesn't. Matthew's genealogy does (Matt 1.5).

MARGINALIA

✣ *See also:* Rahab, Part II · Divine violence, Bible 101 IX.

YOURS

TKC

DOMINION

JOSHUA, FOR THE NOVEL

WHAT IT GIVES TKC

Rahab, entirely. A woman with no standing reads the political situation faster than her whole city and trades information for her family's survival. Matthew later writes her into the line of David (Matt 1.5).

WHAT DOMINION WOULD DO

POSSIBLE Quote it at every expansion, and use Achan as the case for collective punishment. One household endangers the nation, so surveillance is mercy.

QUESTIONS THIS RAISES ABOUT TKC

WHERE THIS BOOK IS ALREADY IN THE MANUSCRIPT, OR SHOULD BE

Judges

Shoftim · twenty-one chapters · Book vii of lxvi

CONTENT NOTE Sexual violence, human sacrifice and mass abduction, ch. 11 and 19–21.

WHERE WE ARE

In the land, with no central government, and it's a catastrophe. The book runs a cycle. The people go wrong, a foreign power oppresses them, a temporary leader rises and there's peace, and it all starts again. Each turn is uglier than the last.

WHAT HAPPENS

A woman judges Israel and summons the general who wins her war. Another woman drives a tent peg through an enemy general's skull. A man sacrifices his daughter to keep a vow. A strongman is undone by his appetites. It ends in gang rape, civil war and the mass abduction of women to repopulate the losing tribe.

WHO MATTERS

Deborah · Barak · Jael · Gideon · Jephthah and his daughter · Samson · Delilah · the unnamed woman of ch. 19

WHAT IT WRESTLES WITH

Whether the absence of a king is freedom or collapse. **INTERPRETATION** It's arguing for monarchy, and it argues by showing what happens to women when no one's in charge, which is a very specific and very political way to make a case for order.

> *In those days there was no king in Israel. All the people did what was right in their own eyes.*
>
> JUDG 21.25

NOTES ON THE TEXT

OT | START: DOMINION

READ FIRST

Ch. 4–5 · 11 · 16 · 19–21

MARGINALIA

✣ *See also:* Deborah, Part II · Power and kingship, Part IV.

YOURS

TKC

DOMINION

JUDGES, FOR THE NOVEL

WHAT IT GIVES TKC

Deborah, a woman with public authority nobody in the book questions, whom no empire can quite explain away. And the woman of chapter 19, the strongest argument in scripture that the state's protection was never the point.

WHAT DOMINION WOULD DO

POSSIBLE Use the closing verse as a founding slogan, with chaos as what happens without a divinely ordered ruler. Deborah becomes an emergency exception and Delilah becomes the lesson about female influence.

QUESTIONS THIS RAISES ABOUT TKC

WHERE THIS BOOK IS ALREADY IN THE MANUSCRIPT, OR SHOULD BE

Ruth

four chapters · Book viii of lxvi

OT | START: CHARACTER

WHERE WE ARE

Set in the time of the judges, deliberately, and reading like a rebuttal. Four quiet chapters about two widows and a harvest, placed right after the most violent book in the collection, arguing that survival is arranged by ordinary loyalty more than by warlords.

WHAT HAPPENS

A famine drives a family abroad, and the men all die. A foreign daughter-in-law refuses to leave her mother-in-law and goes home with her to a town where they have no income and no standing. She gleans in a field and is noticed by its owner. On her mother-in-law's coaching she goes to him at night on the threshing floor and asks him to spread his cloak over her, the idiom for marriage. He does. Their great-grandson is David.

WHO MATTERS

Ruth · Naomi · Boaz · the nearer kinsman who declines

WHAT IT WRESTLES WITH

Who counts as one of us. Ruth is a Moabite, from exactly the nation Deuteronomy 23 bars from the assembly, and she's written into the royal line on purpose. **INTERPRETATION** The book is a quiet act of political dissent about immigration and belonging.

> *Where you go I will go. Your people shall be my people.*
> RUTH 1.16

NOTES ON THE TEXT

READ FIRST

All four chapters. It's short.

MARGINALIA

✣ *See also:* Ruth, Part II · Ezra, focused study F5.

YOURS

TKC

DOMINION

Ruth, for the novel

WHAT IT GIVES TKC

The most famous line of devotion in scripture is spoken by a woman to another woman, and neither to a husband nor to God. The single fact will do more for the relationship writing than any romance in the collection.

WHAT DOMINION WOULD DO

POSSIBLE Read it at every wedding, with the vow reassigned to a husband and the threshing floor softened into modesty. A foreign woman who assimilates completely is the Empire's favorite kind of immigrant.

QUESTIONS THIS RAISES ABOUT TKC

WHERE THIS BOOK IS ALREADY IN THE MANUSCRIPT, OR SHOULD BE

1 and 2 Samuel

fifty-five chapters · Books ix–x of lxvi

CONTENT NOTE Sexual violence and murder, 2 Sam 11 and 13.

WHERE WE ARE

At the invention of the monarchy, and uneasy about it from the first page. The people demand a king. The prophet warns them exactly what a king will take, their sons, their daughters and a tenth of their grain and flocks, and anoints one anyway.

WHAT HAPPENS

A woman who couldn't conceive gives her son to the sanctuary, and her song becomes the template for every reversal-of-power hymn after it. Saul is chosen, comes apart and dies. David rises, takes another man's wife and has the husband killed to cover it. A prophet walks into the palace and says so. The rest is a family destroying itself.

WHO MATTERS

Hannah · Samuel · Saul · Michal · David · Jonathan · Abigail · Bathsheba · Nathan · Tamar · Amnon · Absalom

WHAT IT WRESTLES WITH

Whether a chosen king can be held to account. The astonishing thing is that the book keeps David's crimes in. **CONTESTED** Readers divide on whether Bathsheba consented or was taken by a king she couldn't refuse. The murder of Uriah is in the text plainly, and so is Amnon's rape of Tamar. Every empire descended from this literature has to decide whether to keep that page.

> *You are the man.*
> NATHAN TO THE KING · 2 SAM 12.7

NOTES ON THE TEXT

OT | START: DOMINION

READ FIRST

1 Sam 1–2 · 8 · 16–18 · 25 · 2 Sam 6 · 11–12 · 13

MARGINALIA

✣ *See also:* Bathsheba and Tamar, Part II · Prophecy and who gets believed, Part IV.

YOURS

TKC

DOMINION

1 and 2 Samuel, for the novel

WHAT IT GIVES TKC

The anatomy of the court: anointing, succession, a prophet who can indict a king and survive, and Tamar, a princess assaulted inside the palace whose case is buried to protect the dynasty.

WHAT DOMINION WOULD DO

POSSIBLE Keep the anointing and the giant, and reframe Bathsheba as a temptation more than a crime. Nathan's confrontation becomes a story about private repentance in place of public accountability.

QUESTIONS THIS RAISES ABOUT TKC

WHERE THIS BOOK IS ALREADY IN THE MANUSCRIPT, OR SHOULD BE

1 and 2 Kings

forty-seven chapters · Books xi–xii of lxvi

OT | START: EMPIRE

WHERE WE ARE

At the height of the state and all the way down. The book holds the temple's construction and its destruction. INFERENCE In its final form it was finished in exile, by people explaining how they lost everything. Its last scene is a captive king in Babylon.

WHAT HAPPENS

Solomon builds the temple with conscripted labor, and after his death the kingdom splits over that grievance. A catalogue of kings follows, each rated in a sentence, broken up by prophets who confront them. Elijah takes on a royal couple who seize a vineyard by judicial murder. A forgotten scroll is found in the temple and sets off a purge. After that come Assyria, Babylon and the burning of the temple.

WHO MATTERS

Solomon · the queen of Sheba · Elijah · Ahab · Jezebel · Naboth · Elisha · Athaliah · Huldah · Josiah · Nebuchadnezzar

WHAT IT WRESTLES WITH

Why the state fell, answered theologically and not militarily. The kings were unfaithful. It's a convenient explanation and a dangerous one, because every disaster becomes somebody's insufficient devotion.

> *Have you killed, and also taken possession?*
> ELIJAH TO AHAB · 1 KGS 21.19

NOTES ON THE TEXT

READ FIRST

1 Kgs 3 · 5 · 12 · 18 · 21 · 2 Kgs 11 · 22–23 · 25

The biblical prophet Huldah has no connection to the Prelate. The Prelate's working name is Aurelia (POSSIBLE, FR 33).

MARGINALIA

✣ *See also:* Jezebel and Huldah, Part II · Empires of the Bible, Part IV.

YOURS

TKC

DOMINION

1 and 2 Kings, for the novel

WHAT IT GIVES TKC

Naboth's vineyard, which shows how a state takes what it wants and keeps the paperwork clean. Plus Huldah, the prophet who authenticates a found scroll for a king, and Athaliah, a queen whose reign was written up as usurpation.

WHAT DOMINION WOULD DO

POSSIBLE Preach the temple and the reforming king and skip the forced labor that built it. Jezebel becomes the standing image of a woman with political power, which is why her name survives as an insult and Naboth's doesn't.

QUESTIONS THIS RAISES ABOUT TKC

WHERE THIS BOOK IS ALREADY IN THE MANUSCRIPT, OR SHOULD BE

Chronicles · Ezra · Nehemiah

1 CHR 1–9

1 CHR 3.5

EZRA 9–10

NEH 5

JAPHET, I & II CHRONICLES

These three share a page because they do one job. They're the authorized version, written after the exile by and for the restored establishment, retelling the national story with its failures managed. Here's what state-sponsored scripture looks like from inside.

1 AND 2 CHRONICLES · SIXTY-FIVE CHAPTERS	The same monarchy retold with the scandals removed. David's affair and Uriah's murder are gone, and Bathsheba stays only as a name in a list of Solomon's mother. Absalom's rebellion is gone. Nine chapters of genealogy open the book, because lineage is the argument: this priesthood, this line, this temple, legitimately. Where Kings explains a catastrophe, Chronicles builds a credential. **For TKC:** Dominion's own historiography. Two accounts of the same reign, one of them cleaned, and a character who finds both.
EZRA · TEN CHAPTERS	A return permitted under imperial license, a rebuilt temple and a purity crisis in which the community is pressed to send away its foreign wives and their children. One of the coldest passages in scripture, seven books after Ruth, which says the opposite. **For TKC:** ethnic purity legislated as obedience, with the paperwork of restoration.
NEHEMIAH · THIRTEEN CHAPTERS	A cupbearer to a foreign king gets leave to rebuild his city's walls, and it reads like a project memoir: opposition, logistics, night inspections, armed builders. In chapter 5 the poor are pledging their children against debt, and he makes the wealthy give back what they took. **For TKC:** walls, gates, registers and a reformer aimed at his own class.

WHAT DOMINION WOULD DO WITH ALL THREE

POSSIBLE Make Chronicles the standard history and let Kings go quietly out of print. Cite Ezra whenever purity needs enforcing and Nehemiah whenever a wall needs building, and never read Nehemiah 5 aloud.

EZRA'S DIVORCES

Whether the mass divorce was a tiny community's way of surviving or an exclusion paid for by women and children is argued in good faith both ways. The Empire has picked one.

CORRECTION TO THE OLD COMPANION The old page said Bathsheba is gone from Chronicles. Her story is gone. Her name stays, as "Bath-shua" in 1 Chr 3.5. The old page also put Ezra four books from Ruth. It's seven.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

QUESTIONS THIS RAISES ABOUT TKC

Esther

ten chapters · Book xvii of lxvi

OT | START: CHARACTER

WHERE WE ARE

Inside the palace of a foreign empire, entirely. There's no temple, no prophet and, in the Hebrew text, no mention of God at all. It's the most useful book here for writing a woman surviving a court.

WHAT HAPPENS

A queen refuses to be displayed and is removed. A search across the empire gathers young women into the palace for a year of beauty treatments. An orphan, told by her cousin to hide her people, becomes queen. A minister engineers a genocide. She risks an unsummoned approach, works the king through two banquets, and the minister hangs on the gallows he built. The king's decree can't be revoked, so a second decree lets her people defend themselves.

WHO MATTERS

Vashti · Esther · Mordecai · Haman · the king, whom everyone manipulates

WHAT IT WRESTLES WITH

How to act with no power, no God on the page and no guarantee. The book's ethics are improvised, concealment, timing, flattery and hospitality as strategy, and it never once says whether that's admirable.

> *If I perish, I perish.*
> ESTH 4.16

NOTES ON THE TEXT

READ FIRST

Ch. 1 · 2 · 4 · 7 · 8. Read chapter 1 twice.

ECHOES

Eden · Celeste · Lyris

MARGINALIA

✣ *See also:* Esther and Vashti, Part II.

YOURS

TKC

DOMINION

Esther, for the novel

WHAT IT GIVES TKC

The candidate system, nearly wholesale: a state selection, a year of preparation, a girl told to hide what she is. And Vashti, who says no in chapter one and is erased, which makes the whole plot possible.

WHAT DOMINION WOULD DO

POSSIBLE Canonize her as the patient wife, proof that a woman's power is beauty, obedience and correct timing. Vashti is preached as the warning, and the year of preparation is presented as honor and never as processing.

QUESTIONS THIS RAISES ABOUT TKC

WHERE THIS BOOK IS ALREADY IN THE MANUSCRIPT, OR SHOULD BE

Job

forty-two chapters · Book xviii of lxvi

OT | CONTESTED

READ FIRST

Ch. 1–3 · 19 · 38–42

WHERE WE ARE

Nowhere in particular, on purpose. Uz isn't Israel, and there's no temple and no law. It's a placeless story built to test one idea to destruction, the idea that suffering is earned. INTERPRETATION It reads as an argument with Deuteronomy.

WHAT HAPPENS

A blameless man loses everything as the subject of a wager in heaven he never learns about. Three friends spend round after round of speeches, most of the book, explaining with impeccable orthodoxy that he must have deserved it. He refuses to agree and accuses God to God's face. God answers from a whirlwind with questions, and afterward tells the friends they were wrong and Job was right.

WHO MATTERS

Job · his wife, who has one devastating line · Eliphaz, Bildad and Zophar · Elihu · the voice from the whirlwind

WHAT IT WRESTLES WITH

Whether God is fair, and whether piety that refuses to lie about pain counts as faith. The verdict is startling. The man who accused God is commended, and the men who defended God with correct doctrine are rebuked (Job 42.7).

> *My lips will not speak falsehood.*
> JOB 27.4

NOTES ON THE TEXT

MARGINALIA

✣ *See also:* Deuteronomy, this section · Ecclesiastes, focused study F2.

YOURS

TKC

DOMINION

Job, for the novel

WHAT IT GIVES TKC

Authority for the character who refuses the official explanation of her own suffering, and the canon's own proof that the pious answer can be the wrong one.

WHAT DOMINION WOULD DO

POSSIBLE Teach the first two chapters and the last. Patient endurance and restored fortunes preach well. A man winning an argument with God doesn't.

QUESTIONS THIS RAISES ABOUT TKC

WHERE THIS BOOK IS ALREADY IN THE MANUSCRIPT, OR SHOULD BE

Psalms

one hundred fifty psalms in five books · Book xix of lxvi

OT | START: LITURGY

WHERE WE ARE

In public worship, over centuries. It's a hymnbook and a liturgy assembled from many hands, and among the most quoted books in the collection, which makes it one of the most fought over.

WHAT HAPPENS

Every emotion a religion will admit to, in a set of fixed forms: praise, thanksgiving, royal coronation songs and, in the largest group, lament, where the speaker accuses God of absence and demands an answer. Some psalms curse enemies in language no state would print. One asks how long God intends to hide. Psalm 88 ends in darkness with no answer at all.

WHO MATTERS

No characters. The speaker is a voice, sometimes a king, sometimes a fugitive, sometimes a congregation, often a person alone at night.

WHAT IT WRESTLES WITH

Whether God can be addressed honestly. The remarkable thing is that complaint is a liturgical form here. The tradition built official language for accusing its own God, and most institutions afterward stopped using it.

> *How long will you hide your face from me?*
> PS 13.1

NOTES ON THE TEXT

READ FIRST

Ps 13 · 22 · 23 · 51 · 88 · 137 · 139 · 146

MARGINALIA

✣ *See also:* The prayer pages, Part III.

YOURS

TKC

DOMINION

Psalms, for the novel

WHAT IT GIVES TKC

A liturgy bank, and the lament form, which gives a character a sanctioned way to say the unsayable in public. A forbidden psalm is a very small, very dangerous object.

WHAT DOMINION WOULD DO

POSSIBLE Keep the praise and the royal psalms and retire the laments to a clergy-only volume. An empire can't hold mass worship on a text that teaches the congregation to ask where God has gone.

QUESTIONS THIS RAISES ABOUT TKC

WHERE THIS BOOK IS ALREADY IN THE MANUSCRIPT, OR SHOULD BE

Proverbs · Ecclesiastes · Song of Songs

Three books read against each other. Life is orderly. Life is vapor. And the third, which ignores both and looks at a body.

PROVERBS · THIRTY-ONE CHAPTERS	Instruction for young men entering public life: work hard, hold your tongue, avoid the wrong woman. Wisdom herself is a woman who shouts in the streets and was present at creation (Prov 8), the boldest female figure in the Old Testament and rarely preached as one. It closes with a formidable woman running an estate, usually quoted at wives as a domestic standard. **For TKC:** the exact register of Dominion's advice literature, and the awkward fact that its own ideal woman is a businesswoman.
ECCLESIASTES · TWELVE CHAPTERS	A man with unlimited resources tests every route to meaning and reports that all of it is vapor, that the wise and the fool meet the same end and that memory doesn't last (2.16). Its counsel is small. Enjoy your bread and your work, with the person you love, for the days you have (9.7–10). **For TKC:** the voice of someone inside the palace who has stopped believing the palace means anything. Devastating in a courtier's mouth.
SONG OF SONGS · EIGHT CHAPTERS	Erotic poetry, unembarrassed, with no mention of marriage, children or duty, and God named at most once, in a disputed word in 8.6. The woman speaks most of the lines, takes the initiative and is never rebuked for it. Centuries of allegorical reading exist mainly to make it respectable. **For TKC:** desire with scriptural standing, and a woman's voice as the loudest in the book. The Empire's most awkward inheritance.

WHAT DOMINION WOULD DO WITH ALL THREE

POSSIBLE Teach Proverbs as law, allegorize the Song until the bodies disappear, and leave Ecclesiastes out of the provincial edition.

WHAT THE SONG IS

Whether it's human love poetry or an allegory of divine love has been argued for two thousand years. Which one Dominion teaches decides what the characters are allowed to want.

PROV 8

PROV 31.10–31

ECCL 1–3

ECCL 9.7–10

SONG 8.6

MISHNAH YADAYIM 3.5

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

QUESTIONS THIS RAISES ABOUT TKC

How prophecy works

A prophet in this collection is less a fortune teller than someone who stands in public and tells a government what it's doing, in the name of a God the government also claims. Most of the job is that, and it explains why so many of them are run out of town, imprisoned or killed. Very little in these seventeen books is about the distant future. Nearly all of it is about the harvest, the courts, the treasury, the treaty and who's being crushed this season.

The form is consistent. There's an accusation naming a specific injustice, a verdict, and very often a reversal, the promise that something will be rebuilt after the collapse. Empires like the third part and get nervous about the first. A state religion teaches the prophets as comfort literature and hopes nobody reads the accusations closely enough to notice they're itemized: unjust weights, seized land, bribed judges, unpaid workers, widows without recourse and refugees turned away. Two more things. The prophets attack worship itself, viciously, when it sits alongside exploitation. The festivals are hated, the offerings refused and the singing called noise. It's some of the most anti-clerical literature in existence, and it's in the canon. False prophecy is a live theme too, and the test isn't only accuracy. **INTERPRETATION** The false prophet in these books is usually the one who tells power what it wants to hear (Jer 23, 28).

> *I hate, I despise your festivals… Take away from me the noise of your songs… But let justice roll down like waters.*
>
> AMOS 5.21–24

WHAT DOMINION DOES WITH THEM

POSSIBLE Reads the consolation passages at state occasions and treats the accusations as history, a complaint against ancient kings long settled. The office of prophet is folded into the priesthood, so anyone claiming it independently is unlicensed by definition.

OT | PROPHETS

THE SEVENTEEN

Isaiah · Jeremiah · Lamentations · Ezekiel · Daniel · and the Twelve, Hosea through Malachi

WHAT THIS GIVES TKC

A tradition of sanctioned public speech against the state, sitting inside the Empire's own scripture. A dissident doesn't need a new ideology. She needs a lectionary and the nerve to read the unabridged version aloud.

MARGINALIA

✤ *See also:* Focused studies F3, Ezekiel, and F7, the Twelve.

YOURS

PROPHECY

Who in the novel is a prophet

WHO IN MY NOVEL IS A PROPHET, AND WHO DECIDES

WHICH ACCUSATIONS FROM THE PROPHETS WOULD LAND HARDEST IN DOMINION, WORD FOR WORD

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHAT HAPPENS TO SOMEONE WHO READS ONE OF THEM ALOUD

OT | PROPHET

READ FIRST

Ch. 1 · 6 · 11 · 40 · 53 · 56 · 58

MARGINALIA

Isaiah

sixty-six chapters · Book xxiii of lxvi

WHERE WE ARE

Across three crises and, by the majority scholarly view, at least three sets of hands: a kingdom under Assyrian threat (ch. 1–39), the exile (40–55) and the disappointing return (56–66). One scroll, three eras, and the seams show. **CONTESTED** Traditional readers keep the whole book with the eighth-century prophet.

WHAT HAPPENS

It opens by telling a devout nation God is sick of its worship because its hands are full of blood. After that come judgment, a throne-room vision and the great reversals: swords into plowshares, a child ruler, a banquet for all peoples. Later a servant appears who is despised, silent and destroyed on other people's behalf. It ends with new heavens and a new earth, and a promise aimed squarely at eunuchs and foreigners (ch. 56).

WHO MATTERS

Isaiah · Ahaz · Hezekiah · Cyrus, a foreign king called God's anointed (45.1) · the suffering servant

WHAT IT WRESTLES WITH

Whether God's people are the point or the instrument. It keeps widening the circle, to the nations, to the excluded, to a foreign emperor, and every widening rebukes somebody's purity project.

> *Your hands are full of blood.*
> ISA 1.15

NOTES ON THE TEXT

✣ *See also:* Jesus and the kingdom, Part III.

Isaiah, for the novel

YOURS

TKC

DOMINION

WHAT IT GIVES TKC

The Empire's grandest liturgical language and its sharpest indictment in one scroll. Also the servant, authority through humiliation, the one model of power Dominion can't use.

WHAT DOMINION WOULD DO

POSSIBLE Quote the coming king constantly and never read chapter one aloud. The promise to eunuchs and foreigners gets footnoted as future and spiritual.

QUESTIONS THIS RAISES ABOUT TKC

WHERE THIS BOOK IS ALREADY IN THE MANUSCRIPT, OR SHOULD BE

JER 20

JER 26

JER 32

JER 36

JER 38

LAM 1–5

LAM 3.22–23

Jeremiah · Lamentations

The collapse, and the sound a city makes afterward.

CONTENT NOTE Siege famine and the deaths of children, Lamentations 2 and 4.

JEREMIAH · FIFTY-TWO CHAPTERS	Forty years of telling a capital city it's going to fall, and being hated for it. He's beaten and put in the stocks (ch. 20), put on trial for his life (ch. 26), lowered into a muddy cistern (ch. 38) and accused of weakening the soldiers' morale, all by his own government, while the official prophets promise the city can't be taken. He's right. It falls. The king cuts his scroll apart column by column as it's read and burns it, so he dictates it again (ch. 36). His complaints to God are bitter enough to embarrass. He accuses God of deceiving him and curses the day he was born. In the middle of the siege he buys a field, on the record, as a bet there'll be a country again (ch. 32). **For TKC:** the licensed prophets against the one tried for treason. Also the burned scroll, and the fact that he simply wrote it again.
LAMENTATIONS · FIVE CHAPTERS	Five poems over the ruins of the city. The first four are alphabetical acrostics, grief given the strictest possible structure because structure is all that's left, and the fifth keeps the twenty-two lines without the alphabet. It describes famine, mothers and children and the silence of God without excusing any of it, and it doesn't resolve. One passage in the middle says mercy is new every morning, and the book doesn't pretend that settles anything. **For TKC:** the register for the worst chapter. Grief as a disciplined public form, and a text the Empire can't ban because it's scripture and can't use because it blames the leadership.

WHAT DOMINION WOULD DO

POSSIBLE Teach Jeremiah as a warning about national sin, never about state censorship, and read only the mercy verse from Lamentations, on one fixed day of the year.

PUNISHMENT OR GEOGRAPHY

Whether the fall was punishment or what happens to small states between empires. Jeremiah says the first. The events also support the second.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

QUESTIONS THIS RAISES ABOUT TKC

EZEK 4–5

EZEK 10–11

EZEK 18

EZEK 24

EZEK 34

EZEK 37

DAN 1–6

DAN 7–12

1 MACC 1

Ezekiel · Daniel

Both written from inside somebody else's empire.

EZEKIEL · FORTY-EIGHT CHAPTERS	A deported priest with no temple to serve, receiving visions of extravagant strangeness: wheels full of eyes, the glory of God rising out of the temple and leaving the city eastward (ch. 10–11), a valley of dry bones standing up as an army (ch. 37). He performs his messages more than he speaks them, lying on one side for months, baking bread over dung, shaving his head. When his wife dies he's told not to mourn in public, as a sign. His indictment of the shepherds of Israel (ch. 34) is one of the sharpest attacks on a ruling class in the collection. You fed yourselves, you clothed yourselves with the wool, and you didn't seek the lost. He also insists a child doesn't carry a parent's guilt (ch. 18), which cuts straight against collective punishment. **For TKC:** INTERPRETATION: the mobile God. If the glory can leave the temple and appear to the deported by a foreign river, no state can hold it by holding the building.
DANIEL · TWELVE CHAPTERS	Half court stories, half apocalypse, and the whole book is about keeping your integrity inside a regime that owns your career. Young captives are trained for imperial service and renamed. They negotiate over food, refuse to bow to a statue, survive a furnace and read the dreams the empire's own experts can't. A king goes mad, and another sees writing appear on his banquet wall and is dead that night. The visions in the second half show successive empires as beasts. **INFERENCE** Most scholars date them to the persecution under Antiochus IV around 167 BCE, long after the story's setting, which is how coded resistance literature works. **For TKC:** the manual for a character inside the Ministry. Serve competently, refuse at one precise point, and let the refusal be public.

WHAT DOMINION WOULD DO

POSSIBLE Teach Daniel as a story about personal purity, diet, prayer discipline and courage under trial, and never as a story about refusing to bow to a state image.

WHAT THESE GIVE TKC

Ezekiel's shepherds as an indictment of the clergy, and his rule that guilt isn't inherited, the passage that takes collective punishment apart.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

QUESTIONS THIS RAISES ABOUT TKC

HOS 1–3

JOEL 2.28–29

AMOS 2.6

AMOS 7.10–15

OBAD 11–14

JONAH 4

The Twelve

Hosea through Jonah. Short, furious and mostly about money. The Hebrew Bible counts all twelve as a single book.

BOOK	WHAT IT IS	WHAT IT GIVES TKC
HOSEA · 14 CH.	A prophet's marriage staged as national metaphor. The nation's failure is told through a wife accused of infidelity, with stripping and public shaming as the announced punishment, beside some of the tenderest reconciliation language in scripture.	Covenant as marriage, the theology behind Dominion's whole language of wifely duty.
JOEL · 3 CH.	A locust plague read as the day of the Lord, ending with the spirit poured out on sons and daughters, old and young, and on servants, a word translations render as household servants or as enslaved men and women.	Prophecy for everyone. If daughters prophesy, the Ministry's monopoly is a scriptural error.
AMOS · 9 CH.	A herdsman from Judah goes north and denounces a prosperous kingdom for selling the needy for a pair of sandals. The royal priest tells him to go home.	Some of the most quotable indictment of a comfortable religious state in existence.
OBADIAH · 1 CH.	One chapter aimed at a neighboring nation for standing by and profiting while a city was sacked.	Complicity as its own crime. The bystander province.
JONAH · 4 CH.	Often read as satire. A prophet runs from an order to preach to the enemy capital, is swallowed, obeys, succeeds, and sulks because God spared them.	Mercy for the enemy, and a believer who finds it unbearable.

NOTES

The Twelve, continued

Micah through Malachi. The Old Testament in Christian order ends by auditing its own clergy.

BOOK	WHAT IT IS	WHAT IT GIVES TKC
MICAH · 7 CH.	Judgment on rulers who eat their own people, and the collection's clearest summary of the whole demand. Do justice, love kindness, walk humbly.	Three phrases that fit on a wall, and indict the wall's owner.
NAHUM · 3 CH.	The fall of an imperial capital, described with something close to relish.	What the provinces sing when the center burns.
HABAKKUK · 3 CH.	A prophet argues with God about why injustice is permitted, gets a reply that doesn't answer the question, and ends in waiting and trust.	Faith as an argument you lose and stay in.
ZEPHANIAH · 3 CH.	A total judgment on the ruling class, with the officials and the king's sons named first and a humble remnant left over.	The purge sermon the Ministry would love, aimed at itself.
HAGGAI · 2 CH.	Rebuild the temple, said to people living in paneled houses while the site lies in ruins.	State religion as a construction project.
ZECHARIAH · 14 CH.	Night visions, a high priest re-robed in a heavenly courtroom, and a king who comes on a donkey and not a warhorse.	Ceremony as legitimation, and power that refuses the cavalry.
MALACHI · 4 CH.	An audit of the priesthood: blemished offerings, withheld tithes, men abandoning the wives of their youth. Its closing lines promise Elijah before the day of the Lord.	Corrupt priests, on the record, in the Empire's own book.

CORRECTION TO THE OLD COMPANION The old page said the last word of the Old Testament is an accusation against clergy. The audit is Malachi 1–2. The last verses (4.5–6) promise Elijah and warn of a curse. In the Hebrew order, the Bible ends with Cyrus's decree in 2 Chronicles.

WHICH OF THE TWELVE IS BANNED IN DOMINION, AND WHY

MIC 3
MIC 6.8
HAB 1–3
ZEPH 1.8
HAG 1.4
ZECH 3
ZECH 9.9
MAL 1–2
MAL 4.5–6

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH OF THE TWELVE IS BANNED IN DOMINION, AND WHY

Four accounts

NT GOSPELS

There are four of these, and they don't match, which is the most useful thing about them. The differences are four communities, decades apart, deciding what mattered about one life. Most people who quote the gospels are quoting a blend of all four that exists in no manuscript, and untangling the blend is the same act of attention your characters will have to perform on Dominion's teaching.

MARK · EARLIEST, SHORTEST	Urgent and bleak. No birth story. The disciples never quite understand him, his family thinks he's out of his mind, and he keeps telling people to say nothing. In the earliest manuscripts it ends at 16.8, with women running from an empty tomb, afraid, telling no one. Read this one first.
MATTHEW · THE TEACHER	Argues that this is the fulfillment of the law, so it's built in five great blocks of teaching and cites scripture constantly. Its genealogy includes four women besides Mary, Tamar, Rahab, Ruth and "the wife of Uriah," on purpose. Holds the Sermon on the Mount, the Lord's Prayer and a whole chapter denouncing religious authorities by title (ch. 23).
LUKE · THE REVERSAL	Keeps women, foreigners and the poor in the frame. It opens with a young woman singing that the powerful will be pulled from their thrones and the hungry filled, and it's the only gospel that names women paying for the whole operation (8.1–3). Its parables are the most economically pointed in scripture.
JOHN · THEOLOGY AT ALTITUDE	Long discourses, cosmic language and seven signs. It gives one of the longest conversations in the gospels to a foreign woman at a well, has Martha make the central confession of faith (11.27), and makes Mary Magdalene the first person the risen Jesus speaks to, sent to tell the men.

WHAT THIS GIVES TKC

A character who finds two accounts that disagree. The crisis isn't faith. It's about who did the editing, which is far more dangerous.

CORRECTION TO THE OLD COMPANION The old page called Mary a pregnant teenager. Luke never gives her age. It's an inference from ancient marriage customs.

MARGINALIA

✣ *See also:* The Gospel Grid, Part III.

YOURS

GOSPELS

Which gospel Dominion preaches

WHAT DOMINION WOULD DO

POSSIBLE Publish one harmonized life of Christ and retire the four. A single official account can't be cross-examined, and the women at the tomb can be edited into a footnote.

WHICH GOSPEL DOES DOMINION PREACH FROM, AND WHICH DOES IT LEAVE ON THE SHELF

ONE SCENE THE FOUR TELL DIFFERENTLY, AND WHAT EACH VERSION PROTECTS

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHO IN THE NOVEL HAS READ ALL FOUR

NT | START: RESISTANCE

READ FIRST

Ch. 2 · 4–5 · 8 · 12 · 15 · 16

MARGINALIA

ACTS

twenty-eight chapters · Book xliv of lxvi

WHERE WE ARE

An unlicensed movement spreading across the Roman world with no buildings, no budget and no legal standing, meeting mostly in homes, borrowed rooms and courtrooms.

WHAT HAPPENS

A spirit arrives and everyone hears in their own language. The first community pools its property. A couple who lie about money fall dead. A persecutor is converted on a road. Next comes the great fight over whether outsiders have to adopt the law to belong, settled by a meeting in Jerusalem (ch. 15). Again and again the meeting place is a woman's house, Mary's in Jerusalem (12.12) and Lydia's in Philippi (16.15, 40).

WHO MATTERS

Peter · Stephen · Philip · Paul · Tabitha · Lydia · Priscilla · the Ethiopian official · Gamaliel

WHAT IT WRESTLES WITH

Who's allowed in, and who decides. Every widening of the boundary is resisted first by insiders and accepted after somebody tells a story about what they saw.

> *All who believed were together and had all things in common.*
> ACTS 2.44

NOTES ON THE TEXT

✤ *See also:* Lydia, Part II · Religious institutions, Part IV.

ACTS, FOR THE NOVEL

YOURS

TKC

DOMINION

WHAT IT GIVES TKC

A working model for an underground network: house meetings, women as hosts and patrons, decisions reached by argument and a shared purse. Everything the resistance needs, sourced from scripture.

WHAT DOMINION WOULD DO

POSSIBLE Read it as the founding of the institution and drop the story of an unlicensed movement. The shared property becomes a temporary emergency measure, and the women's houses become hospitality.

QUESTIONS THIS RAISES ABOUT TKC

WHERE THIS BOOK IS ALREADY IN THE MANUSCRIPT, OR SHOULD BE

NT | LETTERS

TWO LIVE ARGUMENTS

Whether the household codes are timeless order or first-century accommodation. And whether 1 Cor 14.34–35 is original, since some manuscripts place it after verse 40. Junia's name and title have been fought over too.

A PATTERN WORTH NOTICING

INTERPRETATION The letters scholars most doubt are Paul's, the Pastorals above all, are the ones most concerned with hierarchy.

WHAT DOMINION WOULD DO

POSSIBLE Teach the letters as legislation, print them without their addressees, and never mention who carried them.

✤ *See also:* Module ix, The household verse · Part IV.

How to read a letter

Twenty-one of the twenty-seven books in this half are letters, and almost every doctrine an empire has built on them depends on forgetting it. They're one side of a correspondence, written to a named group in a specific mess, and reading them is like finding a single reply in someone's desk drawer without the original complaint.

So the discipline is simple. Before pulling out any rule, ask what problem the writer is answering, whether the instruction goes to a whole community, one household or one troublemaker, and whether the same author says something different elsewhere. He often does. The man who tells one congregation women should be silent greets women leading congregations in another letter, calls Phoebe a deacon (Rom 16.1) and names Junia among the apostles (Rom 16.7).

THE FOUR BIG ONES

Romans, the long argument about who belongs and on what basis. **INFERENCE** Phoebe carried it to Rome and would have been the one to answer questions about it. **1 Corinthians**, a congregation tearing itself apart over status, food and sex, with the love chapter nobody reads in context. **Galatians**, furious, about whether outsiders must assimilate to belong. **Ephesians**, where a household code sits directly under the line about mutual submission (5.21).

THE REST

Philippians, written from prison, unreasonably joyful, with a hymn about power given up. **Colossians** and **1–2 Thessalonians**, practical and watching for the end. **Philemon**, a private note about an enslaved man and one of the most argued-over pages in the abolition debate. **1–2 Timothy and Titus**, church management: who may teach, who may be appointed, how widows are enrolled. **Hebrews**, a long sermon arguing the old sacrificial system is finished. **James**, brutally direct about the rich and favoritism in the assembly. **1–2 Peter, 1–3 John and Jude**, staying faithful while powerless, with warnings about teachers in it for the money.

One letter, both sides

PICK ONE INSTRUCTION DOMINION ENFORCES. WHAT PROBLEM WAS THE LETTER ANSWERING

WRITE THE MISSING LETTER, THE ONE THE CONGREGATION SENT FIRST

NT | START: DOMINION

READ FIRST

Ch. 2–3 · 5 · 12–13 · 17–18 · 21

MARGINALIA

Revelation

twenty-two chapters · Book lxvi of lxvi

WHERE WE ARE

On the island of Patmos, "because of the word of God" (1.9), writing to seven congregations under pressure from an empire whose emperors were worshiped as gods. INFERENCE Tradition says he was exiled there. Either way it's dissident literature, written in code.

WHAT HAPPENS

Seven letters assessing seven churches, several of them harshly. The visions follow: a slaughtered lamb on the throne, seals and trumpets and bowls, a beast whose authority comes from a dragon, a mark required to buy and sell, and a gorgeously dressed city called a prostitute whose fall is mourned by merchants because their trade is ruined. It ends with that city replaced by a new one whose gates never close.

WHO MATTERS

John of Patmos · the lamb · the dragon and the beast · the woman clothed with the sun · the merchants, who are the ones who weep

WHAT IT WRESTLES WITH

Whether empires end. Its answer is that they do, that their economy gives them away, and that the throne belongs to something that was killed and not to something that kills.

> *Come out of her, my people.*
> REV 18.4

NOTES ON THE TEXT

✣ *See also:* The shape of the New Testament, Revelation, module v.

Revelation, for the novel

YOURS

TKC

DOMINION

WHAT IT GIVES TKC

A whole visual and rhetorical vocabulary: marks, seals, thrones, beasts, a bride, a prostitute, gates that never close. And the political core, an empire's fall told through the grief of its merchants.

WHAT DOMINION WOULD DO

POSSIBLE Move the whole thing to the distant future and appoint itself the interpreter. If the beast is always still coming, it can never be the government in the room.

QUESTIONS THIS RAISES ABOUT TKC

WHERE THIS BOOK IS ALREADY IN THE MANUSCRIPT, OR SHOULD BE

NOTES

ANYTHING THIS SPREAD STARTED AND DID NOT FINISH

F1

FOCUSED STUDY SPREAD

Numbers

Census, camp, and the two petitions

SOURCE MARGIN

NUM 1–36

MT · LXX

MILGROM, NUMBERS (JPS)

LEVINE, NUMBERS (AB)

Return of the Household

REGISTRY FORM H-1

FILED UNDER THE DOMINION ACT · ONE COPY TO THE TEMPLE, ONE TO THE CROWN

HOUSEHOLD OF	_____
AUTHORITY LINE	*the adult male on record*
COUNTED	*men of age, by house*
REGISTERED APART	*Vowed, Temple staff*
LEFT UNCOUNTED	_____
DEPENDENTS	*entered under the authority line*
DESIGNATION	*to be assigned*

Numbers 1 counts men twenty and older, by ancestral house, who can go to war. **POSSIBLE**
The Registry's household return is the same form with a newer letterhead.

COUNTED

FOCUSED STUDY F1 · ✣

Numbers

A book that opens by counting everyone and closes by deciding who inherits. Between the two it records every complaint the wilderness produced, and treats some of them as rebellion and others as law.

WHY THIS IS A FOCUSED STUDY

Numbers gives the Empire its census, its camp and its line between an approved petition and a criminal one. Three things, so it gets ten pages and not seventeen.

CAN BE PROMOTED

If the Trials lean harder on census and registration than expected, this spread becomes a full dossier. The review box is on the close-the-spread page.

What it is

NAME	English *Numbers*, from the Greek *Arithmoi* and the Latin *Numeri*, named for its two censuses. The Hebrew name, *Bemidbar*, means "in the wilderness," from the book's opening words. The two traditions name different books.
PLACE	Fourth book of the Torah. It carries the story from Sinai to the edge of the land and holds the material Leviticus doesn't narrate.
STRUCTURE	Three movements by place. Chapters 1–10 at Sinai: counting, camp and departure. Chapters 11–21 in the wilderness: complaint, scouts, condemnation, rebellion, death. Chapters 22–36 on the plains of Moab: Balaam, the second census and the inheritance rulings.
GENRES INSIDE	Census register, itinerary, legal ruling, narrative, poetry, oracle, and a folk tale about a talking donkey. The registers and the stories weren't written to be read the same way.
THE FIGURES	603,550 fighting men in chapter 1 and 601,730 in chapter 26, which implies a population in the millions. **CONTESTED** Whether the numbers are literal. Proposals include a different meaning for the word translated "thousand," schematic totals and later expansion. None is settled.
NEIGHBORS	Ancient Near Eastern military rosters, land grants and boundary records cover the same administrative ground. Reading Numbers beside them shows it as a governing document as well as a story.

WHAT THE BOOK IS ABOUT, IF IT'S ABOUT ONE THING

INTERPRETATION Who is on the list, and what being on the list gets you. Nearly the whole generation counted in chapter 1 is dead by chapter 26, Caleb and Joshua excepted, and most of the generation that inherits wasn't counted the first time.

WHAT I ALREADY THINK THIS BOOK IS, BEFORE READING IT AGAIN

NUM 1.1

NUM 1–10

NUM 11–21

NUM 22–36

MILGROM, NUMBERS

TKC: DOM

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHAT I ALREADY THINK THIS BOOK IS, BEFORE READING IT AGAIN

Counting as governance

NUM 1
NUM 2
NUM 3–4
NUM 26
LEVINE, NUMBERS
TKC: DOM

The census counts men twenty years old and up who can go to war, by ancestral house. What it produces is a military muster, an ancestral register and a marching order. Women and children aren't counted. The Levites are registered separately, by a different rule and from a different age. **INFERENCE** A register like this also served taxation, labor drafts and conscription, judging by ancient Near Eastern practice. Numbers itself doesn't say so.

	FIRST CENSUS · CH. 1	SECOND CENSUS · CH. 26
WHERE	The wilderness of Sinai, the second year out	The plains of Moab, a generation later
PURPOSE	Muster for war and order the camp	Divide the land by the size of each tribe
TOTAL	603,550	601,730, almost the same after forty years of death
WHO SURVIVES	The generation that left Egypt	Of that generation, only Caleb and Joshua
WHAT IT PROVES	The people are numerous, organized and ready	**INTERPRETATION** The promise outlived the people who first received it

THE CAMP · CH. 2

Twelve tribes in fixed positions on four sides, three to a side, each under its own standard, with the Levites in an inner ring around the tabernacle and Moses and Aaron at the entrance. A tribe's place in the camp is assigned, recorded and set up the same way at every stop.

WHAT THE EMPIRE TAKES

POSSIBLE The whole apparatus with the theology intact: a register that decides who exists, a place assigned by house, and the claim that the arrangement is holy. Household registration (**FR 32**) is Numbers 2 on Imperial letterhead.

WHO IS COUNTED IN THE EMPIRE, WHO IS ONLY REGISTERED, AND WHO IS NEITHER

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHO IS COUNTED IN THE EMPIRE, WHO IS ONLY REGISTERED, AND WHO IS NEITHER

Two speak. One is marked.

Numbers 12 is usually summarized as Miriam challenging Moses. The Hebrew is more exact than that. Verse 1 uses a feminine singular verb for the speaking while naming Miriam and Aaron together, and verse 2 shifts to plural speech. Aaron is present in both verses. The punishment falls on one of them.

WHO SPEAKS	Miriam and Aaron, both named, against Moses. The grammar puts Miriam first without removing Aaron.
THE STATED OCCASION	The Cushite woman Moses had married. The text raises her and never comes back to her.
THE REAL CLAIM	Prophetic authority: has the LORD spoken only through Moses? The marriage is the occasion, and the claim is about jurisdiction.
THE REPLY	A divine speech that separates how God speaks to prophets in general from how God speaks to Moses. It ranks the office and doesn't deny that others prophesy.
THE PUNISHMENT	Miriam's skin is struck with a scaling disease, described as white. Aaron gets no visible punishment. He pleads for her, Moses intercedes, and she's shut outside the camp seven days.
THE DETAIL NOBODY QUOTES	The people don't move on until she's brought back. The whole march waits for the woman it just expelled.

WHAT THE TEXT DOESN'T SAY

It never explains why only Miriam is marked, and it doesn't rank their guilt. Interpreters have supplied reasons for centuries. Some point to the feminine verb in verse 1. Some argue that a high priest with a skin disease would have shut down the sanctuary. INTERPRETATION The grammar is real, and what it's supposed to justify is never stated. The silence is part of the text.

WHERE I'VE SEEN THIS ASYMMETRY: IN THE TEXT, IN CHURCHES, IN THE EMPIRE, IN MY OWN CHAPTERS

NUM 12.1

NUM 12.2–8

NUM 12.9–16

EXOD 15 (MIRIAM THE PROPHET)

TRIBLE, "BRINGING MIRIAM OUT"

TKC: MIRIAM

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHERE I'VE SEEN THIS ASYMMETRY: IN THE TEXT, IN CHURCHES, IN THE EMPIRE, IN MY OWN CHAPTERS

Korah and the daughters

NUM 16

NUM 17

NUM 27.1–11

NUM 36

JOSH 17.3–6

TKC: TR · DOM

These aren't the same act with different results. They differ in who brings them, what's asked, how and where it's asked, and how the narrator frames them. Side by side, the question isn't whether Numbers approves of dissent. It's which petitions this authority is able to hear.

	KORAH · CH. 16	ZELOPHEHAD'S DAUGHTERS · CH. 27
WHO	Korah the Levite, Dathan, Abiram and On of Reuben, and 250 men of standing	Mahlah, Noah, Hoglah, Milcah and Tirzah, five sisters, each named
ASKS FOR	Priestly access: the holiness of the whole congregation against Aaron's sole office	An inheritance in their father's name, since he died without sons
METHOD	An assembly against Moses and Aaron, then a censer test of authority	They stand before Moses, Eleazar, the chiefs and the whole congregation at the tent of meeting and state their case
FRAMING	The narrator calls it rebellion before the reader can weigh it	The narrator reports the petition without a verdict and lets the ruling answer it
MOSES	Falls on his face, then proposes the test	Takes the case to the LORD instead of deciding it himself
OUTCOME	The ground opens and fire consumes the 250. Chapter 17 secures Aaron's office again with a budding staff.	Granted, and made a general law of inheritance
AFTERWARD	Korah's line survives as singers, the sons of Korah, named in the Psalms headings	Chapter 36 narrows the win: they must marry within their father's tribe so the land stays put. Granted, then fenced.

THE QUESTION TO CARRY, NOT THE CONCLUSION TO PRINT

INTERPRETATION A petition that works through the system's own procedure, asks for a defined thing and leaves the office alone can be granted and written into law. One that contests who holds the office is answered with the ground.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH PETITION IS EDEN BRINGING, AND DOES SHE KNOW WHICH ONE IT LOOKS LIKE TO THE TEMPLE?

Build the procedure

WRITING

NUM 27

NUM 36

TKC: TR · DOM

The Empire has an approved petition and a criminal one, and Numbers gives you the template for both. Draft the Empire's version here. This page is source material for the Trials, not a study exercise.

1 · WHAT A LAWFUL PETITION LOOKS LIKE IN THE EMPIRE: WHO MAY BRING IT, WHERE, AND IN WHOSE PRESENCE

2 · THE LINE A PETITION CROSSES TO BECOME SEDITION, AND WHO DECIDES IT'S BEEN CROSSED

3 · THE CHAPTER 36 MOVE: A CONCESSION THAT'S LATER FENCED. WHERE DOES THE EMPIRE DO THIS?

4 · A SCENE WHERE A WOMAN WINS SOMETHING REAL AND THE WIN IS NARROWED AT ONCE

NUM 11

NUM 13–14

NUM 20

NUM 21.4–9

2 KGS 18.4

NUM 22–24

NUM 27.12–23

Forty years of consequence

THE SCOUTS AND THE CONDEMNED GENERATION · 13–14

Twelve are sent to see the land. All twelve agree it's fertile, ten judge the inhabitants unbeatable, and Caleb and Joshua dissent. The people side with the ten, and the generation is told it won't enter: forty years, a year for each day of scouting. **INTERPRETATION** Whether there's a line between describing an obstacle honestly and making it grounds for refusal is a question the text raises and doesn't settle.

COMPLAINT AS A GENRE · 11, 20, 21

Food, water, leadership, and Egypt remembered as better than freedom. The complaints repeat by design. Moses complains too, at length, and isn't punished for it, which is worth holding beside Miriam's page.

THE BRONZE SERPENT · 21:4–9

Serpents are sent, and Moses is told to make a bronze one. Anyone who looks at it lives. Centuries later Hezekiah destroys it because people had started making offerings to it (2 Kgs 18:4). A commanded object becomes one that has to be destroyed.

WHAT THE WILDERNESS LOOKS LIKE IN THE EMPIRE'S TEACHING

Seers and successors

NUM 22–24

NUM 31.16

2 PET 2.15

NUM 27.12–23

TKC: TR

BALAAM AND THE DONKEY · 22–24

A foreign seer is hired by Balak of Moab to curse Israel. His donkey sees the divine messenger before he does, and speaks. He then blesses Israel four times. Later texts, in Numbers 31 and in the New Testament, treat Balaam as a villain, so the Balaam of chapters 22–24 and the Balaam of later memory behave very differently.

LEADERSHIP PASSED ON · 27:12–23

Joshua is commissioned in public, by the laying on of hands before Eleazar and the congregation, while Moses is still alive. Succession here is a witnessed ceremony and not an inheritance.

WHAT THE EMPIRE HARVESTS FROM THE MIDDLE

POSSIBLE A theology of delay. If the wilderness is punishment for an earlier generation's failure of nerve, any hardship now can be explained as inherited discipline, and endurance becomes the whole of obedience. The Trials' Endurance phase (**TR**) is this doctrine with a broadcast schedule.

WHICH OF THESE FIVE I ACTUALLY NEED, AND FOR WHICH CHAPTER

WRITING

SPREAD CLOSE

QUEUE: F1

What I take out of Numbers

THE ONE THING THIS BOOK CHANGED ABOUT HOW I SEE THE EMPIRE

WHAT I STILL DON'T UNDERSTAND. CARRY IT TO THE RESEARCH LIST.

A LINE, AN IMAGE OR A PROCEDURE I'M TAKING STRAIGHT INTO THE MANUSCRIPT

PROMOTION REVIEW *log only, no promotion is made here*

Numbers is a focused study, and it can be promoted to a full dossier. Promote it if two or more of these turn out true: the census becomes structural to the Trials and not background, Miriam's punishment becomes a load-bearing precedent for how the Empire treats women who speak, the petition contrast drives a real plot decision, or these writing pages fill up and run out of room.

DECISION | DATE | PAGES NEEDED

NOTES

OPEN NOTES

ANYTHING THIS SPREAD STARTED AND DIDN'T FINISH

NOTES

ANYTHING THIS SPREAD STARTED AND DID NOT FINISH

F4

FOCUSED STUDY SPREAD

1 and 2 Chronicles

The same history told again, for a different congregation

SOURCE MARGIN

1–2 CHR

MT · LXX

JAPHET, I & II CHRONICLES (OTL)

KNOPPERS, 1 CHRONICLES (AB)

The Register of Households

COVENANT RECORD, VOL. I

ENTERED BY THE TEMPLE CLERK · CERTIFIED TRUE TO THE OLDER ROLLS

LINE OF	_____
DESCENDED FROM	*entered as far back as the rolls allow*
STANDING	*priestly · landed · resident · none on record*
WOMEN NAMED	_____ *(enter where the line runs through her)*
CERTIFIED BY	_____

First Chronicles 1–9 runs from Adam to the settlers of Jerusalem, name by name. ***POSSIBLE*** *Dominion's household register (**FR 32**) is the same instrument, kept for the opposite reason.*

ENTERED

FOCUSED STUDY F4 · ✣

1 and 2 Chronicles

The same centuries, told again by someone with a temple to justify and a congregation to hold together. What it leaves out is famous. What it adds is more interesting.

WHY THIS IS A FOCUSED STUDY

Chronicles isn't a new story. It's a second telling. Nine pages are enough to hold what changed, why a community after the exile would want it changed, and what an empire learns from a sanctioned retelling.

READ IT AGAINST SAMUEL–KINGS

This spread only works in comparison. Keep a Samuel–Kings text open beside it, or the differences stay invisible.

What it is

NAME	The Hebrew title, *Divrei Hayyamim*, means "the events of the days," an annals title. The Greek tradition called it *Paraleipomena*, "the things left out," which is a judgment about the book wearing the clothes of a label.
WHERE IT SITS	In the Jewish ordering it's the last book of the whole Bible, and it ends with a Persian king telling the exiles to go up. In the Christian ordering it sits after Kings, in the middle. Same text, two different final words.
WHEN AND BY WHOM	Anonymous, and generally placed in the Persian period, after the return. Whether the same hand wrote Ezra–Nehemiah was long assumed and is now widely questioned. Treat "the Chronicler" as a label for an unknown writer and not as an identified person.
STRUCTURE	Nine chapters of genealogy. David, at length. Solomon and the temple. The kings of Judah only, down to the exile, closing with the decree of Cyrus. The northern kingdom mostly isn't its subject.
ITS SOURCES	It draws on Samuel and Kings, often nearly word for word, and also cites records the reader can't check. It's a book openly built out of other books, which makes it the Bible's clearest case of a tradition editing itself.
ITS PURPOSE	Theological, liturgical and genealogical, written for a community after the exile that needed to know it was continuous with what came before. INTERPRETATION Calling it "the authorized version" or "state-sponsored scripture" is an argument about that purpose. Use those phrases as arguments you're making and never as facts you're reporting.

WHAT THE BOOK IS ACTUALLY DOING

INTERPRETATION Proving that a small, occupied province with a rebuilt temple is the same people as the kingdom in the old stories. Continuity is the argument, the genealogies are the evidence and the temple is the proof.

1 CHR 1–9

2 CHR 36.22–23

JAPHET, I & II CHRONICLES

WILLIAMSON, ISRAEL IN CHRONICLES

1–2 KGS (COMPARE)

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHAT I ASSUMED CHRONICLES WAS, BEFORE READING IT NEXT TO KINGS

Subtraction and addition

2 SAM 11–12

1 CHR 3.5

2 SAM 24 · 1 CHR 21

2 CHR 29–31

2 CHR 33.10–20

KNOPPERS, 1 CHRONICLES

The omissions are the famous part and the least interesting way to read the book. Chronicles also adds a great deal Samuel–Kings doesn't have, and keeps damaging material it could easily have dropped. Study the pattern and not only the gaps.

MATERIAL	WHAT CHRONICLES DOES WITH IT
BATHSHEBA AND URIAH	The story isn't retold. Bathsheba isn't erased. She appears in David's genealogy as the mother of Solomon and three other sons, under the name Bath-shua (1 Chr 3.5). The dynastic record keeps her, and the scandal is absent.
AMNON, TAMAR, ABSALOM	The household violence and the revolt aren't retold. The reign comes through war, worship and preparation for the temple instead.
DAVID'S CENSUS	Kept, with the plague and the deaths. Where Samuel says the LORD incited David, Chronicles says an adversary did (1 Chr 21.1). The sin stays and the attribution moves. **INTERPRETATION** A book doing pure whitewash wouldn't have kept the chapter.
LEVITES, SINGERS, MUSICIANS	Added, extensively. Named guilds, rotas, instruments and duties Samuel–Kings barely mentions. For what a working sanctuary staff looked like, this is the source.
HEZEKIAH'S PASSOVER	Added. A mass reform and festival, with invitations sent north to people outside Judah's jurisdiction. A reunification liturgy (2 Chr 30).
MANASSEH	Added. Kings gives Judah's worst king no redemption. Chronicles has him taken to Babylon with hooks, pray and be restored (2 Chr 33.11–13). **INTERPRETATION** The most theologically loaded addition in the book, since it says no reign is beyond repentance.

HOW TO READ THE OMISSIONS HONESTLY

A retelling that assumes its reader knows the older account isn't the same as one that hides it, and Chronicles points readers to other records. **CONTESTED** "Cover-up" is one available reading. Another is a history written for worship more than for judgment. Hold both, and say which one you're using.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

THE OMISSION I FIND HARDEST TO READ CHARITABLY, AND WHY

One reign, two tellings

WORKSHEET

2 SAM · 1 CHR

1–2 KGS · 2 CHR

Pick one king. Read his reign in Samuel or Kings, then in Chronicles, and log what moved.

	SAMUEL–KINGS	CHRONICLES
King and chapters		
How the reign opens		
What's kept word for word		
What's missing		
What's added		
Who gets the blame		
How it ends		

WHAT THE SECOND TELLING PROTECTS, AND WHO IT PROTECTS IT FOR

1 CHR 1–2

1 CHR 2.34–35

1 CHR 4.9–10

1 CHR 4.18

1 CHR 7.18

1 CHR 7.24

1 CHR 9.1–34

KNOPPERS, 1 CHRONICLES

TKC: DOM

The register as an argument

INTERPRETATION The nine chapters most readers skip are the book's foundation. A community whose records were broken by deportation is establishing, name by name, who belongs, who serves and who holds land. It's the same instrument as Numbers 1, used to prove a people didn't end, where Numbers used it to muster an army.

FROM ADAM FORWARD

The list begins with the first human and narrows to the nations, Israel, the tribes, Judah, David, the priests and Levites, and the settlers of Jerusalem. A funnel. The whole world is in the frame at verse one so the small province at the end can be its point.

THE WOMEN IN THE LISTS

Named women turn up more often than these chapters' reputation suggests. Sheerah builds Lower and Upper Beth-horon and Uzzen-sheerah (7.24). Sheshan has no sons and gives his daughter to Jarha, his Egyptian servant, and the line runs through them (2.34–35). The text records the marriage and the descent and doesn't say she inherits. Hammolecheth is named among Manasseh's descendants (7.18). Bithiah, a daughter of Pharaoh, is recorded as a wife without comment (4.18). Jabez's mother names him (4.9). Nobody preaches these chapters, so nobody notices. Mine them.

WHAT A GENEALOGY DOES POLITICALLY

INTERPRETATION It assigns priestly eligibility, land claims and standing. It also excludes, since to be missing from the register is to have no documented claim. The list is a comfort and a boundary at once.

GAPS AND VARIANTS

Names, spellings and lines differ from parallels elsewhere, and some segments are incomplete. Ancient genealogies were claims about relationship, arranged to make a point, more than birth certificates.

THE DIRECT LINE TO DOMINION

POSSIBLE Household registration, lineage verification and the Covenant record are this technology. Chronicles keeps the register to gather in a scattered people. Dominion keeps it to rank a gathered one.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHO IN THE CAST ISN'T ON A REGISTER, AND WHAT IT COSTS THEM

WRITING

2 CHR 36

TKC: DOM · TL

Write the Empire's second telling

Dominion has an official history of the Fall. Chronicles shows how a sanctioned retelling actually behaves. It keeps more than you expect, adds liturgy, moves blame without deleting the event, and ends on the note it wants remembered. Build yours on that model and not on crude deletion.

1 · WHAT THE EMPIRE'S HISTORY OF THE FALL KEEPS, EVEN THOUGH IT'S DAMAGING

2 · WHERE IT MOVES THE BLAME WITHOUT REMOVING THE EVENT

3 · THE LITURGY IT ADDS. WHAT THE OFFICIAL VERSION HAS THAT THE OLD ONE DIDN'T

4 · THE LAST SENTENCE OF THE OFFICIAL HISTORY, DRAFTED WORD FOR WORD

What I take out of Chronicles

WRITING

SPREAD CLOSE

QUEUE: F4

THE ONE DIFFERENCE FROM SAMUEL–KINGS THAT CHANGED MY READING

A NAME FROM THE GENEALOGIES I WANT TO USE, AND WHERE

WHAT I STILL DON'T UNDERSTAND. CARRY IT TO THE RESEARCH LIST.

PROMOTION REVIEW *log only, no promotion is made here*

Chronicles is a focused study. Log a promotion if the Empire's official history becomes a plot object more than background, or if the register material outgrows this spread. **OPEN QUESTION** A combined study with Ezra and Nehemiah, titled Restoration, Record and Exclusion, has been floated. The decision belongs in the backlog.

LOGGED | DATE | REASON

NOTES

OPEN NOTES

ANYTHING THIS SPREAD STARTED AND DIDN'T FINISH

F5

FOCUSED STUDY SPREAD

Ezra

A restoration paid for by an empire, and the assembly that sent families away

SOURCE MARGIN

EZRA 1–10

MT · LXX

WILLIAMSON, EZRA, NEHEMIAH (WBC)

BLENKINSOPP, EZRA–NEHEMIAH (OTL)

Decree of Return

ISSUED UNDER THE ROYAL SEAL

TO THE TREASURERS BEYOND THE RIVER · LET IT BE DONE WITH DILIGENCE

THE HOUSE TO BE REBUILT	*at the place where sacrifices are offered*
ITS COST	*to be paid from the royal treasury*
THE VESSELS	*returned, each counted out by number*
WHO MAY GO	*any of his people who are willing*
WHO MAY STOP IT	*no one, on pain of the decree*

Ezra 6.3–12 quotes the decree as it was found again in the archive at Ecbatana. **POSSIBLE** *Every licensed church in the Empire hangs a framed copy of something like it.*

FOUND IN THE ARCHIVE

FOCUSED STUDY F5 · ✣

Ezra

A homecoming paid for by the empire that allowed it, and a covenant renewal that ends with women and children sent out of the community. Both halves are the same book.

WHY THIS IS A FOCUSED STUDY

Ten chapters, two movements and an ending that doesn't resolve. Nine pages hold the imperial mechanics and the marriage crisis without turning either into a verdict.

CONTENT NOTE

Page 3 deals with the expulsion of wives and children from a community, and with the dispute over what to call it. The note is repeated on the page itself.

WHAT IT IS

ONE BOOK OR TWO	Ezra and Nehemiah were handed down together in the Hebrew tradition and separated later, and they're commonly studied as one body of work. Whether they're one composition, and by whose hand, is still disputed. This companion gives them separate spreads and treats the shared reading as a tradition of study more than a settled fact.
STRUCTURE	Chapters 1–6, the first returns and the rebuilding of the temple, decades before Ezra appears. Chapters 7–10, Ezra arrives with a royal commission and the community confronts intermarriage. The long gap between the halves isn't narrated.
TWO LANGUAGES	Part of the book is in Aramaic, the administrative language of the Persian empire, and that section is mostly correspondence: petitions, archive searches and decrees. The book quotes paperwork. **CONTESTED** Whether the documents are authentic, edited or composed.
WHO PAYS	The empire. Cyrus authorizes the return and releases the temple vessels. Artaxerxes later sends Ezra with silver, gold, supplies, tax exemptions for temple personnel and authority to appoint judges. The restoration is a Persian-sanctioned project from the first verse.
EZRA HIMSELF	A priest by descent and a scribe of the law, arriving from Babylon with a commission. He's a religious authority whose standing is issued by a foreign king. Hold both halves of that at once.
HOW IT ENDS	With a list of names of men who had married foreign women, and a final verse whose Hebrew is hard to read. There's no resolution scene, no aftermath and no account of what happened to the women and children. The book stops.

> **WHAT THE BOOK IS ACTUALLY ABOUT**
>
> **INTERPRETATION** Survival of a small community under imperial patronage, and the boundary it draws to get there. It's a book about what a threatened people is willing to do to stay identifiable.

EZRA 1.1–4

EZRA 4.8–6.18 (ARAMAIC)

EZRA 7.11–26

EZRA 10.44

BLENKINSOPP, EZRA–NEHEMIAH

TKC: DOM

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHAT I EXPECTED A "RETURN FROM EXILE" BOOK TO FEEL LIKE

A TEMPLE BUILT BY PERMISSION

Nothing in the first six chapters happens without imperial authorization, and the book doesn't treat that as a compromise. Persia is the instrument of the return. For a novelist building an empire that licenses religion, this is the primary text.

THE DECREE AND THE VESSELS	Cyrus issues the authorization, and the temple vessels Babylon took are counted back out of an imperial treasury. Looted property comes back as policy. Restoration arrives as an inventory.
THE LIST OF WHO RETURNED	A register by household and town, with a group who couldn't document their descent and were kept out of priestly service until a ruling could be had (2.59–63). The register decides standing on arrival. Put it beside Chronicles and Numbers, the same instrument a third time doing a third job.
TWO SOUNDS AT THE FOUNDATION	When the foundation is laid, the young shout for joy and the old who remembered the first house weep, and the text says the noise couldn't be told apart (3.12–13). One of the most useful sentences in the Bible for writing a restoration scene.
OPPOSITION AS PAPERWORK	The work is stopped by a letter and not an army. Neighboring officials write to the king calling the rebuilding a security risk, an archive is searched, and construction halts until a later search finds the original decree and reverses the ruling. Bureaucratic obstruction, on both sides, in writing.
WHO IS TURNED AWAY EARLY	People already living in the land offer to help build and are refused, with no reason given beyond the decree (4.1–3). The boundary that dominates chapters 9–10 is drawn here first, over labor.

WHAT DOMINION FUNDS, AND WHAT IT REQUIRES IN RETURN FOR FUNDING IT

EZRA 1

EZRA 2.59–63

EZRA 3.10–13

EZRA 4.1–5

EZRA 4.6–24

EZRA 6.1–18

WILLIAMSON, EZRA, NEHEMIAH

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHAT DOMINION FUNDS, AND WHAT IT REQUIRES IN RETURN FOR FUNDING IT

CONTENT NOTE The expulsion of women and their children from a community by collective decision, and the ethical dispute over how to describe it. You can work this page later, or not at all, and the spread still functions.

THE BOUNDARY, AND WHO PAID FOR IT

WHAT HAPPENS	Officials report that men of the community, priests and Levites among them, have married women of the surrounding peoples. Ezra tears his clothes and prays a long confession in the first person plural. A proposal is made to send away the wives and the children born to them. An assembly agrees, a commission examines cases household by household, and a list of names is recorded.
THE CHILDREN	The children are named in the proposal alongside the wives. **INTERPRETATION** Here a boundary about identity becomes a decision about particular children.
THE SILENCES	No woman speaks, and none is named. Where they went, who took them in, whether they had families to return to and what happened to the children aren't recorded. A few men object (10.15), and the text doesn't explain why.
WHAT "FOREIGN" MEANS	**CONTESTED** Some read an ethnic boundary, some a religious one, and some a fight over land and inheritance between returnees and people who never left. Others read the list of peoples as old legal language more than a description of the actual women. The stakes are high, and the text doesn't settle it.
SCALE	The recorded list is a little over a hundred men. **CONTESTED** Whether the action was carried out fully, partly, or is an idealized account of a policy. The parallel scene in Nehemiah 13 suggests it didn't stay settled.

ON THE PHRASE THIS COMPANION WON'T USE

INTERPRETATION "Ethnic cleansing with a liturgy" carries a modern legal category into a text whose scale, mechanism and definition of the group are all disputed. It also flattens a real, serious ethical problem into a slogan, which makes it easier to dismiss. The ethical dispute stays on this page in full. A forceful wording of the objection doesn't get treated as accurate for being forceful.

EZRA 9

EZRA 10

NEH 13.23–30

DEUT 7.1–4

SOUTHWOOD, ETHNICITY AND THE MIXED MARRIAGE CRISIS

ESKENAZI, IN AN AGE OF PROSE

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WRITE ONE OF THE WOMEN. NAME HER. GIVE HER THE SENTENCE THE TEXT DIDN'T.

Write the Empire's file

Ezra is a book that quotes its own correspondence. Draft the Empire's documents on the same model, a letter of complaint, a search of the archive and a decree that settles it.

1 · THE LETTER: WHO WRITES TO THE CAPITAL TO STOP A REBUILDING, AND WHAT DANGER THEY NAME

2 · THE ARCHIVE SEARCH: WHAT'S FOUND, AND WHO GETS TO READ IT

3 · THE DECREE: ITS OPENING WORDS, ITS FUNDING LINE AND ITS PENALTY CLAUSE

WRITING

EZRA 4.11–16

EZRA 5.7–17

EZRA 7.12–26

TKC: DOM

WRITING

SPREAD CLOSE

QUEUE: F5

What I take out of Ezra

A RELIGIOUS AUTHORITY WHOSE POWER IS ISSUED BY THE EMPIRE. WHO IS THIS IN MY CAST?

A BOUNDARY DRAWN TO PROTECT A COMMUNITY THAT COSTS ITS MOST VULNERABLE PEOPLE

WHAT I STILL DON'T UNDERSTAND. CARRY IT TO THE RESEARCH LIST.

PROMOTION REVIEW *log only, no promotion is made here*

Ezra is a focused study. Log a promotion if the marriage crisis becomes a governing precedent in Dominion law more than a parallel, or if the material on imperial patronage carries the Sanctum's origin story. **OPEN QUESTION** The combined Restoration, Record and Exclusion study stays in the backlog.

LOGGED | DATE | REASON

NOTES

OPEN NOTES

ANYTHING THIS SPREAD STARTED AND DIDN'T FINISH

NOTES

ANYTHING THIS SPREAD STARTED AND DID NOT FINISH

F6

FOCUSED STUDY SPREAD

Nehemiah

A wall, a register, a debt crisis, and a governor who worked for the king

SOURCE MARGIN

NEH 1–13

MT · LXX

WILLIAMSON, EZRA, NEHEMIAH (WBC)

ESKENAZI, IN AN AGE OF PROSE

Order of the Gates

POSTED AT EVERY ENTRANCE

BY THE GOVERNOR OF THE PROVINCE · TO THE GATEKEEPERS, SINGERS AND LEVITES

GATES OPEN	*not until the sun is hot*
GATES SHUT	*while the guards are still standing*
GUARDS	*residents, each opposite his own house*
SABBATH	*gates shut from dark, no load to enter*
MERCHANTS OUTSIDE THE WALL	*will be dealt with*

Nehemiah 7.3 and 13.19–21, nearly word for word. ***POSSIBLE*** *Every checkpoint in the Empire runs on this order.*

BY ORDER

FOCUSED STUDY F6 · ✣

Nehemiah

A memoir by a man who held a post at the imperial court, went home with an escort, rebuilt the city's defenses in fifty-two days, made his own class give back what it had taken, and enforced a boundary by force.

WHY THIS IS A FOCUSED STUDY

Nehemiah is among the most administratively detailed books in the Old Testament, and the closest to how Dominion actually runs. Nine pages hold the mechanics: employment, security, registers, debt and enforcement.

FIRST PERSON

Much of the book is Nehemiah's own account of himself, including prayers asking to be remembered for it. Read it as testimony from an interested party.

What it is

HIS JOB	Cupbearer to the Persian king, a trusted office at court that carries personal access to the monarch. He then serves as governor of the province. His authority to act in Jerusalem is delegated imperial authority.
FORM	Largely a first-person memoir, with lists, letters, a covenant document and a long public reading set into it. Scholars commonly identify a "Nehemiah memoir" running through the book with other material inserted. CONTESTED Where the seams fall.
STRUCTURE	Chapters 1–7, the commission, the night inspection, the building, the opposition, the debt crisis and a register. Chapters 8–10, the public reading of the law, confession and a signed covenant. Chapters 11–13, settlement lists, dedication and a final enforcement campaign.
THE WALL	Rebuilt in fifty-two days by crews assigned to the stretch nearest their own houses, with families, guilds and perfumers named. Half the workforce stood armed while the other half built. Defense and construction as one operation.
HOW IT ENDS	With a return visit and a purge in place of a dedication: a temple chamber cleared, Sabbath trade shut down by locking the gates, and confrontations over marriages that include beatings and cursing. The book closes with Nehemiah asking to be remembered for good.

WHAT THE BOOK IS ACTUALLY ABOUT

INTERPRETATION Building an institution and then policing it. The construction is the first half and the enforcement is the second, and the book doesn't present them as different projects.

WHAT I WAS TAUGHT ABOUT NEHEMIAH, AND WHAT THAT TEACHING LEFT OUT

NEH 1.11

NEH 2.1–9

NEH 3

NEH 4.15–23

NEH 6.15

NEH 13

WILLIAMSON, EZRA, NEHEMIAH

TKC: DOM

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHAT I WAS TAUGHT ABOUT NEHEMIAH, AND WHAT THAT TEACHING LEFT OUT

SECURITY AS A THEOLOGY

NEH 2.7–9

NEH 2.11–16

NEH 3.12

NEH 4

NEH 6.1–14

NEH 7.1–5

INTERPRETATION The wall is the book's controlling image, and it's a real defensive perimeter with gates, guards, hours and a list of who may open them. Everything the second half does about identity is already implied in the first half's masonry.

THE PAPERWORK HE ASKS FOR	Letters of safe passage to the provincial governors and a requisition to the keeper of the king's forest for timber. An escort of officers and cavalry. He arrives as an official with a materials order.
THE NIGHT INSPECTION	He surveys the ruins at night, telling no one what he intends, and presents the plan as a decision already made. Information control comes before construction.
WHO BUILDS	Priests, goldsmiths, perfumers, district rulers, people from outlying towns, and one official who builds with his daughters (3.12). Chapter 3 is a labor roster, one of the clearest places in the Bible to see a whole community's trades assigned to public works.
OPPOSITION, RUMOR AND A SETUP	Ridicule, threats of attack, repeated invitations to a meeting outside the city, an open letter claiming he means to make himself king, and a hired prophet urging him to hide in the temple. He refuses all of it. The clearest sequence in scripture on how a construction project becomes a political accusation.
THE GATES AND THE REGISTER	Once the wall stands, he sets the gate hours and appoints guards, and in the same breath convenes an enrollment by genealogy. Wall and register arrive together.

DOMINION'S PERIMETER. WHERE IT IS, WHO GUARDS IT AND WHEN IT OPENS

NEH 5.1–5

NEH 5.6–13

NEH 5.14–19

NEH 10.31

LEV 25 (COMPARE)

DEUT 15 (COMPARE)

TKC: DOM · MEN

Chapter five

In the middle of the building project the account breaks off for a debt crisis. The workers are hungry and their children are being taken. The text doesn't say construction stopped. It reports a crisis serious enough to interrupt the narrative. It's the most economically explicit chapter in the historical books, and one of the least preached.

THE OUTCRY	A great outcry from the people "and their wives" (5.1). Three groups speak: those with no land, those mortgaging land for grain, and those who've borrowed against fields and vineyards to pay the king's tax.
THE CHILDREN	They say their sons and daughters are being forced into slavery for debt, some daughters already, and they're powerless because their fields now belong to others. Debt bondage inside the community, in the same weeks as the sacred building project.
THE CREDITORS	The nobles and officials, the same class doing the building and signing the covenant. The crisis is internal, and no foreign oppressor is needed.
THE REMEDY	Nehemiah confronts them in public, calls it wrong, orders fields, houses and interest returned and makes them swear to it before the priests. He also gives up the governor's food allowance and says he fed a large table at his own expense. Reform by a member of the creditor class, on the creditor class.
THE LIMIT	INTERPRETATION Chapter 5 is immediate relief backed by an oath and personal authority. The covenant in chapter 10 makes a seventh-year release a standing obligation. Neither changes the lending system or the imperial tax that drove the borrowing, and the text doesn't say how long either was enforced.

THE TAX IS THE ENGINE

INTERPRETATION The people say outright that they borrowed to pay the king's tax. The debt crisis is downstream of imperial extraction, and the reform touches the local creditor and leaves the empire alone, since the empire isn't available to be reformed. For a Dominion economy, that's the whole shape of it.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

HOW A DOMINION HOUSEHOLD LOSES A DAUGHTER TO DEBT. WRITE THE MECHANISM.

NEH 8

NEH 9

NEH 10.28–39

NEH 13.4–14

NEH 13.15–22

NEH 13.23–31

FISHBANE, BIBLICAL INTERPRETATION IN ANCIENT ISRAEL

Signed, then policed

The middle of the book is a public reading and a signed agreement. The end is what happens when the agreement isn't kept. Read them together or the ending looks arbitrary.

THE PUBLIC READING	A morning-long reading in an open square before men, women and all who could understand, with Levites giving the sense so the people understood (8.8). The people weep, and they're told to feast and send portions to those with nothing. **CONTESTED** Whether "giving the sense" includes translation into Aramaic is a common reading and a debated one.
THE SIGNED COVENANT	A sealed document with named signatories committing to specific obligations: no intermarriage, no Sabbath trade, a seventh-year release, a temple tax, wood offerings and firstfruits. A funding and compliance schedule with a religious preamble.
THE TEMPLE CHAMBER	He comes back to find a temple room given to an outsider and the Levites unpaid and gone back to their fields. He throws the household goods out and restores the payments. The reform failed the moment its enforcer left.
THE SABBATH SHUTDOWN	Winepresses working, grain hauled and foreign traders selling on the Sabbath. He orders the gates shut before dark and posts his own men, and when merchants camp outside he threatens to lay hands on them. Sabbath observance enforced as a border operation.
THE MARRIAGE CONFRONTATION	He reports contending with the men, cursing them, beating some and pulling out their hair, and driving out a priest's son who'd married into the family of a rival governor. He reports it approvingly, as zeal. Unlike Ezra 10 there's no assembly, commission or list, only an official's personal violence recorded in the first person. **INTERPRETATION** The marriages also tie Jerusalem's priestly families to neighboring provincial power.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

A REFORMER WHOSE REFORM ONLY HOLDS WHILE HE'S IN THE ROOM. WHO IS THAT HERE?

WRITING

SPREAD
CLOSE

QUEUE: F6

What I take out of Nehemiah

THE PERIMETER AND THE REGISTER ARRIVE TOGETHER. WHERE DOES DOMINION DO THIS?

LEADERSHIP AIMED AT ITS OWN CLASS. WHO IN MY CAST REFORMS THE PEOPLE THEY BELONG TO?

A SCENE WHERE OBSERVANCE IS ENFORCED BY LOCKING A GATE

WHAT I STILL DON'T UNDERSTAND. CARRY IT TO THE RESEARCH LIST.

PROMOTION REVIEW *log only, no promotion is made here*

Nehemiah is a focused study. Log a promotion if the debt and bondage material becomes the spine of Dominion's economy more than one mechanism among several, or if chapter 5 outgrows its page here. **OPEN QUESTION** The combined Restoration, Record and Exclusion study stays in the backlog.

LOGGED | DATE | REASON

NOTES

OPEN NOTES

ANYTHING THIS SPREAD STARTED AND DIDN'T FINISH

NOTES

ANYTHING THIS SPREAD STARTED AND DID NOT FINISH

F2

FOCUSED STUDY SPREAD

Ecclesiastes

Hevel, the court passages, and fatalism the Empire can use

SOURCE MARGIN

ECCL 1–12

MT · LXX

FOX, QOHELET AND HIS CONTRADICTIONS

SEOW, ECCLESIASTES (AB)

Ecclesiastes 10.20

Do not curse the king, even in your thoughts,
or curse the rich, even in your bedroom.

For a bird of the air may carry your voice, or
some winged creature tell the matter.

✣

A surveillance proverb in the canon, about two and a half thousand years before the Broadcast.

FOCUSED STUDY F2 · ✣

ECCLESIASTES

A book inside the canon that says the system can't be figured out, the record won't be kept, and you should eat your dinner anyway. Dangerous material for an empire that needs meaning handed down from above.

WHY THIS IS A FOCUSED STUDY

Twelve short chapters and one sustained argument. What you need is hevel handled correctly and the court passages pulled out, and eight pages do that.

READ IT WHOLE FIRST

It's one of the few biblical books short enough to read in an hour, and it doesn't survive being read in fragments. Read it before working these pages.

What it is

NAME	The Hebrew is *Qohelet*, from a root meaning to assemble or convene, roughly "the Assembler," someone who addresses a gathering. The Greek title translates it. A role, more than a personal name.
THE SPEAKER	Introduced as "son of David, king in Jerusalem." Solomon is never named. **INTERPRETATION** Best read as a literary persona, a royal voice adopted so the experiment of chapters 1–2 can run with unlimited means. Modern scholarship generally dates the book's Hebrew well after Solomon, commonly to the Persian or Hellenistic period. If you treat the speaker as a historical king, say you're doing it.
TWO VOICES	First person for most of twelve chapters, then a third-person voice at the end describing Qohelet from outside and commending him, with qualifications. Many read the epilogue as an editorial frame. **CONTESTED** Whether it endorses the book, tames it or corrects it.
GENRE	Wisdom literature turned adversarial. It uses the forms of instruction to question instruction. Royal testament, observation report, proverb collection and poem sit side by side.
STRUCTURE	No tidy outline, and the proposals disagree. What's visible: the royal experiment (1–2), the poem on times (3), a run of observations on injustice, labor, wealth and death (4–10), advice for the young and the closing poem on age (11–12), and the epilogue.
NEIGHBORS	Egyptian and Mesopotamian pessimism literature and royal testaments cover similar ground. Job is the closer neighbor in the canon. Both refuse the standard account of reward and punishment, by different routes.

> **WHAT THE BOOK IS ACTUALLY ARGUING**
>
> **INTERPRETATION** It argues that outcomes don't track merit, that nobody can see the whole pattern, and that this is a reason to take what's in front of you seriously and keep going. The book refuses to lie, and it stops short of despair.

ECCL 1.1

ECCL 1.12

ECCL 12.9–14

FOX, QOHELET

JOB (COMPARE)

TKC: DOM

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHAT I WAS TAUGHT THIS BOOK MEANT, AND WHO TAUGHT ME

Hevel

ECCL 1.2

ECCL 12.8

BDB · HALOT, HEVEL

GEN 4 (ABEL)

VULGATE, VANITAS

KJV 1611

One Hebrew word appears dozens of times across twelve chapters and frames the whole book, first verse and last. Its concrete sense is vapor, breath or mist, something real that won't stay in your hand. Every English rendering is an interpretation, and each one produces a different book.

RENDERING	THE BOOK IT PRODUCES
"VANITY"	The traditional English, reaching us through the Latin *vanitas*. In modern English it suggests conceit, which isn't the sense, and it makes the book sound like a sermon against pride.
"MEANINGLESS"	The strongest and the most misleading. It turns an observation about impermanence into a verdict on existence, and the book keeps recommending things, which a meaningless world wouldn't allow.
"ABSURD"	Stresses the gap between what should follow and what does. Useful, and it carries modern philosophical baggage.
"FUTILE"	Keeps the effort and denies it a result. It fits the labor passages and fits the enjoyment passages badly.
"VAPOR" OR "BREATH"	Keeps the image and lets the reader do the work. It also connects to the name Abel in Genesis 4, the same consonants, a resonance the Hebrew reader hears and the English reader never does.

WHAT THE BOOK ALSO SAYS. DON'T CUT THIS HALF.

Eat, drink and find good in your labor. Enjoy your bread and your work. Do it with the person you love. These recommendations come back again and again, and they're the counterweight to every "vapor" verdict. A summary that keeps only the bleak half isn't summarizing this book.

QUOTATION WARNING

"Eat your bread, love someone, the day is short" is a paraphrase of the enjoyment passages and not a verse. "Nobody will remember you" compresses several passages on memory and drops the ones about a good name. Never print either as a quotation.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH RENDERING I'M USING, AND WHY THAT ONE

Written by someone who's been near power

ECCL 4.1

ECCL 5.8–9

ECCL 8.2–4

ECCL 10.16–20

SEOW, ECCLESIASTES

TKC: DOM

The book's political passages are the ones nobody puts on a coffee mug. They read like advice from someone who has watched administration from inside and doesn't expect it to improve.

OPPRESSION WITH NO COMFORTER · 4.1	He looks at the oppressed and notes twice that they have no one to comfort them, and that power is on the other side. No explanation is offered for why God allows it. The observation is left standing.
THE CHAIN OF OFFICIALS · 5.8–9	Don't be astonished at oppression and the denial of justice in a province, followed by a clause about one official watching over another. These are among the hardest verses in the book, and translations split sharply on who's watching whom and whether verse 9 defends or indicts the king. **CONTESTED** A tiered bureaucracy where each level answers upward is one strong, common reading, and the Hebrew allows others.
OBEY, BECAUSE HE CAN · 8.2–4	Keep the king's command. Don't stand in a bad cause before him. His word is powerful, and no one asks him what he's doing. **INTERPRETATION** Counsel for survival more than an endorsement, and Dominion will print it as an endorsement.
THE BIRDS WILL CARRY IT · 10.20	Don't curse the king even in your thoughts, or the rich in your bedroom, since a bird of the air may carry the word. A surveillance proverb in the canon. Take this one whole.
A CHILD FOR A KING · 10.16–17	Woe to the land whose king is a servant, or a child, and whose princes feast in the morning. Happy the land whose king is nobly born and whose princes eat at the proper time. **INTERPRETATION** Class assumptions fully intact. The book criticizes governance without asking who's entitled to govern.

WHICH OF THESE COULD BE READ ALOUD IN THE SANCTUM WITHOUT ANYONE FLINCHING, AND WHICH COULDN'T

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH OF THESE COULD BE READ ALOUD IN THE SANCTUM WITHOUT ANYONE FLINCHING, AND WHICH COULDN'T

The most useful book in the Empire's hands

ECCL 3.1–8

ECCL 9.11

ECCL 8.2–4

ECCL 12.13–14

TKC: DOM

INTERPRETATION Fatalism is an excellent instrument of government. If nothing can be changed, nothing needs changing, and the person who says so sounds wise instead of compliant. Ecclesiastes can be made to say this. It doesn't say it, but the raw material is all there, and the Sanctum wouldn't have to add a word.

THE PASSAGE	THE USE, AND WHAT IT LEAVES OUT
A TIME FOR EVERYTHING · 3.1–8	**POSSIBLE** Read as divine scheduling. Your suffering has its season, so endure it on time. What it leaves out is that the poem lists killing, tearing down and hating as appointed too, which makes it a description of the whole range of human doing more than a comfort.
TIME AND CHANCE · 9.11	**POSSIBLE** Read as "outcomes aren't yours to control, so accept your placement." What it leaves out is that the verse directly denies that the swift and the strong reliably win, which undercuts every ranked competition the Empire runs.
OBEY THE KING · 8.2–4	**POSSIBLE** Read as a standing command. What it leaves out is the reason given, which is that he has the power, and nothing about his having the right.
THE EPILOGUE · 12.13–14	**POSSIBLE** The Sanctum's favorite verse in the book, since it's the one sentence that sounds like an instruction. Quoting the last two verses and skipping twelve chapters is the cleanest example of the Empire's reading method.

> **THE HARDER QUESTION FOR TKC**
>
> Fatalism also protects people. A woman who believes the outcome was never hers to decide can survive a verdict that would otherwise destroy her. The Empire teaches this doctrine cynically, and some of the characters will need it sincerely. Leave the tension unresolved and write it.

WHO IN MY CAST BELIEVES THIS SINCERELY, AND WHO TEACHES IT KNOWING BETTER

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHO IN MY CAST BELIEVES THIS SINCERELY, AND WHO TEACHES IT KNOWING BETTER

What I take out of Ecclesiastes

WRITING

ECCL 12.9–14

SPREAD CLOSE

QUEUE: F2

THE EPILOGUE. DOES IT ENDORSE THE BOOK, TAME IT OR ARGUE WITH IT? MY READING

A SANCTUM TEACHING BUILT ON THIS BOOK. DRAFT THE ACTUAL WORDING

A CHARACTER WHO HAS REACHED THIS BOOK'S CONCLUSION HONESTLY

WHAT I STILL DON'T UNDERSTAND. CARRY IT TO THE RESEARCH LIST.

PROMOTION REVIEW *log only, no promotion is made here*

Ecclesiastes is a focused study. Log a promotion if the Empire's use of the book becomes a plot thread of its own more than atmosphere. If the Sanctum starts teaching it on the page, the epilogue will need its own spread.

LOGGED | DATE | REASON

NOTES

OPEN NOTES

ANYTHING THIS SPREAD STARTED AND DIDN'T FINISH

F3

FOCUSED STUDY SPREAD

EZEKIEL

Exile, the departing glory, and chapters 16 and 23

SOURCE MARGIN

EZEK 1–48

MT · LXX

GREENBERG, EZEKIEL (AB)

PEARCE & WUNSCH, DOCUMENTS OF JUDEAN EXILES

Route of Departure

AS SEEN BY THE PRIEST, SON OF BUZI

LOGGED FROM A RIVER IN BABYLONIA · THE SIXTH YEAR OF THE KING'S EXILE

STAGE ONE	*from above the cherub to the threshold of the house · 9.3*
STAGE TWO	*from the threshold to the east gate · 10.18–19*
STAGE THREE	*out of the city, to the mountain on the east · 11.23*
RETURN	*by way of the east gate, into a measured house · 43.1–5*
INTERVAL	*thirty-two chapters*

The glory of God leaves the temple in stages, recorded like a route. **POSSIBLE** *Somebody in the Empire has noticed the Sanctum is the building and not the presence.*

DEPARTED

FOCUSED STUDY F3 · ✣

EZEKIEL

A priest deported before the city fell, writing from a river in Babylonia about a God who left the building. Also the book that uses a woman's violated body as its central image of a nation's guilt, twice and at length.

WHY THIS IS A FOCUSED STUDY, FOR NOW

Nine pages hold the exile setting, the departing glory, the symbolic performances and the problem of chapters 16 and 23. If any of these becomes structural to TKC, the spread is promoted. It's the strongest promotion candidate in the queue.

CONTENT NOTE

Page 3 deals with sexual violence, public exposure as punishment and a woman's body used as a metaphor for national guilt. Skipping it is a legitimate choice. Skipping it without knowing isn't.

What it is

THE MAN	A priest, son of Buzi, among the deportees by the river Chebar in Babylonia. He isn't the only prophet of priestly family, since Jeremiah comes from the priests of Anathoth. What's distinctive is the combination, a priest whose whole recorded ministry happens in exile, away from the sanctuary he was trained to serve. It shapes everything the book does with temple, purity and space.
THE SETTING	Babylon takes Jerusalem's elite in stages. Ezekiel goes in an early wave, in 597 BCE, about a decade before the city and temple are destroyed. The first half of the book is a man warning an exile community about a catastrophe that hasn't happened yet, and that most of his hearers believe won't.
WHAT DEPORTATION WAS	Imperial policy and not a stampede: selective removal of a ruling class, craftsmen and royal family, resettlement in communities that kept some property and internal structure, and a client administration left behind. It was designed to take the head off a state while keeping it productive.
STRUCTURE	Chapters 1–24, judgment on Jerusalem before the fall. Chapters 25–32, oracles against the surrounding nations. Chapters 33–48, after the fall: restoration, the shepherds, the bones and a measured temple. The fall of the city is the hinge, and the book is built around it.
DATING SYSTEM	The book dates its oracles by years counted from King Jehoiachin's exile, and not by Babylonian regnal years. **INTERPRETATION** A community that dates its documents from the year its king was taken, and not from the reign of the power that took him, is choosing whose time it lives in.

> **DON'T REDUCE THE BOOK TO A MOBILE GOD**
>
> The departure of the glory from the temple is central and very useful for Dominion, and it isn't the whole book. Ezekiel is also about personal accountability, failed leadership, the ethics of prophetic speech and a detailed plan for rebuilding, and it ends with architecture more than travel.

EZEK 1.1–3

2 KGS 24–25

JER 1.1

EZEK 1–24

EZEK 33–48

GREENBERG, EZEKIEL

TKC: TL · DOM

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHAT AN EXILE COMMUNITY KEEPS, AND WHAT DOMINION WOULD TAKE FIRST

A PROPHET USED AS AN INSTRUMENT

Ezekiel mostly doesn't speak. He's made into a demonstration, positioned, restricted, silenced and bereaved so his body becomes the message. No other prophetic book does this on this scale.

THE CALL AND THE WHEELS · 1–3	A storm from the north, four living creatures with four faces each, wheels that move without turning with eyes on the rims, and above them the likeness of a throne with the likeness of a human form. The vocabulary is hedged at every turn, likeness, appearance, something like, because what he saw can't be reported plainly. He's handed a scroll and told to eat it, and it tastes like honey.
THE GLORY LEAVES · 8–11, RETURNS · 43	He's shown what's being done inside the temple, and the divine presence moves, from the inner sanctuary to the threshold, to the east gate, out of the city. It's a staged withdrawal, recorded like a route. Thirty-two chapters later it comes back by the same gate to a rebuilt house. INTERPRETATION The building was never the point. The presence was.
THE PERFORMANCES · 4–5, 12	He lies on one side and then the other for a counted number of days. He eats a measured siege ration. He shaves his head and beard and divides the hair. He digs through a wall and carries out a packed bag at dusk, like a refugee. Public, humiliating, sustained, and commissioned as prophecy.
THE DEATH OF HIS WIFE · 24.15–27	She's called the delight of his eyes. He's told in advance she'll die and told not to mourn her in public, no weeping and no rites, because his withheld grief is the sign of what's coming to the city. She dies, and he does as he was told. The text names her only by her relation to him, gives her no words and uses her death as an illustration. Whatever else the book is, it does that.

EZEK 1
EZEK 2–3
EZEK 4–5
EZEK 8–11
EZEK 12
EZEK 24.15–27
EZEK 43

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHAT THE EMPIRE WOULD DO WITH A LICENSED PROPHET WHOSE BODY IS THE BROADCAST

CONTENT NOTE Two extended prophetic allegories that describe women's bodies in explicit sexual terms and present stripping, public exposure, mutilation and killing as deserved punishment for infidelity. This page doesn't quote them. You can work it later, or not at all, and the spread still functions.

The metaphor that uses a woman's body

WHAT THEY ARE	Chapter 16 casts Jerusalem as a foundling who is raised, adorned, married and unfaithful. Chapter 23 casts Samaria and Jerusalem as two sisters whose political alliances are pictured as sexual pursuit of foreign soldiers.
THE ARGUMENT	Alliance with imperial powers is pictured as adultery, and the coming destruction as a husband's punishment of a wife, carried out by her former lovers with divine authorization. The violence is the argument.
WHY IT MATTERS	For centuries these chapters were preached with the gendered violence treated as decoration on a spiritual point. A large body of modern scholarship, feminist criticism in particular, argues the imagery can't be incidental and that its long use shapes how women hear divine judgment. It's serious scholarship and not a fringe complaint.
READINGS ON OFFER	**CONTESTED** The metaphor indicts a city and its leaders, and not women. It draws on treaty language, where infidelity is the standard charge. The shock is the intended effect. The imagery does harm whatever its intent. These can all be true together, and none of them makes the text safe.
THE COMPANION'S RULE	Name what the text does. Don't quote it to shock. Don't soften it into "unfaithfulness." Don't treat centuries of preaching on it as a neutral fact.

WHY THIS IS DIRECTLY TKC

POSSIBLE Dominion already measures a household's loyalty on a woman's body and stages exposure as correction. It has a scriptural warrant at length, in a major prophet. The question is whether it quotes these chapters in public or keeps them for the closed catechism.

EZEK 16

EZEK 23

HOS 1–3 (COMPARE)

WEEMS, BATTERED LOVE

GALAMBUSH, JERUSALEM IN THE BOOK OF EZEKIEL

TKC: DOM · MEN

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

MY OWN POSITION. WRITE IT DOWN ONCE, HERE, SO THE MANUSCRIPT STAYS CONSISTENT

AFTER THE CITY FALLS

EZEK 18
EXOD 20.5
LAM 5.7
EZEK 34
EZEK 37.1–14
EZEK 38–39
EZEK 40–48

WHOSE FAULT · 18	The chapter quotes a proverb the exiles are using, the parents have eaten sour grapes and the children's teeth are set on edge, and rejects it. The person who sins is the one who bears it, and someone who turns isn't held to their record. Read it against the commandment's language of punishment visited on later generations (Exod 20.5), against Lamentations' complaint that the children bear their parents' guilt (Lam 5.7), and against Ezekiel's own account of a whole city destroyed together. The Bible doesn't speak with one voice here, and the disagreement is the material.
THE SHEPHERDS · 34	An indictment of rulers who fed themselves on the flock, wore the wool, ate the fat, didn't strengthen the weak, heal the sick or search for the lost, and ruled with force. God removes them and takes the work personally, searching, gathering, feeding, binding up and judging between fat sheep and lean. The chapter then promises one shepherd, "my servant David." The office is emptied, worked directly and refilled on God's terms. **INTERPRETATION** It's the most quotable anti-leadership passage in the prophets and the hardest for an institution to circulate safely.
THE VALLEY OF DRY BONES · 37	He's set in a valley of bones and asked whether they can live, and he answers that God knows. The bones come together and breath enters them. The text interprets itself. The bones are the whole house of Israel, a people who believe they're finished. In context it's about national restoration. Later traditions read it as individual resurrection, and that reading has its own history. Keep the two apart.
GOG AND MAGOG · 38–39	A vast future invasion from the north, defeated. Later apocalyptic writing and modern political preaching have both mined these chapters for the enemy's identity. Note the pattern without adopting it, since naming a final enemy is a durable political technology.
THE MEASURED TEMPLE · 40–48	Nine chapters of specification: gates, courts, chambers, altar, priestly duties, festival calendar, a river flowing out of the sanctuary and a redivided land. A priest in exile answers catastrophe with a building plan and a rota. **CONTESTED** Whether it's a blueprint, a vision or a protest against the temple that failed. **INTERPRETATION** What it plainly is, is hope written as an ordinance.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

DOES DOMINION INHERIT GUILT BY HOUSEHOLD OR BY PERSON, AND DOES IT SAY THE SAME THING TWICE?

What I take out of Ezekiel

WRITING

SPREAD CLOSE

QUEUE: F3

THE DEPARTING PRESENCE. WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE FALL, AND WHO NOTICES IT LEAVING

A CHARACTER WHOSE BODY IS BEING USED AS SOMEONE ELSE'S MESSAGE

WHAT I STILL DON'T UNDERSTAND. CARRY IT TO THE RESEARCH LIST.

PROMOTION REVIEW *log only, no promotion is made here*

Ezekiel is a focused study with promotion available, and it's the likeliest promotion in the queue. Promote it if two or more of these hold: the departing glory becomes a structural motif more than an image, chapters 16 and 23 become part of the Empire's catechism on the page, the exile material feeds the Fall directly, or a character quotes the shepherds oracle.

DECISION | DATE | PAGES NEEDED

NOTES

OPEN NOTES

ANYTHING THIS SPREAD STARTED AND DIDN'T FINISH

F7

COLLECTIVE FOCUSED STUDY

The Twelve

One scroll, twelve arguments, four centuries and three empires

SOURCE MARGIN

HOS–MAL

MT · LXX

NOGALSKI, THE BOOK OF THE TWELVE

SWEENEY, THE TWELVE PROPHETS

Register of the Twelve

ONE SCROLL, COUNTED AS ONE BOOK

HOSEA THROUGH MALACHI · ENTERED IN THE HEBREW ORDER

EIGHTH CENTURY	*Hosea · Amos · Micah · (Jonah, set here)*
SEVENTH CENTURY	*Nahum · Zephaniah · Habakkuk*
PERSIAN PERIOD	*Haggai · Zechariah · Malachi*
UNCERTAIN	*Joel · Obadiah*
EMPIRES ON THE HORIZON	*Assyria · Babylon · Persia*

The printed order isn't the order of writing. Read straight through, the Twelve gives you four centuries out of sequence. ***POSSIBLE*** *The Sanctum's lectionary doesn't mention this.*

OUT OF SEQUENCE

COLLECTIVE STUDY F7 · ✣

The Twelve

Twelve short books copied onto one scroll and counted as one. As a set they cover the rise and fall of two kingdoms under three empires, and no two of them make the same argument.

WHY COLLECTIVE, AND WHY NOW

Twelve separate dossiers would be out of proportion before you've read them. This study introduces the set, keeps each book's setting and argument intact, and leaves the promotions for you to decide.

CONTENT NOTES

Page 3 covers Hosea's marriage metaphor, with sexual accusation and violence against a wife. Page 5 covers a poem celebrating a city's destruction. Both are marked on the page.

One book or twelve

THE NAME	In Jewish tradition it's the Twelve, and one book. "Minor prophets" is a later Latin convention about length and not importance. If the word "minor" ever made you skip them, the convention was working.
ONE SCROLL	Twelve books of this size fit on one scroll, and ancient lists count them as one book. **CONTESTED** Whether they were also edited as one collection, with deliberate links across the seams, is an active scholarly argument.
THE ORDER VARIES	The Hebrew and Greek orders differ in the first six books. The sequence you're reading is a choice someone made, and any argument built on the arrangement depends on which arrangement.
OUT OF CHRONOLOGY	Amos and Hosea belong to the eighth century. Haggai, Zechariah and Malachi belong to the Persian period after the return.
DATING	Some books date themselves precisely by reign, some only by internal evidence, and three, Joel, Obadiah and Malachi, are genuinely uncertain. Don't print a date for those three as if it were given.

WHAT THE SET GIVES YOU THAT THE MAJOR PROPHETS DON'T

INTERPRETATION Twelve different answers to the same conditions. A prophet who says he isn't a professional prophet, a book that celebrates an empire's fall and a book furious that an empire was spared, a demand for justice and a demand for a building. As a set, the Twelve is the Bible arguing with itself in public.

WHICH OF THE TWELVE I COULD NAME BEFORE THIS PAGE, AND WHICH I COULDN'T

HOS 1.1

MAL 4.6

MT ORDER · LXX ORDER

NOGALSKI, BOOK OF THE TWELVE

SWEENEY, TWELVE PROPHETS

2 KGS 14–25

EZRA 1–6

SWEENEY, TWELVE PROPHETS

TKC: TL

Who was in power when

Prophecy is addressed to a situation. Without the empire on the horizon, every one of these books reads as general scolding. The placements below follow mainstream scholarship, and the three marked uncertain are genuinely open.

BOOK	SETTING	THE POWER IN THE ROOM
AMOS	Northern kingdom, 8th c.	Prosperity before Assyria arrives. A man from Judah speaking in the north.
HOSEA	Northern kingdom, 8th c.	Assyrian pressure and collapse inside. The north falls within his horizon.
MICAH	Judah, 8th c.	Assyrian campaigns. A voice from the countryside against the capital.
NAHUM	Judah, 7th c.	Assyria's capital about to fall, or just fallen.
ZEPHANIAH	Judah, 7th c.	Late Assyrian period. Addressed to Jerusalem's officials and merchants.
HABAKKUK	Judah, late 7th c.	Babylon rising and named as the instrument.
HAGGAI	Judah, Persian period	Dated to the month under a Persian king. Temple rebuilding.
ZECHARIAH	Judah, Persian period	The same moment as Haggai in chapters 1–8. Chapters 9–14 are widely held to be later.
JONAH	Set in the Assyrian era	Set then. Generally thought to be written considerably later, looking back.
JOEL	Uncertain	No king named. Placements range widely. Say "uncertain" and mean it.
OBADIAH	Uncertain	Most often tied to the aftermath of Jerusalem's fall, on internal evidence.
MALACHI	Persian period	A working temple with slack practice. No king named, and the title may be a role ("my messenger") more than a name.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH ERA MY EMPIRE IS IN. RISING, PEAKING, OR BEING NAMED AS THE INSTRUMENT

HOS 1–3

JOEL 2.28–29

ACTS 2.16–21

AMOS 2.6–8

AMOS 7.10–17

WEEMS, BATTERED LOVE

SWEENEY, TWELVE PROPHETS

Hosea · Joel · Amos

CONTENT NOTE The Hosea entry concerns a marriage metaphor built on sexual accusation, public exposure and violence against a wife. It doesn't quote the imagery.

HOSEA · NORTH, 8TH C.	A prophet told to marry, and three children whose names are the message: Jezreel, a place of slaughter, Lo-ruhamah, "not pitied," and Lo-ammi, "not my people." The book runs the nation's covenant failure through a wife accused of infidelity, with stripping, drought and public shaming as the announced punishment, beside some of the tenderest reconciliation language in scripture. **Study:** the marriage metaphor, Gomer as a person and as a device, the children's names, sexual accusation, gendered violence, and the reversal of the names at the end.
JOEL · SETTING UNCERTAIN	A locust invasion described in military language, a call to communal lament, and a promise of restoration and of the spirit poured out on the whole community. No king is named and no empire identified, which is why the book won't date. The outpouring names sons and daughters, old and young, and a third group translations render as household servants or as enslaved men and women. Check three translations and a lexicon before quoting, because the social claim changes with the choice. **Study:** the locusts, the Day of the LORD, lament as procedure, and Peter's reuse of the passage in Acts 2.
AMOS · SPEAKS IN THE NORTH, 8TH C.	Oracles against the surrounding nations circle inward until they land on Israel. After that comes a sustained attack on the sale of the poor, the seizure of garments and grain, and worship offered by the people doing it. Confronted at the royal sanctuary by the priest Amaziah and told to go home, he answers that he's a herdsman and a dresser of sycamore figs and that God took him from the flock. **CONTESTED** Whether he's denying any connection to the professional prophets, or only that he was trained among them. He's also from Judah speaking in the north, which is a problem of jurisdiction as much as class. **Study:** the nations sequence, the sale of persons for debt, ivory beds, rejected worship, Amaziah, the plumb line and the basket of summer fruit.

CORRECTION TO THE OLD COMPANION The old companion called Amos "a farmer from the wrong kingdom." He calls himself a herdsman and a worker of sycamore figs, livestock and orchard work, possibly a man of some means. It also said Hosea's God "keeps taking the nation back," which is true of the reconciliation passages and silent about the violence that comes first.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH OF THESE THREE I WANT IN THE MANUSCRIPT, AND IN WHOSE MOUTH

OBAD 10–14

PS 137 (COMPARE)

JONAH 4

2 KGS 14.25

MIC 2.1–2

MIC 3.5–11

MIC 6.8

RAABE, OBADIAH (AB)

Obadiah · Jonah · Micah

OBADIAH · UNCERTAIN · SHORTEST BOOK	One chapter against Edom, a neighboring people condemned for what it did on the day Jerusalem fell: standing aloof, gloating over the disaster, entering the gate and joining the plunder, cutting off fugitives at the crossroads and handing over survivors. Edom isn't shown leading the invasion. It's charged with every item on that list. **Study:** Edom in the family stories and the prophets, bystanding as a named offense, profit from a neighbor's catastrophe, and what the shortest book in the Bible chooses to spend its one chapter on.
JONAH · SET IN THE ASSYRIAN ERA	A prophet gets a commission and sails the other way. A storm, sailors who behave better than he does, the fish, a sermon of five Hebrew words, a mass repentance that includes the livestock, and a prophet furious that it worked. It ends on a question about mercy that's never answered. CONTESTED "Satire" is one major classification and a useful one. Parable, teaching novella and prophetic legend are held seriously too. **Study:** mercy for an enemy empire, nationalism, prophetic refusal, Nineveh as a real capital and a symbol, repentance from the throne down, and the plant, the worm and the unanswered question.
MICAH · JUDAH, 8TH C.	Judgment on both capitals, with a specific economic charge against people who lie awake planning how to take fields and houses, and take them, because they have the power. Rulers who hate justice, judges who take bribes, priests who teach for a price and prophets who cry peace as long as they're fed. In the same book, a ruler from a small town, and the famous line about what's required. **Study:** land seizure, prophets for hire, the threat against Zion, Bethlehem, and the courtroom framing of chapter 6.

MICAH ISN'T ONE VERSE

INTERPRETATION Reading only 6.8 removes the land seizure, the bought clergy, the threat against the capital, and the fact that the verse answers a question about what an offering can buy. Study the argument it concludes.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

A PROPHET WHO IS ANGRY THAT MERCY WAS EXTENDED. DOES DOMINION HAVE ONE?

NAH 3.1–7

HAB 1–2.5

HAB 3

ZEPH 1.7–13

ZEPH 3.11–13

SWEENEY, TWELVE PROPHETS

Nahum · Habakkuk · Zephaniah

CONTENT NOTE The Nahum entry concerns a poem that celebrates a city's destruction and uses sexualized humiliation of a personified capital as part of the celebration. It doesn't quote the imagery.

NAHUM · JUDAH, 7TH C.	Three chapters on the fall of Assyria's capital in fast, visual poetry, chariots in the streets, the crack of the whip, bodies heaped up, and a taunt addressed to the city as a woman to be exposed before the nations. **Hold both:** Calling it a provincial revenge song dismisses where it's written from. Assyria deported whole populations, flayed captives and advertised it, and this is the voice of people who were on the receiving end of a terror state watching it end. It's also not innocent. The gendered humiliation is doing real work, and the book's pleasure in the violence isn't incidental. **Study:** Assyrian imperial practice, the poetry of a city's fall, who's allowed to celebrate, and the opening hymn about patience and wrath.
HABAKKUK · JUDAH, LATE 7TH C.	Built as an argument. The prophet complains that violence goes unanswered. The reply names Babylon as the instrument. The prophet objects that this is worse. The second reply is a set of woes against the plunderer, a line about the righteous living by faithfulness, and an order to write the vision down plainly and wait. It closes with a psalm that chooses trust without claiming anything has improved. **Study:** complaint as a legitimate prophetic form, God's use of an empire, faith or faithfulness and its later reuse, and waiting.
ZEPHANIAH · JUDAH, 7TH C.	A Day of the LORD announced as near, dark and total, and aimed with unusual precision at officials, the king's sons, traders and people grown so comfortable they assume nothing will happen. A remnant is left, described as humble, people who won't do wrong and won't be afraid. **Study:** the Day of the LORD across the Twelve, the ruling class as named target, complacency as an offense, and who the remnant consists of.

CORRECTION TO THE OLD COMPANION The old companion said Habakkuk got "an unsatisfying answer." The phrase is a verdict and not a description. The reply doesn't answer the question asked, and the book knows it, which is why it ends in waiting.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHO IN MY WORLD IS ALLOWED TO CELEBRATE THE FALL, AND WHO IS TOLD IT'S UNSEEMLY

HAG 1.2–11

EZRA 5.1–2

ZECH 1–6

ZECH 3

ZECH 9.9

MAL 2.10–16

MAL 3.1

MAL 4.5–6

HUGENBERGER, MARRIAGE AS A COVENANT

Haggai · Zechariah · Malachi

HAGGAI · PERSIAN PERIOD, DATED PRECISELY	Four dated messages in a few months, all on one subject. The temple is a ruin while people live in finished, paneled houses. The economics are blunt. You sow much and harvest little, you earn wages to put in a bag with holes, and the shortfall is blamed on the unbuilt house. The work restarts, and Ezra names Haggai and Zechariah as the prophets who got it moving. **Study:** rebuilding under imperial authorization, scarcity and its explanation, the governor and the high priest, and what religious construction costs ordinary households.
ZECHARIAH · PERSIAN PERIOD, AND LATER MATERIAL	Eight night visions with a messenger who interprets them, horses and riders, a measuring line, a lampstand, a flying scroll, chariots, and a courtroom where the high priest stands in filthy clothes, is accused and is dressed again. Later oracles include a king riding on a donkey and a shepherd sequence the gospel writers draw on heavily. **Study:** how symbolic vision works, the priesthood restored by new clothes, the two olive trees, the donkey-riding king, the pierced one and the struck shepherd, and the gospels' reuse of them, read as reuse.
MALACHI · PERSIAN PERIOD	Built as a run of disputes. A claim is made, the audience objects and the objection is answered. The targets are priests offering blemished animals, men who've dealt treacherously with the wives of their youth (a passage on divorce with real textual difficulty), people withholding what's owed, and a general feeling that serving God isn't worth it. It promises a messenger who will refine the priesthood and closes with Elijah, turning the hearts of parents and children to each other.

CORRECTION TO THE OLD COMPANION The old companion said the last word of the Old Testament is an accusation against clergy. The claim only works in the Christian order, since Chronicles comes last in the Jewish one, and even there Malachi's closing verses are about Elijah and families. The claim is dropped.

A PROPHET WHOSE MESSAGE IS "FINISH THE BUILDING." WHOSE INTERESTS DOES THAT SERVE?

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

A PROPHET WHOSE MESSAGE IS "FINISH THE BUILDING." WHOSE INTERESTS DOES THAT SERVE?

MIC 3.5–8

AMOS 5.21–24

HAG 1.4–6

MAL 3.8–10

HAB 2.6–17

TKC: DOM

Which prophets an empire keeps

INTERPRETATION The Twelve holds both kinds, prophets who tell an institution to finish its building and prophets who tell it its worship is worthless while it sells the poor. Any empire that licenses a prophetic office is choosing from exactly this range, and the choice is the doctrine.

WHAT THE SANCTUM CIRCULATES	WHAT IT KEEPS IN THE CLOSED CATECHISM
HAGGAI. FINISH THE HOUSE, AND THE SHORTFALL IS YOUR FAULT FOR NOT FINISHING IT.	Micah. The people who lie awake planning how to take fields, and take them, because they can.
MALACHI. BRING THE FULL TITHE INTO THE STOREHOUSE.	Malachi. The priests are the first ones charged.
HOSEA'S RECONCILIATION. THE GOD WHO TAKES HER BACK.	Hosea's mechanism. The exposure and shaming that come before the taking back.
ZEPHANIAH'S REMNANT. THE HUMBLE WHO ARE SPARED.	Zephaniah's target list. Officials, the king's sons and the merchants.
NAHUM. THE ENEMY EMPIRE FALLS, BECAUSE WE'RE THE RIGHTEOUS ONES.	Habakkuk. The empire God is using is judged for the same violence.
AMOS'S CLOSING RESTORATION VERSES.	Everything in Amos before them, and the priest of the royal sanctuary telling him to leave the country.

THE TEST THE TWELVE ACTUALLY OFFERS

INTERPRETATION Micah names prophets who cry peace while they're being fed and declare war on anyone who stops feeding them. Applied, that gives a working test more than a moral one. Follow the money and see whose interest the message serves. It works on the Sanctum and on anyone the characters are inclined to trust. It's an interpretive use of Micah, and the text doesn't prescribe it.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

THE SANCTUM'S APPROVED PROPHETIC CANON. LIST WHAT'S IN AND WHAT'S SEALED

WRITING

HOS–MAL

TKC: DOM · TL

Build the prophetic office

Six pages of reference have given you twelve models. This page turns them into Dominion's institution.

1 · HOW A PERSON BECOMES A LICENSED PROPHET IN DOMINION, AND WHO REVOKES IT

2 · AN UNLICENSED VOICE WHO IS RIGHT. WHAT HAPPENS AT THE SANCTUARY DOOR

3 · THE EMPIRE'S OWN "DAY OF THE LORD." WHAT IT PROMISES AND WHOM IT THREATENS

4 · ONE ORACLE, IN FULL, IN THE SANCTUM'S VOICE. THE SAME EVENT FROM OUTSIDE IT

Which of the Twelve earns more study

The audit names seven as likely to need their own focused study later: Hosea, Amos, Jonah, Micah, Habakkuk, Zechariah and Malachi. Read this collective study before deciding. The audit column records its seven, and the mark column is yours. Nothing is promoted from this page.

BOOK	AUDIT	MARK	WHY, IN ONE LINE
Hosea	AUDIT		
Joel			
Amos	AUDIT		
Obadiah			
Jonah	AUDIT		
Micah	AUDIT		
Nahum			
Habakkuk	AUDIT		
Zephaniah			
Haggai			
Zechariah	AUDIT		
Malachi	AUDIT		

WRITING

SPREAD
CLOSE

QUEUE: F7

What I take out of the Twelve

THE ONE BOOK OF THE TWELVE THAT CHANGED HOW I SEE THE EMPIRE

WHAT I STILL DON'T UNDERSTAND. CARRY IT TO THE RESEARCH LIST.

PROMOTION REVIEW *log only, no promotion is made here*

BOOKS MARKED | DATE | TIER PROPOSED

NOTES

OPEN NOTES

ANYTHING THIS STUDY STARTED AND DIDN'T FINISH

NOTES

ANYTHING THIS SPREAD STARTED AND DID NOT FINISH

I

DEEP-DIVE DOSSIER

Genesis

The book Dominion quotes first and reads least

SOURCE MARGIN

GEN 1–50

MT · LXX

ALTER, GENESIS (TRANS.)

WESTERMANN, GENESIS 1–11

TKC: AM

Genesis 1.28

Be fruitful and multiply, and fill the earth and subdue it,

and have dominion over the fish of the sea and over the birds of the air and over every living thing that moves upon the earth.

✣

The verse the Dominions are named after (**AM**). Fish, birds and living things. No people.

DEEP-DIVE DOSSIER I · ✣

GENESIS

Everything the Empire claims about men, women, land and order is traced back to fifty chapters that spend most of their length undermining that claim.

WHY THIS ONE IS FIRST

It's the source of the Empire's founding doctrine and of your own earliest religious education. Both need digging out, and this dossier is the model for the three that follow.

HOW TO WORK IT

Reference is about a third of these pages, and the rest is yours. A half-filled dossier is more useful than a blank one.

What it is

NAME	Greek *genesis*, "origin." Hebrew *Bereshit*, "in the beginning." Hebrew books are named for their first words more than their contents.
PLACE	The first book of the Torah in every collection. Nobody disputes its position, and nearly everything else about it is discussed.
AUTHORSHIP	Traditionally Moses. **CONTESTED** Most critical scholars read it as woven from more than one source and period, with major editing in or after the exile, and the two creation accounts are the clearest seam. The classic documentary hypothesis has been heavily revised since the 1970s, and traditional readers hold to a single author.
GENRES INSIDE	Cosmology, genealogy, origin stories, family saga, legal precedent, poetry, dream reports and a novella-length court story in the Joseph chapters. Don't run one test across all fifty chapters.
STRUCTURE	Chapters 1–11, the primeval history, from creation to the scattering of peoples. Chapters 12–50, one family across four generations, ending with Joseph's coffin in Egypt (50.26). The seam shows, and the two halves behave differently.
SETTING	No king, no priesthood and no temple. Everything happens in households, and households decide who inherits.
NEIGHBORS	Mesopotamian creation and flood literature covers similar ground with different theology. Comparison is where Genesis's own claims become visible.

> **WHAT THE BOOK IS ACTUALLY ABOUT, IF IT'S ABOUT ONE THING**
>
> **INTERPRETATION** Blessing that keeps passing to the wrong person. Younger over elder, the barren over the fertile, the deceiver over the dutiful, the foreigner into the family. A book used to justify hierarchy spends fifty chapters disrupting the hierarchy it names most often, birth order.

GEN 1.1

GEN 1–11

GEN 12–50

GEN 50.26

WESTERMANN, GENESIS 1–11

ENUMA ELISH · ATRAHASIS

TKC: TL

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHAT I ALREADY THINK THIS BOOK SAYS, BEFORE READING IT AGAIN

Two accounts, unreconciled

GEN 1.1–2.3
GEN 2.4–25
EXOD 18.4
DEUT 33.29
PS 121.1–2
EXOD 26.20
TRIBLE, GOD AND THE RHETORIC OF SEXUALITY

The book opens with two creation accounts in a row, differing in order, method, vocabulary and picture of God. The editors who assembled it kept both. It's the first thing Genesis teaches about how scripture works.

	FIRST ACCOUNT · 1.1–2.3	SECOND ACCOUNT · 2.4B–25
NAME FOR GOD	Elohim, "God"	YHWH Elohim, "the LORD God"
STARTING POINT	Dark water, the deep	Dry ground, no plants, no rain, no one to work it
ORDER	Light, sky, land and plants, lights, sea creatures and birds, land animals, humans last	The human first, then a garden, trees, animals, then the woman
METHOD	Speech and separation	Shaping dust, breathing, planting, building
HUMANS	Male and female together, both in God's image (1.27)	The human (*ha'adam*) from the ground (*ha'adamah*), the woman built from his side
THEIR TASK	Fill the earth, subdue it, have dominion over the creatures (1.28)	Work the garden and keep it (2.15)
ENDS WITH	God resting on the seventh day	Two people naked and unashamed

THE HELPER · 2.18

God makes "a helper fit for him," *'ezer kenegdo*. The noun *'ezer* appears about twenty times in the Hebrew Bible, and most of them describe God helping Israel. It names whoever supplies what the other can't, so "assistant" is a poor gloss. *Kenegdo* means "corresponding to him." The word usually translated "rib," *tsela*, means "side" nearly everywhere else, including the sides of the tabernacle.

WHAT DOMINION DOES WITH THE PAIR

POSSIBLE Teaches the second account as the operative one and the first as poetry. Order of creation becomes order of authority, "helper" becomes a job description, and dominion over the earth quietly becomes dominion inside the household. No word has to change. The only change is which account counts as doctrine.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH ACCOUNT I WAS TAUGHT, AND WHICH ONE I'D NEVER NOTICED WAS SEPARATE

Work the doctrine

Two doctrines come out of these chapters and both hold weight for the Empire. Write them out in Dominion's voice before you write your objection. The Empire's version has to be truly persuasive or Eden's crisis isn't a crisis.

WRITING

GEN 1.26–28

GEN 2.15

VON RAD, GENESIS

TKC: DOM

1 · THE IMAGE OF GOD. WHAT THE EMPIRE SAYS IT MEANS, AND WHO IT QUIETLY LEAVES OUT

2 · DOMINION AS STEWARDSHIP OR AS OWNERSHIP. THE EMPIRE'S ARGUMENT AT ITS BEST

3 · MY OBJECTION, IN ONE PARAGRAPH I'D DEFEND OUT LOUD

4 · WHERE THIS LANDS IN THE MANUSCRIPT: SCENE, CHAPTER OR CATECHISM

☐ POSSIBLE ☐ OPEN QUESTION ☐ DECIDED LOG NO. DATE

GEN 3

GEN 4.7

GEN 4.8–17

GEN 6–9

GEN 11.1–9

SONG 7.10

1 TIM 2.13–14

GILGAMESH XI · ATRAHASIS

The primeval history

INTERPRETATION Four movements, each ending worse than it began, and each answered with a promise more than a punishment. The pattern is the argument.

THE GARDEN · 3	The serpent asks a question and the woman answers, adding that they mustn't even touch the tree. She eats and gives fruit to her husband, "who was with her" (3.6). Only two things are cursed, the serpent and the ground. The woman isn't cursed, and neither is the man. Her pain in childbearing and his toil on the land are the same Hebrew noun, *'itstsavon*. The chapter never uses the word "sin," which first appears in 4.7, spoken to Cain. The fruit is never an apple. The apple came from a Latin pun on *malum*, "evil" and "apple."
THE FIRST KILLING · 4	Violence arrives within a generation of the garden, and God answers it with a mark of protection, not an execution. The first city in the book is founded by the murderer. Genesis isn't sentimental about civilization.
THE FLOOD · 6–9	The counting runs two ways at once, pairs of animals and sevens, forty days and a hundred and fifty, which source critics read as two accounts woven together. Mesopotamian flood stories share the structure and differ sharply on why it happens. This one ends with a one-sided promise never to do it again, and the sign is a war bow hung in the clouds.
THE TOWER · 11	One people, one language and a building project so they won't be scattered. They're scattered anyway. **INTERPRETATION** Read beside an empire that standardizes speech and centralizes construction, it's the most politically pointed story in the first eleven chapters, and the one Dominion would find hardest to teach honestly.

"HE SHALL RULE OVER YOU" · 3.16

Prescription or description. Read as prescription, God sets male rule in place. Read as description, the verse names what the break has done to the pair. The word for "desire," *teshuqah*, appears three times in the Hebrew Bible: here, in 4.7 where sin's desire is for Cain, and in Song 7.10, the man's desire for the woman. The Empire has never once presented this as a dispute.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH OF THE FOUR IS DOMINION'S FOUNDING MYTH, AND WHICH IS ITS INDICTMENT

GEN 12–25

GEN 24–27

GEN 29–35

GEN 37–50

GEN 41.34–36

GEN 47.13–26

EXOD 1.8–11

SPEISER, GENESIS (AB)

Four generations

One household carrying a promise it keeps putting at risk. Read the right column before writing anything about inheritance in the Empire.

GENERATION	WHAT HAPPENS	HOW THE ORDER BREAKS
ABRAHAM AND SARAH	Called to leave, promised land and children, and childless for decades. Sarah gives Hagar to Abraham, and Hagar bears Ishmael. Hagar flees once and is expelled once. A covenant, a near-sacrifice, and a burial cave that's the only land actually acquired.	The firstborn isn't the heir. The enslaved woman's son gets his own promise.
ISAAC AND REBEKAH	The quietest generation. Rebekah asks God about the struggle in her womb, gets the oracle directly and acts on it.	The younger twin is named before birth, and the mother makes it happen.
JACOB, LEAH AND RACHEL	Deception both ways, two sisters married to one man, four mothers of twelve sons, twenty years of labor and a night of wrestling that leaves him renamed and limping.	The unloved wife bears the priests and the kings. The blessing arrives through a lie and isn't withdrawn.
JOSEPH AND HIS BROTHERS	Sold by his brothers, jailed on a false accusation, raised to run an empire's grain and reunited with a family he can now feed or destroy.	The eleventh son governs. Judah carries the royal line.

THE JOSEPH MATERIAL IS AN ADMINISTRATION STORY

A famine is forecast and grain is centralized. Over the crisis the population sells its money, its livestock, its land and finally itself to the crown for food (47.13–26). The Hebrew says he moved the people into the cities, and the Samaritan and Greek texts say he made them slaves. The priests keep their land. A fifth of every harvest goes to Pharaoh "to this day," and the people thank him. Exodus opens on the consequence.

CONTESTED Whether Genesis presents the policy as wise government or as the start of a trap. The text praises his wisdom and records the cost without comment.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH DOMINION POLICY IS THE JOSEPH ADMINISTRATION, AND WHO IN THE EMPIRE ADMIRES HIM

GEN 9.8–17

GEN 12.1–3

GEN 15

GEN 17

GEN 16.10–13

GEN 21.17–18

GEN 28.10–22

GEN 49.8–12

ANE SUZERAIN TREATIES

Seven promises

The book's spine is a promise made seven times, often to someone with less standing to receive it, each with a different sign. Note what's asked in return. For most of them, almost nothing.

TO WHOM	WHAT'S PROMISED, AND WHAT'S ASKED	THE SIGN
NOAH AND EVERY LIVING CREATURE · 9	No flood will destroy the earth again. Made with all flesh, and nothing is required. The only unconditional promise in the book.	A bow in the clouds
ABRAM AT THE CALL · 12	Land, a great nation, a great name, and blessing for "all the families of the earth." Asked only to leave.	None. Only the going.
ABRAM BETWEEN THE PIECES · 15	Descendants like the stars, the land, and four hundred years of oppression first. A firepot and torch pass between the halves. God alone passes through, and Abram sleeps.	Fire between the pieces
ABRAHAM AND SARAH RENAMED · 17	Many nations, kings, an everlasting covenant, a son by Sarah. Asked: circumcision of every male in the household, slaves included.	Flesh
HAGAR, TWICE IN THE WILDERNESS · 16, 21	Descendants too many to count and a great nation from Ishmael. She's enslaved, foreign and expelled, and the promise is in the patriarch's terms.	A well, and a name for God
JACOB AT BETHEL · 28	The same promise, to a man running from the brother he cheated. Jacob answers with a conditional vow of his own.	A stone, and a stairway
JUDAH, IN THE DEATHBED BLESSING · 49	His brothers will bow and the scepter won't leave him. Spoken by the dying Jacob and not by God. "Until Shiloh comes" is one of the most disputed phrases in the book.	Words only

THE STRUCTURE UNDERNEATH

INTERPRETATION The ceremony in chapter 15 borrows the shape of an ancient treaty between a greater power and a lesser one and inverts the key term, since the greater power walks the path alone. It's a reading, and a well-supported one.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH PROMISE DOMINION CLAIMS TO STAND ON, AND WHICH TERMS IT LEAVES OUT TO DO IT

GEN 4.25

GEN 21.10–12

GEN 25.23

GEN 38.27–30

GEN 48.13–20

GEN 49.3–4

1 CHR 5.1–2

RUTH 4.18–22

TKC: TL · MEN

Who inherits, and why not

In every generation the promise passes over the firstborn. The Empire runs on birth order, and this is the book it says it runs on.

FIRSTBORN	PASSED OVER FOR	WHERE
CAIN	Seth, after Abel's death	4.25
ISHMAEL	Isaac. The displaced son still receives a nation.	21.10–12
ESAU	Jacob, by oracle, appetite and deception. Nobody undoes it afterward.	25.23, 27
REUBEN	Judah for rule, Joseph for the double portion	49.3–4, 8–12, 22–26
MANASSEH	Ephraim, by Jacob's crossed hands	48.13–20
ZERAH	Perez, who breaks out first at birth	38.27–30

WOMEN DECIDE SEVERAL OF THESE

Sarah demands Hagar's expulsion, and God tells Abraham to listen to her (21.12). Rebekah engineers Jacob's blessing and takes the risk on herself, "Upon me be your curse, my son" (27.13). Tamar forces Judah to acknowledge her son. **INTERPRETATION** Genesis treats inheritance as election and never as law. The legal heir is the one person the story reliably doesn't choose.

WHERE THE VANE SUCCESSION SITS ON THIS PAGE, AND WHO IS THE ISHMAEL OF THAT HOUSE

Six women, six levers

CONTENT NOTE The Dinah row concerns sexual violence and a massacre.

Genesis pays unusual attention to women without being kind to them. Each of these six works inside a system that gives her no formal power, and each finds a different lever. The character work comes from this page.

WHO	WHAT SHE DOES, AND WHAT IT COSTS	THE LEVER
HAGAR	Enslaved, given to Abram as a wife, treated harshly with the verb Exodus uses for Egypt. She flees once and is expelled once. She's the only person in scripture who names God, and she does it alone. She later finds Ishmael a wife, head of her own household.	None. She has none, and is met anyway.
SARAH	Barren from her first mention, twice passed off as Abraham's sister to protect him, and the one who demands Hagar's expulsion. She laughs at the promise and denies it. God names the boy "he laughs," and she plays on the name afterward.	Household authority, used against a woman with less.
REBEKAH	Answers "I will go" about her own departure, asks God directly about her pregnancy, and redirects the blessing. Her death is never narrated.	Information, and the willingness to act on it first.
LEAH	Married by deception to a man who wanted her sister, and "hated," the text says. Names her sons as running commentary on her marriage. Mother of Levi and Judah, priests and kings. Buried beside Jacob, where Rachel isn't.	Endurance, and the naming of sons.
DINAH	**CONTESTED** Most readers take chapter 34 as rape, and some read the verb as shaming more than force. Used as the pretext for a massacre by her brothers. She doesn't speak once.	Silence. The text's, not hers.
TAMAR	Denied the marriage owed her, she veils herself, takes Judah's seal, cord and staff as a pledge, and produces them when he orders her burned. "She is more righteous than I."	Documentation. She keeps the receipt.

GEN 16

GEN 21

GEN 24–27

GEN 29–30

GEN 34

GEN 38

FRYMER-KENSKY, READING THE WOMEN OF THE BIBLE

WILLIAMS, SISTERS IN THE WILDERNESS

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH OF THE SIX IS EDEN, WHICH IS CELESTE, AND WHICH IS THE ONE NOBODY IN TKC HAS BEEN YET

One woman, all the way down

Pick one from the facing page and work her fully. Don't pick the one you already have an opinion about.

> **THE PATTERN WORTH TAKING**
>
> **INTERPRETATION** Every one of them works the system more than escaping it, and the two who win outright, Rebekah and Tamar, win with information and evidence.
> **POSSIBLE** Eden's method is on this page. So is Celeste's, who wrote "deceased" on the Empire's authority line and made the form answer to it (**DR3**).

SHE IS, AND HER PASSAGES

WHAT THE TEXT SAYS SHE DOES, AND WHAT IT DECLINES TO SAY ABOUT IT

WHAT SHE'S REDUCED TO IN SERMONS AND STUDY NOTES

WHAT DOMINION WOULD TEACH ABOUT HER TO GIRLS AT DESIGNATION AGE

THE SCENE SHE UNLOCKS, AND WHO IN THE PARISH HOUSEHOLD HAS LIVED IT

☐ **POSSIBLE** ☐ **OPEN QUESTION** ☐ **DECIDED** **LOG NO.** **DATE**

GEN 1.27

GEN 3.16

GEN 9.20–27

GEN 19

EZEK 16.49

GEN 22

GOLDENBERG, THE CURSE OF HAM

LEVENSON, DEATH AND RESURRECTION OF THE BELOVED SON

Six fault lines

Sorted by the four kinds of disagreement from the Contested Readings module: I scholarly, II denominational, III open theological, IV unsupported.

THE DISPUTE	KIND	WHAT'S ACTUALLY AT STAKE
THE IMAGE OF GOD	III	Whether it names a capacity, a status, a function or a relationship, and whether it's held individually or only together. The text doesn't define it, and every definition since has been an argument about who qualifies.
"HE SHALL RULE OVER YOU"	I	Prescription or description. The Hebrew permits both, and specialists divide.
THE CURSE OF HAM	IV	The text curses Canaan, not Ham, says nothing about skin, and was attached centuries later to justify racial slavery. A documented misuse more than a contested reading, and the most important thing in this book for TKC to get exactly right.
SODOM	II	What the city is condemned for. The narrative centers a mob's violent demand against guests under protection. Ezekiel names pride, excess and refusing the poor (16.49). Traditions differ.
THE BINDING OF ISAAC	III	A test passed, a test failed, a polemic against child sacrifice, or a horror the text won't soften. Sarah isn't told, and in the narrative Abraham and Sarah never speak again.
GENRE OF CHAPTERS 1–11	II	Historical report, theological narrative, or a kind of writing modern categories don't divide well. The difference drives most modern conflict over the book.

> **THE ONE TO HANDLE WITH BOTH HANDS**
>
> Row three. A category IV claim built into centuries of law and preaching is exactly what Dominion would still teach, and what a novel mustn't reproduce carelessly while depicting it. Write the Empire believing it. Don't let the companion be vague about its falsity.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH OF THE SIX DOMINION TEACHES AS SETTLED, AND WHO IN THE EMPIRE KNOWS OTHERWISE

METHOD

BIBLE 101 VIII

ONE PASSAGE, TWO TRANSLATIONS

Run the eight

One Genesis passage, all eight questions, and two translations side by side. A good first run is the sentence about ruling in 3.16.

PASSAGE

THE TWO RENDERINGS, COPIED OUT WORD FOR WORD

1 · GENRE

2 · SPEAKER

3 · AUDIENCE

4 · BEFORE AND AFTER

5 · WHAT WORLD PRODUCED IT

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

6 · WHAT THE WORDS DO, AND WHERE THE TWO TRANSLATIONS PART

METHOD

BDB · HALOT

TKC: DOM

PART IX LOG

Who gains, who pays

The last two questions, with room to answer them properly, and the record of what the run produced. Nothing on this spread is canon until the status row is filled.

7 · WHO GAINS FROM EACH READING. NAME THEM, INCLUDING WHERE I BENEFIT

8 · WHAT EACH READING COSTS, AND WHO PAYS IT

DOMINION'S READING	WHERE I CURRENTLY LAND

WHAT STILL NEEDS A REAL SOURCE: LEXICON, COMMENTARY OR MANUSCRIPT NOTE

☐ POSSIBLE ☐ OPEN QUESTION ☐ DECIDED

LOG NO. _____ DATE _____

Who used it next

Genesis is quoted, argued with and rewritten across the rest of the collection. Every later use is somebody deciding what the book meant, which is what Dominion does, with a printing press and a lectionary.

WHO	WHAT THEY DO WITH IT
EXODUS	Opens on the result of Joseph's administration. The descendants of the man who centralized the grain are the forced labor. **INTERPRETATION** The two books are one argument, and almost nobody teaches them that way.
THE PROPHETS	Reach back to Abraham and Sodom as precedent. Ezekiel names Sodom's sin as pride, plenty and refusing the poor, a reading of Genesis printed inside the Bible.
RUTH	Closes by tracing David's line through Perez, Tamar's son. The line has always run through outsiders and irregular unions.
MATTHEW	Opens the New Testament with a Genesis-style genealogy and names Tamar in it, with Rahab, Ruth and "the wife of Uriah."
PAUL	Uses Abraham to argue the promise came before the law, Adam as a pattern for Christ, and Hagar as an allegory (Gal 4). Genesis as precedent for a present fight, the same move Dominion makes, aimed differently.
THE PASTORALS	Cite the order of creation and the deception in the garden as grounds for restricting women's teaching (1 Tim 2.13–14). For TKC, the most consequential later use of Genesis 2–3.
REVELATION	Ends the collection by reversing the opening: a garden inside a city, the tree open again, the serpent finished.

AFTERLIVES, BRIEFLY

Jewish midrash treats the gaps as invitations and argues in the margins for centuries. Christian allegory reads the garden forward into doctrine. The Reformation reads it for law and grace. Modern criticism asks who wrote it and when. Each tradition answers a different question, and none reads it cold.

EXOD 1.8–14

EZEK 16.49

RUTH 4.18–22

MATT 1.1–17

ROM 4

ROM 5.12–21

GAL 3

GAL 4.21–31

1 TIM 2.11–15

REV 22.1–5

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH LATER USE DOMINION INHERITED WITHOUT KNOWING IT WAS AN INTERPRETATION

Four documented misuses

These aren't contested readings. They're historical uses of the book to justify harm, and a novel about an empire built on scripture has to know them well enough not to reproduce them by accident.

I · THE SO-CALLED CURSE OF HAM	Noah curses Canaan, Ham's son, and not Ham (9.25). Nothing in the passage mentions skin, color or Africa. David Goldenberg's *The Curse of Ham* (2003) traces how later interpreters attached blackness to Ham and slavery to blackness, and shows the supposed derivation of "Ham" from a word for "black" doesn't hold. In the Atlantic world it became a standard justification for enslaving Africans. Stephen Haynes documents its central place in American proslavery argument in *Noah's Curse* (2002).
II · ORDER OF CREATION AS PERMANENT RANK	Made second, so subordinate. Deceived first, so untrustworthy. Built by reading the second account as a hierarchy chart and setting the first aside, and used to bar women from teaching, testifying, holding property and holding office. **INTERPRETATION** Order alone settles rank in neither account, since the animals come before both humans in chapter 1.
III · DOMINION AS LICENSE	A grant over the earth and its creatures turned into a warrant for extraction, conquest and taking inhabited land. The verse concerns creatures and soil and says nothing about authority over other peoples. Lynn White Jr. made the charge famous in 1967, and the stewardship reading is the main answer.
IV · CHILDBEARING AS A SENTENCE	Pain in childbirth read as a penalty women should bear, and used to refuse them relief. When James Young Simpson began using chloroform in labor in 1847, he published an answer to religious objections. **CONTESTED** Historians debate how widespread the clerical opposition really was.

HOW TO WRITE THESE

Let Dominion hold them sincerely and argue them well, which is what makes the Empire frightening more than cartoonish. Don't let the companion be vague about whether they're true. Sincerity and falsity are both required, and they belong on different pages.

GEN 9.20–27

GEN 2–3

1 TIM 2.11–15

GEN 1.28

GEN 3.16

GOLDENBERG, THE CURSE OF HAM

HAYNES, NOAH'S CURSE

WHITE, "HISTORICAL ROOTS" (1967)

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH OF THE FOUR IS LAW IN DOMINION, AND WHO TEACHES IT BELIEVING IT

What the Empire took

TKC: DOM · AM

GEN 1.26–28

THE SIX INSTRUMENTS, MODULE II

Four doctrines Dominion draws from this book, each traceable to a verse and each needing the rest of the chapter left out. Fill the right column with the instrument from the six: the calendar, the readings, clergy access, schoolbooks, provincial editions or commentary.

DOCTRINE	WHAT HAS TO BE LEFT OUT FOR IT TO HOLD	INSTRUMENT
Order of the household	The first creation account entirely, and the fact that the ruling sentence sits in a description of loss more than a design specification.	
Fruitfulness as duty	The blessing is given to humanity together, and three of the book's matriarchs are barren for years without being judged for it.	
Dominion itself	The grant covers the earth and its creatures and never other people, and the Empire's name comes from a verse that doesn't authorize it.	
Order restored after collapse	The flood story ends with a promise never to do it again, which makes divine catastrophe a poor template for a state that stages one.	

CORRECTION TO THE OLD COMPANION The old page said "four of the book's central women" were barren. Three are, Sarah (11.30), Rebekah (25.21) and Rachel (29.31). Leah is the fertile one. It also said Hagar was driven out twice. She flees once and is expelled once.

THE NAME PROBLEM

The Dominions are named after a verse about rule over the earth and its creatures (AM). **INFERENCE** The verse is 1.28, or 1.26, the only places in Genesis where humans are told to "have dominion." Somebody in the founding generation chose that word and knew what it said. **OPEN QUESTION** Who named the Dominions, and does the Temple teach the verse as rule or as care?

WHO NAMED THE DOMINIONS, AND WHETHER IT WAS PIETY OR A JOKE

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHO NAMED THE DOMINIONS, AND WHETHER IT WAS PIETY OR A JOKE

What changed

YOURS

PART IX LOG

QUEUE: D1

Close every dossier the same way: what you believed, what you found, what's still open and what's now canon. Nothing on the earlier pages is canon until it's entered here and in the log.

WHAT I BELIEVED ABOUT GENESIS BEFORE THIS DOSSIER

WHAT SURPRISED ME, AND WHY SURPRISE ISN'T EVIDENCE YET

WHAT STAYS OPEN, AND WHAT I NEED A REAL SOURCE FOR

WHAT I'M MAKING CANON FROM THIS BOOK, AND THE LOG NUMBER IT GETS

☐ POSSIBLE ☐ OPEN QUESTION ☐ DECIDED

LOG NO. _____ DATE _____

NOTES

OPEN NOTES

ANYTHING THIS DOSSIER STARTED AND DIDN'T FINISH

II

DEEP-DIVE DOSSIER

Exodus

The book every liberation movement has quoted and every empire has learned to quote back

SOURCE MARGIN

EXOD 1–40

MT · LXX

PROPP, EXODUS (AB)

CHILDS, EXODUS (OTL)

MEYERS, EXODUS (NCBC)

Labor Return, Store Cities of Pithom and Raamses

BRICK QUOTA

FILED BY THE TASKMASTERS · COUNTERSIGNED BY THE FOREMEN OF THE PEOPLE

QUOTA	*the same number of bricks as before*
STRAW	*no longer supplied. Gather your own.*
SHORTFALL	*the foremen are beaten*
COMPLAINT LODGED	*"You are idle, you are idle" (5.17)*
BIRTHS REPORTED	*boys to the river · 1.22*

Exodus 5 is a labor dispute in writing, quotas and all. The book's God is introduced as someone who heard the complaint (3.7).

QUOTA UNMET

DEEP-DIVE DOSSIER II · ✣

Exodus

It doesn't end at the sea. Two thirds of the book is what happens after the escape: law, labor, ritual and a people arguing with the God who brought them out.

WHY A FULL DOSSIER

Dominion's whole deliverance liturgy is built on this book, and so is every argument against it. The audit assigns a full dossier and warns against stopping at the escape. This one doesn't.

HOW TO WORK IT

Reference is about a third of these pages, and the rest is yours. Content notes come before pages 6 and 11.

What it is

NAME	Greek *exodos*, "a going out." Hebrew *Shemot*, "names," from the opening list of those who came down to Egypt. The Greek title names the event and the Hebrew title names the people.
PLACE	The hinge of the Torah. A family becomes a people, and the people becomes a nation with law. Genesis ends with a household in Egypt, and Exodus opens with a labor force.
AUTHORSHIP	Traditionally Moses. **CONTESTED** Modern scholarship generally sees more than one hand and a lot of editing, with the law collections and the tabernacle chapters treated as separate bodies of text.
HISTORICITY	There's no outside record of the departure as the book describes it, and proposals for its date, scale and route vary widely. This dossier treats the narrative as scripture and literature and prints no reconstruction as history.
STRUCTURE	Chapters 1–15, oppression and departure. 16–18, the wilderness and the first administration. 19–24, Sinai, the ten words and the covenant code. 25–40, the sanctuary plans, broken by the calf. The escape is a third of the book.
GENRES INSIDE	Narrative, genealogy, the plague cycle, victory poetry, case law, absolute command, ritual calendar and construction specification. The tabernacle chapters are an architectural document. Don't read them the way you read chapter 14.
NEIGHBORS	Ancient Near Eastern law collections, Hammurabi's among them, cover much of the same legal ground in the same "if this, then that" form. Reading the covenant code beside them shows what's conventional in it and what isn't.

WHAT THE BOOK IS ACTUALLY ABOUT

INTERPRETATION Who owns a people's labor, and what a people owes the one who freed them. The question doesn't close when they leave Egypt. It becomes the law, then the argument, then the sanctuary.

EXOD 1.1

EXOD 1–15

EXOD 19–24

EXOD 25–40

PROPP, EXODUS 1–18

LAWS OF HAMMURABI (ROTH)

TKC: DOM

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHAT I ALREADY THINK THIS BOOK SAYS, BEFORE READING IT AGAIN

Six women, then Moses

EXOD 1.8–22

EXOD 2.1–10

EXOD 2.16–22

EXOD 4.24–26

EXOD 6.20

NUM 26.59

MEYERS, EXODUS

TKC: MIRIAM

Before the deliverer says a word, women have already beaten the policy. Two midwives refuse an execution order and lie to the king about it, a mother hides a child, a sister watches over the rescue, and a princess of the ruling house adopts him and pays his mother to nurse him.

WHO	WHAT THE TEXT ACTUALLY SAYS
SHIPHRAH AND PUAH	Ordered to kill Hebrew boys at birth, they "feared God" and didn't. Summoned, they answer with a claim the king can't check: Hebrew women give birth before the midwife arrives. God gives them households. They're named and the king isn't. **CONTESTED** "Hebrew midwives" can also be read "midwives to the Hebrews," which would make them Egyptian, and the Greek reads it that way.
THE MOTHER	Hides the child three months, then builds a sealed basket and sets it in the reeds, a plan more than an abandonment. Named only later, as Jochebed (6.20).
THE SISTER	Watches from a distance and offers Pharaoh's daughter a Hebrew nurse at the moment of discovery. **INFERENCE** She's Miriam. Chapter 2 doesn't name her, and Miriam is first named in 15.20.
PHARAOH'S DAUGHTER	Sees the child crying, pities him, knowingly keeps a Hebrew boy alive against her father's decree and names him. She breaks the ruling house's law without opposing it in public.
ZIPPORAH	A Midianite priest's daughter, one of seven sisters Moses defends at a well. She later performs a circumcision at night that saves his life, in a scene nobody explains. The deliverer's family is foreign.
THE OPPRESSION	Forced labor, then harsher labor, then a birth policy. The king's stated fear is numbers: "too many and too mighty" (1.9). Registration logic before any register exists.

THE READING THE PULPIT SKIPS

INTERPRETATION Two of these women are professionals who lie to the state, and the text approves. Two are mothers running an operation across a class line. One is a daughter of the regime. Any account of Exodus that starts with a burning bush has skipped the part where ordinary women had already made the deliverer possible.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHO IN MY CAST IS SHIPHRAH, INSIDE THE SYSTEM AND QUIETLY NOT COMPLYING

Build the refusal

WRITING

EXOD 1

TKC: DOM · TR

Exodus 1 gives a working model of resistance that doesn't look like resistance: people with licensed access refusing to do the one thing the license exists for. Draft Dominion's version here. This page is source material for the Trials.

1 · WHICH LICENSED PROFESSION IN DOMINION COULD REFUSE AN ORDER AND SURVIVE IT

2 · THE ANSWER THEY GIVE WHEN SUMMONED. WRITE IT AS DIALOGUE

3 · A WOMAN OF THE RULING HOUSE WHO BREAKS ITS LAW WITHOUT OPPOSING IT IN PUBLIC

4 · THE POLICY THAT FOLLOWS WHEN QUIET REFUSAL IS DISCOVERED. WHAT ESCALATES

EXOD 3.1–15

EXOD 4.1–17

EXOD 4.24–26

EXOD 6.2–3

BDB · HALOT

CHILDS, EXODUS

PROPP, EXODUS 1–18

A NAME THAT WON'T SETTLE

Moses asks for a name to carry back as credentials and gets a first-person verb, then a four-letter name, then a promise about ancestors. The whole scene turns on what authority a sent person can produce.

THE SCENE	A bush that burns without burning up, on a mountain, while Moses is working his father-in-law's flock in a foreign country. The call reaches him at work, in exile, doing a job that belongs to his wife's family.
WHAT GOD SAYS FIRST	A report of having heard. "I have seen the affliction of my people… I have heard their cry because of their taskmasters" (3.7). The stated reason for acting is the noise the oppressed make.
THE PHRASE IN 3.14	*'ehyeh 'asher 'ehyeh*. "I am who I am" is the familiar rendering. The verb form can also mean "I will be what I will be," so the tense is genuinely open, and the tense you choose changes the theology.
THE FOUR LETTERS · 3.15	YHWH. Jewish readers traditionally don't pronounce it and say *Adonai*, "my Lord," or *HaShem*, "the Name." Most English Bibles print LORD in small capitals. "Jehovah" is a hybrid of the consonants with Adonai's vowels, and "Yahweh" is a scholarly reconstruction. This companion doesn't print a pronunciation. **CONTESTED** 6.3 says the ancestors didn't know this name, though Genesis uses it throughout.
FIVE OBJECTIONS	Who am I. What's your name. They won't believe me. I'm "heavy of mouth." Please send someone else. Only the last makes God angry, and the answer is Aaron.
THE NIGHT SCENE · 4.24–26	"The LORD met him and sought to put him to death." Zipporah cuts her son's foreskin with a flint, touches it to "his feet" and says "Surely you are a bridegroom of blood to me." The text doesn't say whom God was attacking, whose feet, why, or what the words mean. Every clear translation has supplied the answers. It stays unsmoothed here.

WHY A NAME IS WHAT HE ASKS FOR

INTERPRETATION In a world of named local gods, a name is jurisdiction. It tells you whose authority you're invoking and where it applies. Moses is asking what to say when the elders ask who sent him. Dominion understands this, which is why the Sanctum controls the forms of address.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHAT NAME I WAS TAUGHT FOR GOD, AND WHO TAUGHT ME NOT TO USE ANOTHER

WRITING

EXOD 3–4

TKC: DOM · SANCTUM

Who is allowed to say it

Dominion governs address: which name, which title, in whose presence, on whose authority. Exodus 3 is the founding text for that whole apparatus and for its failure, since the name is given to a fugitive shepherd and not to an institution.

1 · THE SANCTUM'S AUTHORIZED FORMS OF ADDRESS, AND WHAT'S FORBIDDEN OUTSIDE THE TEMPLE

2 · A CHARACTER WHO PRAYS USING A NAME THEY WEREN'T GIVEN PERMISSION TO USE

3 · FIVE OBJECTIONS. WRITE THE REFUSALS OF SOMEONE BEING SENT, AND WHAT ANSWERS EACH

4 · A SCENE THAT'S NEVER EXPLAINED. WRITE ONE AND LEAVE IT UNEXPLAINED

CONTENT NOTE Mass death, including the death of children, presented in the text as divine action. This page doesn't dwell on it. You can work it later, or not at all, and the dossier still functions.

A CONTEST, NOT A TANTRUM

The signs are staged as a public contest over who governs: the Nile, the livestock, the light, the firstborn, each a pillar of Egyptian order and of Pharaoh's claim to guarantee it. God calls the last plague judgment "on all the gods of Egypt" (12.12). **INTERPRETATION** Reading the cycle as an attack on a state's legitimacy, more than a list of disasters, is a strong common reading. The book doesn't state it outright.

SIGN	WHAT IT STRIKES	WHO HARDENS
BLOOD · 7	The Nile, the water supply and the state's central image of life. The court magicians match it.	Pharaoh's heart "was hardened"
FROGS, GNATS, FLIES · 8	Habitability. The magicians fail at the gnats and tell the king, "This is the finger of God" (8.19).	He hardens his own heart
LIVESTOCK, BOILS · 9	Wealth first, then the bodies of the people who run it	God hardens him, from the sixth on
HAIL · 9	The harvest, with a warning first. Some officials heed it and bring their workers and animals inside.	He admits fault, then reverses
LOCUSTS, DARKNESS · 10	Food and daylight. His own courtiers beg him to give in.	The LORD hardens him
THE FIRSTBORN · 11–12	Succession itself, "from the firstborn of Pharaoh who sits on his throne to the firstborn of the slave girl behind the handmill." A great cry in Egypt.	Release, then pursuit

THE HARDENING PROBLEM

Three patterns run through the book. God announces he'll harden Pharaoh's heart (4.21, 7.3), Pharaoh hardens it himself (8.15, 8.32, 9.34), and sometimes it simply "was hardened." Three Hebrew verbs share the work, to strengthen, to make heavy and to make hard, and translations flatten them into one. Whether it's one theology, two sources or a deliberate escalation is argued and not settled here.

EXOD 7–12

EXOD 7.3

EXOD 8.15, 32

EXOD 8.19

EXOD 9.20–21

EXOD 10.7

EXOD 12.12

FRETHEIM, EXODUS

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHO PAYS FOR A RULER'S REFUSAL IN DOMINION, AND WHO IS TOLD IT WAS NECESSARY

Passover and memory

The narrative stops at its most urgent point to install a liturgy, with a calendar, a household unit, rules for a household too small for a whole lamb, dress instructions and a script for answering a child's question years later. Liberation is legislated as an annual practice before it has happened.

THE HOUSEHOLD IS THE UNIT	No temple, no city and no priesthood yet. Aaron and his sons aren't ordained until Leviticus 8. A family, a doorway and a shared meal. The founding rite of the people is performed at home, by whoever's at home.
THE CHILD'S QUESTION	"What do you mean by this service?" (12.26). The answer is a story told in the first person, this is what was done for us. **INTERPRETATION** Memory passed on as testimony inside a family is exactly what an empire can't license.
WHO ELSE LEFT	A "mixed multitude" goes up with them (12.38), and a circumcised resident foreigner may keep the Passover under "one law" for native and stranger (12.48–49). The founding rite has an inclusion clause and a boundary in the same paragraph.
THE UNPAID WAGES	Israel "asks" the Egyptians for silver, gold and clothing and so "plunders" them. The King James "borrow" made it read like a trick. **CONTESTED** Philo and a Talmudic story took the goods as back wages for generations of unpaid labor. Others read a parting gift, and others take the plunder language at face value. Name the reading you're using.
THE FIRSTBORN CLAUSE	Right after the deliverance every firstborn male belongs to God and has to be redeemed (13.1–2, 11–16). God had already called Israel "my firstborn son" (4.22). A claim on the next generation is written into the liberation itself.

THE RITE MY FAMILY KEEPS THAT NO INSTITUTION ISSUED, AND WHAT IT PASSES ON

EXOD 12.1–28

EXOD 12.26–27

EXOD 12.35–36

EXOD 12.38, 48–49

EXOD 13.1–16

PHILO, LIFE OF MOSES 1.141

B. SANHEDRIN 91A

TKC: CELESTE

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

THE RITE MY FAMILY KEEPS THAT NO INSTITUTION ISSUED, AND WHAT IT PASSES ON

Two tellings of one crossing

Chapter 14 tells the crossing in prose, and chapter 15 sings it. They don't describe the mechanics the same way. Reading them together is a lesson in how an event becomes a liturgy and the liturgy becomes the memory.

	THE PROSE · CH. 14	THE SONG · 15.1–18
HOW THE WATER MOVES	A strong east wind all night drives the sea back	"At the blast of your nostrils the waters piled up"
THE EGYPTIANS	Chariot wheels clog, the army turns to run, the water returns at morning	Horse and rider thrown into the sea, sinking like a stone
ISRAEL	Walks through on dry ground, walls of water on both sides	Barely appears. The song is about God.
POINT OF VIEW	The narrator's	The enemy speaks in the first person (15.9)
HOW FAR IT LOOKS	Ends on the shore, with Israel believing	Ahead to Philistia, Edom, Moab and Canaan trembling, and to the sanctuary on God's mountain

MIRIAM, PROPHET AND SONG LEADER

She's called "the prophet" (15.20), the first woman in the Torah given the title. She leads the women with a hand drum and dancing, and her two lines match the song's opening. Micah names her with Moses and Aaron as the three God sent (Mic 6.4). **CONTESTED** Cross and Freedman argued in 1955 that the song was once credited to her, feminist scholars developed the case, and one Qumran manuscript (4Q365) adds lines of a song for Miriam after 15.21. It's a proposal and not a result. Hold this page next to Numbers 12 in focused study F1, where the same woman is punished for speaking.

THE VICTORY SONG DOMINION SINGS, AND WHO IS ALLOWED TO LEAD IT

EXOD 13.17–14.31

EXOD 15.1–18

EXOD 15.20–21

4Q365

MIC 6.4

NUM 12 (COMPARE)

TRIBLE, "BRINGING MIRIAM OUT"

CROSS & FREEDMAN (1955)

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

THE VICTORY SONG DOMINION SINGS, AND WHO IS ALLOWED TO LEAD IT

The week after the sea

WRITING

EXOD 15.22–27

EXOD 16

EXOD 18.13–26

TKC: DOM

Three days after the song there's no water, and by chapter 16 they're saying they ate their fill of bread in Egypt. Manna comes with a rule that nobody can hoard it. Jethro, a Midianite priest, watches Moses judge alone from morning to evening and tells him to appoint officers over thousands, hundreds, fifties and tens. Freedom arrives with a supply problem, an administration problem and a memory problem, and most liberation stories leave that part out.

1 · THE FIRST SHORTAGE AFTER A LIBERATION IN MY WORLD, AND WHO'S BLAMED FOR IT

2 · A CHARACTER WHO SAYS OUT LOUD THAT THE OLD ARRANGEMENT FED THEM BETTER

3 · THE MANNA RULE, A RATION NOBODY CAN HOARD. WHAT WOULD DOMINION DO TO IT?

4 · JETHRO'S ADVICE. WRITE THE MOMENT A MOVEMENT GETS A BUREAUCRACY

EXOD 19

EXOD 20.1–17

DEUT 5 (COMPARE)

EXOD 20.18–21

EXOD 23.12

EXOD 24.3–8

EXOD 34.28

MENDENHALL (1954–55)

A TREATY, A MOUNTAIN, A BOUNDARY

INTERPRETATION George Mendenhall compared the Sinai covenant to Hittite treaties between an overlord and a vassal: a preamble, a history of what the overlord has done, stipulations, provisions for reading the text, witnesses, and blessings and curses. The scene also installs access control, a boundary at the foot of the mountain and rules about who may cross it.

THE PREAMBLE IS THE ARGUMENT	"I am the LORD your God, who brought you out of the land of Egypt, out of the house of slavery" (20.2). Obligation rests on a completed act of liberation, and not on creation or raw power. **INTERPRETATION** Any use of the Ten that drops that clause has changed what kind of document it is.
WHO THE SABBATH ADDRESSES	The household head, the son and daughter, the male and female slave, the livestock and the resident foreigner. It's a labor law addressed to the person with the power to compel work. Exodus 23.12 adds a second reason, "that the son of your female slave and the foreigner may be refreshed."
THE LAST COMMAND LISTS PROPERTY	House first, then wife, male and female slaves, ox and donkey (20.17). The wife appears inside an inventory of what a man owns. Deuteronomy puts her first and gives her a separate verb (5.21).
THE PEOPLE ASK FOR A MEDIATOR	Frightened by the thunder, they ask Moses to speak to God for them, "lest we die." The office of the go-between is created by popular request, and every priesthood afterward has that verse available.
RATIFICATION	The covenant is read aloud, the people answer "All that the LORD has spoken we will do," and Moses throws blood on the altar and on the people (24.3–8).

TRADITION	THE FIRST WORD	COVETING
JEWISH	"I am the LORD your God who brought you out"	One commandment
CATHOLIC AND LUTHERAN	No other gods, with images inside it	Split in two
REFORMED, ORTHODOX, ANGLICAN	No other gods, with images second	One commandment

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

DOMINION'S FOUNDING DOCUMENT. WHAT DOES ITS PREAMBLE CLAIM TO HAVE DONE FOR YOU?

EXOD 21.1–11

EXOD 21.16–32

EXOD 22.21–27

EXOD 23.1–12

LEV 25.44–46

LAWS OF HAMMURABI (ROTH)

WRIGHT, INVENTING GOD'S LAW

TKC: DOM · MEN

CONTENT NOTE Slavery, debt bondage and the legal status of enslaved women and children in the covenant code. The page reports what the text legislates without endorsing it.

THE FIRST LAWS AFTER THE TEN

Chapters 21–23 are case law in the ordinary ancient form. What's striking is the order. Right after the covenant is ratified, the first subject legislated is slavery, by a people just freed.

DEBT SLAVERY	A Hebrew man bought serves six years and goes free in the seventh. If he came married, his wife leaves with him. If the master gave him a wife, she and the children stay. If he chooses to stay with them, his ear is pierced at the door and he serves for life. Freedom is granted to him and withheld from her.
THE DAUGHTER SOLD	She "shall not go out as the male slaves do." She can't be sold to foreigners, and if the man takes another wife he can't reduce her food, clothing or her third due, *ʿonah*, whose meaning is disputed. If he does, she goes free. The protections are real, and it's still a sale.
INJURY AND STATUS	Kidnapping a person to sell is a capital crime. A master who beats a slave to death is punished, and if the slave survives a day or two there's no penalty, "for he is his money." A slave who loses an eye or a tooth goes free. An ox that kills a slave costs thirty shekels, paid to the master.
MONEY LAW	A poor man's cloak taken in pledge goes back by sunset, "for that is his only covering." Credit is regulated at the point where it takes someone's bedding.
THE FOREIGNER AND THE COURTS	Don't oppress the foreigner, "for you know the heart of a foreigner." Don't favor the poor man in his lawsuit, and don't deny justice to the poor. Impartiality in both directions.

HOW TO READ IT WITHOUT LYING IN EITHER DIRECTION

INTERPRETATION The code doesn't abolish slavery. It isn't a charter for the plantation either, since it limits Hebrew debt servitude, makes kidnapping a capital crime and frees a slave for a lost tooth, and American slave codes did none of that. And it gives women fewer exits than men. Say all three. Permanent slavery of foreigners is authorized elsewhere (Lev 25.44–46), and proslavery writers cited it.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH OF THESE CLAUSES DOMINION KEEPS, AND WHICH IT HAS QUIETLY REPEALED

EXOD 32.1–6

EXOD 32.11–14

EXOD 32.21–29

EXOD 32.31–32

EXOD 33.18–23

EXOD 34.6–7

EXOD 36.5–7

DEUT 9.20

CONTENT NOTE A massacre inside the camp, 32.25–29.

Forty days unsupervised

While the sanctuary plans are being given on the mountain, the people ask the acting authority for gods they can see. Aaron makes a calf out of their gold earrings and announces "a feast to the LORD." The crisis is a leadership vacuum, an authorized official improvising, and a rite in the right name with the wrong object.

AARON ISN'T PUNISHED	He collects the gold, makes the image, builds the altar, announces the feast, and tells Moses he threw the gold in the fire "and out came this calf." He remains high priest. Deuteronomy later says God was angry enough to destroy him and Moses prayed for him (Deut 9.20). Hold that next to who does die in the same chapter.
THE PURGE	Moses calls for whoever is on the LORD's side, the Levites answer, and they go through the camp with swords. About three thousand die, and Moses tells them "today you have been ordained for the LORD," each at the cost of a son or brother. A priesthood is ordained by an internal massacre, and the book says so plainly.
MOSES ARGUES WITH GOD, TWICE	First he talks God out of destroying the people, using what the Egyptians will say and the promise to Abraham, and "the LORD relented." Next he offers to be blotted out of God's book with them. Intercession here is legal advocacy, and God is persuadable.
THE REQUEST TO SEE	He's refused the face and shown the back from a cleft in the rock. What he gets instead is a spoken self-description, "merciful and gracious, slow to anger," forgiving, and by no means clearing the guilty (34.6–7), which later books quote and argue with.
THE SECOND TABLETS	The covenant is rewritten after being broken, and the sanctuary is built from offerings so generous the people have to be told to stop. The book ends with a structure, a cloud and a schedule.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHO IN MY WORLD SURVIVES THE THING THEY BUILT, AND WHO DIES FOR ATTENDING IT

METHOD

BIBLE 101 VIII

EXOD 21.2–11

EXOD 1.15–21

One passage, worked properly

Choose one passage and run the method across this spread. If you want one chosen, try 21.2–11, the slave laws, or 1.15–21, the midwives.

PASSAGE

TRANSLATION USED

1 · WHAT IT SAYS. SUMMARIZE WITHOUT INTERPRETING. NO CONCLUSIONS YET

2 · WHO IS SPEAKING, TO WHOM, IN WHAT SITUATION

3 · WHERE TWO TRANSLATIONS DIFFER, AND WHAT TURNS ON THE DIFFERENCE

How it's been used

4 · HOW THIS PASSAGE HAS BEEN USED AGAINST SOMEONE. NAME THE USE AND NOT ONLY THE ABUSE

5 · WHAT IT REFUSES TO SETTLE. THE QUESTION THE TEXT LEAVES OPEN

6 · WHAT DOMINION WOULD DO WITH IT, AND WHICH CLAUSE THE SANCTUM CIRCULATES

7 · WHAT I'M TAKING INTO THE MANUSCRIPT, AND WHICH CHAPTER

Anything found on these two pages begins as POSSIBLE. Move it to DECIDED only after deciding it belongs in the manuscript and logging where it affects the existing files.

☐ POSSIBLE ☐ OPEN QUESTION ☐ DECIDED LOG NO. DATE

ISA 43.16–21

1 COR 10.1–5

RABOTEAU, SLAVE RELIGION (1978)

CONE, A BLACK THEOLOGY OF LIBERATION (1970)

WARRIOR, "CANAANITES, COWBOYS, AND INDIANS" (1989)

TKC: DOM · TL

The most borrowed book

Exodus is quoted by the enslaved and the enslavers, by prophets, empires, movements and settlers. For a novelist writing an empire with a scripture, the reception history is primary material.

INSIDE THE BIBLE	The prophets judge Israel by the deliverance, the return from exile is told in exodus language, the gospels put Jesus in a wilderness and on a mountain, and Paul reads the crossing as a figure (1 Cor 10). Reuse starts inside the canon.
THE SPIRITUALS	Enslaved Black Americans made Exodus the center of a sung theology, Pharaoh, the river, the promised land, often with a double meaning, a coded present inside a biblical past. "Go Down, Moses" was among the first spirituals published, in 1861, and Harriet Tubman was called Moses. For this companion, the most important reception stream.
SLAVEHOLDER USE	The same book was preached to the enslaved with the deliverance removed and the obedience kept, and the covenant code and Leviticus 25 were cited to show scripture regulates slavery and so allows it. The text didn't prevent this. The selection did it.
THE FOUNDERS	In 1776 Benjamin Franklin proposed a Great Seal showing Pharaoh drowning, under the motto "Rebellion to tyrants is obedience to God."
LIBERATION THEOLOGY	James Cone made the God of the exodus the center of *A Black Theology of Liberation* (1970) and *God of the Oppressed* (1975). God is disclosed as one who takes sides.
THE CANAANITE PROBLEM	Robert Allen Warrior read the story from the Canaanites' side in 1989. The exodus ends in someone else's land, and for Native Americans the Puritans had played Israel. A companion that celebrates the exodus without naming this hasn't finished reading.
THE CIVIL RIGHTS ERA	Movement preaching ran on Pharaoh, the wilderness and the mountaintop. Martin Luther King Jr.'s last sermon, in Memphis on April 3, 1968, ended with Moses' view of the promised land: "I may not get there with you."

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH RECEPTION STREAM MY CHARACTERS WERE RAISED INSIDE, AND WHO EDITED IT FOR THEM

EXOD 20.2

EXOD 20.8–11

EXOD 22.25–27

TKC: DOM · SANCTUM

FR 33

A DELIVERANCE ALREADY SPENT

POSSIBLE An empire can't suppress this book, because it's too well known. So it dates it. The deliverance is taught as accomplished, in the founding, by the Empire itself, and what's left for the present is the obedience section. Everything below is a TKC construction to test against the manuscript.

WHAT THE SANCTUM CIRCULATES	WHAT IT KEEPS IN THE CLOSED CATECHISM
THE SEA. DELIVERANCE AS A FOUNDING EVENT, ALREADY GRANTED.	Chapter 1. The resistance began with two working women who lied to a king and were rewarded.
THE COMMANDMENTS, FROM THE SECOND CLAUSE ON.	The preamble. The authority to command rests on having ended somebody's forced labor.
SABBATH AS HOUSEHOLD ORDER AND PUBLIC OBSERVANCE.	Sabbath as a limit on what an owner may take from a worker, an animal or a foreigner.
THE TABERNACLE CHAPTERS. COSTLY, ORDERED, BEAUTIFUL WORSHIP.	The seventh-year release, the interest ban and the returned cloak.
MOSES THE LAWGIVER, OBEDIENT AND UNQUESTIONING.	Moses arguing God out of a decision, twice, and offering to be struck from the book.

THE SANCTUM'S PROBLEM WITH THIS BOOK

POSSIBLE A scripture whose God is introduced as having heard a labor complaint can't be fully tamed. Someone in the Temple has to manage that. Whether it sits with the Prelate's office is open. The Prelate's working name is Aurelia (POSSIBLE, FR 33).

CORRECTION TO THE OLD COMPANION SUPERSEDED The old companion marked "Prelate Huldah's office" as canon and gave it the Empire's handling of Exodus. FR 33 renamed the Prelate, and the office's role here is only POSSIBLE now.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

THE EMPIRE'S DELIVERANCE LITURGY. WRITE THE PART A CHARACTER STOPS BELIEVING

WRITING

DOSSIER CLOSE

QUEUE: D2

What I take out of Exodus

THE ONE THING THIS BOOK CHANGED ABOUT HOW I SEE DOMINION

WHAT I STILL DON'T UNDERSTAND. CARRY IT TO THE RESEARCH LIST.

A LINE, AN IMAGE OR A LAW I'M TAKING STRAIGHT INTO THE MANUSCRIPT

PROOFING GATE *log only, nothing is closed here*

Dossier II has seventeen numbered pages, with content notes on pages 6, 11 and 12. Still outstanding for proofing: full citations with edition and year for the margin entries.

PROOFED BY | DATE | OUTSTANDING

NOTES

OPEN NOTES

ANYTHING THIS DOSSIER STARTED AND DIDN'T FINISH

NOTES

ANYTHING THIS SPREAD STARTED AND DID NOT FINISH

III

DEEP-DIVE DOSSIER

LEVITICUS

The book quoted to condemn and never quoted to release

SOURCE MARGIN

LEV 1–27

MT · LXX

MILGROM, LEVITICUS (AB, 3 VOLS.)

KLAWANS, IMPURITY AND SIN IN ANCIENT JUDAISM

Leviticus 25.10, as cast on the Pennsylvania State House bell, 1753

Proclaim LIBERTY Throughout all the Land unto all the Inhabitants Thereof

✣

Lev. XXV. v X. The abolitionists named it the Liberty Bell in the 1830s.

DEEP-DIVE DOSSIER III · ✣

LEVITICUS

Its most famous verses are three. Its longest arguments are about debt, land, wages and the edge of the harvest, and an empire that cites it has to keep those chapters out of general circulation.

WHY A FULL DOSSIER

The audit gives it a dossier on two grounds: the body treated as a jurisdiction, and the economic and restorative demands Dominion suppresses. Both are here, at the length they need.

HOW TO WORK IT

Reference is about a third of these pages, and the rest is yours. Four pages carry content notes. Skip them if you need to, and the dossier still works.

What it is

NAME	English from the Greek and Latin, "about the Levites," though Levites as a group appear only once (25.32–33). Hebrew *Vayikra*, "and he called," the opening word. The Hebrew title names an address, and the Greek names a professional class.
PLACE	Third book of the Torah, set entirely at Sinai. The tabernacle has just been built at the end of Exodus, and Leviticus is what's said from inside it.
AUTHORSHIP	Traditionally Moses. CONTESTED Modern scholarship generally treats chapters 1–16 and 17–26 as separate bodies of priestly material, the second called the Holiness Code since August Klostermann named it in 1877. Dates and order are debated.
STRUCTURE	1–7, offerings. 8–10, the ordination of the priests and its first disaster. 11–15, clean and unclean. 16, the Day of Atonement. 17–26, holiness, sexuality, festivals, land, debt and release. 27, vows and valuations.
GENRE	Ritual instruction, addressed mostly to priests and sometimes to everyone. It's a procedures manual. Read it the way you'd read a professional standard.
A WARNING	More people quote this book than have read it. INTERPRETATION Any argument built from Leviticus that can't say what chapter 25 requires is quoting selectively.

> **WHAT THE BOOK IS ACTUALLY ABOUT**
>
> INTERPRETATION Proximity. What it costs to live near a holy thing, who's admitted, who's put outside and for how long, and what has to be given back before anyone can come near again. Holiness here is a spatial and economic arrangement.

WHAT I WAS TAUGHT LEVITICUS WAS FOR, AND WHICH VERSES I WAS TAUGHT FROM IT

LEV 1.1

LEV 1–16

LEV 17–26

LEV 27

LEV 25.32–33

MILGROM, LEVITICUS 1–16

TKC: DOM

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHAT I WAS TAUGHT LEVITICUS WAS FOR, AND WHICH VERSES I WAS TAUGHT FROM IT

A SYSTEM WITH A SLIDING SCALE

LEV 1–3

LEV 4.1–5.13

LEV 5.14–6.7

MILGROM, LEVITICUS 1–16

TKC: DOM · SANCTUM

Five main offerings, each with its own occasion, procedure and disposal of the parts. Two are for wrongdoing and three aren't. The scale matters. The same rite can be a bull, a bird or a measure of flour, depending on what the worshipper has. Access is priced to income, and the text says so.

OFFERING	WHAT IT IS FOR	BUILT-IN SCALE
BURNT · *ʿOLAH*	The whole animal burned, the standing offering of the sanctuary	A bull, a sheep or goat, or birds
GRAIN · *MINḤAH*	Flour, oil and frankincense. A handful is burned and the rest goes to the priests, with salt, "the salt of the covenant" (2.13).	Cooked or raw, in several forms
WELL-BEING · *SHELAMIM*	A shared meal. The fat is burned, and the worshipper's household eats the meat.	Herd or flock
PURIFICATION · *ḤATTAʾT*, TRADITIONALLY "SIN OFFERING"	Its blood purges the sanctuary of the impurity a person's error or condition has caused	Graded by status, down to two birds, and down to a tenth of an ephah of flour for someone who can't afford birds
REPARATION · *ʾASHAM*, TRADITIONALLY "GUILT OFFERING"	For misusing holy things and defrauding a neighbor under oath	The full amount restored to the wronged person, plus a fifth, before the ram is offered

THE PART NO EMPIRE PREACHES

INTERPRETATION In the reparation law, ritual doesn't stand in for repayment. You can't settle a defrauded neighbor at the altar. The neighbor is paid first, with a penalty added, and only then is the offering brought. A religion that offers forgiveness without restitution has reversed this chapter.

WHAT DOMINION CHARGES FOR ABSOLUTION, AND WHO IS PAID, IF ANYONE

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHAT DOMINION CHARGES FOR ABSOLUTION, AND WHO IS PAID, IF ANYONE

CONTENT NOTE Disease, bodily discharge and exclusion from the community, including quarantine applied to people.

The body as jurisdiction

Impurity in Leviticus is a status, and mostly not a moral one. It limits access to the sanctuary, it's picked up through ordinary events, birth, discharge, illness, contact with a corpse, and it ends with time, washing and sometimes an offering. Translating it as "dirty" or "shameful" brings in a judgment the system doesn't make.

WHAT IT REGULATES	Who may approach, when and after what interval. Almost everyone is impure at some point, priests included, and priests live under stricter rules about corpses. It's a calendar of access more than a register of character.
TWO KINDS	Jonathan Klawans distinguishes ritual impurity, unavoidable and not sinful, from moral impurity, which comes from grave sins like sexual transgression, idolatry and bloodshed, defiles the land and can't be washed off. The later Christian split into moral and ceremonial law maps onto neither neatly.
THE SKIN CHAPTERS · 13–14	*Tsara'at* can appear on skin, on cloth and on the walls of houses. It isn't leprosy in the modern sense, though the Greek *lepra* carried that name into English. A priest inspects, isolates for seven days, inspects again and declares. Someone declared unclean tears their clothes, leaves their hair loose, covers their upper lip, calls out "Unclean, unclean" and lives alone outside the camp. Readmission is as detailed as exclusion.
DIETARY LAW · 11	Animals sorted by stated criteria, split hooves and chewing the cud, fins and scales, never explained. Hygiene, separation from neighbors and Mary Douglas's anomaly reading have all been proposed. None is settled, and the only reason given is holiness.

WHERE THE DANGER IS FOR A WRITER

INTERPRETATION A status system with an inspector, an interval and a public declaration is the most transferable machinery in the Torah. Dominion doesn't need to invent contamination law. It only has to attach moral weight to a status this book keeps mostly non-moral.

LEV 11

LEV 13–14

LEV 13.45–46

DOUGLAS, PURITY AND DANGER (1966)

DOUGLAS, LEVITICUS AS LITERATURE (1999)

KLAWANS, IMPURITY AND SIN

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHO INSPECTS BODIES IN DOMINION, AND WHAT THEY'RE AUTHORIZED TO DECLARE

CONTENT NOTE Menstruation, childbirth and the regulation of women's bodies by religious law.

Chapter 12 and chapter 15

Two chapters govern access after childbirth and during discharges, for women and for men. Read them together. The male provisions are there, and they're usually left out of any sermon on the female ones.

AFTER A BIRTH	Impure seven days after a son, then thirty-three more before she may touch holy things or enter the sanctuary. For a daughter both numbers double, to fourteen and sixty-six. The text gives no reason. Every explanation you've heard is interpretation.
THE OFFERING AFTER	A lamb and a bird. If she can't afford a lamb, two birds will do (12.8). The concession is written into the law, which means the law expects poor women to use it. Luke records Mary bringing the poorer offering (Luke 2.22–24).
MEN IN CHAPTER 15	Matching sections for men and women: abnormal male discharge, emission, intercourse, menstruation and abnormal female bleeding. A man with an abnormal discharge brings the same two birds as a woman with abnormal bleeding. After intercourse both are impure until evening. The chapter states its purpose, to keep the people from defiling the tabernacle among them (15.31).
WHAT IT ISN'T	These states aren't punishments or sins. They're conditions with a procedure. **INTERPRETATION** Whether the system still weighs more heavily on women in practice is a fair question, and a separate one from what the text calls it.
RECEPTION	Later Jewish law developed these rules into a detailed practice with its own debates, and churches developed their own customs about women after childbirth. Don't read either back into Leviticus. The woman with bleeding who touches Jesus' clothes lives under 15.25–30 (Mark 5).

THE USEFUL QUESTION FOR TKC

INTERPRETATION The question is who runs the calendar. An empire that decides when a woman may enter a building has an instrument for scheduling her whole life, and can attach a fee to it.

LEV 12

LEV 15.1–18

LEV 15.19–33

LUKE 2.22–24

MARK 5.25–34

MILGROM, LEVITICUS 1–16

TKC: DOM

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHAT MY WORLD DOES WITH A WOMAN'S BODY AND A CALENDAR

One day, two goats

Once a year the high priest enters the innermost space, after washings and changes of clothes, and the sanctuary itself is cleansed of a year's accumulated contamination. Two goats are chosen by lot. One is offered. Over the other the high priest confesses the people's sins with both hands on its head, and it's sent alive into the wilderness. The day applies to the resident foreigner as well as the native.

WHAT'S BEING CLEANSED	The building, first. Blood is sprinkled to cleanse the sanctuary "because of the uncleannesses of the people of Israel and their transgressions" (16.16). Sin has a physical residue here, and it collects where God is said to live. The people's atonement follows.
THE GOAT THAT LEAVES	The second goat is "for Azazel." CONTESTED: Tyndale coined "scapegoat" in 1530, reading "the goat that departs." Others propose a place name for a rugged cliff, a wilderness demon (Azazel is a fallen angel in 1 Enoch), or an abstract noun for complete removal. Don't read the modern social meaning of "scapegoat" back into the verse.
CONFESSION ALOUD	The high priest confesses on behalf of the whole people, in public, and the assembly does no work and denies itself. A national accounting on a fixed date, performed by the highest office in everyone's hearing.
TWO PRIESTS DIED IN CHAPTER 10	The chapter opens "after the death of the two sons of Aaron." Nadab and Abihu offered fire they weren't commanded to offer, and fire consumed them. Aaron was silent and was forbidden to mourn in public. The system that follows was written by people for whom improvising at the altar was lethal.
RECEPTION	Later Jewish tradition made Yom Kippur the year's central day of repentance without a temple, and Hebrews reads the chapter through Christ. Both are receptions of Leviticus 16.

DOMINION'S ANNUAL ACCOUNTING. WHO CONFESSES, WHO'S SENT OUT, AND WHO WATCHES

LEV 10.1–9

LEV 16

LEV 16.16

LEV 16.29

LEV 23.26–32

1 ENOCH 8–10

HEB 9 (RECEPTION)

MILGROM, LEVITICUS 1–16

TKC: SANCTUM

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

DOMINION'S ANNUAL ACCOUNTING. WHO CONFESSES, WHO'S SENT OUT, AND WHO WATCHES

CONTENT NOTE Sexual prohibitions, incest, capital penalties, and the modern use of two verses against gay people. The page reports the text and the state of the argument and doesn't settle your theology for you.

The two verses and the rest of the list

Chapter 18 is addressed to Israelite men and opens by refusing the practices of Egypt and Canaan. Most of it is forbidden unions with kin, set out from the man's side. A man's own daughter isn't named, which scholars have explained in different ways. Chapter 20 assigns penalties, often death.

WHAT'S IN THE LIST	Close kin by blood and marriage, a wife's sister as a rival while the wife lives, sex during menstruation, a neighbor's wife, giving children to Molech, lying with a male "as with a woman," and sex with animals, the only verse that makes a woman the one acting.
"ABOMINATION"	*To'evah* covers the whole list. It's used elsewhere for unclean food, dishonest weights and a lying tongue. The English carries a revulsion the Hebrew may not.
THE SELECTION TEST	**INTERPRETATION** Anyone citing chapter 18 as binding is also citing the menstruation clause, and is standing seven chapters from the debt release. Consistency is a question about the reader.

CONTESTED 18.22 AND 20.13	WHAT IT HOLDS	ASSOCIATED WITH
A GENERAL PROHIBITION	All sexual relations between men, carried forward in the New Testament (Rom 1, 1 Cor 6)	Robert Gagnon (2001), and most historic church teaching
A SPECIFIC ACT	The phrasing points narrowly to anal intercourse between men	Saul Olyan (1994). Milgrom also limited it to that act and to Israelite men in the land.
THE CODE'S OWN CONCERNS	Read inside a system organized around lineage, seed and category boundaries	Various, building on Douglas
APPLICABILITY	Whether the Holiness Code binds Christians at all, and by what principle some laws are kept	The moral, ceremonial and civil division, and its critics

LEV 18
LEV 20
GEN 43.32
DEUT 14.3
DEUT 25.16
PROV 6.16–19
GAGNON (2001)
OLYAN (1994)
MILGROM, LEVITICUS 17–22

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH VERSES DOMINION MADE STATUTE, AND WHICH IT LEFT AS SCRIPTURE

The chapter nobody quotes whole

"Love your neighbor as yourself" sits in the middle of a chapter of labor law, harvest law, court procedure and protection for disabled people. In context it's the summary clause of a list of concrete obligations. The chapter opens "You shall be holy, for I the LORD your God am holy" and puts ritual and ethics side by side without ranking them. Revere your mother and father, mother first.

THE HARVEST EDGE	Don't reap to the border of the field, don't strip the vineyard, leave what falls for the poor and the foreigner. A standing claim on private production, collected by the poor themselves. Ruth gleans under this law.
WAGES THE SAME DAY	A hired worker's pay may not be held overnight. Wage theft is named beside robbery.
DISABILITY	Don't curse the deaf or put a stumbling block before the blind, harms the victim can't see coming or answer. Compare chapter 21, the same book with a different logic.
COURTS AND SPEECH	No partiality to great or poor, no slander, and don't stand by while your neighbor's blood is shed. Reprove openly instead of hating in your heart. Confrontation is commanded as the alternative to a grudge.
THE FOREIGNER	Treated as a native, "and you shall love him as yourself, for you were foreigners in Egypt." The famous command appears twice, and the second time it's about immigrants.
HONEST WEIGHTS	Just balances, weights and measures. Commercial fraud closes the chapter that holds the love command.

> **AN ENSLAVED WOMAN, 19.20–22**
>
> Content note. A man who lies with an enslaved woman promised to another man isn't put to death, "because she was not free." There's an inquiry or a penalty (the word is disputed), and he brings a reparation offering. The text says nothing about her.

LEV 19.2–3

LEV 19.9–10

LEV 19.13–18

LEV 19.20–22

LEV 19.33–36

MARK 12.31

RUTH 2

MILGROM, LEVITICUS 17–22

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHERE THE HARVEST EDGE WOULD BE IN MY WORLD, AND WHO FENCED IT

Land, debt and release

Every seventh year the land rests. In the fiftieth year, by proclamation, holdings go back to the families that lost them and people in debt service go home. The stated ground is ownership. Land isn't sold permanently because it isn't the seller's to sell, "for the land is mine, and you are foreigners and sojourners with me" (25.23).

THE SABBATH YEAR	No sowing, no reaping, no harvesting the vines. What grows feeds the household, the workers, the hired laborer, the resident foreigner, the livestock and the wild animals alike.
THE FIFTIETH YEAR	Proclaimed with a horn on the Day of Atonement: liberty throughout the land. The economic reset is announced on the day of national confession, which ties the two together on purpose.
PRICE MECHANICS	Sale prices are counted by the number of harvests left until the release. What changes hands is a lease of crops more than the land itself. Debt is designed to expire. Houses in walled cities are an exception.
NO INTEREST	Take no interest from a poor kinsman, and support him so he can live beside you. One who sells himself is to be treated as a hired worker until the Jubilee.
REDEMPTION DUTY	A kinsman may and should buy back a relative's land or freedom. Rescue is a family obligation with a legal form, the machinery Ruth runs on.
THE BOUNDARY IN IT	The protections are for kin. The same chapter lets Israel buy slaves from the nations and from resident foreigners, pass them on as inheritance and "make them slaves forever" (25.44–46). Print it whenever the Jubilee is praised.
WAS IT PRACTICED	Sabbath years are attested in the Second Temple period. There's no clear record of a Jubilee being kept. **CONTESTED** Whether it was enacted law, a utopian program or an ideal invoked now and then.

WHY AN EMPIRE CAN'T CIRCULATE THIS CHAPTER

INTERPRETATION A permanent land market and inheritable debt are the two ways a household gets captured for generations. Chapter 25 forbids both among kin and grounds the ban in the deliverance the Empire also claims. It can't be denied and can't be taught, so it goes to the closed catechism.

LEV 25.1–7

LEV 25.8–17

LEV 25.23–28

LEV 25.35–46

NEH 10.31

1 MACC 6.49, 53

BERGSMA, THE JUBILEE FROM LEVITICUS TO QUMRAN

TKC: DOM · MEN

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH HOUSEHOLD IN MY CAST A JUBILEE WOULD FREE, AND WHO WOULD LOSE BY IT

Build the suppression

Dominion can't delete a chapter its own scripture contains. It has to manage it: restrict it, spiritualize it, postpone it, or attach conditions that never arrive. Draft the mechanism here.

1 · THE OFFICIAL TEACHING ON DEBT RELEASE, IN THE SANCTUM'S VOICE

2 · THE CONDITION ATTACHED TO IT THAT CAN NEVER BE MET

3 · A CHARACTER WHO READS CHAPTER 25 FOR THE FIRST TIME. WRITE THE SCENE

4 · THE HARVEST EDGE AND THE SAME-DAY WAGE AS DOMINION LABOR LAW. WHAT REPLACED THEM

WRITING

LEV 19

LEV 25

TKC: DOM · SANCTUM

LEV 21.1–15

LEV 21.16–24

LEV 22.10–16

LEV 22.20–25

LEV 19.14

ISA 56.3–5

OLYAN, DISABILITY IN THE HEBREW BIBLE (2008)

TKC: TR

The body of the official

Chapter 21 limits who may serve at the altar by descent, marriage, mourning and body. A priest with a listed condition may eat the holy food and may not officiate. The rule concerns how the sanctuary presents itself, and it shuts a class of people out of an office because of their bodies. Both halves of that sentence belong on the page.

THE LIST	A man who's blind or lame, has a marked face or a limb too long, a broken foot or hand, a hunched back, dwarfism, a defect of the eye, scabs or crushed testicles. The same word, *mum*, marks animals unfit for sacrifice. Interpreters note the symmetry between offerer, offering and officiant, which explains the logic without justifying it.
HELD AGAINST CHAPTER 19	The book that protects the deaf and the blind from harm bars them from the priesthood. It's a real tension inside Leviticus, and the honest move is to name it. Isaiah 56 later promises eunuchs a name in God's house better than sons and daughters.
MARRIAGE AND MOURNING	Limits on whom a priest may marry, tighter for the high priest, and on which dead he may mourn. A priest's daughter who becomes a prostitute is to be burned (21.9). Office reaches into the household and the funeral.
WHAT PRIESTS LIVE ON	Set portions of the offerings, shared with their households and closed to outsiders. The sanctuary is also a payroll, and the text isn't embarrassed about it.

> **FOR DOMINION**
>
> **POSSIBLE** An empire choosing candidates for a public religious role has this chapter as precedent for physical screening, and the Trials are that kind of selection. Whether the Sanctum cites Leviticus 21 for its examinations is a plot decision.

WHAT DISQUALIFIES A BODY FROM SERVICE IN MY WORLD, AND WHO WROTE THE LIST

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHAT DISQUALIFIES A BODY FROM SERVICE IN MY WORLD, AND WHO WROTE THE LIST

METHOD

BIBLE 101 VIII

LEV 25.8–17

LEV 19.9–15

One passage, worked properly

Choose one passage and run the method across this spread. If you want one chosen, try 25.8–17, the Jubilee proclamation, or 19.9–15, the harvest edge and the wage.

PASSAGE

TRANSLATION USED

1 · WHAT IT SAYS. SUMMARIZE WITHOUT INTERPRETING. NO CONCLUSIONS YET

2 · WHO IS ADDRESSED, WHO IS DISCUSSED AND WHO IS ABSENT

3 · WHERE TWO TRANSLATIONS DIFFER, AND WHAT TURNS ON THE DIFFERENCE

How it's been used

4 · HOW THIS PASSAGE HAS BEEN USED AGAINST SOMEONE, AND WHO BENEFITED

5 · WHAT IT COSTS THE PERSON WITH PROPERTY, IF IT'S ACTUALLY KEPT

6 · WHAT DOMINION WOULD DO WITH IT. CIRCULATE, RESTRICT OR SPIRITUALIZE

7 · WHAT I'M TAKING INTO THE MANUSCRIPT, AND WHICH CHAPTER

Anything found on these two pages begins as POSSIBLE. Move it to DECIDED only after deciding it belongs in the manuscript and logging where it affects the existing files.

☐ POSSIBLE ☐ OPEN QUESTION ☐ DECIDED LOG NO. DATE

ISA 61.1–2

LUKE 4.16–21

ACTS 15

AQUINAS, ST I–II Q. 99

WESTMINSTER CONFESSION (1646) 19

BERGSMA, THE JUBILEE

A BOOK USED IN TWO DIRECTIONS

Everything here is reception, what people did with Leviticus.

INSIDE THE BIBLE	The release language of chapter 25 comes back in Isaiah 61, and Luke has Jesus read that passage in the synagogue at Nazareth and say it's fulfilled today (Luke 4.16–21). The Jubilee is quoted as a program.
JEWISH PRACTICE	Rabbinic Judaism developed the purity, dietary and agricultural laws into living practice and argument, sabbatical-year observance included. Treating Leviticus as a dead text is a Christian habit.
EARLY CHRISTIAN USE	In Acts 15 the church decided which of these laws applied to non-Jewish believers. Thomas Aquinas later divided the law into moral, ceremonial and judicial precepts, and the Westminster Confession (1646) made the division Reformed doctrine. The text doesn't contain it, and it's how chapter 18 is kept and chapter 25 dropped.
THE LIBERTY BELL	Cast for the Pennsylvania State House in 1752 and recast in 1753 with 25.10 on it. Abolitionists adopted it in the 1830s. The *Anti-Slavery Record* called it the Liberty Bell in 1835, and a poem in Garrison's *Liberator* in 1839 spread the name.
DEBT CAMPAIGNS	The Jubilee 2000 campaign for cancelling the debts of the poorest countries took its name and its argument from chapter 25.
PURITY AS INSULT	"Unclean" and "leper" have long been used outside the sanctuary system for people a community wants to keep out, by race, disease or sexuality. The most consequential misuse of the book.

CORRECTION TO THE OLD COMPANION The old companion said the word "jubilee" is on the bell. It isn't. The bell reads "Proclaim LIBERTY Throughout all the Land unto all the Inhabitants Thereof," with the reference Lev. XXV. v X. Its debt reading also needed fixing: the Jubilee returns land and frees Israelites in debt service, and the seventh-year debt release is Deuteronomy 15.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHERE I'VE HEARD PURITY LANGUAGE USED ABOUT A PERSON

LEV 19.9–15

LEV 25

LEV 6.1–7

TKC: DOM · SANCTUM

The half the Empire teaches

POSSIBLE Everything on this page is a TKC construction to test against the manuscript.

WHAT THE SANCTUM CIRCULATES	WHAT IT KEEPS IN THE CLOSED CATECHISM
HOLINESS AS PERSONAL PURITY, AND THE SEXUAL PROHIBITIONS AS HOUSEHOLD LAW	Chapter 25 entire. Land returned, debts ended, servitude ended by proclamation.
LOVE YOUR NEIGHBOR, AS A DISPOSITION	The harvest edge, the same-day wage and the ban on interest that define what the love requires
INSPECTION, QUARANTINE AND READMISSION AS PUBLIC HEALTH AND PUBLIC ORDER	Impurity in the source text is temporary, recurring, mostly non-moral, and applies to priests too
ATONEMENT AS AN ANNUAL ACT OF SUBMISSION, SCHEDULED BY THE SANCTUM	The rite cleanses the sanctuary of what the institution itself has accumulated
RESTITUTION AS AN OFFERING PAID TO THE TEMPLE	The defrauded person is paid first, in full, plus a fifth, before any offering counts

THE ARGUMENT IN ONE PARAGRAPH

INTERPRETATION Dominion doesn't need to falsify Leviticus. It teaches chapters 11 through 20 and shelves 19.9–15 and chapter 25, keeping the machinery of exclusion and dropping the machinery of release. A character who reads the whole book finds the Empire's own scripture arguing against it, a stronger plot device than any invented heresy.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHO IN MY CAST WOULD RATHER NOT HAVE HEARD CHAPTER 25 READ ALOUD

WRITING

DOSSIER CLOSE

QUEUE: D3

What I take out of Leviticus

THE ONE THING THIS BOOK CHANGED ABOUT HOW I SEE DOMINION

WHAT I STILL DON'T UNDERSTAND. CARRY IT TO THE RESEARCH LIST.

A CLAUSE I'M TAKING STRAIGHT INTO THE MANUSCRIPT, AND WHERE

PROOFING GATE *log only, nothing is closed here*

Dossier III has fifteen numbered pages, with content notes on pages 3, 4, 6 and 7, and 18.22 carried as CONTESTED with no verdict printed. Outstanding for proofing: full citations with edition and year.

PROOFED BY | DATE | OUTSTANDING

NOTES

OPEN NOTES

ANYTHING THIS DOSSIER STARTED AND DIDN'T FINISH

NOTES

ANYTHING THIS SPREAD STARTED AND DID NOT FINISH

IV

DEEP-DIVE DOSSIER

Deuteronomy

A speech given by a man who isn't allowed to arrive

SOURCE MARGIN

DEUT 1–34

MT · LXX · 4QDEUT

WEINFELD, DEUTERONOMY 1–11 (AB)

LEVINSON, DEUTERONOMY AND THE HERMENEUTICS OF LEGAL INNOVATION

The Law of the King

DEUTERONOMY 17.14–20

TO BE COPIED IN THE KING'S OWN HAND, IN THE PRESENCE OF THE PRIESTS, AND READ ALL THE DAYS OF HIS LIFE

HORSES	*not many, and none bought by sending the people back to Egypt*
WIVES	*not many, "lest his heart turn away"*
SILVER AND GOLD	*not in great quantity*
THE COPY	*written by the king himself and kept with him*
THE REASON	*that his heart may not be lifted up above his brothers*

Six verses, and no enforcement clause. Solomon breaks all four prohibitions (1 Kgs 3.1, 10.27–29, 11.3).

NOT ENFORCED

DEEP-DIVE DOSSIER IV · ✣

Deuteronomy

The book that tells a nation how to be a nation, one sanctuary, one archive, a king held under the law and debts that expire, and the most dangerous book in the Torah for an empire to let people read whole.

WHY A FULL DOSSIER

The audit gives it a dossier on three grounds. It's a constitution, it holds the law that limits a king, and it supplies both the enforcement machinery and the conquest language Dominion runs on.

HOW TO WORK IT

Reference is about a third of these pages, and the rest is yours. Three pages carry content notes. Skip them if you need to, and the dossier still works.

What it is

NAME	English from the Greek *deuteronomion*, "second law." It's a mistranslation. In 17.18 the king is told to write "a copy of this law," *mishneh hattorah hazzot*, and the Greek translators rendered it "this second law." Hebrew *Devarim*, "words."
PLACE	The fifth and last book of the Torah, set on the plains of Moab on the last day of Moses' life. Nothing happens. The book is speech, and then a death, and a grave no one knows (34.5–6).
JOSIAH'S SCROLL	In 2 Kings 22–23, during temple repairs under Josiah, about 622 BCE, the high priest finds "the book of the law." The king tears his clothes, sends to the prophet Huldah, who authenticates it, and purges the outlying shrines. W. M. L. de Wette argued in 1805 that the scroll was a form of Deuteronomy. CONTESTED Whether the core was written for the reform, came south after 722 BCE, or was shaped largely in and after the exile. Traditional readers attribute the book to Moses.
STRUCTURE	1–4, a retelling of the wilderness. 5–11, the commandments, the Shema and the sermon on loyalty. 12–26, the law code. 27–28, blessings and curses. 29–30, covenant renewal. 31–34, succession, a song, a blessing and a grave.
GENRE	A sermon wrapped around a law code, shaped like an ancient treaty between a great king and a subject people.
A WARNING	The book holds the most quoted verse about loving God and the most brutal commands about conquest, in the same speech, from the same mouth. A presentation that gives you one without the other is selling something.

> **WHAT THE BOOK IS ACTUALLY ABOUT**
>
> INTERPRETATION Memory as a political instrument. Almost every command comes with a reason that starts "remember that you were a slave." The book's theory is that a people who forget where they came from will build what they escaped.

DEUT 1.1

DEUT 1–11

DEUT 12–26

DEUT 27–34

DEUT 17.18

2 KGS 22–23

WEINFELD, DEUTERONOMY AND THE DEUTERONOMIC SCHOOL (1972)

TKC: DOM

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHAT I WAS TAUGHT DEUTERONOMY WAS, AND WHETHER ANYONE TOLD ME IT WAS A CONSTITUTION

A LOYALTY OATH, REVERSED

Assyrian and Hittite kings bound subject peoples with documents of a recognizable type. Deuteronomy has the same parts in roughly the same order, with one substitution. The great king is God, and the human monarch is demoted into the text as a regulated official. INTERPRETATION The substitution is the book's central political act.

TREATY PART	WHAT IT DOES	IN DEUTERONOMY
PREAMBLE	Names the sovereign and the setting	1.1–5
HISTORICAL PROLOGUE	Recounts what the sovereign has done, so the terms arrive as gratitude. It differs from Exodus and Numbers in places, and the differences are the argument.	1.6–4.43
GENERAL STIPULATION	Exclusive loyalty, called "love." William Moran showed in 1963 that "love" in treaties names political loyalty.	5–11, the Shema at 6.4–5
SPECIFIC STIPULATIONS	The code: sanctuary, officers, courts, king, priests, prophets, war, property, debt, family, harvest	12–26
DEPOSIT AND READING	Stored beside the ark and read aloud every seventh year, at the feast of Booths, to men, women, children and foreigners	10.1–5, 31.9–13
WITNESSES	Heaven and earth, and a song to be memorized	4.26, 30.19, 31.19, 32.1
BLESSINGS AND CURSES	Enforcement	27–28

WHICH TREATIES

Whether the closer model is the Hittite treaties of the second millennium (Mendenhall), which would support an early date, or the Neo-Assyrian treaties of the seventh century (Weinfeld), which fit Josiah's time.

WHY THE FORM MATTERS FOR TKC

INTERPRETATION If you want to build a state religion, this is the template, and the template is neutral. The same seven parts produce a covenant that limits the king or a loyalty oath that makes him a god, depending on who is named in the preamble. Dominion changes one line and keeps the rest.

DEUT 1–3

DEUT 28

DEUT 31.9–13

ESARHADDON SUCCESSION TREATY (COMPARE)

MORAN (1963)

WEINFELD, DEUTERONOMIC SCHOOL

TKC: DOM · SANCTUM

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

DOMINION'S FOUNDING DOCUMENT. WHO IS IN THE PREAMBLE, AND WHO WITNESSES

The household is the school

DEUT 6.4–9

DEUT 6.10–12

DEUT 6.20–21

DEUT 5.6–21

EXOD 20.8–11 (COMPARE)

DEUT 8.17

MARK 12.29–30

The book's most famous passage is a loyalty clause followed by a method. Keep these words on your heart, teach them to your children, talk about them sitting in your house and walking on the road, lying down and rising, bind them on your hand and write them on your doorposts and gates. It's a curriculum with a delivery schedule, located in the house more than the sanctuary.

WHERE TEACHING SITS	With parents, in domestic time, in ordinary conversation. No priest appears, and no building. **INTERPRETATION** An institution that wants a monopoly on teaching has to get around chapter 6, not cite it.
THE CHILD'S QUESTION	When a child asks what the laws mean, the answer is a story: "We were Pharaoh's slaves in Egypt" (6.20–21). The catechism is historical. The reason for the law is a memory of servitude.
TWO DECALOGUES	Deuteronomy 5 repeats the ten words with real differences. Exodus says "remember" the sabbath and Deuteronomy says "observe." Exodus grounds it in creation, and Deuteronomy in slavery, "that your male and female slave may rest as well as you." Deuteronomy's coveting command puts the wife first, gives her her own verb and adds the neighbor's field.
THE PROSPERITY WARNING	Right after the teaching method: when you live in houses you didn't build and eat from vines you didn't plant, you'll forget (6.10–12). Later, don't say "my power and the might of my hand have gotten me this wealth" (8.17). The book's named enemy is comfort.
RECEPTION	The verses became a fixed recitation in Judaism, and Jesus names them the first commandment (Mark 12.29–30). Both are receptions of Deuteronomy 6.

WHO IS ALLOWED TO TEACH A CHILD IN MY WORLD, AND WHAT HAPPENS IN THE HOUSE INSTEAD

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHO IS ALLOWED TO TEACH A CHILD IN MY WORLD, AND WHAT HAPPENS IN THE HOUSE INSTEAD

Centralization and its price

DEUT 12

DEUT 14.22–29

DEUT 18.6–8

DEUT 26.12

2 KGS 23.9

LEVINSON, LEGAL INNOVATION

TKC: SANCTUM

Chapter 12 abolishes local altars and requires sacrifice at one chosen place. The single provision reorganizes a society. It moves worship away from the village, concentrates revenue, leaves a class of local priests without altars and turns pilgrimage into infrastructure. The chapter then works through the consequences, which makes it legislation.

THE RULE	Sacrifice only at "the place the LORD your God will choose." Local shrines are to be destroyed. Jerusalem is never named.
MEAT BECOMES SECULAR	Since you can't slaughter at a local altar any more, ordinary slaughter at home is allowed. Eat meat in your towns, and pour out the blood. A monopoly at the center creates a whole area of life the sanctuary no longer touches.
TITHE INTO COIN	If the journey's too long, sell the tithe, carry the money and buy "whatever you desire, oxen or sheep or wine or strong drink," and eat it there with the household and the Levite. A tax in kind turned into currency for logistical reasons, and the text says so.
THE THIRD-YEAR TITHE	Every third year the tithe stays in the town for the Levite, the foreigner, the fatherless and the widow. A centralized system with a mandatory local redistribution valve built in.
THE DISPLACED PRIESTS	Local Levites without altars appear again and again among the dependents "within your gates." A Levite who comes to the central place may serve there equally (18.6–8). In Josiah's reform the shrine priests didn't serve at the Jerusalem altar (2 Kgs 23.9), so the law and the history don't match.

THE MECHANISM WORTH STEALING

POSSIBLE One authorized place, one authorized calendar, and travel required to comply. Attendance becomes traceable, absence becomes evidence, and the road becomes a tax. Dominion doesn't need to invent a Sanctum monopoly. It keeps chapter 12 and loses chapter 14's local tithe.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHAT THE JOURNEY TO THE CENTER COSTS A POOR HOUSEHOLD IN MY WORLD

The king under the text

INTERPRETATION Six verses, and the most politically radical passage in the Torah. Monarchy is permitted, conditionally, and then stripped. The office is placed under a document.

HOW THE KING ARRIVES	By popular demand, "like all the nations around me," then by God's choice, and from among the people, not a foreigner. Kingship is a concession framed as copying the neighbors.
THE FOUR PROHIBITIONS	Horses, Egypt, wives and treasure. Read as policy: no standing cavalry, no military alliance with Egypt, no network of dynastic marriages, no royal hoard. They're the four instruments of ancient state power.
THE COPYING CLAUSE	He writes out the law in a scroll before the priests and keeps it with him. A sovereign who has to copy out the limits on his own office, and reread them, can't claim not to know them.
THE STATED REASON	"That his heart may not be lifted up above his brothers." Neither efficiency nor piety. The reason is anti-hierarchical, and it's written into the clause.
THE OTHER OFFICES	Judges, priests and prophets are each limited in the surrounding chapters: no bribes, no partiality, a test for false prophecy, portions in place of estates. Chapter 17 sits inside a scheme that spreads authority out and checks it.
WHAT'S MISSING	No enforcement. Nobody is named who can remove a king who breaks the list, which is the flaw every later empire uses. Solomon breaks all four: horses from Egypt, Pharaoh's daughter and seven hundred wives, and silver "as common as stone."

THE CENTRAL TKC FINDING

POSSIBLE The Empire's own scripture forbids the Emperor to pile up wealth, weapons and wives and requires him to copy the law by hand. Dominion can't delete it, so it reinterprets it, most likely by declaring the Emperor exempt as the law's author and not its subject. The move is the theological center of the Empire, and it's available to any character who can read.

DEUT 17.14–20

DEUT 16.18–20

DEUT 18.15–22

1 SAM 8

1 KGS 3.1

1 KGS 10.27–29

1 KGS 11.3

TKC: DOM · MEN

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH OF THE FOUR PROHIBITIONS MY EMPEROR BREAKS MOST VISIBLY, AND WHO NOTICED

Debt with an expiry date

Every seventh year, release. Debts between Israelites are cancelled, and debt servants go free, and not empty-handed. The master has to load them with livestock, grain and wine, because you were slaves and were brought out. The chapter also closes the obvious loophole: don't refuse a loan because the seventh year is near.

THE RELEASE	Creditors release what they've lent to a fellow Israelite. A foreigner's debt can still be collected, and the text says so. Print the limit with the promise.
TWO SENTENCES THAT DISAGREE	"There will be no poor among you" (15.4) and "the poor will never cease out of the land" (15.11), a few verses apart. The first is conditional on obedience, and the second is the reason to open your hand. Jesus quotes the second (Mark 14.7).
THE HARD-HEART CLAUSE	Don't harden your heart or shut your hand, and don't let your eye be hostile because the release is coming. Reluctance is named as a sin, which means the drafters expected it.

DEUT 15.1–11

DEUT 15.12–18

DEUT 23.15–16

DEUT 24.10–15

EXOD 21.7 (COMPARE)

HAMMURABI §§15–20

JER 34

NEH 5

MARK 14.7

TKC: DOM

DEUT 15.1–11

DEUT 15.12–18

DEUT 23.15–16

DEUT 24.10–15

EXOD 21.7 (COMPARE)

HAMMURABI §§15–20

JER 34

NEH 5

MARK 14.7

TKC: DOM

Debt with an expiry date, continued

SEVERANCE	A Hebrew man or woman freed in the seventh year leaves with provisions from the flock, the threshing floor and the winepress. Freedom made survivable. **CONTESTED** Whether this revises Exodus 21.7, which kept a sold daughter from going free, or addresses a different case.
THE ONE WHO STAYS	An awl through the ear at the door, "and to your female slave you shall do the same." Consent is provided for and then made permanent and visible.
RUNAWAYS · 23.15–16	An escaped slave who takes refuge with you isn't returned and may live wherever he chooses. The Code of Hammurabi made harboring a runaway a capital offense.
WAS IT PRACTICED	In Jeremiah 34, Jerusalem frees its slaves under siege and then takes them back, and Jeremiah answers with a "release" to the sword. Nehemiah 5 settles a debt crisis under pressure. The law was invoked, and there's no evidence of it working as designed.

HELD BESIDE LEVITICUS 25

INTERPRETATION Leviticus returns land every fiftieth year, and Deuteronomy cancels debt every seventh. Two instruments aimed at the same failure, the permanent capture of a household. Together they make generational poverty illegal, which is why an empire teaches neither.

HOW DEBT PASSES TO A CHILD IN MY WORLD, AND WHO WROTE THAT RULE

CONTENT NOTE Commanded killing, the destruction of civilian populations including children, siege warfare and the taking of captive women. The page reports the text and the state of the argument and doesn't resolve it for you.

The commands nobody embroiders

The book that says love the foreigner because you were foreigners also orders the total destruction of seven named peoples. Both are in it, and a companion that prints one and hides the other isn't a companion.

THE DEVOTED THING	*Ḥerem*, often "utterly destroy," marks persons or property removed from ordinary use by destruction. It isn't unique to Israel. The Moabite king Mesha's inscription, about 840 BCE, boasts of devoting an Israelite town to his god and killing seven thousand people.
TWO RULES OF WAR	A distant city is offered peace first. If it accepts, its people become forced labor. If not, its men are killed and the women, children and livestock taken. The cities of the land itself are to leave nothing alive that breathes. The law is two-tier, with the harsher tier for the nearest neighbors.
THE STATED REASON	Contamination: "they would turn away your sons from following me," and "that they may not teach you." The justification is ideological containment, the one purges have used since. The same chapter forbids marrying these peoples, which assumes they'll still be there.
EXEMPTIONS AND THE TREES	Men with a new house, an unharvested vineyard, a fiancée, or fear are sent home before battle. Fruit trees may not be cut down in a siege: "Are the trees in the field human, that they should be besieged by you?" Restraint and annihilation, drafted on the same page.

DEUT 7.1–6

DEUT 20

DEUT 21.10–14

JUDG 1

JOSH 6–11 (RECEPTION)

MESHA STELE (C. 840 BCE)

KENYON, JERICHO (1950S)

KITCHEN · HOFFMEIER

DEUT 7.1–6

DEUT 20

DEUT 21.10–14

JUDG 1

JOSH 6–11 (RECEPTION)

MESHA STELE (C. 840 BCE)

KENYON, JERICHO (1950S)

KITCHEN · HOFFMEIER

The commands nobody embroiders, continued

THE CAPTIVE WOMAN · 21.10–14	She shaves her head, cuts her nails, puts off her captive's clothes and mourns her father and mother a month before marriage. If he later doesn't want her, he must let her go where she wants and may not sell her, "since you have humbled her." CONTESTED: Mitigation or legitimation. Both readings are serious.
DID IT HAPPEN	**CONTESTED** Archaeology doesn't support a sweeping conquest. Kathleen Kenyon's Jericho excavations and the work at Ai found no city of the right period matching the account, and many see Israel emerging gradually in the central highlands. Judges 1 itself lists peoples not driven out. Kenneth Kitchen, James Hoffmeier and others defend more of the narrative. If the commands were written long after as ideology, that explains their origin and doesn't soften the words.

WHAT DOMINION DOES WITH A DIVINE WAR COMMAND, AND WHICH OF MY CHARACTERS CARRIED IT OUT

CONTENT NOTE Rape law, virginity evidence, capital penalties and divorce, including a clause that compels marriage to an assailant.

Whose property is injured

The sexual and family laws are addressed to men and largely built around damage to a household's standing. Read as an ethic of consent they make no sense. Read as property and lineage law they make a coherent and disturbing system.

THE CLOTH	A husband who claims his bride wasn't a virgin goes before the elders, and her parents bring out the cloth from the wedding night. If his charge is false, he pays a hundred shekels to her father and can never divorce her. If it's true, she's stoned. Her reputation is treated as her father's asset and her body as evidence.
THE FIELD AND THE CITY	If a betrothed woman lies with another man in the city, both die, on the reasoning that she didn't cry out. In the field only the man dies, because "she cried out and there was no one to rescue her." Geography stands in for testimony.
THE FIFTY SHEKELS	A man who seizes an unbetrothed virgin pays her father fifty shekels, must marry her and can never divorce her. Exodus 22 lets the father refuse the marriage, and Deuteronomy doesn't mention refusal. Naming this plainly is reading the clause.
DIVORCE	A husband who finds "some indecency" in his wife may write a certificate and send her away. She may remarry, and she can't go back to him. The certificate lets her prove she's free, and only he can start it. The house of Shammai allowed divorce only for unchastity, and the house of Hillel for anything, even a spoiled dish. Jesus is asked about this verse.
WHAT CUTS THE OTHER WAY	The same chapters exempt a new husband from war for a year "to be happy with his wife," forbid taking a widow's garment in pledge, and leave harvest for the widow and orphan. Protection and subordination are the same code here.
HOW TO CITE IT HONESTLY	The Middle Assyrian Laws let a raped virgin's father hand the rapist's own wife over to be raped. Hammurabi executes a man who rapes a betrothed virgin and declares her blameless. "Better than its neighbors" and "good" are different claims, and some neighbors weren't worse.

DEUT 22.13–29

DEUT 24.1–4

DEUT 24.5

DEUT 24.17–22

EXOD 22.16–17

M. GITTIN 9.10

MATT 19.3–9

MIDDLE ASSYRIAN LAWS A 55

HAMMURABI §130

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH OF THESE CLAUSES DOMINION KEPT AS STATUTE, AND WHO IS STANDING AT THE GATE

Write the exemption

Dominion holds a scripture that forbids its Emperor to hoard, to marry widely and to arm without limit, and requires him to copy the law by hand. Build the doctrine that makes the clause harmless without denying it.

1 · THE SANCTUM'S OFFICIAL READING OF THE LAW OF THE KING, IN ITS OWN VOICE

2 · THE COPYING RITE AS THEATER. WHAT THE EMPEROR ACTUALLY WRITES OUT, AND WHO HOLDS THE PEN

3 · THE SCENE WHERE SOMEONE READS THE FOUR PROHIBITIONS ALOUD AT COURT

4 · THE PUBLIC READING EVERY SEVEN YEARS. WHAT DOMINION PUT IN ITS PLACE

WRITING

DEUT 17

DEUT 15

DEUT 31.9–13

TKC: DOM · MEN

DEUT 13.6–11

DEUT 27.11–26

DEUT 28

DEUT 30.11–20

ESARHADDON SUCCESSION TREATY (672 BCE)

STEYMANS (1995)

JOB · ECCL (DISSENT)

TKC: DOM

CONTENT NOTE Siege famine and cannibalism, 28.53–57.

Enforcement

Twelve curses are pronounced from Mount Ebal, and the people answer "Amen" to each. Consent to the penalty clause is gathered in public, out loud.

THE TWELVE CURSES	An idol made in secret, a boundary stone moved, a blind man sent the wrong way, justice perverted for the foreigner, the orphan and the widow. Almost every one names an act done where nobody can see. The curse list handles offenses that slip past the courts.
THE ASYMMETRY	Blessings take fourteen verses (28.1–14). Curses take fifty-four (28.15–68), a little under four times as many: disease, siege, deportation, madness, a famine where parents eat their children, and the people shipped back to Egypt for sale with no buyer. **INTERPRETATION** A document that spends that many words on punishment is telling you what its drafters expected to need.
THE ASSYRIAN PARALLEL	Several curses closely match Esarhaddon's Succession Treaty (672 BCE), known from copies at Nimrud and one found at Tell Tayinat in 2009, the sky as bronze and the earth as iron among them. **CONTESTED** Hans Ulrich Steymans argues 28.20–44 borrows directly. Others think the shared language came through common treaty convention.
CHAPTER 13	Report and execute even a brother, son, daughter, wife or friend who secretly urges other gods. The treaty makes the same demand about anyone, family included, who speaks against the king.

Enforcement, continued

WHAT IT DOES TO SUFFERING	If disaster is a penalty clause, every plague, defeat and famine becomes evidence of guilt. The prophets use this logic. Job and parts of Ecclesiastes refuse it. The Bible argues with itself here.
CHOOSE LIFE	Chapter 30 says the command "is not too hard for you, neither is it far off. It is not in heaven," and ends, "I have set before you life and death, blessing and curse. Therefore choose life." It adds a promise of return after exile, written by people who already knew exile.

CORRECTION TO THE OLD COMPANION The old companion said the curses run "more than four times as many" verses as the blessings. Fifty-four to fourteen is just under four times.

THE INSTRUMENT DOMINION INHERITS

POSSIBLE A liturgy in which the population says amen to its own punishment turns obedience into self-administration and any later misfortune into proof of an earlier offense. An empire holding this chapter never has to explain a famine. It only has to ask what the people did.

HOW MY WORLD EXPLAINS ITS LAST DISASTER, AND WHO WAS BLAMED FOR IT

DEUT 13.6–11

DEUT 27.11–26

DEUT 28

DEUT 30.11–20

ESARHADDON SUCCESSION TREATY (672 BCE)

STEYMANS (1995)

JOB · ECCL (DISSENT)

TKC: DOM

METHOD

BIBLE 101 VIII

DEUT 17.14–20

DEUT 15.1–11

One passage, worked properly

Choose one passage and run the method across this spread. If you want one chosen, try 17.14–20, the law of the king, or 15.1–11, the release.

PASSAGE

TRANSLATION USED

1 · WHAT IT SAYS. SUMMARIZE WITHOUT INTERPRETING. NO CONCLUSIONS YET

2 · WHO IS ADDRESSED, WHO IS DISCUSSED AND WHO IS ABSENT

3 · WHERE TWO TRANSLATIONS DIFFER, AND WHAT TURNS ON THE DIFFERENCE

How it's been used

4 · HOW THIS PASSAGE HAS BEEN USED AGAINST SOMEONE, AND WHO BENEFITED

5 · WHAT IT COSTS THE PERSON IN POWER, IF IT'S ACTUALLY KEPT

6 · WHAT DOMINION WOULD DO WITH IT. CIRCULATE, RESTRICT OR SPIRITUALIZE

7 · WHAT I'M TAKING INTO THE MANUSCRIPT, AND WHICH CHAPTER

Anything found on these two pages begins as POSSIBLE. Move it to DECIDED only after deciding it belongs in the manuscript and logging where it affects the existing files.

☐ POSSIBLE ☐ OPEN QUESTION ☐ DECIDED LOG NO. DATE

2 KGS 22–23

JOSH–KGS (NOTH, 1943)

MATT 4.1–11

MARK 12.29

WINTHROP, "A MODEL OF CHRISTIAN CHARITY" (1630)

FUGITIVE SLAVE ACT (1850)

TKC: DOM

The book that wrote the rest

Everything here is reception, what people did with Deuteronomy.

A SCROLL IN A WALL	A law book found during temple repairs, read to the king and answered with a national purge. Whatever the scroll was, the narrative makes a found document the trigger for a political revolution, the most useful plot mechanism in the Hebrew Bible.
THE HISTORY IT SHAPED	Martin Noth argued in 1943 that Joshua through Kings form a "Deuteronomistic History," grading every king by this book's standards, chapter 12 above all. What looks like national chronicle is closer to an audit against a statute.
IN THE GOSPELS	Jesus answers all three temptations with Deuteronomy (8.3, 6.16, 6.13) and names the Shema the first commandment. It's the book he quotes most in argument.
COVENANT AS POLITICS	John Winthrop closed "A Model of Christian Charity" (1630) by paraphrasing 30.15–20, "Therefore let us choose life," and Puritan covenant theology read New England through the book's terms. The conquest chapters were read as precedent by people arriving on other people's land.
AND THE OTHER WAY	Abolitionists cited 23.15–16 against the Fugitive Slave Act of 1850, and 24.7 with Exodus 21.16 against kidnapping and the slave trade. The same volume served the conqueror and the freed in the same century.

WHERE A FOUND DOCUMENT COULD OVERTURN SOMETHING IN MY MANUSCRIPT

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHERE A FOUND DOCUMENT COULD OVERTURN SOMETHING IN MY MANUSCRIPT

DEUT 17.14–20

DEUT 15

DEUT 31.9–13

DEUT 28

TKC: DOM · SANCTUM

The half the Empire teaches

POSSIBLE Everything on this page is a TKC construction to test against the manuscript.

WHAT THE SANCTUM CIRCULATES	WHAT IT KEEPS IN THE CLOSED CATECHISM
ONE SANCTUARY, ONE CALENDAR, ONE AUTHORIZED PLACE OF OFFERING	The third-year tithe that stays in the town, and the tithe turned to coin and eaten by the household itself
THE CURSES OF CHAPTER 28, AS THE EXPLANATION FOR EVERY PLAGUE AND DEFEAT	The same covenant makes the sovereign subject to the document, with four named prohibitions
OBEDIENCE TAUGHT AS LOYALTY TO THE SANCTUM'S READING OF THE LAW	The law is read aloud to the whole assembly, women, children and foreigners included, on a fixed schedule
THE CONQUEST CHAPTERS, AS PRECEDENT FOR CLEANSING A PROVINCE	The runaway-slave clause, the seventh-year release and the ban on interest among kin
INSTRUCTION AS THE SANCTUM'S OFFICE, DELIVERED IN ITS BUILDINGS	Chapter 6 puts teaching in the house, in the parents' mouths, with no priest present

THE ARGUMENT IN ONE PARAGRAPH

INTERPRETATION Dominion keeps Deuteronomy's enforcement and drops its constitution. The curses, the central sanctuary and the war commands stay in general circulation. The law of the king, the release, the household school and the public reading go into the closed catechism. The Empire isn't opposed by a rival scripture. It's opposed by the second half of its own.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHO IN MY CAST HAS READ CHAPTER 17, AND WHAT THEY DID THE DAY AFTER

WRITING

DOSSIER CLOSE

QUEUE: D4

What I take out of Deuteronomy

THE ONE THING THIS BOOK CHANGED ABOUT HOW I SEE DOMINION

WHAT I STILL DON'T UNDERSTAND. CARRY IT TO THE RESEARCH LIST.

A CLAUSE I'M TAKING STRAIGHT INTO THE MANUSCRIPT, AND WHERE

PROOFING GATE *log only, nothing is closed here*

Dossier IV has fifteen numbered pages, with content notes on pages 7, 8 and 10, and the conquest material carried as CONTESTED with no verdict printed. Outstanding for proofing: full citations with edition and year.

PROOFED BY | DATE | OUTSTANDING

NOTES

OPEN NOTES

ANYTHING THIS DOSSIER STARTED AND DIDN'T FINISH

NOTES

ANYTHING THIS SPREAD STARTED AND DID NOT FINISH

I–IV

AFTER THE DOSSIERS

The Torah and TKC

Where the four books touch the world, by source, with every guess labeled

FIVE PAGES

TKC: TR · TL · CR · DR3 · AM · MEN

FR 0

FR 33

FR 35

FR 39

Genesis and Exodus in the world

THE PHASES	Phase One belongs to the Temple and is called Genesis, "Who are you?" Phase Two belongs to the Crown and is called Exodus, "How smart are you?" (TR). POSSIBLE The Crown's phase is named for the book about a ruler who loses an argument to two midwives and a labor force.
EDEN AND THE EVE PROBLEM	Eden is named for the garden (TL). The Broadcast's name for its narrative against a candidate whose intelligence becomes the story is the Eve problem, the woman "blamed for asking rather than thanked" (TR). INTERPRETATION Genesis 3 doesn't curse the woman or blame her for asking. The blame in the chapter comes from the man (3.12), and the Broadcast's narrative runs his defense.
GENESIS 3.16 IN THE ASSESSMENT	The Temple's marriage theology (CR) depends on reading 3.16 as prescription. POSSIBLE One of the three questions the Prelate writes for Eden personally (TR, name changed under FR 33) asks her to explain 3.16, and the grade depends on which reading she gives.
LEAH	Eden's younger sister Leah is a Commonwife under Temple review for not conceiving within the Covenant timeline (TL, MEN). In Genesis, Leah is the fertile wife, and the three barren matriarchs are the women the promise runs through. POSSIBLE The Temple's review quotes "be fruitful and multiply" and never mentions Sarah, Rebekah or Rachel.

Genesis and Exodus in the world, continued

TKC: TR · TL · CR · DR3 · AM · MEN

FR 0

FR 33

FR 35

FR 39

REASSIGNMENT AND TAMAR	Miriam was reassigned to another man's household after Thomas left (**FR 0**). Thomas left voluntarily (**FR 3**). How reassignment works is deliberately open. **POSSIBLE** The Temple grounds it in levirate logic (Gen 38, Deut 25.5–10), which in scripture protects a widow's claim, and the Empire uses it to keep an abandoned wife inside the quota.
HAGAR AND NAMING	Hagar is the one person in scripture who names God. Celeste gave Eden a second name that's used only in the house (**TL**). **INTERPRETATION** Both are names the official record doesn't hold.
SUCCESSION	Crest's claim came through survivorship and not birth order, and Dorian is the rightful heir's son (**FR 35, 39**). Crest is Dorian's uncle (**FR 35**). **POSSIBLE** The Temple preaches Jacob over Esau and Judah over Reuben to make the 2061 succession sound like election.
SHIPHRAH AND PUAH	**POSSIBLE** The model for a Vowed officer who quietly doesn't comply. **INTERPRETATION** Eden's Public Testimony, where every sentence is defensible and the whole is incendiary (**TR**), is the midwives' answer to Pharaoh at book length.
EXODUS 20.12 IN THE ASSESSMENT	Draft Three turns "Honor thy father and thy mother" into a question about reporting an Unbound woman who housed her children without male authority (**DR3**). Celeste is that woman.

TKC: TL · DOM · CR · DR3 · MEN

FR 32

FR 41–43

Leviticus and Deuteronomy in the world

JOSEPH'S ADMINISTRATION	**POSSIBLE** Imperial schoolbooks teach Joseph as the model administrator and the Fracture Years as Egypt's famine, with the Coalition as the steward who stored grain. The Restoration Act made rights conditional (**TL**), and Genesis 47 is the scriptural picture of a people trading freedom for food and thanking the crown.
THE CURSE OF HAM	Aurelia was built over Atlanta's Black memory (**DOM**). **OPEN QUESTION** Does the Temple teach the curse of Ham? If a character uses it, the narration has to know it's a documented misuse.
PASSOVER AND THE HOUSEHOLD	**INTERPRETATION** Celeste's kitchen table (**TL**), the Salt Ceremony and the old way of burial (**DOM**) are household religion of the kind Exodus 12 and Deuteronomy 6 describe, which is why the Temple can't license them.
SALT	Leviticus 2.13 requires "the salt of the covenant" on every grain offering. **POSSIBLE** The women's Salt Ceremony (**DOM**) uses the Temple's own covenant salt, and nobody in the Temple has noticed.

Leviticus and Deuteronomy in the world, continued

TKC: TL · DOM · CR · DR3 · MEN

FR 32

FR 41–43

INSPECTION	**POSSIBLE** The Vowed household assessments (**MEN**) and the Designation (**DOM**) borrow the Leviticus 13 procedure, with a moral weight Leviticus keeps out.
THE SCAPEGOAT	**POSSIBLE** The Broadcast's antagonist narrative, assigned to the candidate who threatens a comfortable outcome (**TR**), is the Empire's Azazel goat. The confession is spoken over her, and she's sent out.
LEVITICUS 25.10	**POSSIBLE** The Empire can't read the Liberty Bell verse aloud. In Pacific, where people remember trying to leave (**DOM**), somebody still can.
DEUTERONOMY 13	**POSSIBLE** The command to report a family member who secretly worships other gods is the Temple's warrant for the Vowed as surveillance (**CR**) and for the Assessment's reporting question (**DR3**).
GUILT BY HOUSEHOLD	"Children shall not be put to death for their fathers" (Deut 24.16). The Empire classifies children by household registration (**FR 32**). **INTERPRETATION** Deuteronomy, Ezekiel 18 and the Empire disagree about where guilt lives.
RUNAWAYS	**POSSIBLE** Ungoverned crossings through Sable (**DOM**) are the case Deuteronomy 23.15–16 was written for, and the Temple never reads it in that Dominion.
JOSIAH'S SCROLL AND THE LEDGER	Azrael found the ledger in the east wing archive, Dorian removed it with the Covenant of Dissent, and Judah has been looking for the Dissent since before his brother's exile (**TL**, **FR 41–43**). **POSSIBLE** Judah is a Josiah who hasn't found his scroll.

TKC: DOM · SANCTUM

FR 33

What it teaches and what it shelves

POSSIBLE The three "Dominion's" spreads from the dossiers, gathered in one place. Every row is a construction to test.

BOOK	WHAT THE TEMPLE CIRCULATES	WHAT IT LEAVES OUT OF PUBLIC TEACHING
EXODUS	The sea, as a deliverance already accomplished in the founding	Chapter 1, where the resistance starts with two midwives who lied to a king
EXODUS	The commandments from the second clause on	The preamble, which grounds the right to command in ending forced labor
EXODUS	Moses the obedient lawgiver	Moses arguing God out of a decision twice
LEVITICUS	Holiness as personal purity, chapters 18 and 20 as household law	Chapter 25 entire, and the harvest edge, the same-day wage and the interest ban
LEVITICUS	Restitution as an offering paid to the Temple	The wronged person is paid first, plus a fifth
DEUTERONOMY	The curses of chapter 28 as the explanation for every disaster	The law of the king
DEUTERONOMY	Teaching as the Temple's office	Chapter 6, where parents teach at home with no priest present
DEUTERONOMY	The conquest chapters as precedent	The runaway-slave clause and the seventh-year release

THE PATTERN

INTERPRETATION The pattern is the same in all three. The Empire keeps Deuteronomy's enforcement and drops its constitution, keeps Leviticus's machinery of exclusion and drops its machinery of release, and teaches the exodus as finished so only the obedience half applies now.

CORRECTION TO THE OLD COMPANION SUPERSEDED The old companion's Exodus page marked "Prelate Huldah's office" as canon. FR 33 renamed the Prelate. The working name is Prelate Aurelia, POSSIBLE, and whether the office manages the Temple's teaching of Exodus is only POSSIBLE now.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

THE ROW I'D ADD, AND THE BOOK IT COMES FROM

Twelve working questions

Answer in any order. Each answer that settles something goes to the log with a number.

1 · WHAT DOES THE BOOK OF COVENANT PRINT AT GENESIS 3.16, AND WHAT DOES THE AURELIA TEMPLE PREACH FROM IT ON THE SUNDAY BEFORE A BINDING?

2 · WRITE THE ASSESSMENT QUESTION ON 3.16 THE PRELATE GIVES EDEN. WHAT ANSWER GETS FULL MARKS, AND WHAT DOES EDEN SAY?

3 · WHO NAMED THE DOMINIONS, AND DID THEY KNOW WHAT GENESIS 1.28 SAYS?

4 · WHICH OF GENESIS'S SIX WOMEN DOES CELESTE TEACH EDEN ABOUT AT THE KITCHEN TABLE, AND WHICH DOES THE TEMPLE TEACH GIRLS AT DESIGNATION AGE?

5 · WHAT DOES LEAH OSEI KNOW ABOUT THE GENESIS LEAH, AND WHO TOLD HER?

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

6 · HOW DOES THE TEMPLE EXPLAIN COMMONWIFE REASSIGNMENT FROM SCRIPTURE, IF IT DOES? WHO SIGNED MIRIAM'S?

Twelve working questions, continued

7 · WHICH LICENSED PROFESSIONAL IN THE EMPIRE IS A SHIPHRAH, AND WHAT DOES SHE SAY WHEN SHE'S SUMMONED?

8 · WHAT DOES THE EMPIRE'S LIBERATION LITURGY SAY GOD DELIVERED THE PEOPLE FROM, AND WHEN DOES A CHARACTER STOP BELIEVING IT?

9 · WHICH HOUSEHOLD IN THE CAST WOULD A JUBILEE FREE, AND WHO WOULD LOSE BY IT?

10 · WHAT DISQUALIFIES A BODY FROM SERVICE IN THE EMPIRE? WHO WROTE THE LIST, AND DOES IT CITE LEVITICUS 21?

11 · WHO IN THE CAST HAS READ DEUTERONOMY 17 ALL THE WAY THROUGH, AND WHAT DID THEY DO THE NEXT DAY?

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

12 · IF THE COVENANT OF DISSENT TURNED UP IN THE REGISTRY TOMORROW, WHO WOULD BE ASKED TO AUTHENTICATE IT, THE WAY HULDAH AUTHENTICATED JOSIAH'S SCROLL?

NOTES

ANYTHING THIS SPREAD STARTED AND DID NOT FINISH

II

PART TWO · ✦

The People of the Text

Almost everyone in this book has been flattened into a lesson by somebody who needed them to mean one thing. Go back and find out what they actually did.

i · How to read a person	382
ii · The women of the Hebrew Bible	383
iii · The women of the New Testament	403
iv · The men	410
v · Who echoes whom	417

How to read a person

Every profile in this part runs the same fields, and the order matters. It starts with what the person has been reduced to, because that reduction is what you inherited, and it'll keep steering your instincts until it's written down and looked at. The text comes next, only what's on the page, including the parts that are inconvenient for everyone.

After that, the Empire's use of them, because Dominion has a position on each of these people, and a state that quotes scripture is always curating a gallery of approved and cautionary lives. After that come the echoes in your own cast, and most important, where the parallel breaks, because the break is where your character stops being a reference and starts being a person.

USUALLY REDUCED TO	The received version: the sermon, the flannelgraph, the insult the name has become.
WHAT THE TEXT GIVES	Only what's written, with the silences marked as silences and left unfilled.
WHAT DOMINION DOES	The Empire's official reading, and what it needs that reading to authorize.
TKC ECHOES	Which of your characters this lights up, and in which scene.
WHERE IT BREAKS	The required field. No character is an allegory, and the difference is the character.
QUESTIONS AND NOTES	Yours. Nothing printed here has any claim on it.

A NOTE ON THE UNNAMED

A great many women in this collection have no name: Lot's wife, Jephthah's daughter, the woman of Judges 19, the woman who bled for twelve years, the woman at the well, the woman who anointed him. Who got a name tells you who was doing the recording. The Registry makes the same choices.

PEOPLE ALREADY WORKED

Sarah, Rebekah, Leah, Dinah, Shiphrah and Puah, and Zipporah are worked in the Genesis and Exodus dossiers and cross-referenced here.

MARGINALIA

✣ *See also:* Deep dives I and II · the cast-name table at the end of this part.

Eve

Genesis 2–4 · the woman of the garden · the first dialogue in the Bible

USUALLY REDUCED TO	The woman who brought sin into the world.
WHAT THE TEXT GIVES	Called *ishshah*, "woman," by the man, and named Ḥawwah, "mother of all living," only after the judgment (3.20). Her conversation with the serpent is the first dialogue in the Bible. She names her sons, and both times she speaks of God: "I have gotten a man with the LORD" (4.1), "God has appointed for me another offspring" (4.25). Genesis 3 doesn't curse her, and the word "sin" doesn't appear in it.
WHERE THE BLAME CAME FROM	Later, and from outside the chapter. Sirach, about 180 BCE: "from a woman sin had its beginning." 1 Timothy 2.14: "Adam was not deceived, but the woman was." Tertullian, about 200 CE: "you are the devil's gateway." Paul's undisputed letters put it on Adam: "sin came into the world through one man" (Rom 5.12).
WHAT DOMINION DOES	POSSIBLE The Broadcast's Eve problem, the woman "blamed for asking rather than thanked" (TR), runs the man's defense from 3.12.
WHERE IT BREAKS	Eve is never asked what she wanted. Eden is asked constantly, on camera, and graded on the answer.

QUESTIONS FOR THE NOVEL

OT · ORIGINS

THEMES

Asking · blame · naming · the first speech

MARGINALIA

✣ *See also:* Deep dive I, Genesis, pages 2 and 4.

OT | CHARACTER

THEMES

Surrogacy · exile · being seen · the used body

MARGINALIA

Hagar

Genesis 16 · 21 · Egyptian · enslaved · the only person in scripture who names God

USUALLY REDUCED TO	A subplot. The servant who caused trouble, the mistake made while waiting on a promise, the woman whose son wasn't chosen.
WHAT THE TEXT GIVES	An enslaved foreign woman handed to her mistress's husband with no recorded consent and no line of dialogue until she's pregnant and being mistreated. She runs once. In the desert she's met, addressed by name, given a promise about her own descendants, and told to go back. When the chosen son is born she's expelled with bread and a skin of water, and she sets the boy under a bush because she can't watch him die. She's the one who names God, El-roi, the God who sees. Nobody else in Genesis does that. She later takes a wife for Ishmael from Egypt, head of her own household.
AFTERLIVES	Paul makes her an allegory of slavery (Gal 4). Islamic tradition honors her as Hajar, and pilgrims at Mecca retrace her run between two hills. Delores Williams built womanist theology on her survival in *Sisters in the Wilderness* (1993).
WHAT DOMINION DOES	**POSSIBLE** Makes her a warning about the servant who forgets her place, and cites the order to return as proof God sends women back to the households they flee. Her naming of God isn't taught.
TKC ECHOES	Any woman whose body is the instrument of someone else's covenant. The candidate who's used and then surplus.
WHERE IT BREAKS	Hagar is met in the wilderness and survives it twice. If your character runs and no one meets her, that's a different theology, and you should know which one you're writing.

✣ *See also:* Deep dive I, Genesis, page 8.

QUESTIONS FOR THE NOVEL

OT | CHARACTER

THEMES

Legal limbo · evidence · veiling · vindication

MARGINALIA

Tamar

Genesis 38 · twice widowed · defrauded of her claim · declared righteous by the man who wronged her

USUALLY REDUCED TO	A scandal skipped in public reading. If she's mentioned, she's the woman who pretended to be a prostitute.
WHAT THE TEXT GIVES	Married into a family, widowed, married to the next brother by custom, widowed again, and sent back to her father's house while the family quietly keeps the third son from her. She's left in legal limbo, neither wife nor free, with no court to appeal to. She veils herself, waits on the road her father-in-law will travel, and takes his seal, cord and staff as a pledge. Accused and sentenced to burn, she sends the three items with a message: "Identify whose these are." He says she's more righteous than he is. Her son Perez enters the royal line.
HOW SCRIPTURE REMEMBERS HER	The elders bless Ruth's marriage, "may your house be like the house of Perez, whom Tamar bore to Judah" (Ruth 4.12), and Matthew names her in Jesus' genealogy (1.3).
WHAT DOMINION DOES	**POSSIBLE** Omits her. There's no usable version of a story in which a woman entraps a patriarch, is vindicated by the record and written into the ancestry of kings.
TKC ECHOES	Any woman with no legal standing who has to create evidence. She doesn't accuse. She collects.
WHERE IT BREAKS	Tamar's society had a law on her side that wasn't being enforced. If Dominion's law is against your character, producing evidence won't be enough. She'll have to change the court.

✤ *See also:* Deep dive I, Genesis, pages 7 and 8.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

QUESTIONS FOR THE NOVEL

EXOD 2

EXOD 15.20–21

NUM 12

NUM 20.1–2

MIC 6.4

B. TA'ANIT 9A

TKC: MIRIAM · TL

Miriam

Exodus 2 · 15 · Numbers 12 · 20 · Micah 6.4 · the first woman the Torah calls a prophet

WHAT THE TEXT GIVES	Moses' sister, if the unnamed girl at the river is her. Called "the prophet" at the sea, where she leads the women with a hand drum (Exod 15.20–21). She and Aaron challenge Moses' sole authority, and she alone is struck with a skin disease. The camp doesn't move until she's brought back (Num 12). She dies at Kadesh, and the next verse says there was no water (Num 20.1–2). The rabbis built on that the tradition of Miriam's well, which traveled with Israel for her sake. Micah names her with Moses and Aaron as the three God sent.
HER NAME	Miriam in Greek is Mariam, which is where every Mary in the New Testament gets hers.
WHAT DOMINION DOES	**POSSIBLE** Teaches Numbers 12 as the lesson on women who speak against ordained authority, and leaves out the song and the well.
TKC ECHOES	Eden's mother carries her name (**TL**). Miriam was reassigned to another man's household after Thomas left (**FR 0**), and Celeste has no proof she's alive (**FR 16**).
WHERE IT BREAKS	The biblical camp waits for Miriam. Whether anyone in the Empire waits for this one is the question.

QUESTIONS FOR THE NOVEL

Deborah

Judges 4–5 · prophet · judge · the problem no empire has solved

JUDG 4–5
JUDG 5.1
JUDG 5.7
JUDG 5.28–30
TKC: DOM

USUALLY REDUCED TO	An exception. The woman God used because no man was available, a reading the text doesn't support anywhere.
WHAT THE TEXT GIVES	Already a prophet and the judge of Israel when we meet her, hearing cases under a palm tree. No emergency is offered to excuse it, and no apology. **CONTESTED** *'eshet lappidot* can mean "wife of Lappidoth" or "a woman of torches." She summons the commander Barak, who won't go unless she goes with him. She goes, and tells him the glory will go to a woman. It goes to Jael, a civilian who kills the enemy general with a tent peg. The victory song, among the oldest poetry in the Bible, calls her "a mother in Israel" and ends with Sisera's mother at her window imagining her son dividing the spoil, "a womb or two for every man."
WHAT DOMINION DOES	**POSSIBLE** Emergency doctrine. She's taught as a temporary provision for a lawless age, proof that when men fail God shames them by using a woman. Her authority becomes an insult aimed at men, and stops being a precedent for women.
TKC ECHOES	The woman with real authority who's constantly called an exception so the rule survives. And the general who'll only act if a woman stands beside him.
WHERE IT BREAKS	Deborah is never punished, never diminished and never justifies herself. If your character's authority costs her something, the cost is your invention, and worth being honest about.

CORRECTION TO THE OLD COMPANION The old companion said Deborah composed the song. The heading credits "Deborah and Barak" (5.1). The song speaks of her in the first person in places, and who composed it isn't stated.

QUESTIONS FOR THE NOVEL

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

QUESTIONS FOR THE NOVEL

Rahab · Ruth

Two foreign women who talk their way into the royal genealogy.

JOSH 2

JOSH 6.22–25

JOSEPHUS, ANT. 5.1.2

MATT 1.5

HEB 11.31

JAS 2.25

RUTH 1–4

RUTH 3.9

LEV 19.9–10

DEUT 23.3

RAHAB · JOSHUA 2, 6	**Reduced to:** her profession, permanently. A *zonah*, usually "prostitute" (Josephus calls her an innkeeper). **The text:** her house is built into the city wall. She hides two spies, lies to the king's men, and gives an assessment of the war more accurate than anything her own city has produced: "I know that the LORD has given you the land." She bargains for her whole household, and the spies swear an oath and tell her to tie a scarlet cord in her window. When the city falls they bring her family out, "and she has lived in Israel to this day." The New Testament remembers her three times. **Dominion:** POSSIBLE: a conversion story, the fallen woman who chose correctly, never a woman who conducted foreign policy from the wall. **Breaks:** Rahab's intelligence is believed. Ask whether yours would be.
RUTH · THE BOOK OF RUTH	**Reduced to:** a wedding reading. **The text:** a Moabite widow with no obligation to anyone, who binds herself to her mother-in-law in the most famous vow of devotion in scripture, spoken by a woman to a woman. She gleans as a foreign laborer under the harvest-edge law. Naomi sends her to the threshing floor to uncover Boaz's feet and wait, "and he will tell you what to do." Ruth doesn't wait. She tells him to spread his cloak over her, the same word he'd used for the wings of the God she'd sheltered under. When the son is born, the women say "a son has been born to Naomi," and that Ruth is better to her than seven sons. Deuteronomy 23.3 bars Moabites from the assembly, and the book writes one into the royal line. **Dominion:** POSSIBLE: the model immigrant who assimilates completely, the threshing floor retold as modesty and the vow given to a husband. **Breaks:** Ruth's gamble works because one man chose to honor a law he could have ignored.

CORRECTION TO THE OLD COMPANION The old companion said Rahab's deal was "in writing." It's an oath and a scarlet cord, and the text doesn't say her house was left standing. It also said Ruth proposed on Naomi's coaching. Naomi told her Boaz would tell her what to do, and Ruth spoke first.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

QUESTIONS FOR THE NOVEL

Hannah · Abigail · Michal

Three women of the early monarchy, and the three ways the record lets a woman speak to power.

HANNAH · 1 SAMUEL 1–2	One of two wives, provoked for years by the one with children. Her husband asks, "Am I not more to you than ten sons?" She prays at the sanctuary with her lips moving and no sound, and the priest thinks she's drunk. She corrects him. She vows her son to God's service, leaves him at Shiloh after weaning, and brings him a little robe every year. Her song says the LORD raises the poor from the dust and brings down the mighty, and it's the model for Mary's song. It ends with the first mention in the Bible's order of a king as God's "anointed," from a woman praying before Israel has a king.
ABIGAIL · 1 SAMUEL 25	Married to Nabal, a rich man called harsh. David, an outlaw with six hundred men, asks for provisions in return for having left Nabal's shepherds unharmed. **INTERPRETATION** Many readers hear a protection payment. Nabal refuses, and David arms four hundred men to kill every male in the house. Abigail loads donkeys with food and rides out without telling her husband. She kneels, takes the blame on herself, and talks David out of blood guilt he'd regret as king. Nabal dies ten days later, and David marries her. The Talmud counts her among seven women prophets.
MICHAL · 1 SAMUEL 18–19, 2 SAMUEL 3, 6	Saul's daughter. The narrator says she loved David, a thing the Hebrew Bible rarely says of a woman. She saves his life by letting him down through a window and putting an idol in his bed. Saul gives her to another man, Palti. David later demands her back as a political condition, and Palti follows her weeping until he's ordered home. When David dances before the ark she despises him, and the chapter ends: "Michal the daughter of Saul had no child to the day of her death."

FOR TKC

Hannah is House Mother of House Aurem (**TL**). "Six Trials. Twelve girls. None of them hers" (**TL**). Abigail is the House's Debate and Protocol Advisor, "pressure in a pretty dress" (**WR 30**). **POSSIBLE** Hannah's story runs the biblical one in reverse, a woman deciding whether to give her daughter Naomi to the institution she's served (**FR 29**).

1 SAM 1–2

1 SAM 25

1 SAM 18–19

2 SAM 3.13–16

2 SAM 6.16–23

B. MEGILLAH 14A

LUKE 1.46–55

TKC: TL · WR

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

QUESTIONS FOR THE NOVEL

Bathsheba · Tamar of the palace

2 SAM 11–12

2 SAM 13

1 KGS 1–2

MATT 1.6

TRIBLE, TEXTS OF TERROR (1984)

What the court does to a woman it has already harmed.

CONTENT NOTE Sexual violence and murder.

BATHSHEBA · 2 SAMUEL 11–12, 1 KINGS 1–2	**Reduced to:** a temptress on a roof. **The text:** she's purifying herself after her period, and the text doesn't say where. Every verb in the scene belongs to the king: he saw, he sent, he took. Her only words are "I am pregnant," two words in Hebrew. Her husband is killed on David's written order, carried in his own hand. Nathan's parable makes her the poor man's lamb. Her first child dies. Decades later she works with Nathan to put her son on the throne and sits at his right hand as queen mother. Matthew names her only as "the wife of Uriah." **Dominion:** POSSIBLE: keeps the roof and drops the verbs. A woman's visible body explains a powerful man's decision, the most useful doctrine a court can have. **Breaks:** Bathsheba survives into power. Ask what that costs, and what she becomes.
TAMAR · 2 SAMUEL 13	**Reduced to:** nothing. Most people raised in church have never heard of her. **The text:** a princess sent by her father's own instruction to her half-brother's sickroom, and raped there. Before it she argues, tells him "such a thing is not done in Israel," and offers a lawful alternative. Afterward she tears the robe worn by the king's virgin daughters, puts ashes on her head and goes away crying aloud. Her full brother tells her to be quiet. Her father is very angry and does nothing. She lives "a desolate woman" in her brother's house, and that's the last line she gets. Absalom later names his own daughter Tamar. **Dominion:** POSSIBLE: never read aloud. A king burying his daughter's assault to protect the succession isn't survivable material for a dynasty. **Breaks:** Tamar's outcry changes nothing. If your character's does, you've chosen mercy. Earn it.

CORRECTION TO THE OLD COMPANION The old companion placed Bathsheba bathing "in her own home" and gave her first words as five. The text doesn't give the place, and the words are two in Hebrew.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

QUESTIONS FOR THE NOVEL

Jezebel · Athaliah · Huldah · Vashti

Four women with public power, and four ways the record handles it.

JEZEBEL · 1 KINGS 16–21, 2 KINGS 9	A Sidonian princess married to Ahab who supports Baal worship and has the LORD's prophets killed. When Naboth won't sell his vineyard, she writes letters in Ahab's name, seals them with his seal and arranges false witnesses so Naboth is executed by correct procedure. The crime is real. Her death comes in 2 Kings 9. She paints her eyes, calls down to the usurper from her window and is thrown out of it. **Afterlife:** the name became an insult for any woman with influence, and under slavery and Jim Crow "Jezebel" named a stereotype of Black women as sexually predatory, used to excuse their abuse. The insult makes power the sin, more than the murder.
ATHALIAH · 2 KINGS 11	The only woman to rule Judah in her own name, for six years. She takes the throne by killing the royal family, as several male kings took theirs. An infant prince survives because his aunt Jehosheba hides him in the temple. In the seventh year a priest crowns the boy, and Athaliah cries "Treason! Treason!" before she's killed. Her reign is recorded as usurpation, and the same conduct in men as accession.
HULDAH · 2 KINGS 22	A prophet in Jerusalem. When the law scroll is found in the temple, King Josiah sends the high priest, the royal secretary and three other officials to inquire of the LORD, and they go to her. Jeremiah and Zephaniah were active, and nobody explains why they chose her or remarks that she's a woman. She authenticates the scroll and gives an oracle, and the greatest reform in the kingdom's history follows. **Dominion:** POSSIBLE: not in the syllabus at any level. The biblical Huldah has no connection to the Prelate, whose working name is Aurelia (POSSIBLE, FR 33).
VASHTI · ESTHER 1	Ordered to appear in her crown before drunk officials, she refuses. The advisers panic about precedent, since every wife will hear of it. She's deposed by decree, and letters go out that every man is to be master in his own house. The plot of the book runs on her empty place.

CORRECTION TO THE OLD COMPANION The old companion cited 1 Kings for Jezebel's death. It's 2 Kings 9. It also said Vashti is "never mentioned again." The king remembers her in 2.1, and Esther is made queen "instead of Vashti."

1 KGS 16.31

1 KGS 21

2 KGS 9.30–37

2 KGS 11

2 KGS 22.14–20

ESTH 1–2

REV 2.20

WHITE, AR'N'T I A WOMAN? (1985)

TKC: DOM · FR 33

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH OF THESE FOUR IS IN DOMINION'S SYLLABUS, AND HOW SHE'S TAUGHT

Esther · the woman of worth

ESTH 2–9

ESTH 4.14–16

ESTH 9.29–32

PROV 31

RUTH 3.11

TKC: DR3 · TR

ESTHER · THE BOOK OF ESTHER	Hadassah, an orphan raised by her cousin, is "taken" in a royal search for young virgins. Twelve months of beauty treatment, six with oil of myrrh and six with spices, then one night with the king. She hides her people on her cousin's instruction. When Haman wins a decree to destroy the Jews, Mordecai says "Who knows whether you have not come to the kingdom for such a time as this?" Approaching the king unsummoned is punishable by death, and she goes: "If I perish, I perish." She works through two banquets, exposes Haman and wins a counter-decree. In chapter 9 the Jews kill their attackers, seventy-five thousand in the provinces. She then writes with full authority to fix Purim, so the book ends with her issuing a decree. God isn't named anywhere in the Hebrew. The Assessment in Draft Three uses "Esther's crown" as proof a woman could influence government "so long as she was beautiful, obedient, and prepared to die for the privilege" (**DR3**).
THE WOMAN OF WORTH · PROVERBS 31	An acrostic poem. *ʾEshet ḥayil* is usually "virtuous" or "capable" wife, and *ḥayil* also means an army's strength and wealth. She buys a field and plants a vineyard with her own earnings, makes garments and sells them to merchants, "opens her mouth with wisdom," and her husband is known at the gates because of her. The chapter opens with what King Lemuel's mother taught him: stay off wine when judging, and "open your mouth for the mute… defend the rights of the poor and needy." Boaz uses the same phrase for Ruth. Verse 29 is printed on the Assessment and read before the scores (**DR3**). In Jewish practice it's sung at the Friday evening table.

FOR TKC

The Trials are a state search for young women with a long preparation (**TR**). **POSSIBLE** The Temple teaches Vashti right before Esther as the warning, and never teaches that Esther ends the book issuing a decree in her own name.

QUESTIONS FOR THE NOVEL

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

QUESTIONS FOR THE NOVEL

The unnamed, and two widows

GEN 19.26

JUDG 11.29–40

JUDG 19–21

2 KGS 4.1–37

2 KGS 8.1–6

TRIBLE, TEXTS OF TERROR

CONTENT NOTE The woman of Judges 19, sexual violence and dismemberment. Jephthah's daughter, a child sacrifice.

LOT'S WIFE · GENESIS 19	Looks back at Sodom and becomes a pillar of salt. No name.
JEPHTHAH'S DAUGHTER · JUDGES 11	Her father vows to sacrifice whatever comes out of his house first if he wins. She comes out dancing. She asks for two months in the mountains with her companions to mourn, he carries out the vow, and "it became a custom" for the daughters of Israel to lament her four days a year. No name.
THE WOMAN OF JUDGES 19	A Levite's secondary wife. At Gibeah men surround the house demanding the guest, and the Levite pushes her outside. She's raped all night and found at dawn with her hands on the threshold. He cuts her body into twelve pieces and sends them through Israel. The civil war that follows ends with the abduction of the women of Jabesh-gilead and the dancing girls of Shiloh. "Everyone did what was right in his own eyes." No name.
THE PROPHET'S WIDOW · 2 KINGS 4	A creditor is about to take her two children as slaves. Elisha tells her to borrow every empty jar, shut the door and pour her one jar of oil. It runs until the jars do. She pays the debt and lives on the rest. The miracle keeps two children out of debt slavery.
THE SHUNAMMITE · 2 KINGS 4, 8	A wealthy woman who builds Elisha a room. When her son dies she rides to the prophet and won't leave without him. Years later she comes home from a famine to find her land taken, petitions the king herself, and gets it back with the income it earned while she was gone.

WHICH UNNAMED WOMAN IN THE EMPIRE'S RECORDS I'LL GIVE A NAME TO

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH UNNAMED WOMAN IN THE EMPIRE'S RECORDS I'LL GIVE A NAME TO

Mary of Nazareth

Luke 1–2 · Mark 3 · John 2 · 19 · Acts 1 · a young woman who sings about thrones emptied

USUALLY REDUCED TO	Serenity. A statue in blue, silent and compliant, the whole personality reduced to one word of consent.
WHAT THE TEXT GIVES	Told she'll bear a son, she asks a practical question, "How will this be?", before she agrees. She goes "with haste" to Elizabeth's house in the hill country and stays three months, and the song she sings there takes Hannah's as its model: God has brought down the mighty from their thrones, filled the hungry and sent the rich away empty, all in the past tense, as though already done. At Cana she tells him there's no wine and tells the servants to do whatever he says. In Mark the family comes to take him home because people say he's out of his mind. She stands at the cross in John and is with the disciples after.
CONTESTED	Matthew quotes Isaiah 7.14 from the Greek, "a virgin shall conceive." The Hebrew *'almah* means a young woman of marriageable age, and the translation is one of the oldest disputes between Jewish and Christian readers. Luke never gives her age. **INFERENCE** The usual "teenager" comes from ancient marriage customs.
WHAT DOMINION DOES	**POSSIBLE** Builds a doctrine of womanhood on her single yes and sets the song so gently nobody hears the words. The revolution she sings is footnoted as spiritual.
WHERE IT BREAKS	Her consent is asked for. An angel waits for an answer. At an Aurem Binding, "nobody asks if she consents. They ask if she is worthy" (**DOM**). **INTERPRETATION** Every Binding held in a Temple that honors Mary contradicts the story it honors.

CORRECTION TO THE OLD COMPANION The old companion said she "travels alone" to Elizabeth's. The text doesn't say whether anyone went with her.

QUESTIONS FOR THE NOVEL

LUKE 1–2

LUKE 1.34–38

LUKE 1.46–55

JOHN 2.1–5

MARK 3.21, 31–35

JOHN 19.25–27

ACTS 1.14

ISA 7.14

TKC: DOM

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

QUESTIONS FOR THE NOVEL

Mary Magdalene · the woman at the well

Two women sent to speak, and what was said about them afterward.

LUKE 8.1–3

JOHN 20.11–18

LUKE 24.10–11

GREGORY THE GREAT, HOMILY 33 (591)

JOHN 4.1–42

TKC: TR

MARY MAGDALENE · ALL FOUR GOSPELS	**Reduced to:** a prostitute. The text never says so. **The text:** from Magdala. Seven demons had gone out of her, and she and other women supported Jesus and the twelve "out of their own means." She's at the cross and the burial in all four and named first in most lists of the women. In John she's the first to see the risen Jesus and is sent to tell the disciples, "I have seen the Lord." In Luke the apostles think the women's report is nonsense. **Afterlife:** Pope Gregory the Great merged her with the unnamed sinful woman of Luke 7 and with Mary of Bethany in a sermon in 591, and it stuck for fourteen centuries. The Catholic calendar dropped the identification in 1969 and in 2016 raised her memorial to a feast with the old title "apostle to the apostles." **TKC:** POSSIBLE: The Broadcast's Eve narrative "implies and never accuses" (TR), and the reputations it assigns outlast the Trial.
THE WOMAN AT THE WELL · JOHN 4	**Reduced to:** her five husbands. **The text:** a Samaritan woman at noon. Jesus asks her for a drink, and she asks why a Jewish man is asking a Samaritan woman. Their conversation is the longest Jesus has with any one person in the gospels. She raises the live dispute between their peoples, Gerizim or Jerusalem, and gets a serious answer. He says she's had five husbands, and the text doesn't explain or condemn it. She's the first person in John to whom he says plainly he's the Messiah. She leaves her water jar, and "many Samaritans believed because of the woman's testimony." She's never given a name. **Breaks:** she gets a real answer. Ask who in Dominion would answer her.

CORRECTION TO THE OLD COMPANION The old companion said "women in that world did not divorce men." Under Jewish law only a husband could start a divorce, and Roman law let either spouse. The text doesn't say how her marriages ended.

QUESTIONS FOR THE NOVEL

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

QUESTIONS FOR THE NOVEL

The bleeding woman, the anointer, Martha and Mary

MARK 5.25–34

LEV 15.25–30

MARK 14.3–9

LUKE 10.38–42

JOHN 11.27

JOHN 12.1–8

THE WOMAN WHO BLED TWELVE YEARS · MARK 5	She's spent everything on doctors and gotten worse. She comes up behind him in a crowd and touches his cloak. Under Leviticus 15 she'd count as impure. He stops and asks who touched him, and she comes forward trembling and tells "the whole truth." He calls her "Daughter." The story is set inside the raising of a twelve-year-old girl. **INTERPRETATION** She takes what she needs without permission and is commended for it.
THE WOMAN WHO ANOINTED HIM · MARK 14	Two days before his arrest an unnamed woman breaks a jar of costly ointment over his head. The men scold her for the waste, and he says wherever the gospel is preached, what she's done will be told in memory of her. Her name wasn't kept.
MARTHA AND MARY OF BETHANY · LUKE 10, JOHN 11–12	In Luke, Mary sits at his feet, the posture of a disciple, while Martha is "distracted with much serving." He says Mary has chosen the good portion. In John, Martha makes the confession Peter makes in the other gospels: "You are the Christ, the Son of God." Mary anoints his feet and wipes them with her hair.

QUESTIONS FOR THE NOVEL

ROM 16.1–7

ACTS 18.24–26

ACTS 16.11–15, 40

ACTS 9.36–43

ACTS 6.1–6

1 TIM 5.3–16

EPP, JUNIA (2005)

TKC: DOM

The women who ran things

Named, titled and working, in the same letters used to silence women. Any institution has to choose which list is the rule.

PHOEBE · ROMANS 16	A *diakonos* of the church at Cenchreae, the word translated "deacon" for men, and a *prostatis*, a patron, "of many and of myself as well." INFERENCE: She carried the letter to Rome, and couriers often read letters aloud and explained them. The KJV and ESV call her a "servant." The NRSV and NIV (2011) say "deacon."
JUNIA · ROMANS 16	Greeted with Andronicus as "of note among the apostles," and as Paul's fellow prisoners. Early writers including John Chrysostom read her as a woman apostle. From the Middle Ages many editions printed a masculine "Junias," a name with no ancient attestation. Eldon Epp traces the change (2005). **CONTESTED** "Prominent among the apostles" or "well known to the apostles."
PRISCILLA · ACTS 18, ROMANS 16	A tentmaker with her husband Aquila, with a church in their house. When the gifted preacher Apollos arrives knowing only John's baptism, they take him aside and explain "the way of God more accurately." She's named first in four of six mentions.
LYDIA · ACTS 16	A dealer in purple cloth, a luxury trade, with her own household and no husband mentioned. The first person baptized in Philippi. She insists the missionaries stay with her, and after prison they go back to her house to meet the believers. The patron.

The women who ran things, continued

ROM 16.1–7

ACTS 18.24–26

ACTS 16.11–15, 40

ACTS 9.36–43

ACTS 6.1–6

1 TIM 5.3–16

EPP, JUNIA (2005)

TKC: DOM

TABITHA · ACTS 9	The only person in the New Testament called *mathētria*, the feminine of "disciple." When she dies, the widows show Peter the garments she'd made. Mutual aid, recorded as ministry.
THE WIDOWS · ACTS 6, 1 TIMOTHY 5	The first recorded dispute in Jerusalem is over Greek-speaking widows neglected in the daily food. 1 Timothy sets up an enrolled order of widows, age sixty and up, with support.

FOR TKC

POSSIBLE Titles like deacon and patron are rendered as domestic words in some translations, and the Empire's designations do the same on purpose. Tabitha's widows look like Irongate's Kitchen and Meridian's Reading Circles (**DOM**).

CORRECTION TO THE OLD COMPANION The old companion said Junia was "imprisoned for it," for being an apostle. The text says only that she'd been in prison with Paul.

WHO IS MY PHOEBE, MY LYDIA, MY JUNIA

GEN 12–25

GEN 18.22–33

GEN 25–35

GEN 37–50

GEN 44.18–34

EXOD 2.11–15

EXOD 7.7

ACTS 7.23, 30

KIERKEGAARD, FEAR AND TREMBLING (1843)

THE FOUNDERS

The founders aren't presented as moral exemplars. They're presented, with startling candor, as men whose obedience keeps endangering the people in their care.

ABRAHAM · GENESIS 12–25	Held up as the model of faith. The text records him twice passing his wife off as his sister to protect himself, sending Hagar and Ishmael into the wilderness, and taking his son up a mountain with a knife. It also records him bargaining with God over Sodom, from fifty righteous down to ten: "Shall not the Judge of all the earth do what is just?" Paul reads him as justified by faith, James by works. **POSSIBLE** Dominion preaches the mountain and never the bargaining.
JACOB · GENESIS 25–35	Buys his brother's birthright for stew and takes the blessing by disguise. Deceived in turn on his wedding night, he works twenty years under shifting terms. He wrestles all night, is renamed Israel, "strives with God," and limps afterward. He loves Rachel over Leah and Joseph over his brothers, openly. **For TKC:** the favoritism engine.
JUDAH · GENESIS 37–38, 43–44	Leah's fourth son. He proposes selling Joseph instead of killing him, wrongs Tamar and admits it, and in Egypt offers himself as a slave in Benjamin's place, in the longest speech in Genesis. His name became the tribe's, the kingdom's and finally the word "Jew."
JOSEPH · GENESIS 37–50	Sold, imprisoned on a false accusation, and raised to run Egypt's grain. His famine policy ends with the population selling its land and itself to the crown. "You meant evil against me, but God meant it for good." **For TKC:** the competent administrator whose competence builds the machine.
MOSES · EXODUS–DEUTERONOMY	Raised in the palace of the regime killing his people. He kills an overseer and runs to Midian. He argues with God five times before he goes and later talks God out of destroying the people. He's eighty when he faces Pharaoh. Barred from the land after striking the rock, he dies in sight of it, in a grave no one knows.

CORRECTION TO THE OLD COMPANION The old companion said Moses spent "forty years as a shepherd." Exodus doesn't give the length. The forty years come from Stephen's speech (Acts 7) and later tradition.

QUESTIONS FOR THE NOVEL

1 SAM 16 – 1 KGS 2

1 SAM 13.14

1 SAM 25

2 SAM 6

2 SAM 7

2 SAM 11–13

1 KGS 2.5–9

TKC: TL

David

1 Samuel 16 – 1 Kings 2 · the man every scriptural monarchy has claimed as precedent

USUALLY REDUCED TO	A boy with a sling, a psalmist with a harp, and "a man after God's own heart." Three images, all from the first third of his story.
WHAT THE TEXT GIVES	The most fully drawn character in the Hebrew Bible, and the portrait isn't flattering. A gifted musician and a brilliant political operator. An outlaw whose men ask Nabal for payment. A king who dances before the ark and quarrels with Michal over it. A man who sees a woman from a roof, sends for her, and has her husband killed by written order. A father who does nothing when his son rapes his daughter, and nearly loses the kingdom to another son. On his deathbed he gives his heir a list of men to deal with.
WHAT DOMINION DOES	**POSSIBLE** Everything. Divinely chosen, anointed by a prophet, forgiven after private repentance and promised an eternal dynasty (2 Sam 7), the legal basis of every throne that ever called itself Christian. His crimes are taught as a lesson in personal repentance and never as a case for accountability.
TKC ECHOES	The Emperor, and the founding myth he's measured against. Judah, if he's being trained into a role built on a man whose worst acts are on the record and forgiven in advance.
WHERE IT BREAKS	A prophet walks into the throne room, tells him what he did, and lives. The scene is the difference between a monarchy with a conscience mechanism and one without. **OPEN QUESTION** Does anyone in Dorian's court have Nathan's office?

QUESTIONS FOR THE NOVEL

Kingmakers, prophets and priests

The oldest fight in the collection. The priest is appointed, hereditary and salaried. The prophet is called, unlicensed and unpaid.

SAMUEL	When the people ask for a king "like all the nations," he warns them what a king will take: sons for his chariots, daughters for his kitchens, the best fields, a tenth of the flocks, "and you shall be his slaves." He anoints one anyway, and later anoints the replacement while the first is still alive. The cleric who makes rulers and outlives them.
NATHAN	Delivers the dynastic promise, then tells David the story of the rich man and the poor man's lamb and says "You are the man." He survives, and later works with Bathsheba to put Solomon on the throne.
SOLOMON	Wins the succession and has rivals killed. His first judgment is between two women who are prostitutes, each claiming a baby, and he hears them both in person. He builds the temple with conscripted labor. 1 Kings 9 says the forced labor fell on non-Israelites, and 1 Kings 12 says the north revolted over his "heavy yoke," so the passages pull against each other. He breaks all four prohibitions of Deuteronomy 17.
GIDEON	Offered hereditary rule, he refuses: "The LORD will rule over you." Afterward he makes a gold ephod that becomes a snare. His son Abimelech kills seventy brothers to be king, and the survivor Jotham answers with the fable of the trees, where the olive, fig and vine all decline the crown and the bramble accepts it.

1 SAM 8.11–18

2 SAM 12

1 KGS 1–11

1 KGS 9.20–22

1 KGS 12

1 KGS 17–19

JUDG 6–9

JER 26

JER 36

JER 38.7–13

EXOD 32

LEV 10

1 SAM 8.11–18

2 SAM 12

1 KGS 1–11

1 KGS 9.20–22

1 KGS 12

1 KGS 17–19

JUDG 6–9

JER 26

JER 36

JER 38.7–13

EXOD 32

LEV 10

Kingmakers, prophets and priests, continued

ELIJAH	Confronts Ahab and Jezebel and wins on Carmel. Afterward he runs, asks to die, and is fed and told to sleep. God comes to him in "a sound of thin silence." Malachi promises his return. The King James New Testament spells him Elias.
JEREMIAH	Tried for his life, his scroll cut up and burned, dropped in a muddy cistern. A Cushite palace servant, Ebed-melech, gets the king's permission and pulls him out with ropes and rags.
AARON	The first high priest. He makes the calf, announces a feast to the LORD and says the gold went into the fire "and out came this calf." He keeps his office, joins Miriam's challenge and isn't struck.

THE STRUCTURAL POINT FOR DOMINION

POSSIBLE When Dominion folded the prophet into the priest, it didn't abolish prophecy. It made prophecy an employment category, a far more elegant solution.

QUESTIONS FOR THE NOVEL

The men of the New Testament

The men closest to the center are shown getting it wrong again and again, and the record was kept by the movement they went on to lead.

PETER	Rebukes Jesus and is called "Satan." Cuts off a servant's ear in the garden. Denies knowing him three times, the first to a servant girl. Restored over breakfast with a question asked three times. Paul rebukes him in public at Antioch for withdrawing from gentile tables.
PAUL	A Pharisee who persecuted the movement and joined it. Imprisoned repeatedly, he writes that in Christ there is "no longer slave or free, no longer male and female," and greets women leaders by name.
JUDAS	Keeps the common purse. The gospels give different reasons for what he does. Matthew has him ask what they'll pay, John calls him a thief, Luke and John say Satan entered him. Matthew and Acts give two different deaths.
PILATE	The Roman prefect of Judea, 26–36 CE. All four gospels have him find no case and order the execution anyway. Only Matthew has him wash his hands. An inscription found at Caesarea in 1961 names him. **For TKC:** POSSIBLE: the Crown advisor in the Pairing Introduction (TR) is a Pilate.
JOHN THE BAPTIST	A priest's son preaching in the wilderness, who calls the crowds a "brood of vipers." Herod Antipas has him beheaded at a banquet. The gospels give a personal reason, his objection to Herod's marriage. Josephus gives a political one, Herod's fear of his hold on the crowds.

CORRECTION TO THE OLD COMPANION The old companion said the silencing verses and Galatians 3.28 are "both his." 1 Corinthians 14.34–35 sits elsewhere in some manuscripts and may be a later addition, and 1 Timothy's authorship is CONTESTED. It also said "one gospel implies disillusionment" for Judas. None does.

MARK 8.32–33

JOHN 21.15–17

GAL 2.11–14

GAL 3.28

1 COR 14.34–35

JOHN 12.6

MATT 26.14–16

MATT 27.24

JOSEPHUS, ANT. 18.116–119

PILATE INSCRIPTION, CAESAREA (1961)

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH OF THESE MEN IS JUDAH, AND WHICH IS DORIAN

The names in the cast

TKC: TL · TR · FR 0 · FR 3 · FR 33

DECIDED

Many of the cast carry biblical names. The table records what each name points to. Whether an echo is meant is your call, so every application after this page is POSSIBLE unless it carries a source tag.

NAME	WHO IN TKC	BIBLICAL SOURCE
EDEN SELAH OSEI	Covenant Daughter of Aurem (**TL**)	The garden (Gen 2–3). *Selah* is a liturgical marker of unknown meaning, seventy-one times in Psalms and three in Habakkuk.
MIRIAM OSEI	Eden's mother (**TL**)	Miriam the prophet. Mariam in Greek, so every Mary in the New Testament.
LEAH OSEI	Eden's younger sister (TL, DECIDED)	Leah, the fertile, unloved wife (Gen 29–30)
ZION OSEI	Eden's brother (**TL**)	A place: Jerusalem's hill, and the city addressed as "daughter Zion"
SOLOMON OSEI	Eden's brother, sixteen (DECIDED)	Solomon, Bathsheba's son, born after the household broke
THOMAS OSEI	Eden's father, who left voluntarily (**FR 3**)	Thomas, who wouldn't believe without seeing (John 20)
HANNAH	House Mother, House Aurem (**TL**)	Hannah, who gave her only son to the sanctuary
NAOMI	Hannah's daughter (**TL**)	Naomi, who came home empty and planned Ruth's future
ABIGAIL	Debate and Protocol Advisor (**TL**)	Abigail, who talked an armed man out of a massacre on her knees

TKC: TL · TR · FR 0 · FR 3 · FR 33

DECIDED

The names in the cast, continued

NAME	WHO IN TKC	BIBLICAL SOURCE
RUTH GIDEON	Covenant Daughter of Heartland (TR)	Ruth, and Gideon, who refused a crown and made a snare
JUDAH ELIJAH VANE	Crown Heir (TL)	Judah, who offered himself in his brother's place. Elijah, who confronted a king and queen.
ELIAS VANE	Founder (TL)	Elias is the King James New Testament spelling of Elijah
ZARA VOSS	Covenant Daughter of Sable (TR)	Zara is the King James spelling of Zerah, Tamar's twin
SERA CALLUM VANE · SERA MONTOYA	Elias's wife (TL) · Covenant Daughter of Pacific (TR)	Serah, daughter of Asher, one of the few daughters named in the genealogies
PETRA SOLANO	Covenant Daughter of Mountain (TR)	A word: Greek *petra*, "rock" (Matt 16.18)
AZRAEL VANE	Dorian's elder son (TL)	No biblical source. The angel of death in later Islamic and Jewish tradition.

SUPERSEDED The timeline's age of thirteen for Solomon. **DECIDED** Solomon is sixteen, and Leah is younger than Eden.

Echoes, labeled

TKC: TL · TR · DOM · DR3 · WR · AM · FR 26 · FR 29 · FR 41–42

SEVEN WOMEN PROPHETS	The Talmud's list (Megillah 14a) is Sarah, Miriam, Deborah, Hannah, Abigail, Huldah and Esther. Eden's mother, her House Mother and her protocol advisor all carry prophets' names. **POSSIBLE** Celeste knows the list and has never said so.
ELIAS AS ELIJAH	**POSSIBLE** The Temple reads its canonized founder (**TL**) as the Elijah Malachi promised, and named the Crown Heir Judah Elijah to carry it. Elijah's story includes the collapse after the victory, and the Temple doesn't teach it.
HULDAH	The ledger and the Covenant of Dissent are found documents (**TL**, **FR 41–42**). **OPEN QUESTION** Who in the Empire would be asked to authenticate the Dissent if it surfaced?
TAMAR'S METHOD	**POSSIBLE** Eden's method in a world run by the Registry, and its limit. Tamar had a law on her side that wasn't enforced. Eden's law is against her.
JEZEBEL	Aurelia is built over Atlanta's Black memory, and Gulf candidates are penalized for warmth (**DOM**). **POSSIBLE** "Jezebel" is the word the Broadcast never says on air and its editors use in the room.
SAMUEL 8 AND JOTHAM'S FABLE	Two anti-monarchy texts in the Empire's own canon. **POSSIBLE** Pacific's grandmothers (**DOM**) know the bramble fable by heart.
EBED-MELECH	**POSSIBLE** Hannah, who knows the back staircases and the camera gaps (**TL**), is this kind of insider.
JEREMIAH'S SCROLL	Dorian removed the Covenant of Dissent (**FR 42**). **POSSIBLE** Someone can still recite it, the way Celeste can recite the Covenant of Purpose (**AM**).
JOHN THE BAPTIST	**INTERPRETATION** The Empire's "sudden medical event" for Azrael and Petra works the same way as the gospels' account of John, a private explanation for a public act.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

THE ECHO I'M KEEPING, AND THE ONE I'M CUTTING

Working questions

YOURS

OPEN QUESTIONS

PART IX LOG

1 · WHICH BIBLICAL NAMES IN THE CAST WERE CHOSEN BY A CHARACTER, AND WHICH BY THE REGISTRY? WHO NAMED LEAH, ZION AND SOLOMON?

2 · DOES HANNAH KNOW SHE'S NAMED FOR A WOMAN WHO GAVE HER CHILD TO THE SANCTUARY? DOES NAOMI?

3 · WHAT DOES ABIGAIL SAY TO EDEN THAT THE BIBLICAL ABIGAIL SAID TO DAVID?

4 · WRITE THE TEMPLE'S LESSON ON VASHTI FOR GIRLS AT DESIGNATION AGE, THEN THE VERSION CELESTE TOLD EDEN

Working Questions, Continued

5 · WHICH COVENANT DAUGHTER IN EARLIER TRIALS GOT THE MARY MAGDALENE TREATMENT, AND WHERE IS SHE NOW?

6 · DOES JUDAH KNOW THE END OF ELIJAH'S STORY, THE CAVE AND THE SILENCE? WHO TAUGHT IT TO HIM?

7 · WHICH BIBLICAL WOMAN DOES CELESTE NAME MOST OFTEN AT THE KITCHEN TABLE, AND WHICH ONE WON'T SHE TALK ABOUT?

III

PART THREE · ✝

Jesus, Kingdom and Power

The novel is named after a line from his prayer. Here's what he meant by it, and what the Empire has decided he meant.

i · What he meant by kingdom	424
ii · Four things he kept doing	426
iii · The Lord's Prayer, clause by clause	428
iv · The Gospel Grid	433
v · For TKC	444

NT | KINGDOM

TWO SAYINGS THE EMPIRE NEEDS

"My kingdom is not of this world" (John 18.36). **CONTESTED** *Ek tou kosmou toutou* is "from this world," and many read it as a statement about the kingdom's source more than its location. "Render to Caesar" (Mark 12.13–17) answers a trap about Roman tax. He asks whose image is on the coin. **CONTESTED** Two spheres, an evasion, or a challenge, since his hearers know whose image human beings bear (Gen 1.27).

MARGINALIA

✣ *See also:* For TKC, at the end of this part.

What he meant by kingdom

Start with the word, because everything turns on it. *Basileia* means kingdom, kingship or reign, and it's the word for the empire that ruled Judea. "The kingdom of God" is the center of his preaching in the first three gospels. Mark's summary is "The time is fulfilled, and the kingdom of God has come near." Matthew usually says "kingdom of heaven," a reverent way of not saying God, and means the same thing. He wasn't inventing a private spiritual category. He was making a claim about who governs, in a province where saying so got people crucified along the roads.

What he poured into that political word runs against what the word normally carries. The parables describe the kingdom as small, hidden and growing without permission: a mustard seed, yeast in flour, treasure buried in a field, a merchant who sells everything for one pearl. It belongs to the poor. Children, tax collectors and prostitutes go in ahead of the respectable, and it's harder for the rich to enter than for a camel to go through a needle's eye. Rank is turned over on purpose. When his followers argue about who's greatest he tells them the rulers of the nations lord it over their subjects, "but it shall not be so among you." In John he washes their feet, a slave's work. When a crowd wants to make him king by force he withdraws. He enters Jerusalem on a donkey. **INTERPRETATION** Marcus Borg and John Dominic Crossan read the entry as a counter-procession to the Roman governor's arrival with troops at Passover. The charge on the cross, in all four gospels, is "King of the Jews." CONTESTED: Whether the kingdom is present, future or both. Albert Schweitzer argued in 1906 that Jesus expected the end of the world soon, C. H. Dodd argued in 1935 that the kingdom was already present in his ministry, and most scholars now hold some version of "already and not yet." Luke 17.21 says the kingdom is *entos hymōn*, "within you" or "among you," and the translation turns it from an inner state into a present reality in a community.

> *The rulers of the nations lord it over them. It shall not be so among you.*
> MATT 20.25–26

What Dominion teaches the kingdom is

YOURS

TKC: TL

AM

THE RELOCATION

POSSIBLE The Temple empties the word. The kingdom becomes an inner condition of the obedient heart or a reward after death, anywhere but here and never a claim on territory. Having emptied it, the Empire claims the word for itself: Dominion is the kingdom come, which makes resisting the state the same as resisting God. The old companion called this the engine of the novel (AM).

WHAT THE TEMPLE TEACHES THE KINGDOM IS, IN ITS OWN WORDS

A SCENE WHERE THE SAME LINE IS SAID TWICE, BY TWO PEOPLE MEANING OPPOSITE THINGS

MARK 1.22

MARK 11.28

MATT 23

MARK 11.15–17

MARK 1.41–44

MARK 5.25–34

MARK 7.24–30

LUKE 8.1–3

LUKE 10.38–42

MARK 10.17–22

LUKE 4.16–30

FREDRIKSEN

LEVINE, THE MISUNDERSTOOD JEW (2006)

Four things he kept doing

AUTHORITY	Crowds say he teaches "as one who had authority, and not as the scribes," and officials keep asking "By what authority are you doing these things?" He argues sabbath practice, calls scribes and Pharisees "blind guides" and "whitewashed tombs," and drives the money changers out of the temple court. **For TKC:** POSSIBLE: unlicensed authority is the crime Dominion can't forgive, since it's the only one that threatens the licensing system itself.
BODIES	He touches a man with a skin disease and takes a dead girl by the hand. The bleeding woman touches him first, without asking, and he commends her faith. INTERPRETATION The contagion runs the other way. He doesn't become unclean, and they become well. CONTESTED Whether that amounts to opposing the purity system. Paula Fredriksen and Amy-Jill Levine warn that reading Jesus as against Jewish law is a Christian habit with an ugly history. He sends the healed man to the priest with the offering Moses commanded.
WOMEN	Mary of Bethany sits at his feet in the student's place, and he defends her. Named women fund the movement. A Syrophoenician woman argues with him over healing her daughter, answers his refusal with "even the dogs under the table eat the children's crumbs," and he grants it "for this saying." She wins the exchange. He's anointed by a woman in a room of men who call it waste. No gospel records him telling a woman to be silent.
MONEY	He tells a rich man to sell everything, and the man goes away grieving. Luke pairs blessings on the poor with woes on the rich and adds the rich fool and the rich man and Lazarus. In his first sermon, at Nazareth, he reads Isaiah 61, "release to the captives... the year of the Lord's favor," which echoes the Jubilee, and says it's fulfilled today. **For TKC:** INTERPRETATION: The most suppressed material in Dominion's scripture is economic more than sexual. Follow the money and you'll find the censorship.

CORRECTION TO THE OLD COMPANION The old companion said the Nazareth room "turns on him" over the year of release. The congregation first speaks well of him (4.22). They try to throw him off a cliff after he says Elijah and Elisha were sent to foreigners, a widow of Sidon and a Syrian general (4.24–30).

QUESTIONS FOR THE NOVEL

MATT 6.7–13

LUKE 11.1–4

P75

CODEX VATICANUS

CODEX SINAITICUS

DIDACHE 8.2

Thy kingdom come

The prayer appears twice, in different settings and forms. In Matthew it's part of the Sermon on the Mount, taught in place of heaping up empty phrases. In Luke the disciples ask "Lord, teach us to pray," and he gives a shorter version. Every pronoun for the people praying is plural. There's no "I" in it.

CLAUSE	MATTHEW 6.9–13	LUKE 11.2–4	COMMON LITURGICAL FORM
ADDRESS	Our Father in heaven	Father	Our Father, who art in heaven
NAME	Hallowed be your name	Hallowed be your name	Hallowed be thy name
KINGDOM	Your kingdom come	Your kingdom come	Thy kingdom come
WILL	Your will be done, on earth as it is in heaven	Absent in the earliest manuscripts	Thy will be done, on earth as it is in heaven
BREAD	Give us this day our daily bread	Give us each day our daily bread	Give us this day our daily bread
FORGIVENESS	Forgive us our debts, as we also have forgiven our debtors	Forgive us our sins, for we ourselves forgive everyone indebted to us	Forgive us our trespasses, as we forgive those who trespass against us
TESTING	Lead us not into temptation, but deliver us from evil (or "the evil one")	Lead us not into temptation	Lead us not into temptation, but deliver us from evil
DOXOLOGY	Absent in the earliest manuscripts	Absent	For thine is the kingdom, and the power, and the glory, for ever. Amen.

CORRECTION TO THE OLD COMPANION The old companion presented one prayer and treated "on earth as in heaven" as part of the title line. "Thy kingdom come" is in both gospels. "On earth as in heaven" is Matthew's alone, the doxology is a later addition, and the prayer most people recite is Matthew's text with a liturgical ending.

Clause by clause

OUR FATHER IN HEAVEN	A shared parent makes the people praying siblings, and rank inside the family a fiction. **INTERPRETATION** Authority is placed where no earthly office can occupy it. **POSSIBLE** Dominion prefers the clause said upward and never sideways.
HALLOWED BE YOUR NAME	A request that God's name be treated as holy. **INTERPRETATION** It implies no other name is, imperial or dynastic. Ask what Dominion has carved above its doors.
YOUR KINGDOM COME	The title line, in both gospels. It asks for the kingdom's arrival, which assumes it isn't fully here. The Jewish Kaddish, an Aramaic prayer whose core many date early, also pairs the hallowing of God's name with a prayer that the kingdom come soon, and the two are often compared.
YOUR WILL BE DONE, ON EARTH AS IN HEAVEN	Matthew's. It's absent from Luke in the earliest manuscripts (P75, Codex Vaticanus) and was added by later copyists. **INTERPRETATION** In Matthew it ties the kingdom to the earth, to the place where taxes are collected and soldiers are stationed.
OUR DAILY BREAD	*Epiousios*, "daily," appears nowhere in Greek before the gospels, and its meaning is uncertain: "for today," "for tomorrow," "necessary for existence." Jerome translated it two ways, "supersubstantial" in Matthew and "daily" in Luke. It asks for enough, and for "our" bread more than "my" bread.

KADDISH

EPIOUSIOS

JEROME, VULGATE

TYNDALE (1526)

BOOK OF COMMON PRAYER (1549)

MATT 6.14–15

KADDISH

EPIOUSIOS

JEROME, VULGATE

TYNDALE (1526)

BOOK OF COMMON PRAYER (1549)

MATT 6.14–15

Clause by clause, continued

FORGIVE US OUR DEBTS	Matthew says debts, *opheilēmata*. Luke says sins, though his second half keeps the debt language. Both tie the request to the one praying it. "Trespasses" isn't in either gospel's prayer. It comes from Tyndale's Matthew (1526) and the Book of Common Prayer (1549), and passed into Anglican and Catholic English. Matthew's very next verses do use a word for trespasses.
LEAD US NOT INTO TEMPTATION	*Peirasmos* means testing or trial as well as temptation. **INTERPRETATION** A request to be spared the test, more than to pass it heroically. Pope Francis criticized the wording in 2017, and the French and Italian Catholic liturgies changed it. "From evil" can also be "from the evil one."
FOR THINE IS THE KINGDOM	Absent from the earliest manuscripts of Matthew and from every early Luke. A shorter form appears in the Didache, about 100 CE. Later manuscripts added it, the King James printed it, and most modern translations footnote it.

CORRECTION TO THE OLD COMPANION The old companion said institutions render the clause "trespasses" to blunt its money sense. Debts, sins and trespasses track which text and translation tradition a church inherited, and they aren't evidence of motive. Churches that say "debts," Presbyterian and Reformed ones among them, follow the King James Matthew.

Dominion's version

WRITING

TKC: DR3 · TL

OPEN QUESTION

INFERENCE The Book of Covenant uses King James wording (**DR3**), so the Temple's base text is probably Matthew 6 as the KJV prints it: "debts," "Thy will be done in earth, as it is in heaven," and the doxology. **OPEN QUESTION** Does the Temple say "debts" or "trespasses" in public worship, and does it print Luke's shorter version anywhere?

DOMINION'S OFFICIAL TEXT, LINE BY LINE. WHAT'S CUT, WHAT'S ADDED

WHO IN THE CAST SAYS "DEBTS" AND WHO SAYS "TRESPASSES," AND DOES ANYONE NOTICE?

WRITING

TKC: TL

The line, in the house

Elias Vane's 2033 sermon is called Thy Kingdom Come, and it's been required curriculum in every Dominion school since 2061 (TL).

THE PASSAGE OF ELIAS'S SERMON THAT EXPLAINS WHAT "THY KINGDOM COME" MEANS. THE LINE EVERY SCHOOLCHILD KNOWS

WHAT CELESTE SAYS THE LINE MEANS, AT THE KITCHEN TABLE, WHEN EDEN IS SMALL

Luke 1.1–3

Many have undertaken to compile a narrative of the things that have been accomplished among us...

it seemed good to me also, having followed all things closely for some time past, to write an orderly account for you.

✣

A gospel that opens by saying there were others. Four, kept side by side.

SOURCE MARGIN

MATT · MARK · LUKE · JOHN

NA28 · UBS5

SANDERS, THE HISTORICAL FIGURE OF JESUS (1993)

EHRMAN, THE NEW TESTAMENT

REFERENCE UNIT · ◈

The Gospel Grid

There's no single gospel. There are four, written for different communities decades apart, and they disagree about the order of events, the wording of the sayings, the day of the death and what happened at the tomb. This unit holds all four at once.

WHY A GRID AND NOT A HARMONY

A harmony stitches the four into one story and quietly deletes the differences. The differences are the most useful material in the New Testament for a writer. They show four groups deciding what mattered.

WHAT THIS UNIT WON'T DO

Tell you which account is right, whether the differences are contradictions or perspectives, or what any of it obliges you to believe. Every date and source theory is marked as argued.

MARK 1.1

MATT 1.1

LUKE 1.1–4

JOHN 1.1

JOHN 20.31

PAPIAS (2ND C.)

THE RECORD ON EACH

All four are formally anonymous. The names were attached by tradition, generally in the second century. Every date is a mainstream range, and every one is argued.

	MARK	MATTHEW	LUKE	JOHN
USUAL DATE	About 65–75	About 80–90	About 80–95	About 90–110
LENGTH	16 chapters, the shortest	28 chapters	24 chapters, continued in Acts	21 chapters
OPENS WITH	John the Baptist in the wilderness	A genealogy from Abraham	A dedication claiming orderly research	"In the beginning was the Word," before creation
BIRTH STORY	None	Magi, Herod's massacre, flight to Egypt	Shepherds, Mary's song, the temple	None
GENEALOGY	None	Abraham to Joseph, naming Tamar, Rahab, Ruth and "the wife of Uriah"	Back to Adam, by a different line after David	None
TEACHING	Short, often private explanations	Five large blocks, the Sermon on the Mount first	The Sermon on the Plain, the most parables	Long first-person discourses, the "I am" sayings
EXORCISMS	Central	Frequent	Frequent	None
LEANS TOWARD	Disciples who don't understand. His identity is named at the cross by a Roman soldier.	Fulfillment, the law, community discipline, judgment	The poor, reversals of status, women, foreigners	Who Jesus is, and belief

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH OF THE FOUR VOICES IS CLOSEST TO HOW MY WORLD TELLS ITS OWN FOUNDING STORY

MARK 15.34

MATT 27.46

LUKE 23.34, 46

JOHN 19.30

MARK 16.8

MARK 16.9–20

THE RECORD ON EACH, CONTINUED

	MARK	MATTHEW	LUKE	JOHN
LORD'S PRAYER	Absent	6.9–13	11.2–4	Absent
MINISTRY	Can be read as about a year, one trip to Jerusalem	Same	Same	Three Passovers and several trips, the source of "three years"
TEMPLE ACTION	Final week, the trigger for the arrest	Final week	Final week	At the start (ch. 2)
LAST MEAL	A Passover meal	A Passover meal	A Passover meal	Before Passover. He dies as the lambs are slaughtered.
LAST WORDS	"My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?" then a loud cry	The same cry	"Father, into your hands I commit my spirit"	"It is finished"
AT THE TOMB	Three women, the stone rolled away, a young man inside. They flee and tell no one.	Two Marys, an earthquake, an angel, guards. They meet Jesus on the way.	Several named women, two men in dazzling clothes. The apostles think it's nonsense.	Mary Magdalene, then Peter and another disciple. Jesus appears to her first.
ENDING	The earliest manuscripts end at 16.8 with the women afraid. The longer ending is a later addition.	A commission on a mountain in Galilee	Appearances near Jerusalem, the ascension	Two endings, 20.30–31 and ch. 21

CORRECTION TO THE OLD COMPANION The old companion said "no two of the four give the same last words." Mark and Matthew give the same cry, Eloi in Mark and Eli in Matthew. Luke's "Father, forgive them" (23.34) is missing from some of the earliest manuscripts, and its originality is CONTESTED.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH ENDING MY WORLD'S FOUNDING ACCOUNT USES, AND WHO CUT THE OTHERS

MARK 8.22–26

MARK 14.51–52

MATT 2

MATT 25.31–46

LUKE 1.46–55

JOHN 11

GOODACRE, THE CASE AGAINST Q (2002)

THE OVERLAP PROBLEM

Matthew, Mark and Luke run parallel closely enough to print in columns, same episodes, same order, sometimes identical Greek for long stretches. Independent memory doesn't do that. Some literary relationship is certain. **CONTESTED** Which one.

PROPOSAL	WHAT IT CLAIMS	ITS WEAK POINT
TWO-SOURCE, THE MAJORITY VIEW	Matthew and Luke each used Mark, plus a lost sayings collection called Q, plus material of their own	Q has never been found and is reconstructed from the texts it explains
FARRER · GOODACRE (2002)	Luke used Mark and Matthew both, so no lost source is needed	It has to explain why Luke broke up Matthew's sermons and moved the pieces
MATTHEW FIRST · GRIESBACH	Matthew is earliest, and Mark condensed the others	It has to explain why a condenser would add rough Greek and unflattering details
JOHN	Knew the other three, knew a tradition behind them, or wrote independently. A separate dispute.	Its differences are too large to be editorial trimming

ONLY IN MARK	A healing that takes two tries, a young man who runs away naked at the arrest, and the abrupt ending at the empty tomb.
ONLY IN MATTHEW	The magi, the massacre of the children, the guard at the tomb, and the sheep and the goats.
ONLY IN LUKE	The shepherds, Mary's song, the good Samaritan, the prodigal son, the rich man and Lazarus, the road to Emmaus. Most of what's quoted about poverty and mercy is his.
ONLY IN JOHN	Cana, Nicodemus at night, the Samaritan woman, Lazarus raised, the foot washing and the long farewell.

THE FINDING THAT MATTERS FOR TKC

INTERPRETATION Whatever the order, later writers visibly edited earlier ones, softening, reordering, adding a birth and adding an ending. Scripture inside the canon is visibly revised scripture. An empire that claims a fixed, unedited text is claiming something its own documents contradict, and that's a device as much as a polemic.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHO EDITED THE FOUNDING ACCOUNT IN MY WORLD, AND WHAT THEY SOFTENED

METHOD

BIBLE 101 VIII

WORKSHEET

Run any episode through it

Pick an episode that appears in more than one gospel and fill the columns from the text, not from memory. Good starters: the temple action, the anointing, the trial before Pilate, the words from the cross, the empty tomb.

EPISODE	TRANSLATION USED

GOSPEL	REFERENCE AND WHAT HAPPENS	WHAT'S ADDED, MISSING OR CHANGED
Mark		
Matthew		
Luke		
John		

THE DIFFERENCE THAT ACTUALLY CHANGES THE MEANING, AND WHOSE INTEREST IT SERVES

WHICH VERSION MY WORLD WOULD CANONIZE, AND WHICH IT WOULD SUPPRESS

Where they don't match

These are differences in the text. Whether they're contradictions or complementary perspectives is a theological judgment this companion leaves to you. Their being differences isn't in dispute.

THE TEMPLE ACTION	In the first three it happens in the final week and triggers the arrest. In John it opens the ministry. Same event, opposite role.
THE DAY OF DEATH	The first three make the last meal a Passover meal. John puts the crucifixion before the Passover meal, so the death coincides with the slaughter of the lambs.
THE GENEALOGIES	Matthew and Luke give different lines with different names between David and Joseph, running in opposite directions. Reconciliations have been proposed, and none commands agreement.
AFTER THE BIRTH	Matthew has a flight to Egypt to escape a massacre. Luke has a calm presentation at the temple and a return to Nazareth. The two itineraries are hard to run at once.
THE BEATITUDES	Matthew sets them on a mountain and blesses the poor in spirit. Luke sets them on level ground, blesses the poor, and adds matching woes on the rich. One is interior and one is economic.
THE PRAYER	Luke's is shorter, and the familiar closing line is missing from the oldest manuscripts of both. The prayer most recited in the world is a composite.
AT THE TOMB	The number of women, the number of figures, whether the stone is already moved, who's told, Galilee or Jerusalem, and whether anyone speaks all differ. Women are the first witnesses in every one.

THE ONE DETAIL THEY ALL KEEP

INTERPRETATION Four accounts that agree on almost no logistics all put women at the tomb first, in a culture where women's testimony carried little legal weight. Some scholars argue an inventing community wouldn't have chosen it. It's an argument from plausibility and not a proof.

JOHN 2.13–22

JOHN 19.14–31

MATT 1 · LUKE 3

MATT 5 · LUKE 6

MATT 6 · LUKE 11

MARK 16 · JOHN 20

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHOSE TESTIMONY MY WORLD REFUSES TO COUNT, AND WHAT THEY SAW ANYWAY

What I take out of the grid

WRITING

UNIT CLOSE

QUEUE: G0

THE DIFFERENCE BETWEEN TWO ACCOUNTS THAT I'M PUTTING INTO THE MANUSCRIPT

WHICH GOSPEL THE SANCTUM CIRCULATES MOST, AND WHY THAT ONE

WHAT I STILL NEED TO CHECK. CARRY IT TO THE RESEARCH LIST.

PROOFING GATE *log only, nothing is closed here*

The Gospel Grid has six numbered pages. Source theories and dates are carried as CONTESTED. Textual facts about manuscript endings are research. Outstanding for proofing: full citations with edition and year.

PROOFED BY | DATE | OUTSTANDING

TKC: TL · DR3 · TR · DOM · CR · WR · AM

The prayer and the Trials

THE TITLE, TWICE	Elias Vane's 2033 sermon is called Thy Kingdom Come (**TL**), and the novel takes the same words. **INTERPRETATION** Every character who prays the line is asking either for the Empire to last or for something to replace it, and may not know which.
RELOCATING THE KINGDOM	**POSSIBLE** The Temple makes "My kingdom is not of this world" its favorite verse and then names the Empire as the kingdom come. The move needs both halves, the kingdom emptied of territory and the Empire claiming the territory.
ON EARTH AS IN HEAVEN	**POSSIBLE** The clause the Temple can't spiritualize, because it names the earth. Someone who's read Luke knows the prayer works without it, and someone who's read Matthew knows it doesn't.
DEBTS AND LEVIES	In Aurem, families of the top five Assessment finishers get the kind of review where unpaid levies disappear (**DR3**). **INTERPRETATION** The Empire forgives a household's debts in exchange for its daughter. **POSSIBLE** A character notices the Temple says "trespasses" in the same building as the levy office.
LEAD US NOT INTO TESTING	**INTERPRETATION** Twelve Covenant Daughters pray every week to be spared the test while the Empire tests them for four months. **POSSIBLE** The Temple teaches the clause as a prayer for the strength to pass.
WOMEN AT THE TOMB	Eden's Theological Interview report runs three pages longer than anyone else's, and the officer can't tell whether she's the most aligned woman in twenty years or the most clear-eyed (**TR**). **POSSIBLE** Whose testimony counts is the Trials' question too.
THE SYROPHOENICIAN WOMAN	**POSSIBLE** The precedent for Eden's Public Testimony, where every sentence is defensible and the whole is incendiary (**TR**).

The Procession and the Broadcast

TKC: DOM · CR · TR · WR 36 · WR 38–39

THE DONKEY AND THE BOULEVARD	The Opening Procession gives Aurem's Covenant Daughter forty-seven seconds on Sovereign Boulevard (**DOM**), and every walk is choreographed (**CR**). **POSSIBLE** Someone knows the entry into Jerusalem was read as a parody of a governor's procession, and walks the Boulevard thinking about it.
RANK TURNED OVER	**POSSIBLE** Judah knows Mark 10.42–44, and it's part of why he doesn't perform (**WR 36**). In the Pairing Introduction he sends the officials out (**TR**), the closest thing in the Trials to washing feet.
FOUR GOSPELS AND ONE BROADCAST	The Broadcast edits the Civic Debates for Dominion release, cutting exchanges and building narratives decided in advance (**TR**). **INTERPRETATION** The gospels show four communities shaping one story, openly and in the canon. The Broadcast does it in secret and calls the result the record.
KEEPING THE ANTI-JEWISH TROPE OUT	The Temple of TKC is the Empire's institution. When Jesus argues with Pharisees and scribes, the argument is inside first-century Judaism. If the novel uses those scenes against the Temple, the narration has to know the difference, or it repeats an old Christian slander (**WR 38–39**).
LUKE 4	**POSSIBLE** The Temple preaches the release of Luke 4.18 as spiritual and drops 4.25–27, since favor to outsiders is what the Empire can't afford in any Dominion.

THE SCENE I'M BUILDING FROM THIS PAGE

YOURS

OPEN QUESTIONS

PART IX LOG

Working Questions

1 · WHICH OF THE FOUR GOSPELS DOES THE TEMPLE READ FROM MOST, AND WHICH IS ALMOST NEVER READ ALOUD?

2 · DOES THE TEMPLE TEACH THAT MARK ENDS AT 16.8? WOULD A GIRL WITH EDEN'S SCORES HAVE FOUND OUT ON HER OWN?

3 · WHO IN THE CROWNWARD HAS READ THE MAGNIFICAT AS A POLITICAL TEXT, AND WHAT HAPPENED TO THEM?

4 · WHICH SAYING OF JESUS WOULD GET A COVENANT DAUGHTER FLAGGED IF SHE QUOTED IT IN THE CIVIC DEBATES?

5 · WHEN EDEN PRAYS "LEAD US NOT INTO TEMPTATION" DURING THE TRIALS, WHAT DOES SHE MEAN BY IT?

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

6 · WHAT DOES THE EMPIRE DO WITH "THE RULERS OF THE NATIONS LORD IT OVER THEM"? WHAT IS JUDAH'S PRIVATE READING OF "MY KINGDOM IS NOT OF THIS WORLD"?

NOTES

ANYTHING THIS SPREAD STARTED AND DID NOT FINISH

IV

PART FOUR · ▣

Empire and Interpretation

No empire in this literature ever had to change a word of scripture. It only had to decide which words were read aloud, to whom, and how often.

i · Empires of the Bible 450

ii · Who gets to say what it means 452

iii · Passages put to work 454

iv · Passages kept quiet 456

v · American history, 1630 to now 458

vi · For TKC 470

EXOD 1–14

2 KGS 17–19

2 KGS 18.26–28

2 KGS 24–25

DAN 1.3–7

EZRA 1, 6–7

ESTH 1–2

ESTH 8.8

DAN 6.8

TKC: MEN · TL

Five occupations

Almost the whole Bible was written by people living under someone else's government. Read the empires as a menu of methods, because Dominion uses some combination of them.

EGYPT · LABOR	Forced labor, rising quotas and a decree controlling births. Unrest is answered with more work. Its method is exhaustion, people too tired to organize. Read Exodus 1–14.
ASSYRIA · SUBMISSION, ADVERTISED	Terror and deportation. Conquered peoples were broken up and resettled among strangers, and the northern kingdom disappeared this way. Its envoy shouts terms at Jerusalem's wall in the local language so the people on the wall can hear. Read 2 Kings 17–19 and Nahum.
BABYLON · THE TOP OF A SOCIETY	It deported the educated and skilled, trained young men in its own language and literature, renamed them and gave them careers, and left the poor to work the land. It also besieged Jerusalem, burned the temple and blinded the king, so it used both methods. Read 2 Kings 24–25, Daniel 1–6 and Lamentations.
PERSIA · ORDER AT LOW COST	Licensed and funded local religion. It sent the exiles home, paid for the temple and authorized its law. Its decrees can't be revoked. Its court gathers young women by search and removes a queen by legislation. Read Ezra, Nehemiah, Esther and Daniel 6.
ROME · TAXES AND QUIET	Governed through local clients, a client king, a temple aristocracy and a governor who signs orders he disagrees with. Crucifixion was public and slow, by roads. The emperor was honored as divine and his rule called peace. Read the gospels, Acts and Revelation.

CORRECTION TO THE OLD COMPANION The old companion called Babylon's elite capture "far cheaper than terror," as if it chose one. It used both (2 Kgs 25.7–9).

THE COMPOSITE FOR DOMINION

POSSIBLE The Empire uses the cheap methods, Babylon's elite capture, Persia's licensed religion and Rome's local clients. The Imperial Education Track takes exceptional common boys and makes them Crown-adjacent for life (**MEN**), which is Daniel 1. Terror is kept for the edges: the Ungoverned, Azrael, the 2061 removal (**TL, FR 35–36**).

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH METHODS DOMINION USES, AND ON WHOM

TYNDALE (D. 1536)

GENEVA BIBLE (1560)

SLAVE BIBLE (1807)

SOUTH CAROLINA NEGRO ACT (1740)

NAT TURNER (1831)

TKC: DR3 · DOM

Seven separate powers

Authority over a text is a set of separate powers, usually held by different people. A religious state becomes total when one institution holds all of them. Work out which ones Dominion holds, because the ones it doesn't are where the plot lives.

POWER	WHAT IT DECIDES	HISTORICAL CASE
THE CANON	Which books count	Settled for most churches long ago, and so invisible
THE TRANSLATION	Which words	William Tyndale was executed in 1536, in part for translating the Bible into English without license
THE LECTIONARY	Which passages are read aloud, on which days	Most worshippers hear only what the calendar of readings allows
THE COMMENTARY	What a passage is taken to mean	The Geneva Bible's margin notes (1560) were one reason James I wanted a new translation without them
THE PULPIT	Who may stand up and speak	The licensing of preachers, and its withdrawal
THE COPY	Who owns a book, and which edition	Abridged editions like the 1807 Slave Bible
LITERACY	Who can read it unaided	South Carolina's Negro Act of 1740 banned teaching enslaved people to write, and several Southern states tightened anti-literacy laws after Nat Turner's revolt in 1831

> **THE HISTORICAL PATTERN**
>
> INTERPRETATION Movements that broke a religious monopoly usually did it by attacking translation, literacy or the copy. Reform tends to arrive as a printing problem before it's a theological one.

WHAT THE EMPIRE HOLDS

The pulpit (the Temple and its ministers), the lectionary (what's read before the scores, DR3), the commentary (the Assessment's doctrine section, DR3) and much of literacy (the Designation, DOM). OPEN QUESTION Does it hold the translation and the copy? Is the Book of Covenant a full Bible, and who may own another one?

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH OF THE SEVEN DOMINION DOESN'T CONTROL, AND WHO IN THE CAST HAS QUIETLY TAKEN IT

GEN 3.16

ROM 13.1–7

EPH 5.21–22

1 TIM 2.11–12

DEUT 28

JOSH 7

NUM 16

JUDG 21.25

2 SAM 7

THE STATE'S WORKING TOOLKIT

Every one of these is in the text, and each has been read more narrowly or more widely than the text requires.

PASSAGE	HOW IT'S BEEN USED	WHAT THE TEXT DOES
GENESIS 3.16	As a charter for male rule in the household and the law	**CONTESTED** Prescription or description. The woman isn't cursed in the chapter.
ROMANS 13.1–7	As a demand to obey whatever government holds power. Loyalist clergy preached it against the American Revolution, and in June 2018 the U.S. attorney general cited it to defend a border policy that separated children from their parents.	Written by a man repeatedly jailed by the authorities he describes, in a canon full of prophets defying kings
EPHESIANS 5.22	As household law	Grows out of 5.21, "submit to one another," and is followed by a longer section demanding self-giving from husbands
1 TIMOTHY 2.11–12	As a permanent ban on women teaching	CONTESTED authorship. Named women teach elsewhere in the New Testament.
DEUTERONOMY 28	As a national scoreboard: prosperity proves virtue, disaster proves sin	One side of an argument the Bible has with itself. Job and Ecclesiastes refuse it.
JOSHUA 7	As a case for collective punishment	Set against Deuteronomy 24.16 and Ezekiel 18
NUMBERS 16	As the standing sermon against challenging ordained leaders	Paired in the same book with the daughters of Zelophehad, whose petition succeeds
2 SAMUEL 7	As a promise of an eternal dynasty	Followed in the same book by "You are the man"

CORRECTION TO THE OLD COMPANION The old companion called Genesis 3.16 "a curse, not a command." The woman isn't cursed, and whether the line is a command is the disputed point.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH OF THESE IS CARVED ON A DOMINION WALL

LEV 25

DEUT 17

NUM 27

1 SAM 8

1 KGS 21

2 KGS 22

AMOS 5

EZEK 18 · 34

LUKE 1.46–55

LUKE 4.16–30

MATT 23

REV 18

What can't be read aloud

PASSAGE	WHY IT CAN'T BE READ ALOUD
LEVITICUS 25	Land returned every fiftieth year and Israelites in debt service freed, by law. Among the most economically dangerous chapters in scripture.
DEUTERONOMY 15	Debts released every seventh year, and the freed servant sent off with provisions
DEUTERONOMY 17	Limits on the king: no hoard of horses, wives or silver, and the law copied in his own hand
NUMBERS 27	Five women petition to change inheritance law, and God rules for them
1 SAMUEL 8	God's own warning, itemized, of what a monarchy will take from you
1 KINGS 21	The state kills a man for his land by correct procedure, and a prophet calls it murder to the king's face
2 KINGS 22	Officials take a found scroll to a woman, and the whole reform proceeds on her word
AMOS 5	God refuses the festivals and calls the worship music noise while injustice goes on
EZEKIEL 18 · 34	Guilt isn't inherited, and the shepherds are indicted for feeding themselves
LUKE 1.46–55	The Magnificat. Thrones emptied and the rich sent away, sung in the past tense
LUKE 4.16–30	Release for captives, and a congregation that turns on him for naming foreigners
MATTHEW 23	A whole chapter denouncing religious leaders by title
REVELATION 18	An empire falls, and the merchants weep because their trade is ruined

CORRECTION TO THE OLD COMPANION The old list had Leviticus 25 cancelling debts. The Jubilee returns land and frees Israelites in debt service. The debt release is Deuteronomy 15, added here.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH ONE SHE FINDS FIRST

1630 | 1961 | 1989

FOR TKC

The Covenant Coalition's platform was "America was great when it was godly. Return to God. Return to greatness" (TL). **INTERPRETATION** The Coalition reads Winthrop the way later politicians did and drops his point, that a covenant people is watched and judged by its failures. **POSSIBLE** Elias's 2033 sermon quotes "choose life" and Deuteronomy 30 together.

MARGINALIA

✣ *See also:* Deep dive IV, Deuteronomy, page 13.

THE CITY ON A HILL

The Puritans who settled Massachusetts Bay in 1630 understood their colony as a community bound to God by covenant, on the model of Israel in Deuteronomy. Blessing would follow faithfulness, and judgment would follow breach. "A Model of Christian Charity" is traditionally attributed to John Winthrop and dated to 1630, given aboard or beside the Arbella. **CONTESTED** Some scholars suggest another minister wrote it, and it wasn't printed until 1838.

It says the colony "shall be as a city upon a hill," borrowing Matthew 5.14, and its point is that the whole world will watch, so failure will be public. It closes by paraphrasing Deuteronomy 30: "Therefore let us choose life." Daniel Rodgers (*As a City on a Hill*, 2018) argues the sermon was little known until the twentieth century. John F. Kennedy quoted it to the Massachusetts legislature as president-elect on January 9, 1961. Ronald Reagan made "a shining city upon a hill" a theme of his speeches and the center of his farewell address on January 11, 1989, adding the word "shining." INTERPRETATION: In Winthrop's use the image is a warning about being watched. In later political use it became a description of national greatness.

One Bible, two readings of slavery

Both sides of the American slavery debate read the same Bible and claimed it.

THE PROSLAVERY CASE	Noah's curse on Canaan, read as a curse on Africans. The permanent slavery of foreigners in Leviticus 25.44–46. Abraham's household slaves. The instructions to slaves in Ephesians 6.5, Colossians 3.22 and 1 Peter 2.18. Paul sending Onesimus back in Philemon. And the claim that Jesus never condemned slavery.
RICHARD FURMAN	After the Denmark Vesey plot in Charleston in 1822, the Baptist minister wrote an exposition, dated that December, for the South Carolina Baptist Convention defending slavery from scripture. Southern defenders used its arguments until the Civil War.
THORNTON STRINGFELLOW	A Virginia Baptist pastor who published *A Brief Examination of Scripture Testimony on the Institution of Slavery* (Richmond, 1841).
THE ABOLITIONIST ANSWER	The Golden Rule, "God made of one blood all nations" (Acts 17.26, KJV), "there is neither bond nor free" (Gal 3.28), the capital law against kidnapping a person to sell (Exod 21.16), the refusal to return runaways (Deut 23.15–16), and the exodus itself.
ANGELINA GRIMKÉ	From a South Carolina slaveholding family, she published *An Appeal to the Christian Women of the South* (1836) through the American Anti-Slavery Society and made the Bible her test.
FREDERICK DOUGLASS	Added an appendix to his *Narrative* (1845) to make clear his attacks were on "the slaveholding religion of this land," which he set against "the Christianity of Christ."

> **THE CRISIS UNDERNEATH**
>
> Mark Noll argues the war exposed a crisis in how Protestants read the Bible. Both sides held scripture to be authoritative and plain, and neither could persuade the other from it.

GEN 9.25

LEV 25.44–46

EPH 6.5

COL 3.22

1 PET 2.18

PHILEMON

FURMAN, EXPOSITION (1822)

STRINGFELLOW, BRIEF EXAMINATION (1841)

NOLL, THE CIVIL WAR AS A THEOLOGICAL CRISIS (2006)

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH PROSLAVERY ARGUMENT THE EMPIRE STILL TEACHES, UNDER A DIFFERENT NAME AND ABOUT A DIFFERENT GROUP

The churches split, and the Slave Bible

THE SPLIT	Methodists divided in 1844. The Southern Baptist Convention was founded in Augusta, Georgia, in 1845, after the national Baptist mission board refused to appoint slaveholders as missionaries. Presbyterians divided in stages, finally in 1861. In June 1995, meeting in Atlanta, the Southern Baptist Convention adopted a resolution repenting of its past racism and apologizing to African Americans.
THE 1807 "SLAVE BIBLE"	A London missionary society published *Select Parts of the Holy Bible, for the Use of the Negro Slaves, in the British West-India Islands*. According to Anthony Schmidt of the Museum of the Bible, it kept 232 of the 1,189 chapters in a standard Protestant Bible, leaving out about ninety percent of the Old Testament and about half the New. The exodus is gone. Passages that reinforce slavery, Ephesians 6.5 among them, are kept. A copy on loan from Fisk University was shown at the museum in 2018–2019. The name "Slave Bible" is modern.

Select Parts of the Holy Bible — London, 1807

FOR THE USE OF THE NEGRO SLAVES IN THE BRITISH WEST-INDIA ISLANDS

CHAPTERS KEPT	*232 of 1,189*
EXODUS	*removed*
EPHESIANS 6.5	*kept. "Servants, be obedient to them that are your masters."*
GALATIANS 3.28	*removed*

INTERPRETATION *The clearest case on record of controlling scripture without changing a word, by deciding which words are in the copy.*

ABRIDGED

SBC, AUGUSTA (1845)

SBC RESOLUTION, ATLANTA (1995)

SELECT PARTS OF THE HOLY BIBLE (LONDON, 1807)

MUSEUM OF THE BIBLE (2018–19)

NPR, DEC. 9, 2018

TKC: DOM

TKC: DOM

OPEN QUESTION

THE COPY AS DOCTRINE

FOR TKC

POSSIBLE The Book of Covenant is an abridgment on the 1807 model, the full canon on paper and a selection in practice. **OPEN QUESTION** Is it? Aurem's territory includes Georgia and South Carolina, where the Southern Baptist Convention was founded over slaveholding missionaries and apologized 150 years later (**DOM**).

WHAT THE BOOK OF COVENANT LEAVES OUT, IF IT DOES

WHO IN THE CAST OWNS A BOOK THEY SHOULDN'T, AND WHERE IT'S KEPT

The Black church

THE INVISIBLE INSTITUTION	Under slavery much Black Christian worship was what the sociologist E. Franklin Frazier called the "invisible institution," held in secret, often in woods and gullies known as hush harbors, beyond white supervision and the laws against Black gatherings. Albert Raboteau's *Slave Religion* (1978) is the standard history.
PHILADELPHIA	Richard Allen and other Black worshippers walked out of St. George's Methodist Church over segregated seating. Allen dated it to 1787, and some historians argue for 1792. He founded Mother Bethel in 1794, and in 1816 the African Methodist Episcopal Church became an independent denomination with Allen as its first bishop.
CHARLESTON	The African church that became Emanuel AME was burned by white authorities in 1822 after Denmark Vesey, one of its founders, was accused of planning a revolt. Its members worshiped in secret until 1865. On June 17, 2015, a white supremacist killed nine people at a Bible study in the same church.
WHAT GREW FROM IT	C. Eric Lincoln and Lawrence Mamiya describe seven historically Black denominations (1990). The spirituals, the exodus as the central story, the preaching tradition and the civil rights movement's base in churches, from the Southern Christian Leadership Conference in 1957 to King's last sermon, all come out of this history.

RABOTEAU, SLAVE RELIGION (1978)

FRAZIER, "INVISIBLE INSTITUTION"

MOTHER BETHEL (1794)

AME CHURCH (1816)

EMANUEL AME, CHARLESTON (1822, 2015)

LINCOLN & MAMIYA (1990)

SCLC (1957)

FOR TKC

INTERPRETATION Worship held out of sight of the authorities, in places the cameras don't reach. The Grace Bridge (**CR**) and the outer districts' kitchens (**DOM**) are the Empire's hush harbors. Douglass set "the slaveholding religion of this land" against "the Christianity of Christ," and Celeste's faith is on his side of that line. **POSSIBLE** Aurelia's outer districts remember the hush harbors, the burned church at Charleston and the walkout at St. George's, and the Temple teaches none of it.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

IS THERE A HUSH HARBOR IN SECTOR SEVEN? WHO LEADS IT, AND HAS EDEN BEEN?

Christian nationalism

CONTESTED, as a term and in its boundaries.

A DEFINITION	The sociologists Andrew Whitehead and Samuel Perry define it as "a cultural framework... that idealizes and advocates a fusion of Christianity with American civic life," and argue the "Christian" in it is more an identity than a faith.
A MEASUREMENT	A 2023 PRRI and Brookings survey built a scale from five statements about Christianity and American law and society. It classed about 10 percent of American adults as adherents and 19 percent as sympathizers, with 39 percent skeptics and 29 percent rejecters. Among white evangelical Protestants, 29 percent were adherents and 35 percent sympathizers.
THE OBJECTION	Critics, the political scientist Mark David Hall among them, argue the definitions are too broad and sweep in ordinary religious participation in politics.
THE EMBRACE	Some on the right have taken the term for themselves. Stephen Wolfe's *The Case for Christian Nationalism* (2022) argues for it openly.

WHITEHEAD & PERRY, TAKING AMERICA BACK FOR GOD (2020)

PRRI · BROOKINGS (FEB. 2023)

HALL, CHRISTIAN REFLECTIONS ON CHRISTIAN NATIONALISM

WOLFE, THE CASE FOR CHRISTIAN NATIONALISM (2022)

TKC: TL

FOR TKC

INTERPRETATION The Coalition, as the timeline describes it, megachurches, political action groups and militias running candidates at every level (TL), fits Whitehead and Perry's definition closely. It's a reading of your own invented history, and the real-world use of the term is CONTESTED.

WHO IN THE FOUNDING GENERATION READ WINTHROP, DOUGLASS AND RUSHDOONY, AND WHAT THEY TOOK FROM EACH

RUSHDOONY, INSTITUTES OF BIBLICAL LAW (1973)

BAHNSEN, THEONOMY (1977)

THEONOMY: A REFORMED CRITIQUE (1990)

DIAMOND, SPIRITUAL WARFARE (1989)

TAYLOR, THE VIOLENT TAKE IT BY FORCE (2024)

Reconstruction, dominion, seven mountains

CHRISTIAN RECONSTRUCTIONISM	R. J. Rushdoony founded the Chalcedon Foundation in 1965 and published *The Institutes of Biblical Law* in 1973, arguing that God's law in scripture, the Torah's case laws included, should be the standard for civil law. Greg Bahnsen's *Theonomy in Christian Ethics* (1977) gave the position its name, and Gary North extended it into economics. Its most distinctive claim is that the Mosaic civil penalties remain valid, and its writers listed the death penalty for offenses including adultery, homosexual acts, blasphemy and witchcraft. **CONTESTED** How consistently Rushdoony applied the penalties. Most evangelical and Reformed theologians rejected theonomy, and Westminster Seminary's faculty published a critique in 1990. Rushdoony's influence on Christian schooling and homeschooling was large and is acknowledged on both sides.
DOMINIONISM	CONTESTED, as a label. Sara Diamond described "dominion theology" in 1989, and Frederick Clarkson and others used "dominionism" for Christian Right groups that read Genesis 1.28 as a mandate for Christian control of public life. Critics call it a smear used too loosely.

Reconstruction, dominion, seven mountains, continued

RUSHDOONY, INSTITUTES OF BIBLICAL LAW (1973)

BAHNSEN, THEONOMY (1977)

THEONOMY: A REFORMED CRITIQUE (1990)

DIAMOND, SPIRITUAL WARFARE (1989)

TAYLOR, THE VIOLENT TAKE IT BY FORCE (2024)

THE SEVEN MOUNTAINS	The mandate holds that Christians are called to influence or lead seven spheres: family, religion, education, media, arts and entertainment, government and business. Proponents trace it to a 1975 meeting where Loren Cunningham and Bill Bright each received the same list, framed as evangelism. After Lance Wallnau heard it from Cunningham in 2000 and was mentored by C. Peter Wagner of the New Apostolic Reformation, it took a more political turn. Some trace it back to Abraham Kuyper's "sphere sovereignty." Matthew D. Taylor traces the movement's networks and their role on January 6, 2021, including the Appeal to Heaven flag.

FOR TKC

POSSIBLE Whoever named the Dominions held the dominionist reading of Genesis 1.28 and chose the word because of it. The Triune Rule puts three of the seven mountains, religion, government and media, into the constitution as the Temple, the Crown and the Broadcast (TL), and the founders may have thought of the Trials as taking the "family" mountain. The Covenant Court may cite theonomist arguments for Imperial penalties and quietly decline the parts of Mosaic law that would bind the Crown.

WHICH OF THE SEVEN MOUNTAINS THE EMPIRE THINKS IT HASN'T TAKEN YET

DANVERS STATEMENT (1987–88)

CBE, "MEN, WOMEN AND BIBLICAL EQUALITY" (1989)

TKC: CR · DOM

Headship, settled in 1987

DANVERS	The Council on Biblical Manhood and Womanhood drafted the complementarian Danvers Statement in Danvers, Massachusetts, in December 1987 and published it in final form in November 1988.
CHRISTIANS FOR BIBLICAL EQUALITY	Founded in 1987. It published its egalitarian statement, "Men, Women and Biblical Equality," in 1989, and it reached a wide audience in *Christianity Today* in 1990.

FOR TKC

The Temple's official theology of marriage (CR) is the Danvers position written into civil law and enforced at the counter. INFERENCE The egalitarian position has no legal standing in the Empire. OPEN QUESTION Do its arguments survive in Meridian's Reading Circles or in Heartland's theological inquiry (DOM)?

A TIMELINE, 1630 TO 2024

YEAR	EVENT
1630	Massachusetts Bay. "A city upon a hill."
1740	South Carolina bans teaching enslaved people to write
1787	The walkout at St. George's, Philadelphia
1807	The "Slave Bible," London
1816	The AME Church becomes independent
1822	Vesey. Emanuel burned. Furman's exposition.
1845	The Southern Baptist Convention, Augusta
1957	The Southern Christian Leadership Conference
1973	Rushdoony, *Institutes of Biblical Law*
1987	Danvers. Christians for Biblical Equality.
1995	The SBC apology, Atlanta
2015	Emanuel AME, Charleston
2021	January 6

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHERE MY TIMELINE STARTS TO DIVERGE, AND THE FIRST YEAR THAT ISN'T OURS

YOURS

OPEN QUESTIONS

PART IX LOG

Working Questions

1 · WHICH OF THE FIVE BIBLICAL EMPIRES DOES CELESTE COMPARE THE COVENANT EMPIRE TO, AND WHICH ONE DOES THE TEMPLE?

2 · WHAT DID ATLANTA'S BLACK CHURCHES DO BETWEEN 2033 AND 2044, AND WHAT'S LEFT OF THEM IN AURELIA?

3 · DOES THE COVENANT COURT EVER CITE LEVITICUS 20 OR DEUTERONOMY 22 IN A SENTENCE? WRITE THE CASE.

4 · WHO CHOSE THE WORD "DOMINION," AND DID THEY READ GENESIS 1.28 THE WAY DOMINIONISTS DO?

5 · IF A CHARACTER FOUND A FULL, UNABRIDGED BIBLE IN 2104, WHAT WOULD SHE READ FIRST, AND WHAT WOULD HAPPEN TO HER FOR OWNING IT?

6 · WHAT WOULD A DOUGLASS OF THE EMPIRE WRITE IN HER APPENDIX?

NOTES

ANYTHING THIS SPREAD STARTED AND DID NOT FINISH

V

PART FIVE · ✚

The Fall of the United States

About eighteen years, from a stadium sermon in 2033 to a constitution in 2051. Almost every step went through a vote, a referendum or an agreement.

i · The timeline	475
ii · How the Empire tells it	478
iii · The Restoration Act	480
iv · Living memory	482
v · Founder files	484
vi · Working questions	494

SOURCE TAGS

TL Timeline · TR Trials · TR-orig original Trials file · DOM Dominions · MEN Men in the Empire · CR Crownward · DR3 Draft Three · WR Writing Rules · FR Final Rulings · AM Audit Master · Ruling, the October 23 calibration

DECIDED CANON

Solomon is sixteen. Leah is younger than Eden. Thomas left voluntarily (**FR 3**). Celeste has no proof Miriam is alive (**FR 16**). Leah sat for an assessment.

MARGINALIA

✤ *See also:* The canon register, at the back.

THE WORLD STARTS HERE

The United States became the Covenant Empire of America over about eighteen years. It started with a stadium sermon in 2033 and ended in 2051, when the Crown, the Temple and the Broadcast were written into the constitution as the three branches of government. Almost every step went through a vote, a referendum or an agreement (**TL**). Nobody in Eden's lifetime remembers the country before. The oldest person in her cast was born around 2035, into its last few years.

From this part on, the companion is about your world, and the rules change slightly. Anything your files establish carries a source tag and no label. Everything else is labeled at the start of the sentence it governs: INFERENCE for what the files imply without saying, POSSIBLE for ideas that aren't canon, OPEN QUESTION for what you still have to decide, CONFLICT where two files disagree, SUPERSEDED where older material no longer controls, and DECIDED for a call you've made. The Final Rulings outrank everything. Where a file and a ruling disagree, the ruling wins and the page says so.

2025 TO 2051

TKC: TL · CR

YEAR	EVENT	SOURCE
2025–2031	The Fracture Years. A contested election leaves two men claiming the presidency at once. Automated labor wipes out forty percent of working-class jobs. Domestic attacks on federal buildings go uncontained, and a climate disaster makes the Gulf Coast uninhabitable. Faith in federal institutions collapses, and church attendance triples.	TL
2031	Evangelical megachurches, conservative political action groups and private militias organize as the Covenant Coalition. "America was great when it was godly. Return to God. Return to greatness." They run candidates at every level at once.	TL
2033	Elias Vane, a little-known Georgia preacher, preaches *Thy Kingdom Come* for six hours to 400,000 people at The Gathering House, the former Mercedes-Benz Stadium in Atlanta. Every Coalition network carries it live.	TL
2035	Vane wins a Senate seat from Georgia, and within eighteen months he effectively controls the legislative agenda. Celeste Parish is born about now (INFERENCE).	TL
2039	California, Oregon and New York attempt to secede. The federal government calls it treason, and a two-year standoff follows.	TL
2041	The Partition Agreement brings the three states back with "regional autonomy," dismantled about four years later. Vane's Restoration Act passes Congress narrowly, under conditions later described as coercion.	TL
2043	Vane declares the United States dissolved and reborn as the Covenant Empire of America and takes the title First Elector. The Crownward is established over Washington, D.C.	TL, CR
2044	The Dominion Act makes the states Twelve Dominions, each under a Governor-Prelate. Atlanta becomes Aurelia, seat of Aurem.	TL
2048	Elias, 52, marries Sera Callum, 28, a Vowed woman and Temple scholar. The first Anointed marriage.	TL
2051	The Triune Rule makes the Crown, the Temple and the Broadcast the three constitutional governing bodies.	TL

TKC: TL · DOM · FR 35–36 · FR 39

2054 to 2104

YEAR	EVENT	SOURCE
2054	Vane becomes Emperor by a referendum returning 94 percent approval, and founds the House of Vane.	TL
2058	The Commonwife quota system is piloted in Red Earth.	DOM
2061	Elias dies of heart failure at 65. The Temple canonizes him within the year, his face goes on the currency and his sermon becomes required curriculum. The same year, Elias's elder child, the rightful successor and Dorian's parent, is removed.	TL, FR 35–36
2062	Crest Vane takes the throne at 34. The Commonwife quotas go Empire-wide, and the Ungoverned are designated criminal.	TL
2065	The first Covenant Trials	TL
2077	Azrael Vane born	TL
2079	Judah Vane born	TL
2085	Crest dies mid-cycle. Dorian takes the throne at 40, and that year's Trial is cancelled.	TL, FR 39
2098	Azrael, 21, finds a ledger in the east wing archive	TL
2100	Azrael is declared dead. The ledger and the Covenant of Dissent vanish the same week.	TL
2104	The 39th Covenant Trial	TL

> **CONFLICT**
>
> The timeline introduces the Commonwife quotas under Crest in 2062, and the Dominions file says Red Earth piloted them in 2058. **INFERENCE** Both hold if the 2058 pilot ran under Elias in one Dominion and Crest took it Empire-wide in 2062.

THE YEAR I WANT A SCENE IN, AND WHOSE EYES IT'S THROUGH

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

THE YEAR I WANT A SCENE IN, AND WHOSE EYES IT'S THROUGH

TKC: TL · AM · FR 19

Official version, lived reality

Everyone in Eden's world learned the left column in school. Where a character sits between the two columns says a lot about who she is. The Empire's phrasing is what people would actually say aloud, so it's the version to use in dialogue (AM).

WHAT THE EMPIRE CALLS IT	WHAT HAPPENED
THE FRACTURE YEARS, WHICH GOD ENDED	Six years of overlapping disasters that a well-organized coalition was ready to inherit
THE RESTORATION	A 400-page law that made rights conditional, passed under coercion nobody had to name
REGIONAL AUTONOMY, GRANTED IN MERCY	A four-year holding pattern for three states that tried to leave, dismantled once the leverage was gone
PUBLIC MANDATE, 94 PERCENT	A referendum controlled tightly enough to produce the number it wanted
REORGANIZED FOR ACCURACY AND UNITY	The press became a branch of government
CITIZENSHIP CLARIFIED THROUGH COVENANT	A woman's legal standing became dependent on whether a man has married her
A CELEBRATION OF THE EMPIRE'S FINEST WOMEN	A televised selection producing one Anointed Wife a year, and eleven women married down the elite ladder (FR 19)
A SUDDEN MEDICAL EVENT	The phrase the Empire uses for Azrael in 2100 and for Petra in 2104

THREE LINES A SCHOOLTEACHER IN AURELIA SAYS ABOUT THE FALL, WORD FOR WORD

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

THREE LINES A SCHOOLTEACHER IN AURELIA SAYS ABOUT THE FALL, WORD FOR WORD

TKC: TL

OPEN QUESTION

The legal root

The Restoration Act is the legal root of almost everything in Eden's life. It passed Congress, so the Empire's founding argument is that nothing illegal happened (TL).

The Restoration Act

PUBLIC LAW · 2041

AUTHORED BY SENATOR ELIAS VANE OF GEORGIA · PASSED BY THE CONGRESS OF THE UNITED STATES

TITLE I · RIGHTS	*conditional on standing, compliance and designation*
TITLE II · MARRIAGE	*a legal and theological designation*
TITLE III · CITIZENSHIP	*a woman's, dependent on marital status*
TITLE IV · THE PRESS	*"reorganized for accuracy and unity"*
PREAMBLE	_____

Ten years after Title IV the same apparatus is a branch of government, and today it controls forty percent of a Covenant Daughter's score. The Binding, the Commonwife quota and the Anointed marriage all descend from Title II. Unbound is a legal category with a file because of Title III.

PASSED

OPEN QUESTION

What does the preamble say? You'll want the actual wording for any scene where a character quotes the Restoration.

DRAFT THE PREAMBLE, IN THE ACT'S OWN VOICE

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

DRAFT THE PREAMBLE, IN THE ACT'S OWN VOICE

TKC: TL · TR · DOM · FR 35–44

Grandmothers and documents

Nobody in the cast lived through the Fall as an adult. What survives comes down through grandmothers and through the House of Vane's own papers.

CELESTE PARISH · TL	About nine in 2044, she remembers the renaming of Atlanta and her own grandmother crying when they changed the signs. She watched the Empire take her mother's identity through a Commonwife marriage, then raised Miriam alone under Unbound designation rather than let it happen again. The real name of the city is the last thing she says to Eden before the Crownward. (Volume Two, Celeste.)
SERA MONTOYA'S GRANDMOTHER · TR	She was at the last protest before the Partition Agreement ended Pacific's resistance in 2041. She tells it to Sera as a warning and not a hero story: the difference between impact and loss is knowing when and how.
PACIFIC'S GENERATIONS · DOM	The people who remember trying to leave raised children who grew up with parents who'd tried and failed, and their grandchildren grew up knowing the story. The Empire still checks every Pacific girl's Designation for signs that the secession story survived in her.
ZARA VOSS'S GRANDMOTHER · TR	She has a real name the desert knows and the Empire doesn't. She raised Zara in Sable Reach and the desert beyond it.
THE HOUSE OF VANE · TL, FR 35–44	The family keeps documents instead of grandmothers' stories, and those documents are the most dangerous things in the Crownward.

Celeste, to Eden, before the Crownward

The real name of the city.

✣

Write the line she actually says on the facing page.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHAT CELESTE'S GRANDMOTHER LOST WHEN THE SIGNS CHANGED, AND WHO SHE WAS BEFORE THE FALL

TKC: TL · CR · AM

Elias Vane

c. 1996–2061 · First Elector 2043 · Emperor 2054–2061 · canonized

PORTRAIT · ELIAS VANE · THE CURRENCY LIKENESS

Founder Record

HOUSE OF VANE · I

BORN
c. 1996, Georgia (INFERENCE from his ages)

SENATE
2035

RESTORATION ACT
2041

FIRST ELECTOR
2043

EMPEROR
2054, by referendum

DIED
2061, heart failure, 65

WHAT THE FILES SAY	A little-known Georgia preacher until the 2033 sermon (TL). His face is on the currency, and *Thy Kingdom Come* is required curriculum in every Dominion school. The Temple teaches that God chose him to restore the nation and that his descendants carry the anointing forward (CR).
HIS METHOD	INTERPRETATION The old companion's reading holds. He never took anything until refusing him would cost more than giving in. He ran candidates everywhere, made himself the man every faction needed, outlasted the secession instead of winning it, and wrote the law himself (AM).

WRITING

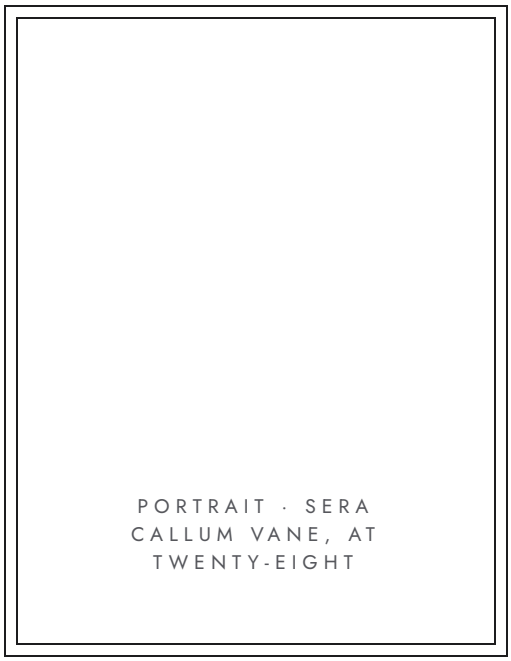
FROM THE FACING PAGE

ONE LINE OF THE 2033 SERMON EVERY SCHOOLCHILD KNOWS

TKC: TL

Sera Callum Vane

Vowed woman · Temple scholar · the first Anointed Wife, 2048



WHAT THE FILES SAY	A Vowed woman and Temple scholar who married Elias in 2048, when she was 28. She became the most powerful woman in the Empire's history while appearing entirely devoted to her husband. She wrote most of his domestic policy, and no official record says so (TL).
HER LEGACY	Her marriage is the template for the Covenant Trials.

CONFLICT

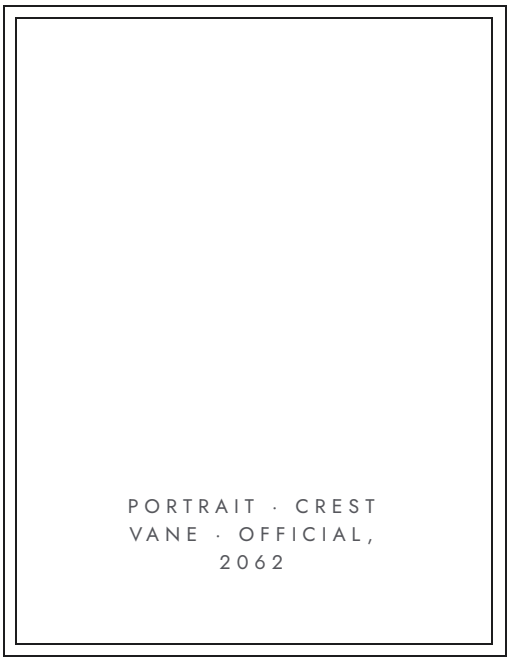
The timeline says she came from "the Northern Dominion." None of the Twelve Dominions has that name. **OPEN QUESTION** Where did she come from?

THE POLICY SHE WROTE THAT HAS HIS NAME ON IT

Crest Vane

TKC: TL · FR 35 · FR 37 · FR 39 · FR 40

Emperor 2062–2085 · Dorian's uncle (**FR 35**)



WHAT THE FILES SAY	Elias's son. He took the throne at 34, so he was born around 2028, twenty years before his father's Anointed marriage (INFERENCE). Cold and procedural. He manages people instead of inspiring them, and under him the Empire grows more efficient and more brutal (**TL**).
WHAT HE BUILT	The Commonwife quotas, the criminal category of the Ungoverned, and the Trials.

HIS CLAIM	Survivorship, not birth order (**FR 35, 39**). He knew about his elder sibling's removal, didn't arrange it and didn't prevent it (**FR 37**).
THE ONE THING HE DID	He preserved the documents, leaving them where the east wing archive would someday be inventoried (**FR 40**).

WHY CREST KEPT THE DOCUMENTS

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHY CREST KEPT THE DOCUMENTS

The removed heir and Dorian Vane

TKC: TL · FR 35–38 · FR 44 · RULING

THE REMOVED HEIR	Elias's elder child, and the rightful successor. Removed in 2061, when Dorian was still a child (**FR 35–36**). **OPEN QUESTION** What did the heir know or do that made removal necessary? The rulings cover how it happened and why Dorian was spared, and not why the heir had to go.
DORIAN VANE · EMPEROR SINCE 2085	The removed heir's son. He took the throne at 40 and is 59 in 2104 (**TL**, **Ruling**). He was spared because a child's claim can be supervised. Removing him would have needed a public reason, and raising him inside the house needed none (**FR 38**). He has known since 2061 that the documents name Elias (**FR 44**). Under him the Broadcast became genuinely sophisticated, and the Trials became the most-watched event of the year (**TL**).

PORTRAIT · DORIAN VANE, AT FORTY

NO PORTRAIT ON RECORD · THE REMOVED HEIR

SUPERSEDED The Crownward file gives Dorian's age as 61. The ruling uses 59, which matches the timeline and the Audit Master. The Crownward file also calls Crest Dorian's father. Under FR 35, Crest is his uncle.

WHAT DORIAN HAS KNOWN SINCE 2061, AND THE FIRST TIME HE ALMOST SAID IT

WRITING

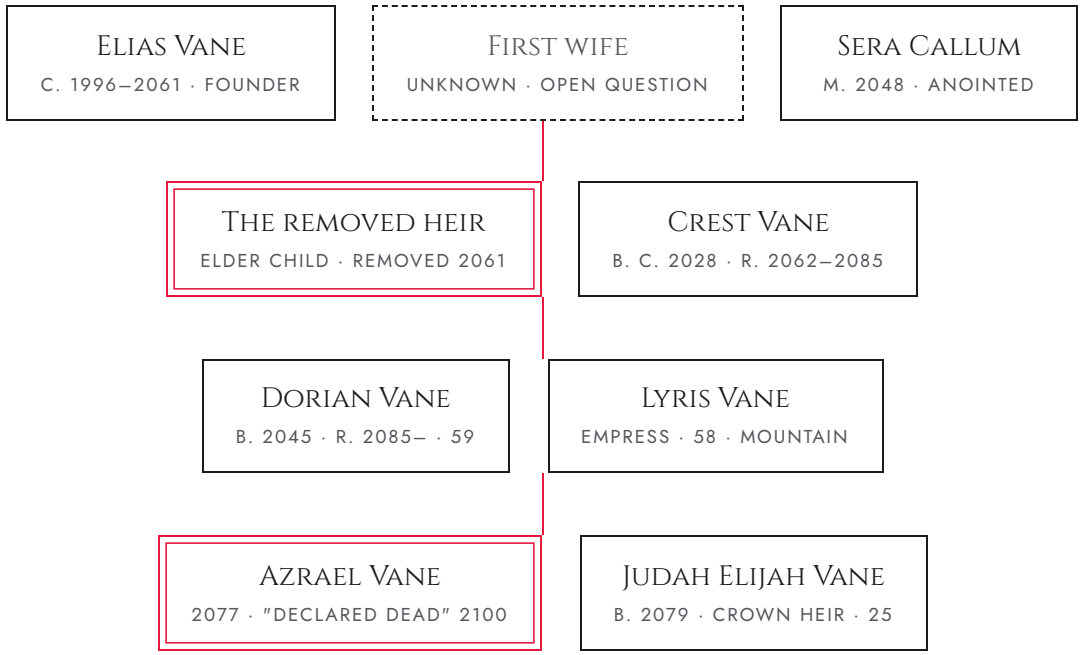
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WHAT DORIAN HAS KNOWN SINCE 2061, AND THE FIRST TIME HE ALMOST SAID IT

The family tree

TKC: TL · FR 35 · CR · WR

OPEN QUESTION



The removed heir is Dorian's parent, and Crest is Dorian's uncle (**FR 35**). **INFERENCE** Dorian's birth year follows from his age at accession. The marks show the 2061 removal and the 2100 "sudden medical event."

WHO WAS ELIAS'S FIRST WIFE, AND HOW DOES THE OFFICIAL HISTORY TREAT HER?

TKC: TL · FR 40–44

The ledger and the Covenant of Dissent

2098	During a Crown advisory access period, Azrael found a ledger in the east wing archive. It ties the Empire's founding documents to a series of deliberate removals, which the Covenant of Purpose describes as God's order and the ledger describes as something else. It had sat there unmoved since 2085, because nobody was looking (**FR 41**).
PUT IT BACK	He took it to his father, who told him to put it back. Azrael kept it and went looking for its companion, the Covenant of Dissent, which Elias wrote in the same year and the same hand, as the theological counter-argument to everything the Empire was built on.
2100	Dorian removed both documents the week Azrael was declared dead (**FR 42**). He'd told Azrael to put the ledger back because a document Azrael had read and returned would be one Dorian controlled. Destroying it would have told Azrael it mattered (**FR 43**).

East Wing Archive · Holdings Card

CATALOGUED UNTIL 2100

ITEM	*Covenant of Dissent, in the hand of E. Vane*
COMPANION ITEM	*Ledger, uncatalogued*
LAST WITHDRAWN	_____
STATUS	*missing, the week of 2100 in which A. Vane was declared dead*

WITHDRAWN

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHAT THE "DELIBERATE REMOVALS" WERE: PEOPLE, POPULATIONS, RECORDS, OR ALL THREE

YOURS

OPEN QUESTIONS

PART IX LOG

Working Questions

1 · WHAT DOES THE COVENANT OF DISSENT ARGUE, IN A SENTENCE ELIAS COULD HAVE PREACHED? WHY DID HE WRITE IT: DOUBT, INSURANCE, VANITY, OR SOMETHING ELSE?

2 · WHERE DID SERA CALLUM COME FROM, IF NOT A "NORTHERN DOMINION"?

3 · HOW DO SCHOOLS IN PACIFIC TEACH THE PARTITION, AND HOW DOES THAT DIFFER FROM WHAT PACIFIC GRANDMOTHERS SAY AT HOME?

4 · WHICH LINES FROM THE 2033 SERMON DOES EVERY SCHOOLCHILD KNOW BY HEART?

VI

PART SIX ·

Building the Empire

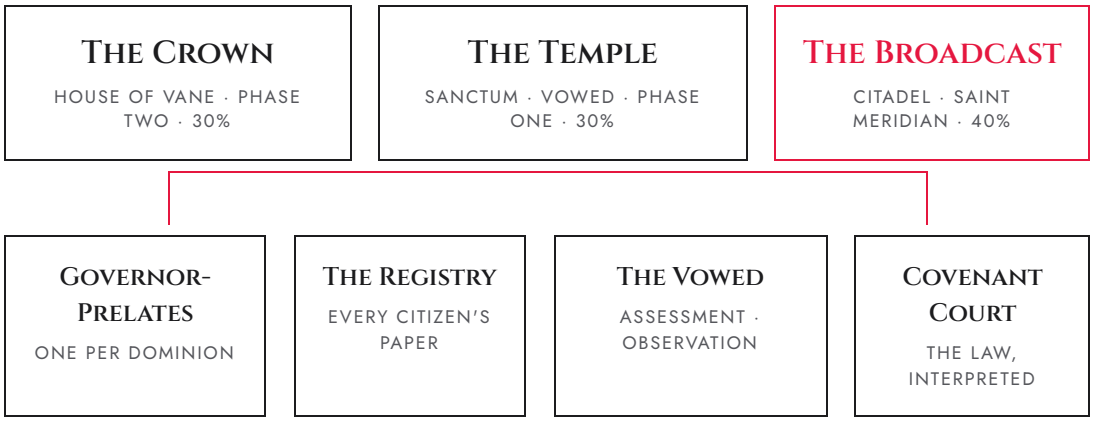
Three constitutional bodies, twelve Dominions, a Registry that holds everyone's paper, a Temple that tells each woman what she is, and the religion people practice where nobody is watching.

i · The Triune Rule	496
ii · The Crown and the House of Vane	497
iii · The Crownward	499
iv · The Temple and the Vowed	501
v · The Broadcast, the Governors, the Registry	503
vi · Men, labor and the economy	507
vii · Doctrine and lived religion	509
viii · Women, marriage and the household order	521

TKC: TL · TR · CR

Three bodies, one score

In 2051 the Crown, the Temple and the Broadcast were made the three governing bodies of the Empire. What had worked informally since 2043 became constitutional, and the Broadcast stopped being a network of Coalition media companies and became a branch of government (TL).



HOW THE TRIALS ARE SPLIT	The Temple runs Phase One and the Crown runs Phase Two. Endurance belongs to the terrain. The Covenant Score is weighted 30 percent Temple, 30 percent Crown and 40 percent Broadcast (TR).
THE SECRET	The Broadcast's share is never disclosed, because the public would be angry to learn that a broadcaster outweighs the Church in choosing the Empire's most powerful woman (TR).

WHO IN THE CAST KNOWS THE FORTY PERCENT, AND HOW THEY FOUND OUT

Four rulers, three methods

TKC: TL · AM · RULING · FR 35 · FR 39 · FR 41 · CR · MEN · WR

Every Emperor descends from Elias Vane, who founded the House in 2054 (TL). The Temple teaches that God chose Elias and that the bloodline carries the anointing forward, so the family's status is theological as well as political (CR).

RULER	YEARS	HOW HE HELD POWER	SOURCE
ELIAS VANE	First Elector 2043, Emperor 2054–2061	Belief. A preacher who made people want what he wanted.	TL, AM
CREST VANE	2062–2085	Procedure: quotas, designations, criminal categories and the Trials	TL
DORIAN VANE	2085 to now, 59 in 2104	Performance. He brought back the spectacle and made the Trials the year's biggest event.	TL, Ruling
JUDAH ELIJAH VANE	Crown Heir, 25 in 2104	He hasn't yet. He was raised by the Temple as much as by his parents.	TL

SUCCESSION	By survivorship and the absence of any other recognized claimant (FR 39). Crest inherited after his elder sibling was removed in 2061. Dorian, that sibling's son, inherited after Crest died (FR 35, 39). When Azrael was declared dead in 2100, the line passed to Judah (TL).
THE HEIR'S MARRIAGE	A matter of state. Dorian has pushed Judah toward an Anointed Wife since he turned 23, because an unmarried heir is an heir whose loyalties are still unwritten (CR). Elite men usually marry between 25 and 35. The Trials exist partly because of Judah's reluctance, to make the choice feel like an honor instead of pressure (MEN).
ADVISORY ACCESS	Young members of the House take part in "Crown advisory access periods," which is how Azrael got legitimate access to the east wing archive (TL, FR 41).
LYRIS VANE	Empress, 58, and the most sophisticated political operator in the Empire. She's spent thirty years performing perfect Anointed Wifehood while running the Crownward's domestic and diplomatic machinery, and lobbied through Dorian for a decade to shape the Anointed Wife's legal protections, framing every gain as his gift (CR). She came from Mountain Dominion (WR).

SUPERSEDED The Crownward file calls Crest Dorian's father. Under FR 35, Crest is Dorian's uncle.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

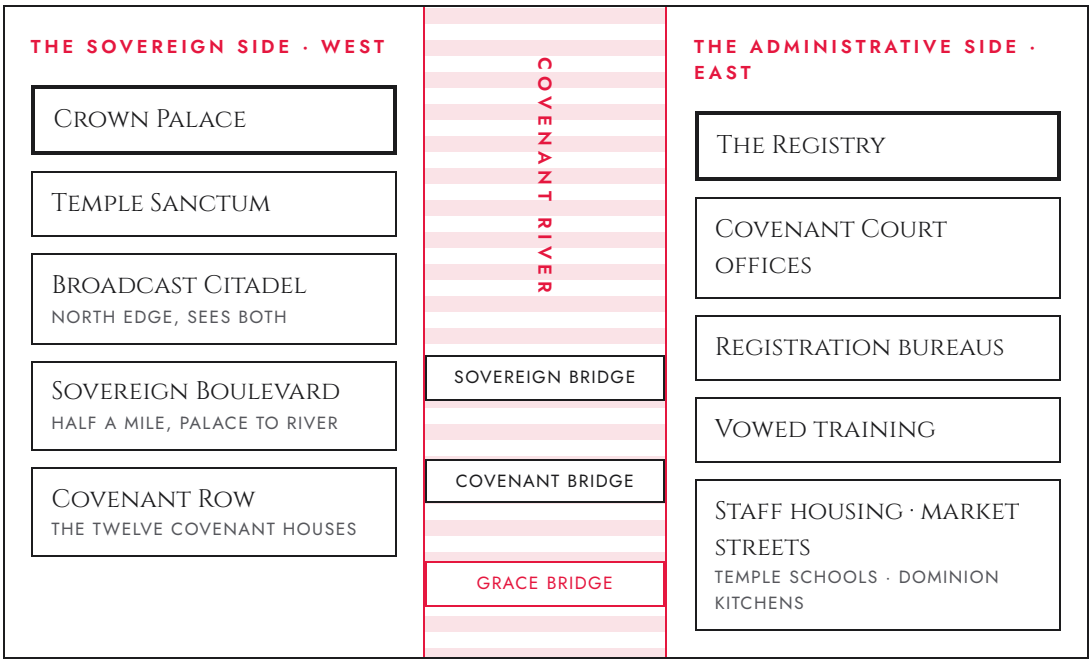
HOW DID LYRIS, A WOMAN FROM MOUNTAIN, BECOME DORIAN'S WIFE? WHAT DID THE TRIALS HAVE TO DO WITH IT?

The capital

TKC: CR

RESEARCH
ARLINGTON, VIRGINIA

The Crownward is built over Washington, D.C., formally established in 2043. Elias occupied the old capital instead of moving it, because you don't abandon the seat of the thing you claim to restore. Most people in 2104 have never seen a photograph of Washington (**CR**). The Potomac is now the Covenant River, and it divides the city.



THE BRIDGES	The Sovereign Bridge is the widest and appears on the currency. The Covenant Bridge is narrower and used by staff. The Grace Bridge is the oldest, never fully renovated, and has blind spots in Broadcast coverage, so it's where people go when they don't want to be filmed.
RESEARCH	In the real city central Washington sits on the Potomac's east bank, and the west bank is Arlington, Virginia. Read literally, the Sovereign Side stands where Arlington National Cemetery and the Pentagon are now. **POSSIBLE** Somebody in the Crownward knows the Crown Palace is built over the old national cemetery.

TKC: CR

The order nobody writes down

The Crownward has a rigid social order that nobody writes down and everybody enforces (CR).

THE HOUSE OF VANE	At the top.
THE ANOINTED COURT	About forty families whose standing is measured by how close they live to the Palace. They attend quarterly audiences with the Emperor, and the Temple High Prelates sit among them.
THE ADMINISTRATIVE CLASS	The senior staff of the Crown, Temple and Broadcast. Most of their wives hold Stewardwife designation.
THEIR DAUGHTERS	The Crownward's daughters who enter the Trials are rarely the most celebrated candidates, and they're almost always the most dangerous (CR).

WHAT SOMEONE ON THE GRACE BRIDGE CAN DO THAT THEY CAN'T DO ANYWHERE ELSE

A WALK ACROSS THE CROWNWARD, WEST TO EAST, IN EDEN'S FIRST WEEK

Ministers, Vowed and the Prelate

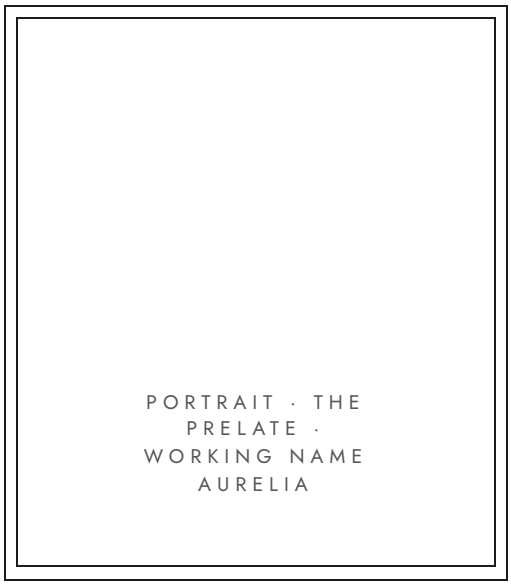
TKC: DR3 · CR · DOM · MEN · TR · TL · FR 30 · FR 33

The Temple is a church and a branch of government. In Eden's world it shows up as ministers, Vowed women and doctrine. Its scripture is read from the Book of Covenant (DR3), and the Temple Sanctum in the Crownward is its seat (CR).

MINISTERS	Senior Minister Bell is the model: a man who signs Binding certificates, sponsors Assessment candidates, and prays God will close every door not intended for a girl (DR3).
THE VOWED	Women in Temple service, who run most of the Empire's contact with women. A Vowed officer assesses every Aurem girl at eighteen (DOM). They conduct the quarterly household assessments in Aurem's Commonwife homes (MEN), run the Regional Assessments, and observe, examine and interview the Covenant Daughters (TR). In Red Earth they attend school performances as "pastoral care" (DOM).
THE CROWNWARD VOWED	The Temple's elite and the Empire's most efficient intelligence network. The Temple calls it spiritual discernment and the Crown uses it as surveillance, and it's never written down anywhere the Empire could confiscate it (CR).
LEAVING	The designation can be left through marriage. Delphine's mother went from Vowed to Bonded Wife, and Hannah was Vowed before she became House Mother (TR, FR 30). Sera Callum was Vowed when Elias married her (TL). Hannah's daughter Naomi has one year left in Vowed education (TL).

TKC: DR3 · CR · DOM · MEN · TR · TL · FR 30 · FR 33

The Prelate



THE PRELATE

She heads the Crownward's Vowed. She's 67, has served three Emperors, and knows better than anyone in the city how power actually works. She assessed Judah's spiritual formation personally. In the Trial's first week she'll reach a conclusion about Eden that she shares with no one, the Emperor included. She anoints the Crown Heir's bride (**CR**).

The files call her Prelate Naomi. FR 33 renames her so Hannah's daughter keeps the name. **POSSIBLE** Prelate Aurelia is the working name. She is never Huldah.

WHAT THE PRELATE CONCLUDES ABOUT EDEN IN THE FIRST WEEK, AND WHAT SHE DOES WITH IT

Paper and cameras

TKC: CR · DOM · TR · TL · DR3 · MEN

THE BROADCAST	State media and the third branch. Its Citadel stands in the Crownward, and its studios, where Trial scores are announced, sit in old Midtown Manhattan in Saint Meridian (**DOM**). It holds 40 percent of the Covenant Score, including "narrative priority decisions" by the Broadcast Director. It edits the Civic Debates for Dominion release and builds a story around every candidate in real time. When a candidate's intelligence becomes the story instead of her compliance, it runs the "Eve narrative," which implies and never accuses (**TR**).
GOVERNOR-PRELATES	One political and religious office per Dominion (**TL**). They choose each Covenant Daughter from the top three of the Regional Assessment, and in practice take whoever the Crown has quietly signaled it prefers (**TR**). Gulf's first lasted fourteen months. Lone's has always been born in Texas. Pacific's was appointed by Dorian. Ardenne's has mostly stopped trying to fix the marriage records from outside Ashford (**DOM**).
THE REGISTRY	On the Administrative Side. Every citizen's Imperial record: birth designations, marriage registrations, Covenant Scores, Designation results and deaths. Only the Crown Palace is guarded more heavily. Whoever controls what the Registry says about you controls something more basic than law, faith or the Broadcast, and Eden will understand this before most people in the story (**CR**).
THE COVENANT COURT	Interprets Imperial law, with offices on the Administrative Side and secondary chambers in Blessed Shore, where the law "gets interpreted, refined, and weaponized" (**CR, DOM**).
SURVEILLANCE	Cameras and screens everywhere in the seat cities. The Covenant Houses are wired in every common area but not the bedrooms, a deliberate illusion of privacy that keeps candidates manageable (**CR**). Pacific has more cameras per block than any other Dominion. Eden's file reads "Exceptional intellect. Monitor closely," later "Selected for Trial. Monitor closely" (**TL**).
THE GAPS	The Grace Bridge, the Ardenne hollows, the Sable desert, west Lone's distances, Saint Meridian's density, and the Mountain terrain where Endurance runs mostly without cameras (**CR, DOM, TR**).

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHO RUNS THE REGISTRY, AND WHO HAS EVER CHANGED WHAT IT SAYS ABOUT A PERSON

The forms

TKC: DR3 · TL · MEN · TR · CR · DOM

OPEN QUESTION

Household Return

REGISTRY FORM H-1 · AUREM

ONE COPY TO THE TEMPLE, ONE TO THE CROWN · ALL FIELDS REQUIRED

HOUSEHOLD OF	*Parish, Celeste · Unbound*
ADULT MALE AUTHORITY	*"deceased" · returned with the word circled, next adult male requested*
DEPENDENTS	_____
RECLASSIFICATION	*six years pending*
AUTHORITY, ON RESUBMISSION	*Zion Osei, eighteen*

RETURNED

THE AUTHORITY LINE	Household forms demand an adult male authority. Celeste wrote "deceased" on the line, and the form came back with the word circled and a request for the next adult male (**DR3**). Solomon's vocational form kept coming back to the house until Zion, at eighteen, declared himself the authority (**TL**, **DR3**).
RECLASSIFYING	A woman reclassifying her household under her own registration has to prove the arrangement is permanent (**TL**). Celeste's took six years.
MOVING	Moving between Dominions requires Crown authorization, technically available and practically difficult (**MEN**).
CITATIONS	Any Ungoverned citation disqualifies a woman from the Covenant Registry (**TR**). **OPEN QUESTION** What else does it do? Criminal record, designation, or both?
DEATHS	Registered within 48 hours in the Crownward and 24 in Meridian (**CR**, **DOM**).

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

A FORM FROM THE OSEI HOUSEHOLD I WANT ON THE PAGE, FIELD BY FIELD

Control by Structure

TKC: MEN · DOM · TL

The Empire controls women through designation and men through structure. Men are told they're free, and the control sits in housing, careers and marriage approvals (MEN).

CLASS	WHO THEY ARE	MARRIAGE
COMMON MEN	The labor and service class, registered to their Dominion	Expected by 21. Unmarried men past 22 stay in labor dormitories. Within caste and region.
BONDED MEN	Mid-tier administrators and skilled professionals, steered by Crown labor allocation	Between 21 and 25, from Unbound and Commonwife-eligible women, with Crown approval
COVENANT MEN	Crown officers, Temple leadership, Broadcast directors, senior military	Between 25 and 35. Their wives are Anointed.
CONSCRIPT MEN	Common boys whose scores flag them. Officially they don't exist.	Crown approval at the Covenant Man level, for life

THE IMPERIAL EDUCATION TRACK	A common boy whose Designation scores come back exceptional gets a visit from a Crown education officer within three months, offering a scholarship. The family can decline, and declining routes him to the worst labor for life. Accepting makes him Crown-adjacent for life (MEN). (Volume Two, Solomon.)
THE COVENANT DECLARATION	At 18, common men register a public statement of loyalty and readiness for service and marriage. Elite men register theirs at the end of the Track (MEN).
TWELVE ECONOMIES	Irongate manufacturing. Lone oil and space infrastructure. Mountain classified operations, extraction and military capacity. Gulf tourism, rebranded "cultural pilgrimage." Meridian law and administration. Vane the Broadcast (DOM).

INFERENCE The forty percent of working-class jobs lost to automation in the Fracture Years never came back, which is what makes Imperial service look like opportunity to a common man.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

HOW AN AUREM COMMON MAN GETS AUTHORIZATION TO MOVE, AND HOW OFTEN IT'S GRANTED

The official religion, in one line

TKC: CR · TL · DR3 · TR

Preached every week in every Temple

The husband leads, the wife supports, the household reflects divine order in miniature.

✣

THE OFFICIAL THEOLOGY OF MARRIAGE (**CR**)

THE VANE ANOINTING	God chose Elias to restore the nation, and the bloodline carries divine sanction (**CR**). Elias was canonized within a year, "not quite sainthood but close enough" (**TL**).
THE HOUSE JUDGES FAIRLY	Bell tells Celeste "The House always judges fairly," and Celeste answers "The House calls whom it calls." Before the scores Bell speaks about "divine order, talent as stewardship, and elevation as burden," and closes with "May every daughter receive with grace the portion appointed to her" (**DR3**).
THE HOUSE VIRTUES	The banners in the Aurelia Temple atrium read obedience, discernment, modesty, stewardship and endurance (**DR3**).
SELECTION AS REVELATION	The Broadcast frames the Trials as a revelation and never a competition: anointing, covenant, calling, worthy, chosen. A competition can be rigged, and a revelation can't (**TR**).
BEING BOUND AS SERVICE	"Every girl in Aurem wanted to be Bound. It was the only way they knew how to serve." Covenant Candidacy is "the closest thing a woman could get to godliness" (**DR3**).

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH VERSES ARE CARVED OVER THE DOORS OF THE AURELIA TEMPLE AND THE SANCTUM

Four documents

TKC: TL · AM · DR3

PART IV, THE SLAVE BIBLE

THY KINGDOM COME · 2033	Six hours, preached by Elias at The Gathering House. Required curriculum in every Dominion school since 2061 (TL). **INTERPRETATION** The old companion reads it as a familiar prayer taken literally in public for the first time. Nobody in the stadium heard a coup. They heard their own prayer said aloud by a man who wasn't embarrassed by it (AM).
THE COVENANT OF PURPOSE	A founding document. It describes a series of deliberate removals as God's order, and the east wing ledger describes the same removals as something else (TL). Celeste can recite it (AM).
THE COVENANT OF DISSENT	Written by Elias in the same hand and the same year, as the theological counter-argument to everything the Empire was built on. Catalogued until 2100, when it disappeared the same week as the ledger. Judah has been looking for it since before his brother's exile (TL).
THE BOOK OF COVENANT	The book Bell reads from at the Assessment. It includes Proverbs 31.29, "Many daughters have done virtuously, but thou excellest them all," in King James wording (DR3). **OPEN QUESTION** A full Protestant Bible, an abridged edition on the 1807 model, or scripture bound with the Empire's own founding texts?

PASSAGE	WHAT THE ASSESSMENT MADE OF IT (DR3)
HONOR THY FATHER AND THY MOTHER (EXOD 20.12)	A question about reporting an Unbound woman who housed her children without male authority
THE WIDOW'S OIL (2 KGS 4)	An argument for household rationing
ESTHER'S CROWN	Proof a woman could influence government, "so long as she was beautiful, obedient, and prepared to die for the privilege"
PROVERBS 31	Printed on the first page and read before the scores

Eden's read: "Facts might earn professional placement. Knowing which facts the House needed her to believe could carry her farther" (DR3).

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

THE PASSAGE OF THE COVENANT OF PURPOSE ABOUT THE REMOVALS, IN THE EMPIRE'S OWN VOICE

What people actually practice

TKC: DOM · MEN

In every Dominion people do things around the official rites that the Empire doesn't know about, tolerates because stopping them would cost too much, or eventually approves because it already lost (DOM, MEN).

DOMINION	PRACTICE	WHAT IT IS	THE EMPIRE'S POSITION
AUREM	The Salt Ceremony	The bride's mother or grandmother washes her hands in salt water the night before her Binding and tells her the truth about marriage	Doesn't know it exists
AUREM	The old way of burial	Three days, family-led, no Empire officiant: the Telling, the Feeding, the Release. Red clay packed down by family hands.	Doesn't know. The paperwork is filed anyway.
AUREM	The Speaking	The night before a boy's Declaration, each man present tells him one true thing about being a man in Aurelia. The boy can't speak.	Unregulated
AUREM	Kitchens	Recipes that "looked like submission and tasted like memory"	Never thought the kitchen worth watching
GULF	Music in worship	Live music at Bindings, against three ordinances, classed "ceremonial expression within approved parameters"	Tolerated for tourism money
GULF	The Last Free Night	The women of the family dance, drink and tell the bride the truth	Never on paper

WHICH OF THESE MY CHARACTERS HAVE DONE, SEEN OR ONLY HEARD ABOUT

TKC: DOM · MEN

What people actually practice, continued

DOMINION	PRACTICE	WHAT IT IS	THE EMPIRE'S POSITION
GULF	The Procession	At 14, girls walk the boulevard in white, and the crowd turns it into a second line	Can't be stopped without a Broadcast incident
GULF	Funerals	Three days of open house, a second line to the grave, then the Quiet, an hour of silence	Approved in 2052
ARDENNE	Hollow marriages	A community declaration and a broom jump	Records left incomplete
ARDENNE	The First Winter Work, the Sitting	A real job in the community's survival at 13 or 14. Sitting with the dead through the night.	Unregulated
MERIDIAN	Reading Circles	Officially Temple Bible studies. Actually a legal-literacy network for Stewardwives, running since 2069.	Doesn't know what they are
MERIDIAN	The record	Before his Declaration, a father walks his son through the family's complete Imperial record	Within the rules

WHICH OF THESE MY CHARACTERS HAVE DONE, SEEN OR ONLY HEARD ABOUT

What people actually practice, continued

TKC: DOM · MEN

DOMINION	PRACTICE	WHAT IT IS	THE EMPIRE'S POSITION
VANE	Ghost Marriages, the Ghost Declaration	Unions outside registration, and a boy's private statement of what he actually intends	Doesn't know they exist
IRONGATE	The Kitchen	The women's mutual aid network	Never mapped by the Vowed
IRONGATE	The Placement, the First Shift	A girl's work assessed at 14, a boy's first adult shift at 18	Unregulated
IRONGATE	Music	Blues and jazz, "morally ambiguous musical forms" since 2053	Suppressed. Survives underground.
HEARTLAND	The Anointing	The women wash and braid the bride's hair, each speaking a private word over her	"The most tender thing the Empire accidentally preserved"
HEARTLAND	Planting	After a burial the community plants something that will come back	Approved in 2058

WHICH OF THESE MY CHARACTERS HAVE DONE, SEEN OR ONLY HEARD ABOUT

TKC: DOM · MEN

WHAT PEOPLE ACTUALLY PRACTICE, CONTINUED

DOMINION	PRACTICE	WHAT IT IS	THE EMPIRE'S POSITION
RED EARTH	The Second Covenant	The morning after a Binding, a mother tells her daughter what the first covenant means and what she may keep for herself	Unrecorded, word for word across the Dominion
RED EARTH	Score coaching	For twenty years mothers have taught high-scoring sons how much ability to show	Never documented
RED EARTH	Sitting with the dead	Women sit with the body in shifts. Burial at midday.	Never understood, so never regulated
LONE	The Giving, the First Ride	The bride receives something of her grandmother's. A girl navigates a long distance alone.	Never acknowledged
LONE	Boots	The dead are buried with boots on	Approved without being understood
MOUNTAIN	The Witness Walk	A couple walks alone in the mountains before the ceremony	Unregulated

WHICH OF THESE MY CHARACTERS HAVE DONE, SEEN OR ONLY HEARD ABOUT

What people actually practice, continued

TKC: DOM · MEN

DOMINION	PRACTICE	WHAT IT IS	THE EMPIRE'S POSITION
MOUNTAIN	The name to the mountain	A death prayer said once, with the name spoken to the mountain	Unregulated
SABLE	Desert names	Every woman has two names, one for the Empire and one for the house. A girl earns hers at the Finding.	Doesn't know they exist
SABLE	The Desert Walk, fire burials	A couple's night alone in the desert. The name said once into a fire left to burn out.	Unregulated
PACIFIC	The Real Binding	A private ceremony with the promises the couple actually means	Unregistered
PACIFIC	Facing West	A boy faces the ocean at dawn, then turns back to the city. The dead are buried facing west.	Ignored until the Empire gave up in 2078

WHICH OF THESE MY CHARACTERS HAVE DONE, SEEN OR ONLY HEARD ABOUT

TKC: DOM · WR 26 · DR3 · AM

Faith that isn't performance

INFERENCE Where the files don't say how the Empire treats a practice, the column reads "Unregulated."

THE BLIND SPOT

The files don't make every believer a dupe. Heartland faith is genuine, and its women call their questions about the Commonwife designation theological inquiry and mean it (**DOM**). Ruth Gideon "believes the Empire more than Eden does," sincere without being foolish (**WR 26**). Eden's own faith is real and "required more maintenance" than Maribel Vale's (**DR3**). Celeste is the most religious person in the book and the least Imperial (**AM**). **INTERPRETATION** The Empire approves what it's already lost and tolerates what makes money. What women do in kitchens, at bedsides and the night before a wedding mostly goes unseen. Celeste's whole faith is built in that blind spot, and the novel's religious line runs between faith the Temple can use and faith that answers to something it doesn't control.

Working Questions

YOURS

OPEN QUESTIONS

PART IX LOG

1 · WHAT DOES THE COVENANT OF DISSENT ARGUE, AND WHICH LINE WOULD GET SOMEONE ARRESTED TODAY?

2 · WHAT HAPPENS TO A WOMAN CAUGHT PERFORMING A SALT CEREMONY, IF ANYONE EVER HAS BEEN? HAS EDEN ATTENDED ONE?

3 · WHAT DID THE MEN TELL ZION AT HIS SPEAKING? ONE LINE EDEN WILL NEVER HEAR.

4 · IS THERE AN AUREM EQUIVALENT OF THE READING CIRCLES OR THE KITCHEN, A NETWORK CELESTE BELONGS TO?

5 · WHAT HYMNS DOES THE TEMPLE APPROVE, AND WHAT DO THE OUTER DISTRICTS SING INSTEAD?

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

6 · WHAT DOES A HEARTLAND WOMAN'S THEOLOGICAL INQUIRY INTO THE COMMONWIFE DESIGNATION ACTUALLY ARGUE? THIS MATTERS FOR RUTH.

What each woman is

TKC: CR · MEN · FR 1 · FR 19 · TR · DOM · TL

Since the Restoration Act of 2041, a woman's citizenship has depended on her marital status (**TL**). The Empire controls women by telling each one what she is and making that classification the frame of her whole life (**MEN**).

Anointed Wife
WIFE OF A COVENANT MAN · THE TRIALS' PRODUCT · LOST AT WIDOWHOOD

Stewardwife
THE ADMINISTRATIVE CLASS

Bonded Wife
WIFE OF A BONDED MAN (INFERENCE)

Commonwife
A REGISTRATION STATUS (FR 1) · QUOTAS · TEMPLE REVIEW

Vowed
TEMPLE SERVICE · LEFT BY MARRIAGE

Unbound
UNMARRIED · "DIFFICULT AND SURVEILLED"

Ungoverned
OUTSIDE THE SYSTEM · CRIMINAL SINCE 2062

TKC: CR · MEN · FR 1 · FR 19 · TR · DOM · TL

What each woman is, continued

THE WIDOWED COVENANT	Because the designation belongs to the marriage, an Anointed widow holds a temporary status for two years that keeps most protections. She's expected to remarry within the class or drop to Stewardwife. The senior Anointed Wives run a network so efficient that no widow has ever fallen below Stewardwife (CR).
THE SIX	INFERENCE Older notes describe a six-tier caste system. Leaving out the Ungoverned, the six are Anointed, Stewardwife, Bonded, Commonwife, Vowed and Unbound. OPEN QUESTION Is that the six, what's the official order, and where does Vowed rank?

CAN A WOMAN MOVE UP, OR ONLY DOWN? WHERE EACH DOOR LOCKS

Designation

TKC: DOM · DR3 · DECIDED

Every girl is assessed and given an initial classification. In Aurem it happens at eighteen, by a Vowed officer, testing literacy, theological knowledge and "domestic aptitude." The result is the Unbound track or the elevated track, which means better education and a chance at Covenant Daughter consideration (**DOM**).

DOMINION	WHEN AND HOW
AUREM	At 18, by a Vowed officer
GULF	At 14, the Procession
ARDENNE	Standard in Ashford. Hollow children tested when they can be brought in.
MERIDIAN	Three-day sessions: theology, written reasoning, policy, "relational compliance"
VANE	At 16, the Broadcast Assessment, partly filmed
IRONGATE	At 14 the Placement, at 18 Imperial Designation
HEARTLAND	At 13, the First Covenant, where her track is set in public
RED EARTH	At 18, two weeks in Temple spaces, Crown facilities and "domestic simulation environments"
LONE	At 16 in Covenant Basin. The First Ride outside it.
MOUNTAIN	At 16, with a physical assessment. Girls chosen for classified Vowed service disappear from public life.
SABLE	At 18 in Sable Reach. The Finding outside it.
PACIFIC	At 18. Every score reviewed in the Crownward for signs of inherited resistance.

THE AURELIA BOARD	Administration, Education, Domestic Service, Housekeeping, Food Service, Binding Recommendation and Remedial Instruction. Strong doctrine can lead to Temple Administration, strong household judgment to a Binding recommendation, and girls who test well everywhere to professional placement (**DR3**).
LEAH	**DECIDED** Leah sat for an assessment. Bell offered to nominate her "for Home Instruction the following year" as a consolation (**DR3**). **OPEN QUESTION** What is Home Instruction?

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

LEAH'S ASSESSMENT DAY, FROM HER SIDE

Marriage as designation

TKC: TL · DOM · DR3 · CR · AM

The Binding is marriage as a legal and theological designation (**TL**). In Aurem it's held in a Temple, witnessed by a Vowed officiant, and registered with the Crown and the Temple at once. The bride wears white and gold and takes a surname hyphenated with her husband's. Ministers sign Binding certificates beneath each husband's name (**DR3**).

The Aurem Binding

Nobody asks if she consents. They ask if she is worthy. The correct answer is yes.

✣

DOM

ACROSS THE DOMINIONS	Meridian's is the most legally elaborate, with registration that can take three weeks. Red Earth's is the most surveilled, with Vowed witnesses at every one. Mountain adds Crown officers. Sable Reach binds at dawn. Gulf keeps its music. In the Crownward a Commonwife Binding is a short registration at the Crown office, and an Administrative Class Binding is recorded for the Broadcast (**DOM**, **CR**).
THE IMPERIAL BINDING	Seven public stages: the Declaration, Covenant Week, the Anointing (a private ceremony on the sixth day in which the Prelate anoints the bride), the Binding Night, the Grand Binding (four hours in the Sanctum), the Procession down Sovereign Boulevard, and the Private Supper, five guests at most. The bride's vows are twice as long as the heir's. The Empire calls that theology. In practice it's a legal document spoken aloud in a sacred building (**CR**).
NAMES	**OPEN QUESTION** Does the hyphenated surname apply only in Aurem? Celeste never took a Binding name, so she's still a Parish (**AM**). Miriam's would be something like Parish-Osei.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHAT AN AUREM BRIDE ACTUALLY SAYS WHEN SHE'S ASKED IF SHE'S WORTHY

Two ends of the ladder

TKC: DOM · TL · MEN · FR 0 · FR 3 · FR 16 · FR 19 · FR 28 · CR · TR

COMMONWIFE MARRIAGE	How the Empire marries off the labor class. Aurem has the highest Commonwife rate, because the Empire made marriage look like the highest honor available there (**DOM**). A Commonwife is expected to conceive within the Covenant timeline. A Vowed officer conducts quarterly household assessments, and two years without a pregnancy brings informal comments first and then Temple review (**MEN, TL**). (Volume Two, Leah.)
REASSIGNMENT	When a husband abandons his Commonwife, she can be reassigned to another man's household. It happened to Miriam after Thomas left (**FR 0**). Thomas left voluntarily (**FR 3**). Celeste has no proof Miriam is alive (**FR 16**). **OPEN QUESTION** Who decides it, what is her status during it, and why did Solomon keep the Osei name?
ANOINTED WIVES	All thirty-nine Trials place Anointed wives, and the Crown contest is a layer on top. One woman goes to the heir, the other eleven are married down the elite ladder, and nobody goes home unassigned (**FR 19**). The husbands are chosen by the oversight committee and ranked by standing. A man can't reject the woman assigned to him, but he can decline the assignment altogether, which removes him from the ladder. It has happened twice (**FR 28**).
THE ARRANGEMENT	Among the Anointed Court, male headship is mostly performance. Wives manage the information, relationships and social intelligence that make their husbands' positions work, and surface the right idea in private so the husband can present it in public. They never take credit or contradict him in public. New Anointed Wives learn it in the first year. Lyris runs the whole network, inherited from the Anointed Wife who mentored her. Celeste told Eden about the Arrangement before she left Aurem (**CR**).

INFERENCE Ladies in Waiting, the third- and fourth-place finishers, stay in the Crownward in supporting roles (**TR**). Under FR 19 they'd also be married into elite households. Both hold if they're placed in Crownward households and serve the Anointed Wife too.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHO THE TWO MEN WERE WHO DECLINED THEIR ASSIGNMENTS, AND WHAT HAPPENED TO THEM

Unbound, Ungoverned, and four households

TKC: TL · DR3 · FR 31 · FR 32 · DOM

UNBOUND	"Difficult and surveilled" (TL). An Unbound woman can head a household only through reclassification, and household paperwork still demands an adult male authority.
CHILDREN	The Empire classifies children by household registration, not parentage or appearance (FR 32). Hannah's daughter Naomi is eligible through Hannah's household and standing, whatever her father's status (FR 31).
THE UNGOVERNED	Women who chose exile over designation. Their deepest roots are in the Ardenne hollows, where some communities have lived outside the system for two or three generations. The Empire calls them criminals, and the mountain people call them something closer to saints. Crossings happen through the Sable desert. Lone interprets "Ungoverned" loosely and never files a full report. Saint Meridian has the largest population of sympathizers, people inside the system who leave gaps in it on purpose (DOM).

	CELESTE'S	LEAH'S	HANNAH'S	AN ANOINTED HOUSEHOLD
On the paper	Unbound, reclassified. A young man on the authority line.	Commonwife	A former Vowed woman's	Covenant man, Anointed Wife
Who decides				
What's assessed				
What's hidden				

POSSIBLE Each one is a different answer to the same law.

YOURS

OPEN QUESTIONS

PART IX LOG

Working Questions

1 · WHAT EXACTLY IS THE COVENANT TIMELINE FOR CONCEPTION, AND WHAT HAPPENS AFTER TEMPLE REVIEW?

2 · HOW DOES COMMONWIFE REASSIGNMENT WORK, AND WHO IN AURELIA DECIDES IT?

3 · WHAT CAN AN UNBOUND WOMAN LEGALLY OWN, SIGN OR INHERIT?

4 · WHAT HAPPENS TO A WOMAN'S DESIGNATION IF HER HUSBAND IS CONVICTED, OR DECLARED UNGOVERNED?

5 · WHAT DO THE SENIOR ANOINTED WIVES DO FOR A WIDOW IN THOSE TWO YEARS?

6 · HOW DOES A GIRL IN THE ARDENNE HOLLOWS END UP UNGOVERNED INSTEAD OF DESIGNATED, AND DOES ANYONE EVER GO BACK?

NOTES

ANYTHING THIS SPREAD STARTED AND DID NOT FINISH

VII

PART SEVEN · ◈

The Twelve Dominions

The Dominion Act of 2044 reorganized the states into twelve Dominions by region and economic function. Each has a seat city renamed from an American one, a Governor-Prelate, and a culture that's sometimes Imperial on the surface and sometimes all the way through.

1 · Aurem · Aurelia 536

2 · Gulf · Port Seraphine 538

3 · Ardenne · Ashford 540

4 · Meridian · Blessed Shore 542

5 · Vane · Saint Meridian 544

6 · Irongate · Iron Benediction 545

7 · Heartland · Providence Cross 547

8 · Red Earth · Canaan's Gate 548

9 · Lone · Covenant Basin 550

10 · Mountain · Crestfall 551

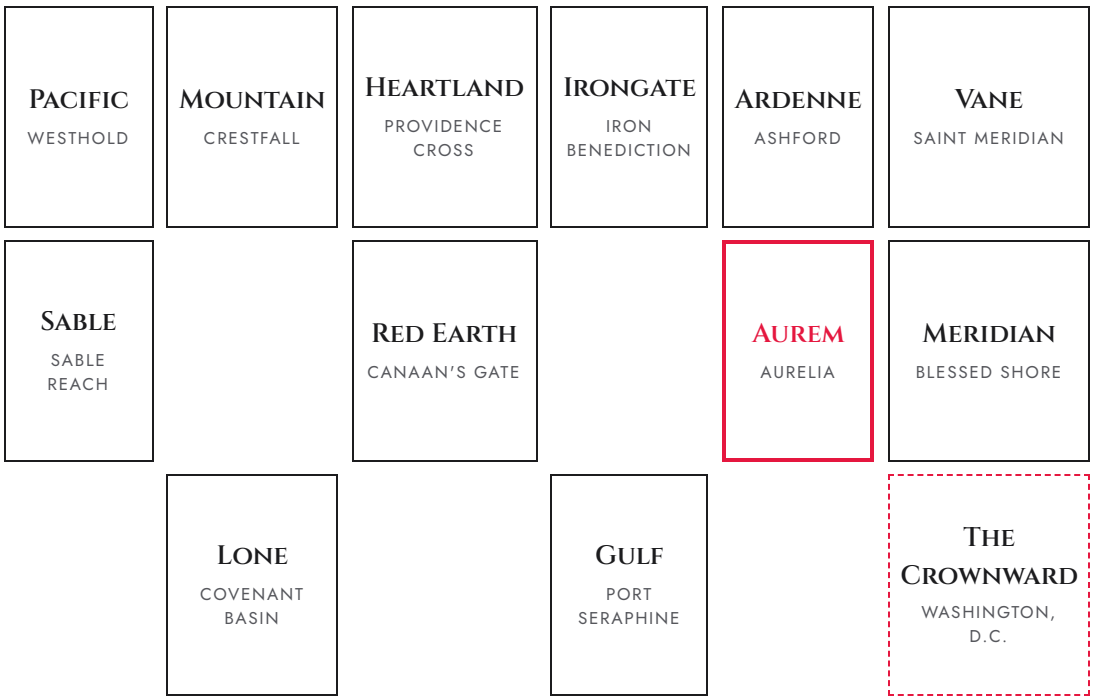
11 · Sable · Sable Reach 553

TKC: TL · DOM

OPEN QUESTION

Twelve Dominions over the old map

A schematic, west to east. The borders roughly follow the old state lines but not exactly, since some states were absorbed and some were split (TL).



INFERENCE Mississippi, Kansas, Missouri, Louisiana, New Mexico, Nevada and Utah each show up in two Dominions, which fits "some states split." OPEN QUESTION: Washington, Alaska and Hawaii don't appear in any Dominion. Inside Pacific, outside the Empire, or something else?

WHERE WASHINGTON, ALASKA AND HAWAII ARE

Seats and records

TKC: DOM · TR

DOMINION	SEAT (FORMERLY)	TERRITORY	IN THE TRIALS
AUREM	Aurelia (Atlanta)	Georgia, Alabama, Mississippi, Tennessee, South Carolina, North Carolina	15 Anointed Wives in 38 Trials, the most of any Dominion
GULF	Port Seraphine (New Orleans)	Louisiana, the Mississippi Gulf Coast, Florida	Historically penalized for warmth
ARDENNE	Ashford (Charleston, West Virginia)	West Virginia, Virginia, Kentucky, Appalachia	Rarely produces Covenant Daughters
MERIDIAN	Blessed Shore (Philadelphia)	Pennsylvania, Maryland, New Jersey, Delaware	Extremely prepared candidates
VANE	Saint Meridian (New York City)	New York and New England	The legacy Dominion, with the most Anointed Wives after Aurem
IRONGATE	Iron Benediction (Chicago)	Illinois, Indiana, Ohio, Michigan, Wisconsin	Almost always administrative daughters
HEARTLAND	Providence Cross (Kansas City)	Missouri, Kansas, Iowa, Nebraska, Minnesota, the Dakotas	The most theologically fluent
RED EARTH	Canaan's Gate (Oklahoma City)	Oklahoma, Arkansas, eastern Kansas, southwestern Missouri	Often scored mid-pack until it's too late
LONE	Covenant Basin (Houston)	Texas, New Mexico, western Louisiana	Pragmatic about the outcome
MOUNTAIN	Crestfall (Denver)	Colorado, Wyoming, Montana, Idaho, parts of Utah and Nevada	Has never produced an Anointed Wife
SABLE	Sable Reach (Phoenix)	Arizona, Nevada, New Mexico, parts of Utah	"Two Sable women are worth five from anywhere else"
PACIFIC	Westhold (Los Angeles)	California, Oregon, parts of Nevada	Watched before they arrive

Source for this part: DOM, unless tagged otherwise.

TKC: DOM · TR · TL

SEAT: AURELIA

FORMERLY ATLANTA

Aurem

Aurelia, formerly Atlanta · Georgia, Alabama, Mississippi, Tennessee, South Carolina, North Carolina

SEAL OF AUREM · DRAW OR PASTE

IN THE TRIALS	15 Anointed Wives in 38 Trials, the most of any Dominion
DESIGNATION	At 18, by a Vowed officer
39TH COVENANT DAUGHTER	Eden Selah Osei · Aurelia · 21

Atlanta had Black wealth, Black culture, Black education and Black memory built so deep into the city that the Coalition couldn't flatten it without admitting what it was erasing. So the Empire dressed it up and called it restoration. The BeltLine became a ceremonial promenade lined with statues and Broadcast screens. Historic neighborhoods became Stewardwife districts, and Peachtree Street became Covenant Way. Magnolias were planted everywhere because they photograph well and rot slowly. Aurelia is the Empire's favorite mirror, Atlanta wearing somebody else's clothes, and the most surveilled and showcased territory in the Empire (TL).

It's humid from May through October. Storms leave the streets smelling of pine and wet concrete, and the red clay keeps bleeding through the paving. Black culture went deepest underground here and survived most stubbornly. Imperial hymns play on Covenant Way, and something else plays in the outer districts. Food is the main vessel of memory, and the Empire never thought the kitchen was dangerous enough to watch.

Aurem has the highest Commonwife rate and the most elaborate marriage ceremonies in the Empire, on purpose. Its Covenant Daughter gets forty-seven seconds on Sovereign Boulevard in the Opening Procession, more than anyone else, and every girl in Aurem knows that number before she can read. An Aurem candidate is expected to win. Death is the place where "the Empire lost completely and still has no idea."

RITES THE EMPIRE DOESN'T RUN

The Salt Ceremony · the old way of burial (the Telling, the Feeding, the Release) · the Speaking · kitchens

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHAT THE FORTY-SEVEN SECONDS ACTUALLY SHOW, EVERY YEAR

TKC: DOM · TR · TL

SEAT: PORT SERAPHINE

FORMERLY NEW ORLEANS

GULF

Port Seraphine, formerly New Orleans · Louisiana, the Mississippi Gulf Coast, Florida

SEAL OF GULF · DRAW OR PASTE

IN THE TRIALS	Historically penalized for warmth
DESIGNATION	At 14, the Procession
39TH COVENANT DAUGHTER	Delphine Fontenot · Port Seraphine · 22

New Orleans was never going to be easy. The first Governor-Prelate lasted fourteen months and reported the city "resistant to spiritual reorientation." The Empire settled for managing it. Port Seraphine is loyal enough for the Broadcast and layered enough underground that the Vowed have learned to look away. Hurricane season takes half the year, and the city is "built on water and spite."

Gulf is the most culturally intact Dominion. Music survived here, standing in plain sight, because tourism, rebranded as "cultural pilgrimage," earns too much to lose. Gulf candidates arrive fluent in being watched, and the scoring system has historically penalized them for warmth, which Crown advisors read as performance. A Gulf woman who knows the gap between what she shows and what she keeps is one of the most dangerous women in the room.

RITES THE EMPIRE DOESN'T RUN

Music at Bindings · the Last Free Night · the Procession · three-day funerals and the Quiet

WHAT HAPPENED THE YEAR THE EMPIRE TRIED AND FAILED TO STOP THE MUSIC

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHAT HAPPENED THE YEAR THE EMPIRE TRIED AND FAILED TO STOP THE MUSIC

TKC: DOM · TR · TL

SEAT: ASHFORD

FORMERLY CHARLESTON, WEST VIRGINIA

Ardenne

Ashford, formerly Charleston, West Virginia · West Virginia, Virginia, Kentucky, Appalachia

SEAL OF ARDENNE · DRAW OR PASTE

IN THE TRIALS	Rarely produces Covenant Daughters
DESIGNATION	Standard in Ashford. Hollow children tested when they can be brought in.
39TH COVENANT DAUGHTER	Maren Cole · Ashford · 23

Appalachia was never fully inside America's idea of itself, and it isn't fully inside the Empire's. Ashford is the city the Empire keeps as proof that Ardenne is pacified, and everything past the tree line says otherwise. It has real winters, hollows that cut communities off from each other and from surveillance, and fog thick enough to hide the next house.

The Ungoverned have their deepest roots here. Outer Ardenne children who get assessed score extraordinarily well, since children raised to solve real problems do well on problem-solving tests. Ardenne rarely sends a Covenant Daughter, and when it does she's usually from Ashford and quiet about the gap. Its Governor-Prelate has mostly stopped trying to fix the marriage records from outside Ashford.

RITES THE EMPIRE DOESN'T RUN

Hollow marriages and the broom · the First Winter Work · the Sitting

WHO LEADS THE UNGOVERNED IN THE HOLLOWS, AND WHAT THEY KNOW ABOUT THE CROWNWARD

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHO LEADS THE UNGOVERNED IN THE HOLLOWS, AND WHAT THEY KNOW ABOUT THE CROWNWARD

TKC: DOM · TR · TL

SEAT: BLESSED SHORE

FORMERLY PHILADELPHIA

Meridian

Blessed Shore, formerly Philadelphia · Pennsylvania, Maryland, New Jersey, Delaware



IN THE TRIALS	Extremely prepared candidates
DESIGNATION	Three-day sessions: theology, written reasoning, policy, "relational compliance"
39TH COVENANT DAUGHTER	Corinne Vale · Blessed Shore · 22

The Empire took Philadelphia for its symbolism. The city that held the Declaration of Independence now holds the legal architecture of everything the Declaration claimed to prevent. Blessed Shore houses the Covenant Court's secondary chambers, where the law "gets interpreted, refined, and weaponized."

Meridian absorbed Imperial culture more completely than almost anywhere, because its administrators trust process. Its underground is made of lawyers and bureaucrats filing precise challenges that go nowhere and documenting them for a future someone is preparing. Stewardwives here are expert readers of Binding contracts, trained in Reading Circles. Meridian candidates know every rule and where the gaps are, which makes one who decides to move almost impossible to stop.

RITES THE EMPIRE DOESN'T RUN

Reading Circles, since 2069 · a father walks his son through the family record

WHAT THE READING CIRCLES HAVE DOCUMENTED, AND FOR WHOM

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHAT THE READING CIRCLES HAVE DOCUMENTED, AND FOR WHOM

TKC: DOM · TR · TL

SEAT: SAINT MERIDIAN

FORMERLY NEW YORK CITY

Vane

Saint Meridian, formerly New York City · New York and New England

SEAL OF VANE · DRAW OR PASTE

IN THE TRIALS	The legacy Dominion, with the most Anointed Wives after Aurem
DESIGNATION	At 16, the Broadcast Assessment, partly filmed
39TH COVENANT DAUGHTER	Calla Merritt · Saint Meridian · 21

New York was the hardest cultural conquest and the one the Empire brags about most. It named the whole Dominion after its founding Emperor, which is both honor and leash. Saint Meridian is the Broadcast capital, and the studios that announce Trial scores sit in old Midtown. The skyline stayed, and everything underneath it changed.

The city's density makes surveillance both total and porous, and it has the largest Ungoverned-sympathizer population of any seat city. Vane is the legacy Dominion. Some families have sent Covenant Daughters to three consecutive Trials, and high-scoring girls are prepared for candidacy from the time they can read.

RITES THE EMPIRE DOESN'T RUN

Ghost Marriages · the Ghost Declaration

WHICH FAMILIES HAVE SENT DAUGHTERS TO THREE TRIALS RUNNING, AND WHAT IT COST THEM

Irongate

Iron Benediction, formerly Chicago · Illinois, Indiana, Ohio, Michigan, Wisconsin

SEAL OF IRONGATE · DRAW OR PASTE

IN THE TRIALS	Almost always administrative daughters
DESIGNATION	At 14 the Placement, at 18 Imperial Designation
39TH COVENANT DAUGHTER	Nadia Orin · Iron Benediction · 20

Chicago gave the Empire industry and political machinery, which it kept, and music, which it tried to dismantle. Blues and jazz were labeled "morally ambiguous musical forms" in 2053 and went underground. Iron Benediction is the manufacturing heart of the Empire.

Irongate is the most class-divided Dominion, and its labor and administrative districts might as well be different civilizations. The labor-district women run a mutual aid network called the Kitchen that the Vowed have never mapped. Covenant Daughters are almost always administrative daughters, because selection rewards polish and polish costs money. Nadia Orin is the exception, the most working-class Covenant Daughter in Trial history (TR).

RITES THE EMPIRE DOESN'T RUN

The Kitchen · the Placement · the First Shift · blues and jazz underground

HOW NADIA GOT THROUGH A SELECTION BUILT FOR POLISH

TKC: DOM · TR · TL

SEAT: IRON BENEDICTION

FORMERLY CHICAGO

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

HOW NADIA GOT THROUGH A SELECTION BUILT FOR POLISH

Heartland

TKC: DOM · TR · TL

SEAT: PROVIDENCE CROSS

FORMERLY KANSAS CITY

Providence Cross, formerly Kansas City · Missouri, Kansas, Iowa, Nebraska, Minnesota, the Dakotas

SEAL OF HEARTLAND · DRAW OR PASTE

IN THE TRIALS	The most theologically fluent
DESIGNATION	At 13, the First Covenant, where her track is set in public
39TH COVENANT DAUGHTER	Ruth Gideon · Providence Cross · 22

The Heartland didn't need conquering, because the Coalition had been building here for decades. Providence Cross is the most genuinely loyal seat city in the Empire. People sing the hymns because they mean them.

The sincerity is the Empire's most valuable asset and one of its hardest to control, because real believers have opinions about what faithfulness requires. Some of the Empire's most serious theological debates happen here, including Heartland women's "theological inquiry" into the Commonwife designation. Heartland sends the most theologically fluent Covenant Daughters, for whom devotion is both credential and liability.

RITES THE EMPIRE DOESN'T RUN

The Anointing, hair washed and braided · planting after a burial

WHAT RUTH BELIEVES THAT THE EMPIRE WOULD RATHER SHE DIDN'T

TKC: DOM · TR · TL

SEAT: CANAAN'S GATE

FORMERLY OKLAHOMA CITY

Red Earth

Canaan's Gate, formerly Oklahoma City · Oklahoma, Arkansas, eastern Kansas, southwestern Missouri

SEAL OF RED EARTH · DRAW OR PASTE

IN THE TRIALS	Often scored mid-pack until it's too late
DESIGNATION	At 18, two weeks in Temple spaces, Crown facilities and "domestic simulation environments"
39TH COVENANT DAUGHTER	Delia Cross · Canaan's Gate · 24

Oklahoma's history of land taken and people removed came before the Empire. Canaan's Gate is built over a city that survived the 1995 bombing, and the Empire likes that resilience story. Red Earth piloted the Commonwife quota in 2058, and its women have lived under the full version longest.

It's the most visibly religious Dominion in its architecture and the most privately exhausted, with scripture on every building and the Vowed embedded as "pastoral care." Under the performance runs a language of small signals refined over decades. Red Earth candidates are the best in the Empire at performing compliance while thinking something else. Delia Cross's family was transferred there from Aurem when she was six, and she carries a grudge against the Dominion she left (TR).

RITES THE EMPIRE DOESN'T RUN

The Second Covenant · score coaching · sitting with the dead

THREE OF THE SMALL SIGNALS, AND WHAT EACH ONE MEANS

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

THREE OF THE SMALL SIGNALS, AND WHAT EACH ONE MEANS

TKC: DOM · TR · TL

SEAT: COVENANT BASIN

FORMERLY HOUSTON

Lone

Covenant Basin, formerly Houston · Texas, New Mexico, western Louisiana

SEAL OF LONE · DRAW OR PASTE

IN THE TRIALS	Pragmatic about the outcome
DESIGNATION	At 16 in Covenant Basin. The First Ride outside it.
39TH COVENANT DAUGHTER	Vivienne Hale · Covenant Basin · 23

Texas negotiated its surrender. The Empire got the territory and Texas kept the attitude. Covenant Basin runs on oil wealth and space infrastructure. Its Governor-Prelate is always Texas-born and has more independence than any other.

The distances leave real gaps in the surveillance grid, so west Lone is managed through local Vowed officers. People here perform loyalty loudly and then do what they were going to do anyway, and outer-territory women have a practical autonomy that would get them flagged in Aurem. Lone interprets "Ungoverned" loosely and never files a full report. It treats the Trials like any other Imperial requirement.

RITES THE EMPIRE DOESN'T RUN

The Giving · the First Ride · burial in boots

WHAT A WEST LONE WOMAN CAN DO THAT WOULD GET HER FLAGGED IN AUREM

Mountain

Crestfall, formerly Denver · Colorado, Wyoming, Montana, Idaho, parts of Utah and Nevada

SEAL OF MOUNTAIN · DRAW OR PASTE

IN THE TRIALS	Has never produced an Anointed Wife
DESIGNATION	At 16, with a physical assessment
39TH COVENANT DAUGHTER	Petra Solano · Crestfall · 22

The Empire wanted the mountains for what's inside them: minerals, military installations, elevation and secrecy. Crestfall is the face, and the mountains are the truth. The classified operations there are the Empire's least documented and most important work: surveillance technology, resource extraction, Temple expansion funding and military capacity.

Crestfall women are the most physically capable in the Empire and among the most watched. Girls selected at Designation for classified Vowed service disappear from public life. Endurance was held in Mountain terrain for Trials 1 through 31, moved to a controlled facility for 32 through 38, and returned for the 39th without explanation. Azrael is hidden here, in a community whose patriarch owes the Vanes a debt (TL). Lyris is from Mountain too (WR).

RITES THE EMPIRE DOESN'T RUN

The Witness Walk · the name spoken to the mountain

WHAT DEBT THE PATRIARCH OWES THE VANES, AND FROM WHEN

TKC: DOM · TR · TL

SEAT: CRESTFALL

FORMERLY DENVER

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHAT DEBT THE PATRIARCH OWES THE VANES, AND FROM WHEN

SABLE

Sable Reach, formerly Phoenix · Arizona, Nevada, New Mexico, parts of Utah

SEAL OF SABLE · DRAW OR PASTE

IN THE TRIALS	"Two Sable women are worth five from anywhere else"
DESIGNATION	At 18 in Sable Reach. The Finding outside it.
39TH COVENANT DAUGHTER	Zara Voss · Sable Reach · 21 · desert name Tazaleh

The desert resists the Empire the way deserts resist everything, by not caring. Heat destroys equipment, sand gets into everything, and the distances defeat centralized monitoring. Sable Reach is the ornate Imperial city the Empire keeps as proof it can reach hard country. The desert beyond it is where Ungoverned crossings happen.

The desert held civilizations long before the United States, and the Empire renamed the cities but not the land. Women in the outer communities carry plant and land knowledge the Empire has never catalogued. Every Sable woman has two names, one for the Empire and one for the house. Zara Voss's desert name is Tazaleh (TL, TR). INTERPRETATION Sable's two-name custom and Celeste's house name for Eden are the same instinct in two Dominions, and Eden and Zara's name exchange in the middle of the book rests on it.

RITES THE EMPIRE DOESN'T RUN

Desert names · the Desert Walk · fire burials

THE SCENE WHERE EDEN AND ZARA EXCHANGE NAMES

TKC: DOM · TR · TL

SEAT: SABLE REACH

FORMERLY PHOENIX

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

THE SCENE WHERE EDEN AND ZARA EXCHANGE NAMES

Pacific

Westhold, formerly Los Angeles · California, Oregon, parts of Nevada

SEAL OF PACIFIC · DRAW OR PASTE

IN THE TRIALS	Watched before they arrive
DESIGNATION	At 18. Every score reviewed in the Crownward for inherited resistance.
39TH COVENANT DAUGHTER	Sera Montoya · Westhold · 24

Pacific carries the memory of resistance like scar tissue. The secession attempt and the two-year standoff produced a generation that remembers trying to leave, and their grandchildren know the story. The Empire watches Westhold harder than anywhere: more cameras per block, more loyalty programming, and a Governor-Prelate Dorian appointed personally, who performs warmth while administering iron.

Old Los Angeles's creative industries adapted instead of dying, and people still make what they actually want and pass it through networks the Empire can't map. Every Pacific girl's Designation is reviewed in the Crownward for inherited resistance, and every Pacific Covenant Daughter arrives already flagged.

RITES THE EMPIRE DOESN'T RUN

The Real Binding · Facing West · burial facing the ocean

HOW PACIFIC SCHOOLS TEACH THE PARTITION, AND WHAT THE GRANDMOTHERS SAY AT HOME

TKC: DOM · TR · TL

SEAT: WESTHOLD

FORMERLY LOS ANGELES

YOURS

OPEN QUESTIONS

PART IX LOG

Working Questions

1 · HOW DID AUREM GET FIFTEEN ANOINTED WIVES? WHICH TRIALS, AND DOES AURELIA REMEMBER THEIR NAMES?

2 · WHAT IS THE REAL NAME OF AURELIA'S OUTER DISTRICTS, AND WHAT DO PEOPLE IN SECTOR SEVEN CALL THEIR OWN STREETS?

3 · WHAT DOES EACH GOVERNOR-PRELATE WANT FROM THE 39TH TRIAL?

4 · WHICH DOMINION WOULD EDEN MOST FEAR BEING SENT TO, AND WHY?

5 · WHAT DO PEOPLE IN THE OTHER ELEVEN DOMINIONS THINK OF AUREM, ITS FORTY-SEVEN SECONDS AND ITS FIFTEEN ANOINTED WIVES?

5 · WHAT DO PEOPLE IN THE OTHER ELEVEN DOMINIONS THINK OF AUREM, ITS FORTY-SEVEN SECONDS AND ITS FIFTEEN ANOINTED WIVES?

NOTES

ANYTHING THIS SPREAD STARTED AND DID NOT FINISH

VIII

PART EIGHT · ⌖

The Covenant Trials

A televised selection. Each Dominion sends one Covenant Daughter, and over about four months the Crown Heir's Anointed Wife is chosen from the twelve. The other eleven are married down the elite ladder.

i · History	561
ii · Eligibility and nomination	563
iii · The Regional Assessment	565
iv · Arrival and the Covenant Houses	567
v · The three phases	569
vi · Scoring	572
vii · The Declaration and its rules	573
viii · The Covenant Daughters of the 39th Trial	575

TR | FR 19–28

THE WEIGHTS

Temple 30 · Crown 30 · Broadcast 40. Never disclosed.

THE OUTPUT

One Anointed Wife for the heir, eleven married down the ladder, nobody sent home unassigned (**FR 19**).

MARGINALIA

Revelation, not competition

The Empire presents the Trials as revelation, never as competition, because "a competition can be rigged. A revelation cannot" (**TR**). The Broadcast's words are anointing, covenant, calling, worthy and chosen. This part covers how the Trials work in any year. What happens in the 39th belongs to Volume Two.

The Trials sit where every earlier part of this companion meets. The Temple runs the first phase and names it Genesis. The Crown runs the second and names it Exodus. The terrain runs the third. A girl is examined on scripture by people who've decided which scripture counts, debated on governance by the heir to a throne her own scripture limits, and sent into the mountains with no cameras by a Broadcast that will reconstruct what happened afterward.

✣ *See also:* Part VI, the Triune Rule and the Binding.

"A competition can be rigged. A revelation cannot."

Thirty-nine Trials

TKC: TL · TR · DOM · FR 30 · FR 34 · FR 39

WHEN	WHAT	SOURCE
2048	Elias marries Sera Callum. The first Anointed marriage becomes the template.	TL
2065	Crest introduces the Trials as "a celebration of the Empire's finest women." The first cycle is rough, and the ratings are extraordinary.	TL
22ND TRIAL	Ladies in Waiting introduced, to keep high performers in the Crownward instead of sending them home with influence nobody can manage	TR
TRIALS 1–31	Endurance held in Mountain terrain	DOM
2085	Cancelled after Crest dies mid-cycle and Dorian's accession forces a transition. The twelve go home with their designations intact and no placements.	FR 34, 39
FROM 2085	Under Dorian the Trials become the most-watched event in the Empire's calendar	TL
TRIALS 32–38	Endurance moved to a controlled facility with continuous filming	TR, DOM
2104	The 39th Trial. Endurance returns to Mountain terrain without public explanation.	TR

EVERY YEAR	INFERENCE The Trials run annually. The first was in 2065, and with 2085 skipped, the 39th lands in 2104 (FR 39).
THE 2085 COHORT	They met while being assembled and measured against each other, and they're scattered through their home Dominions now. The shared history makes a network possible, and it doesn't activate before Book Two (FR 34). The 2085 cohort is the thing Hannah has never said out loud (FR 30). INFERENCE She was one of the twelve.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHAT THE TRIALS WERE LIKE IN THE 2060S AND 2070S, BEFORE DORIAN MADE THEM SPECTACLE

The Covenant Registry

TKC: TR · DR3 · TL · FR 27

Every Dominion keeps a Covenant Registry of women aged 18 to 25 who meet five requirements (**TR**): Unbound or elevated designation, no prior marriage registration, no Ungoverned citations, completion of the standard Imperial curriculum, and "demonstrated covenantal aptitude," which means whatever the Governor-Prelate needs it to mean.

Covenant Registration

AUREM

NOMINATED · BORDERED IN GOLD

CANDIDATE

_____

NOMINATED BY

Vowed officer · family · community leader

FEE

none

NOMINATED

Independent Submission

AUREM

SELF-NOMINATED · PRINTED IN RED

CANDIDATE

Eden Selah Osei

NOMINATED BY

herself

FEE

ten dollars, nonrefundable

INDEPENDENT

SELF-NOMINATION	The Empire frames it as exceptional faith. In practice the process is built to exhaust anyone without institutional support, and most self-nominations fail for that reason alone (**TR**). In Aurem it's "independent submission," a ten-dollar nonrefundable fee and a card printed in red instead of bordered in gold (**DR3**). Eden is the first Aurem candidate in the Trials' history to enter that way (**TL**).
ELIGIBILITY ISN'T ENTRY	A House Mother can submit a name, and she isn't the only one who can (**FR 27**).

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

THE MORNING EDEN PAID THE TEN DOLLARS

Three days, a ranked list

TKC: TR · TL · DR3

Each Dominion runs a three-day Regional Assessment under senior Vowed officers, which produces a ranked list (**TR**, **TL**).

Regional Assessment · Results

AURELIA TEMPLE ATRIUM

POSTED THE THIRD MONDAY OF JUNE · SEVEN O'CLOCK IN THE MORNING

APPOINTED TO THE COVENANT	*the top five, photographs hung through the summer*
FAMILIES	*formal review, the kind where unpaid levies disappear*
DISCERNMENT · SPIRITUAL FITNESS	*graded by ministerial review*
READ BEFORE THE SCORES	*Proverbs 31.29, King James wording*

POSTED

MINISTERIAL REVIEW	Some sections, like Discernment and Spiritual Fitness, are graded by ministerial review, so a girl can know every answer and still fail for a lack of humility (**DR3**).
THE CHOICE	The Governor-Prelate chooses the Covenant Daughter from the top three. In practice he picks whoever the Crown has quietly signaled it prefers, then documents it as a choice from the top three regardless of the real ranking (**TR**).

WHAT A GIRL'S FAMILY IN AUREM GETS, SPECIFICALLY, WHEN SHE'S APPOINTED

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHAT A GIRL'S FAMILY IN AUREM GETS, SPECIFICALLY, WHEN SHE'S APPOINTED

Covenant Row

TKC: TR · CR · TL · FR 26

ARRIVAL	The twelve arrive in the first week of summer, staggered across seven days so each arrival can be released as its own day of content. Each travels by Dominion transport with two Appointed Officers and her House Mother (**TR**). Each walks Sovereign Boulevard on camera. The walk is choreographed: what pace to keep, where to look, how to hold her hands (**CR**).
THE HOUSES	Twelve townhouses on Covenant Row, one per Dominion, under five minutes' walk from Sovereign Boulevard. Cameras in every common area, entrance and garden, and not the bedrooms (**CR**). The candidates aren't sequestered. They're embedded in Crownward public life: Temple services, forums, the approved dining rooms, the Administrative Side markets (**CR**).
HOUSE STAFF	In House Aurem, the House Mother, the House Coordinator, the stylist and the Debate and Protocol Advisor (**TL**). A House hosts one Covenant Daughter per Trial, and staff serve across many. Hannah's "six Trials, twelve girls" counts her whole career across several Houses and posts (**FR 26**).

HOUSE AUREM · COVENANT ROW · FLOOR PLAN, DRAW IT

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHERE THE CAMERAS ARE IN HOUSE AUREM, AND THE ONE PLACE EDEN FINDS THAT THEY AREN'T

TKC: TR

Three powers, three questions

The Trials run in three phases. Each belongs to a different power and asks a different question, and they line up with the novel's Genesis, Exodus and Revelation (**TR**).

I · GENESIS

The Covenant Examination

"Who are you?"

THE TEMPLE · WEEKS 1–4

- The Settling
- The Doctrinal Assessment
- The Theological Interview
- The Public Testimony

30%

II · EXODUS

The Governance Trials

"How smart are you?"

THE CROWN · WEEKS 5–10

- The Dominion Forum
- The Civic Debates
- The Anointed Evening
- The Pairing Introduction

30%

III · REVELATION

Endurance

"What are you willing to endure?"

THE TERRAIN · THREE DAYS

- Coordinates to reach
- No schedule
- No handlers
- No cameras after deployment

FEEDS THE BROADCAST'S 40%

SUPERSEDED The original Trials file had four phases: the Covenant Examination, the Governance Trials, the Public Season and the Declaration. **OPEN QUESTION** The original also had candidates sign a confidentiality covenant before the Crown's phase, with removal and a permanent Ungoverned citation for breaking it (**TR-orig**). Does it still exist?

WHICH PHASE EACH OF THE TWELVE IS BUILT TO SURVIVE

TKC: TR

What happens in each

THE SETTLING	Presented as a grace period. It's the most intensive assessment of all, because the Vowed watch everything.
THE DOCTRINAL ASSESSMENT	A six-hour written exam in the Temple Sanctum, set at each candidate's ceiling, so no two girls get the same questions.
THE THEOLOGICAL INTERVIEW	A conversation with a senior Vowed officer, who's told to pursue any rehearsed answer until she finds what's underneath it.
THE PUBLIC TESTIMONY	A fifteen-minute statement of faith and purpose, broadcast live, the first time the Empire hears each candidate unmediated. Candidates are given Vowed handlers to "ensure theological accuracy," and they can decline them.
THE DOMINION FORUM	Every remaining candidate in a room with an Empire-wide crisis and no assigned leader.
THE CIVIC DEBATES	Three filmed debates on governance, theology and social policy, topics given an hour before. The Crown Heir moderates the social policy debate.
THE ANOINTED EVENING	Four hours with the Anointed Court in the Crown Palace, where the cameras can't follow into the side rooms.
THE PAIRING INTRODUCTION	Thirty minutes alone with the Heir, with a Crown advisor and a Vowed officer present and a camera outside the door. The room isn't recorded. The Commission has been known to wire candidates beforehand.
ENDURANCE	What the Empire calls covenantal fortitude and the terrain calls survival. The Broadcast films the deployment and the final checkpoint, and everything between is reconstructed from the candidates' accounts, always incomplete.

A DOCTRINAL ASSESSMENT QUESTION AT EDEN'S CEILING. WRITE ONE

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

A DOCTRINAL ASSESSMENT QUESTION AT EDEN'S CEILING. WRITE ONE

TKC: TR

The Evening Reckoning

Sovereign Boulevard · every evening at seven

The scores update on the screens.

✣

THE EMPIRE NAMED IT THE EVENING RECKONING (**TR**)

THE COMPOSITE	Temple 30 percent, Crown 30 percent, Broadcast 40 percent, never disclosed. The Broadcast's share includes narrative-priority decisions by the Broadcast Director (**TR**).
THE ANTAGONIST NARRATIVE	Every Trial produces one, assigned to the candidate who most threatens a comfortable outcome, and not to the eventual winner (**TR**).
THE EVE PROBLEM	When a candidate's intelligence becomes the story instead of her compliance, the Broadcast calls it internally the Eve problem. The narrative implies and never accuses. It moves the score without changing a single formal assessment, and it has worked every time it's been used (**TR**).

WHAT THE NARRATIVE-PRIORITY DECISION LOOKS LIKE INSIDE THE CITADEL, AND WHO SIGNS IT

Sovereign Boulevard, live

TKC: TR · FR 20–25

After the Endurance rankings are confirmed, the Crown Heir names his Anointed Wife in a public ceremony on Sovereign Boulevard, broadcast live in all twelve Dominions (TR). The rules around that moment come from the Final Rulings.

THE RANKED WINNER · FR 20	The heir may choose any of the twelve. "Without deviation" describes the record, not a rule.
WHAT WINNING MEANS · FR 21	Being the choice that costs the Crown nothing. The rankings tell the heir which selection is free. Deviation is permitted and expensive, and no heir has ever paid it.
REFUSAL · FR 22	The recommendation stands by default once the window closes. Refusing is abstention, not resistance, and produces the same result as complying.
CANCELLATION · FR 23	Impossible once the Trial is announced, except in a public dynastic emergency: the Heir's death or incapacity, or the Emperor's death forcing an immediate transition. A candidate's death doesn't downgrade a Trial.
A CANDIDATE'S DEATH · FR 24	Her status goes back to her family, with no compensation and no punishment, as though the designation had never been made.
REJECTED CANDIDATES · FR 25	Married down as designated. The rejection follows them "not in the record, in the room."
LADIES IN WAITING · TR	The third- and fourth-place Endurance finishers stay in the Crownward in supporting roles to the Anointed Wife and the Crown household.

WHAT THE MEN ASSIGNED TO THE ELEVEN KNOW ABOUT THEIR BRIDES BEFORE THE DECLARATION

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

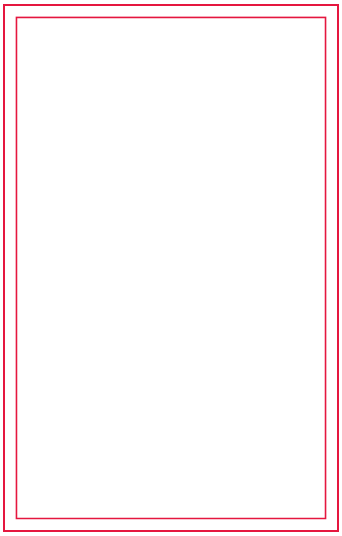
WHAT THE MEN ASSIGNED TO THE ELEVEN KNOW ABOUT THEIR BRIDES BEFORE THE DECLARATION

The twelve, I

TKC: TR · RULING

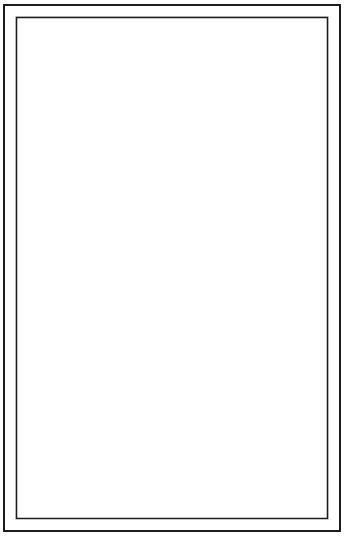
VOLUME TWO, PART III

For reference. Their stories are in Volume Two. Each frame is for a portrait, a Broadcast still, or whatever you draw.



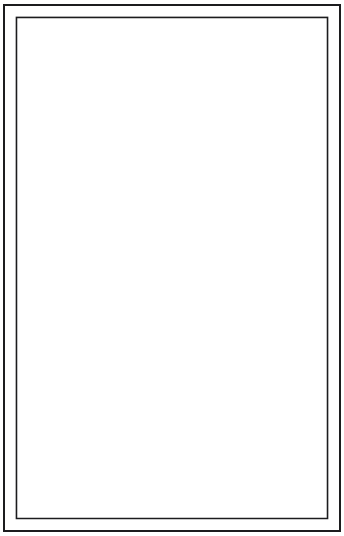
Eden Selah Osei

AUREM · AURELIA · 21



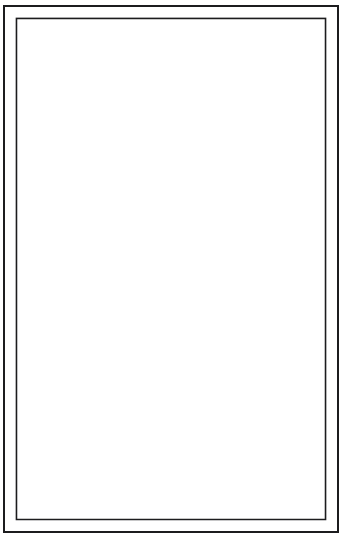
Delphine Fontenot

GULF · PORT SERAPHINE · 22



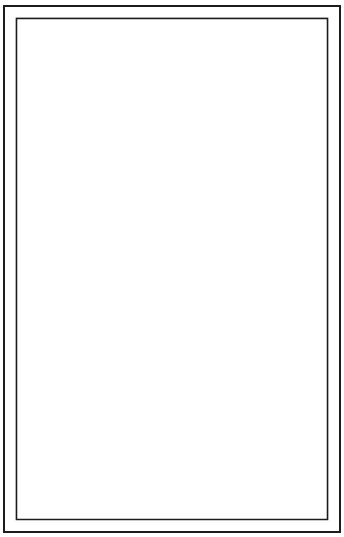
Maren Cole

ARDENNE · ASHFORD · 23



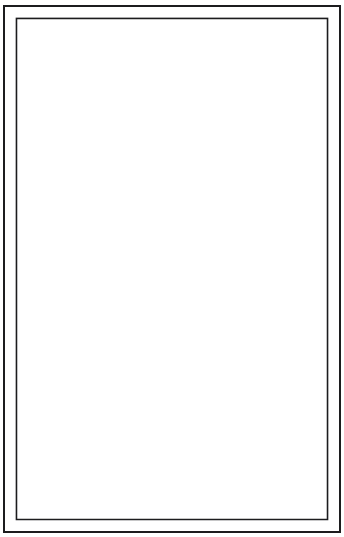
Corinne Vale

MERIDIAN · BLESSED SHORE · 22



Calla Merritt

VANE · SAINT MERIDIAN · 21



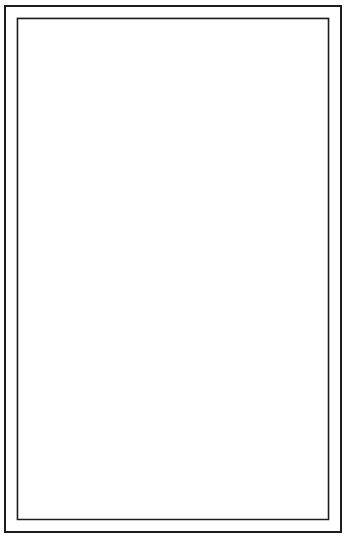
Nadia Orin

IRONGATE · IRON BENEDICTION · 20

TKC: TR · RULING

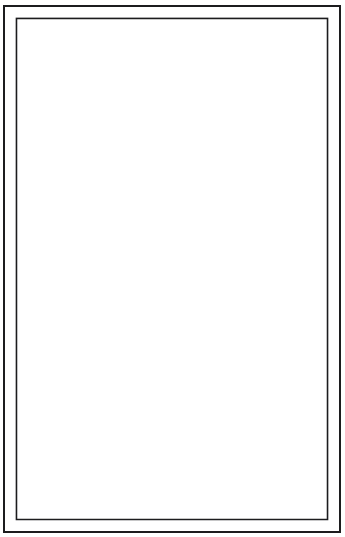
VOLUME TWO, PART III

The twelve, II



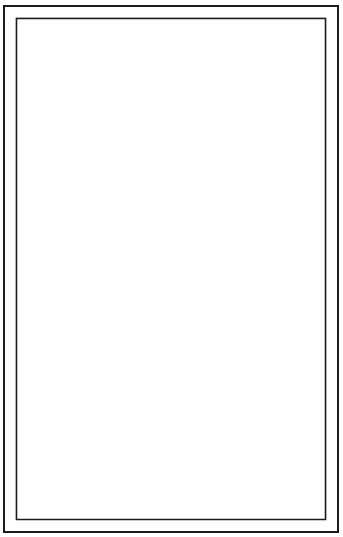
Ruth Gideon

HEARTLAND · PROVIDENCE CROSS · 22



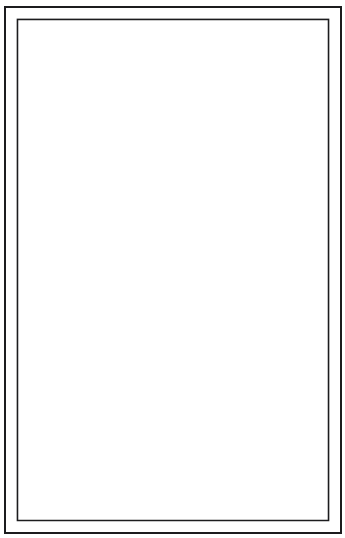
Delia Cross

RED EARTH · CANAAN'S GATE · 24



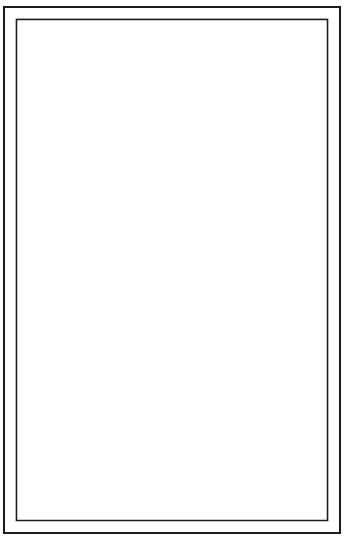
Vivienne Hale

LONE · COVENANT BASIN · 23



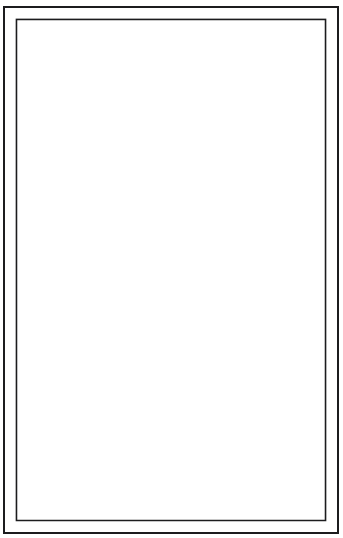
Petra Solano

MOUNTAIN · CRESTFALL · 22



Zara Voss

SABLE · SABLE REACH · 21



Sera Montoya

PACIFIC · WESTHOLD · 24

Calla's surname is from your ruling. Sources: TR, Ruling.

Working Questions

YOURS

OPEN QUESTIONS

PART IX LOG

1 · WHO SITS ON THE TRIALS COMMISSION AND THE OVERSIGHT COMMITTEE, AND ARE THEY THE SAME BODY?

2 · WHAT DO LADIES IN WAITING DO DAY TO DAY, AND WHO HAS HELD THE TITLE?

3 · WHO CHOSE TO BRING ENDURANCE BACK TO MOUNTAIN TERRAIN FOR THE 39TH, AND WHY?

4 · WHAT DOES A HOUSE MOTHER DO ACROSS A CAREER? WHAT HAPPENS TO HOUSE STAFF WHEN THEIR GIRL LOSES?

5 · WHAT HAS HAPPENED TO THE WOMEN THE EVE NARRATIVE WAS USED ON IN EARLIER TRIALS?

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

6 · HAS A COVENANT DAUGHTER EVER DIED BEFORE PETRA? HOW DID THE EMPIRE HANDLE IT?

BACK MATTER

Register, Sources and Log

What's fixed, what's open, where everything came from, and the record of what you decide next.

The canon register	580
Superseded and in conflict	582
Open questions, gathered	583
The discovery log	585
Sources and editions	589

DECIDED

FINAL RULINGS

What's fixed

Everything on this page is canon until you overrule it. The Final Rulings outrank every source file, and your own decisions outrank the rest of this book.

ITEM	RULING	WHERE IT LANDS
SOLOMON'S AGE	**DECIDED** sixteen. The timeline's thirteen is SUPERSEDED.	Part II cast table, Part VI men
LEAH AND EDEN	**DECIDED** Leah is younger than Eden.	Part II cast table
THOMAS	Left voluntarily (**FR 3**)	Part VI Commonwife marriage
MIRIAM	Reassigned after Thomas left (**FR 0**). Celeste has no proof she's alive (**FR 16**).	Part V, Part VI
LEAH'S ASSESSMENT	**DECIDED** Leah sat for an assessment.	Part VI Designation
THE PRELATE	Renamed under FR 33 so Hannah's daughter keeps the name Naomi. **POSSIBLE** working name Aurelia. Never Huldah.	Part VI Temple
CREST	Dorian's uncle (**FR 35**). His claim came through survivorship (**FR 39**).	Parts V, VI
THE REMOVED HEIR	Elias's elder child, Dorian's parent, removed in 2061 (**FR 35–36**)	Part V
DORIAN	59 in 2104 (**Ruling**)	Parts V, VI
CALLA'S SURNAME	Merritt (**Ruling**)	Part VIII
CHILDREN'S STATUS	By household registration, not parentage (**FR 32**)	Part VI
THE ELEVEN	Married down the elite ladder. Nobody goes home unassigned (**FR 19**).	Parts VI, VIII
DECLINING AN ASSIGNMENT	A man may decline the whole assignment. It has happened twice (**FR 28**).	Part VI
THE DECLARATION	FR 20–25, as printed in Part VIII	Part VIII

Decided after this printing

LOG NO.	DATE	WHAT I DECIDED	REPLACES	PAGES AFFECTED

What no longer controls, and where the files disagree

SUPERSEDED · THE OLD COMPANION'S PRELATE	Page 182 of the old companion marked "Prelate Huldah's office" as canon. FR 33 renamed the Prelate. Huldah is only the biblical prophet.
SUPERSEDED · SOLOMON AT THIRTEEN	The timeline's age. **DECIDED** sixteen.
SUPERSEDED · DORIAN AT 61	The Crownward file's age. The ruling uses 59.
SUPERSEDED · CREST AS DORIAN'S FATHER	The Crownward file. Under FR 35, his uncle.
SUPERSEDED · FOUR PHASES	The original Trials file's Public Season and Declaration phases. The updated file has three.
CONFLICT · THE COMMONWIFE QUOTAS	Introduced under Crest in 2062 (**TL**), piloted in Red Earth in 2058 (**DOM**). **INFERENCE** A pilot under Elias, made Empire-wide under Crest.
CONFLICT · SERA CALLUM'S ORIGIN	"The Northern Dominion" (**TL**). No Dominion has that name.

CORRECTION TO THE OLD COMPANION Corrections to the old companion's research run through every part, each printed where it falls under the heading "Correction to the old companion."

A CONFLICT I'VE FOUND SINCE THIS PRINTING

What you still have to decide

OPEN QUESTION

Each one appears where it belongs in the book. They're gathered here so you can work through them in one sitting.

QUESTION	PART	DECIDED?
What the Restoration Act's preamble says	V	
Who Elias's first wife was	V	
Where Sera Callum came from	V	
What the heir knew or did that made removal necessary in 2061	V	
What the "deliberate removals" in the ledger were	V	
What the Covenant of Dissent argues	V, VI	
Whether the Book of Covenant is a full Bible, abridged, or bound with the Empire's texts	IV, VI	
The Empire's official text of the Lord's Prayer	III	
What an Ungoverned citation does beyond disqualification	VI	
The six designations, their order, and where Vowed ranks	VI	
How Commonwife reassignment works, and why Solomon kept the Osei name	VI	
What Home Instruction is	VI	

OPEN QUESTION

What you still have to decide, continued

QUESTION	PART	DECIDED?
Whether the hyphenated Binding surname is Aurem's alone	VI	
Where Washington, Alaska and Hawaii are	VII	
Whether the confidentiality covenant still exists	VIII	
Who sits on the Trials Commission and the oversight committee	VIII	
Who named the Dominions, and whether it was piety or a joke	I, IV	
Whether the Temple teaches the curse of Ham	I	
Who in the Empire would authenticate the Covenant of Dissent	I, II	
Whether anyone in Dorian's court has Nathan's office	II	
What the Prelate is finally called	VI	

The discovery log

Anything you find while working these pages starts as POSSIBLE. It moves to DECIDED only when you've decided it belongs in the manuscript, given it a number here, and noted which files it changes.

NO.	DATE	WHAT I FOUND	STATUS	FILES IT CHANGES

The discovery log, continued

NO.	DATE	WHAT I FOUND	STATUS	FILES IT CHANGES

The discovery log, continued

NO.	DATE	WHAT I FOUND	STATUS	FILES IT CHANGES

YOURS

LOG

The discovery log, continued

NO.	DATE	WHAT I FOUND	STATUS	FILES IT CHANGES

Where all of this came from

Every page carries a narrow source margin on its outer edge, in compressed form, author and short title. The compressed forms point to the full citations on the next pages. Nothing in a margin is a citation by itself.

RESEARCH	Unlabeled prose in Parts I to IV is research: the text says it, or the manuscript evidence shows it, and you can check it in any study Bible with a critical apparatus.
CONTESTED	Responsible scholars or traditions disagree. The dispute is printed, with the strongest case on each side, and no verdict.
INTERPRETATION · INFERENCE	A reading offered as a reading, or a conclusion drawn from your files that they don't state.
POSSIBLE	A TKC construction, about Dominion, the Temple or the manuscript, and not a claim about scripture. Test it before use.
DECIDED	A call you've made. Fixed until you rule otherwise.

ON THE SECONDARY LITERATURE

The works listed are standard reference points and not endorsements of any one position. Where two disagree, and several do sharply, the companion prints the disagreement. Several are technical commentaries that assume Hebrew or Greek. You don't need them to use this book. They're listed so every claim can be traced.

TRANSLATION I'M WORKING FROM	EDITION OR PRINTING	USED FOR

PART I

DOSSIERS I–IV

FOCUSED STUDIES

PART II

Texts, lexicons and commentaries

MT	*Biblia Hebraica Stuttgartensia*. Stuttgart: Deutsche Bibelgesellschaft. The standard printed Masoretic text. Cite the printing you use.
LXX	Rahlfs–Hanhart, *Septuaginta*. Deutsche Bibelgesellschaft. Consulted where the Greek differs from the Hebrew.
DSS	Dead Sea Scroll manuscripts cited by siglum, such as 4QDeut and 4Q365.
BDB	Brown, Driver and Briggs, *A Hebrew and English Lexicon of the Old Testament*. Oxford: Clarendon, 1906.
HALOT	Koehler and Baumgartner, *The Hebrew and Aramaic Lexicon of the Old Testament*. Leiden: Brill. The current standard. Use it over BDB where they conflict.
MILGROM	Jacob Milgrom, *Leviticus*. Anchor Bible 3, 3A, 3B. New York: Doubleday, 1991–2001.
KLAWANS	Jonathan Klawans, *Impurity and Sin in Ancient Judaism*. Oxford University Press, 2000.
DOUGLAS	Mary Douglas, *Purity and Danger*. Routledge, 1966, and *Leviticus as Literature*. Oxford, 1999.
OLYAN	Saul M. Olyan, *Disability in the Hebrew Bible*. Cambridge University Press, 2008.
BERGSMA	John Sietze Bergsma, *The Jubilee from Leviticus to Qumran*. Leiden: Brill, 2007.
WEINFELD	Moshe Weinfeld, *Deuteronomy 1–11*. Anchor Bible 5. Doubleday, 1991, and *Deuteronomy and the Deuteronomic School*. Oxford: Clarendon, 1972.
LEVINSON	Bernard M. Levinson, *Deuteronomy and the Hermeneutics of Legal Innovation*. Oxford University Press, 1997.
GOLDENBERG	David M. Goldenberg, *The Curse of Ham*. Princeton University Press, 2003.

Texts, lexicons and commentaries, continued

HAYNES	Stephen R. Haynes, *Noah's Curse*. Oxford University Press, 2002.
LEVENSON	Jon D. Levenson, *The Death and Resurrection of the Beloved Son*. Yale University Press, 1993.
TRIBLE	Phyllis Trible, *God and the Rhetoric of Sexuality* (1978) and *Texts of Terror* (1984). Fortress.
WILLIAMS	Delores S. Williams, *Sisters in the Wilderness*. Orbis, 1993.
WESTERMANN · ALTER · PROPP · CHILDS · MEYERS · JAPHET · WILLIAMSON · BLENKINSOPP · FOX · SEOW · GREENBERG · NOGALSKI · SWEENEY	The commentaries named in the focused-study and dossier margins. Record the editions you own on the last page.

PART I
DOSSIERS I–IV
FOCUSED STUDIES
PART II

PART III

PART IV

GOSPEL GRID

Greek texts, Jesus research, ancient neighbors

NA28	*Novum Testamentum Graece*, 28th revised edition. Deutsche Bibelgesellschaft, 2012. Where the companion says a reading is absent from the oldest manuscripts, this is the apparatus it means.
UBS5	*The Greek New Testament*, 5th revised edition. United Bible Societies, 2014.
SANDERS	E. P. Sanders, *The Historical Figure of Jesus*. Penguin, 1993.
EHRMAN	Bart D. Ehrman, *The New Testament: A Historical Introduction*. Oxford University Press. Record your edition, since page references move.
GOODACRE	Mark Goodacre, *The Case Against Q*. Trinity Press International, 2002.
BORG AND CROSSAN	Marcus Borg and John Dominic Crossan, *The Last Week*. HarperOne, 2006.
LEVINE	Amy-Jill Levine, *The Misunderstood Jew*. HarperOne, 2006.
EPP	Eldon Jay Epp, *Junia: The First Woman Apostle*. Fortress, 2005.
COS	William W. Hallo and K. Lawson Younger, eds., *The Context of Scripture*. Brill, 1997–2002. The flood parallels, the Mesha inscription and the law codes.
SAA 2	Simo Parpola and Kazuko Watanabe, *Neo-Assyrian Treaties and Loyalty Oaths*. Helsinki University Press, 1988. The succession-treaty curses compared with Deuteronomy 28.
STEYMANS	Hans Ulrich Steymans, *Deuteronomium 28 und die adê zur Thronfolgeregelung Asarhaddons*. 1995.
MENDENHALL · MORAN	George Mendenhall, "Covenant Forms in Israelite Tradition" (1954–55). William Moran, "The Ancient Near Eastern Background of the Love of God in Deuteronomy" (1963).

Behind Part IV's American history

PART IV, V

LINKS TO CLICK THROUGH AT PROOFING

These were checked against search results. The pages themselves still need a click-through at proofing.

WINTHROP	Wikisource, *A Model of Christian Charity* · Teaching American History, "A City upon a Hill" · Museum of the Bible, "A City Upon a Hill" · Rodgers, *As a City on a Hill* (2018)
SLAVERY AND THE BIBLE	Furman University, Richard Furman's *Exposition* · Wake Forest, "Defending the Indefensible" · HathiTrust, Stringfellow's *Brief Examination* · Grimké, *Appeal to the Christian Women of the South* · Douglass, *Narrative*, Appendix · Noll, *The Civil War as a Theological Crisis* (2006)
THE SOUTHERN BAPTIST CONVENTION	*Christianity Today* on the 1995 resolution · the SBC Racial Reconciliation Resolution · Baptist News Global
THE 1807 SLAVE BIBLE	NPR, December 9, 2018 · Wikipedia, *Select Parts of the Holy Bible*
THE BLACK CHURCH	Raboteau, *Slave Religion* (1978) · Lincoln and Mamiya, *The Black Church in the African American Experience* (1990) · Wikipedia, Richard Allen and Emanuel AME · BlackPast · Equal Justice Initiative, July 2, 1822
CHRISTIAN NATIONALISM	PRRI and Brookings, February 2023 · Whitehead and Perry, *Taking America Back for God* (2020) · Mark David Hall · Wolfe, *The Case for Christian Nationalism* (2022)
RECONSTRUCTIONISM	Rushdoony, *The Institutes of Biblical Law* (1973) · Bahnsen, *Theonomy in Christian Ethics* (1977) · Barker and Godfrey, eds., *Theonomy: A Reformed Critique* (1990) · Chalcedon
DOMINIONISM AND THE SEVEN MOUNTAINS	Diamond, *Spiritual Warfare* (1989) · Northeastern University, November 15, 2022 · Wikipedia, Seven Mountain Mandate · Good Faith Media · *Christian Post* · Taylor, *The Violent Take It by Force* (2024)
DANVERS AND CBE	Wikipedia, Council on Biblical Manhood and Womanhood · CBE, "A Brief History" · *Christianity Today*, July 2011

YOURS

PROOFING

Editions I actually own

WORK	EDITION AND YEAR	CHECKED

WHAT'S STILL OUTSTANDING

Page-level references. The lists identify the works behind each claim and don't yet give a page for every one. Adding them is a proofing task, and every dossier's proofing gate carries it until it's done.

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